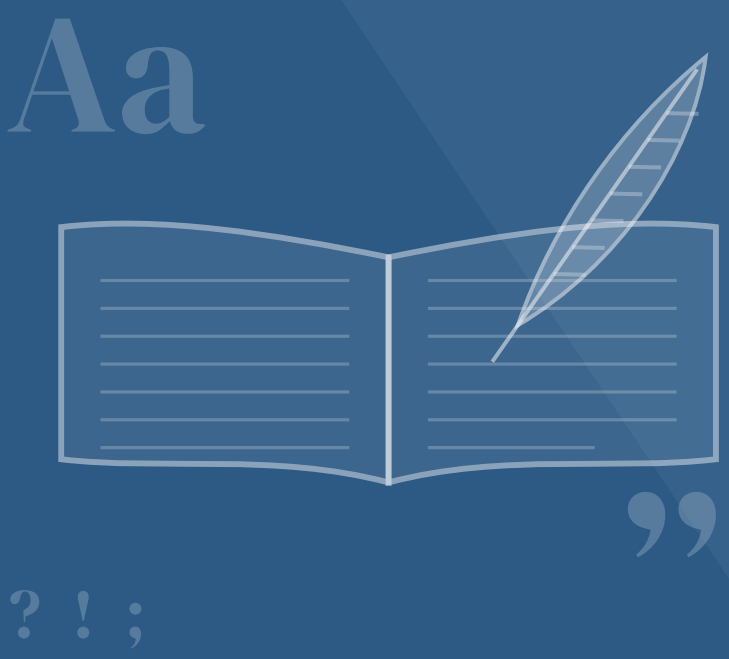
VENVLEARNING

STUDENT READER



English Language Arts

GRADE 7

Every story, play, and novel for the year in one book

2026–2027 School Year · 9 units

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

VENVLEARNING

Grade 7 Reader

English Language Arts · 2026–2027

IN THIS READER

PART ONE — **A Christmas Carol**
Charles Dickens

PART TWO — **Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde**
Robert Louis Stevenson

PART THREE — **The Time Machine**
H. G. Wells

PART FOUR — **Voices of the Harlem Renaissance**
An anthology, with background by VenvLearning

HOW TO USE THIS READER

One book for the whole year

This Reader holds every story, play, novel, and selection that your Grade 7 English Language Arts lessons ask you to read. When a lesson says Read in your Reader, find the part and the pages it names, then read with the lesson's question in mind.

This book has four parts. Each part keeps its own page numbers, so the pages in a lesson always go with the part named. For example, “Reader: A Christmas Carol, pp. 3–9” means pages 3 to 9 of A Christmas Carol.

Reading on a screen? Use the bookmarks to jump to any part or chapter, or open the lesson links on VenvLearning, which go straight to the right page.

WHICH UNITS READ WHAT

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Units 3–4	Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde, Chapters 1–10
Units 5–6	The Time Machine, Chapters 1–12
Unit 7	Voices of the Harlem Renaissance
Unit 8	The Time Machine, Chapters 13–15, After the Story, and Epilogue
Unit 9	Voices of the Harlem Renaissance (Hughes, Georgia Douglas Johnson, McDougald)

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CREDITS AND LICENSES

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PART ONE

A Christmas Carol

Charles Dickens

Read in Units 1–2: the complete story, stave by stave, from Marley's Ghost to The End of It.

I have endeavoured in this Ghostly little book, to raise the Ghost of an Idea, which shall not put my readers out of humour with themselves, with each other, with the season, or with me. May it haunt their houses pleasantly, and no one wish to lay it.

Their faithful Friend and Servant, C. D. December, 1843.

BEFORE YOU READ

Introduction

WORDS TO KNOW

Victorian	Belonging to the reign of Queen Victoria (1837–1901).
workhouse	A grim public building where very poor people lived and worked in exchange for food and a bed.
debtors' prison	A prison for people who could not pay what they owed.
stave	A verse of a song; Dickens calls each chapter of his “carol” a stave.

In the autumn of 1843, Charles Dickens was thirty-one years old, famous, and worried about money. His newest novel was selling poorly, and he had a growing family to support. He was also angry. That year he had read a government report about children working long hours in mines and factories, and he had visited a “ragged school,” a free school for the poorest children of London. He wanted to strike a blow for them. He decided not to write a pamphlet but a story, and he wrote it in about six weeks.

The story was A Christmas Carol. It went on sale on December 19, 1843, and the first six thousand copies sold out by Christmas Eve. It has never been out of print since.

Dickens knew poverty from the inside. When he was twelve, his father was sent to a debtors' prison, and young Charles was taken out of school to work ten-hour days in a factory, pasting labels onto pots of boot polish. He never forgot the shame and hunger of those months, and he never forgot that a child's whole future can depend on whether anyone cares what happens to him.

Victorian London was the largest and richest city in the world, and also one of the poorest. Factories and trade made some people very wealthy, while many families lived crowded into single rooms, burning what coal they could afford. People who could not support themselves might be sent to a workhouse, where families were separated and the food was kept deliberately meager so that no one would want to stay. Many comfortable people believed that the poor had only themselves to blame.

Ebenezer Scrooge believes exactly that. He is a rich, lonely, tight-fisted businessman who thinks that prisons and workhouses are all the help the poor deserve, and that Christmas is “humbug,” or nonsense. On Christmas Eve he is visited by the ghost of his dead business

partner, Jacob Marley, and then by three Spirits, who show him his past, his present, and a possible future. The question of the story is whether a person like Scrooge can change.

Dickens called his book a carol, a joyful song sung at Christmas, and he divided it into five staves, or verses, instead of chapters. He wrote it to be read aloud, and he later performed it on stage himself, playing every character. As you read, listen to the voices: Dickens's narrator talks to you directly, jokes, and exaggerates, and every character has a way of speaking all his or her own.

This is the complete text of the story, as Dickens published it in 1843. Some words and customs are old-fashioned, so each section begins with Words to Know. Read slowly, read aloud when you can, and keep your lesson's question in mind.

CHARACTERS

Ebenezer Scrooge	a rich, miserly London businessman
Jacob Marley	Scrooge's business partner, dead seven years
Bob Cratchit	Scrooge's clerk
Mrs. Cratchit, Martha, Belinda, Peter, and Tiny Tim	Bob's family
Fred	Scrooge's cheerful nephew
Fan	Scrooge's little sister, Fred's mother
Mr. Fezziwig	the kindly merchant Scrooge worked for as a young man
Belle	the young woman Scrooge once planned to marry
The Ghost of Christmas Past	a strange, glowing figure, both childlike and old
The Ghost of Christmas Present	a jolly giant robed in green
The Ghost of Christmas Yet to Come	a silent, hooded phantom

STAVE ONE

Marley's Ghost

WORDS TO KNOW

covetous	Greedy; eager to get more money or things.
solitary	Alone; without companions.
humbug	Nonsense; something false or foolish.
morose	Gloomy and bad-tempered.
destitute	Without money, food, or a home.
surplus	Extra; more than is needed.
counting-house	A merchant's office where accounts were kept.

MARLEY was dead: to begin with. There is no doubt whatever about that. The register of his burial was signed by the clergyman, the clerk, the undertaker, and the chief mourner. Scrooge signed it: and Scrooge's name was good upon 'Change, for anything he chose to put his hand to. Old Marley was as dead as a door-nail.

Mind! I don't mean to say that I know, of my own knowledge, what there is particularly dead about a door-nail. I might have been inclined, myself, to regard a coffin-nail as the deadest piece of ironmongery in the trade. But the wisdom of our ancestors is in the simile; and my unhallowed hands shall not disturb it, or the Country's done for. You will therefore permit me to repeat, emphatically, that Marley was as dead as a door-nail.

Scrooge knew he was dead? Of course he did. How could it be otherwise? Scrooge and he were partners for I don't know how many years. Scrooge was his sole executor, his sole administrator, his sole assign, his sole residuary legatee, his sole friend, and sole mourner. And even Scrooge was not so dreadfully cut up by the sad event, but that he was an excellent man of business on the very day of the funeral, and solemnised it with an undoubted bargain.

The mention of Marley's funeral brings me back to the point I started from. There is no doubt that Marley was dead. This must be distinctly understood, or nothing wonderful can come of the story I am going to relate. If we were not perfectly convinced that Hamlet's Father died before the play began, there would be nothing more remarkable in his taking a stroll at night, in an easterly wind, upon his own ramparts, than there would be in any other middle-aged gentleman rashly turning out after dark in a breezy spot—say Saint Paul's

Churchyard for instance— literally to astonish his son's weak mind.

Scrooge never painted out Old Marley's name. There it stood, years afterwards, above the warehouse door: Scrooge and Marley. The firm was known as Scrooge and Marley. Sometimes people new to the business called Scrooge Scrooge, and sometimes Marley, but he answered to both names. It was all the same to him.

Oh! But he was a tight-fisted hand at the grind-stone, Scrooge! a squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous, old sinner! Hard and sharp as flint, from which no steel had ever struck out generous fire; secret, and self-contained, and solitary as an oyster. The cold within him froze his old features, nipped his pointed nose, shrivelled his cheek, stiffened his gait; made his eyes red, his thin lips blue; and spoke out shrewdly in his grating voice. A frosty rime was on his head, and on his eyebrows, and his wiry chin. He carried his own low temperature always about with him; he iced his office in the dog-days; and didn't thaw it one degree at Christmas.

External heat and cold had little influence on Scrooge. No warmth could warm, no wintry weather chill him. No wind that blew was bitterer than he, no falling snow was more intent upon its purpose, no pelting rain less open to entreaty. Foul weather didn't know where to have him. The heaviest rain, and snow, and hail, and sleet, could boast of the advantage over him in only one respect. They often "came down" handsomely, and Scrooge never did.

Nobody ever stopped him in the street to say, with gladsome looks, "My dear Scrooge, how are you? When will you come to see me?" No beggars implored him to bestow a trifle, no children asked him what it was o'clock, no man or woman ever once in all his life inquired the way to such and such a place, of Scrooge. Even the blind men's dogs appeared to know him; and when they saw him coming on, would tug their owners into doorways and up courts; and then would wag their tails as though they said, "No eye at all is better than an evil eye, dark master!"

But what did Scrooge care! It was the very thing he liked. To edge his way along the crowded paths of life, warning all human sympathy to keep its distance, was what the knowing ones call "nuts" to Scrooge.

Once upon a time—of all the good days in the year, on Christmas Eve—old Scrooge sat busy in his counting-house. It was cold, bleak, biting weather: foggy withal: and he could hear the people in the court outside, go wheezing up and down, beating their hands upon their breasts, and stamping their feet upon the pavement stones to warm them. The city clocks had only just gone three, but it was quite dark already— it had not been light all day—and candles were flaring in the windows of the neighbouring offices, like ruddy smears upon the palpable brown air. The fog came pouring in at every chink and keyhole, and was so dense without, that

although the court was of the narrowest, the houses opposite were mere phantoms. To see the dingy cloud come drooping down, obscuring everything, one might have thought that Nature lived hard by, and was brewing on a large scale.

The door of Scrooge's counting-house was open that he might keep his eye upon his clerk, who in a dismal little cell beyond, a sort of tank, was copying letters. Scrooge had a very small fire, but the clerk's fire was so very much smaller that it looked like one coal. But he couldn't replenish it, for Scrooge kept the coal-box in his own room; and so surely as the clerk came in with the shovel, the master predicted that it would be necessary for them to part. Wherefore the clerk put on his white comforter, and tried to warm himself at the candle; in which effort, not being a man of a strong imagination, he failed.

"A merry Christmas, uncle! God save you!" cried a cheerful voice. It was the voice of Scrooge's nephew, who came upon him so quickly that this was the first intimation he had of his approach.

"Bah!" said Scrooge, "Humbug!"

He had so heated himself with rapid walking in the fog and frost, this nephew of Scrooge's, that he was all in a glow; his face was ruddy and handsome; his eyes sparkled, and his breath smoked again.

"Christmas a humbug, uncle!" said Scrooge's nephew. "You don't mean that, I am sure?"

"I do," said Scrooge. "Merry Christmas! What right have you to be merry? What reason have you to be merry? You're poor enough."

"Come, then," returned the nephew gaily. "What right have you to be dismal? What reason have you to be morose? You're rich enough."

Scrooge having no better answer ready on the spur of the moment, said, "Bah!" again; and followed it up with "Humbug."

"Don't be cross, uncle!" said the nephew.

"What else can I be," returned the uncle, "when I live in such a world of fools as this? Merry Christmas! Out upon merry Christmas! What's Christmas time to you but a time for paying bills without money; a time for finding yourself a year older, but not an hour richer; a time for balancing your books and having every item in 'em through a round dozen of months presented dead against you? If I could work my will," said Scrooge indignantly, "every idiot who goes about with 'Merry Christmas' on his lips, should be boiled with his own pudding, and buried with a stake of holly through his heart. He should!"

"Uncle!" pleaded the nephew.

"Nephew!" returned the uncle sternly, "keep Christmas in your own way, and let me keep it in mine."

"Keep it!" repeated Scrooge's nephew. "But you don't keep it."

"Let me leave it alone, then," said Scrooge. "Much good may it do you! Much good it has ever done you!"

"There are many things from which I might have derived good, by which I have not profited, I dare say," returned the nephew. "Christmas among the rest. But I am sure I have always thought of Christmas time, when it has come round—apart from the veneration due to its sacred name and origin, if anything belonging to it can be apart from that—as a good time; a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time; the only time I know of, in the long calendar of the year, when men and women seem by one consent to open their shut-up hearts freely, and to think of people below them as if they really were fellow-passengers to the grave, and not another race of creatures bound on other journeys. And therefore, uncle, though it has never put a scrap of gold or silver in my pocket, I believe that it has done me good, and will do me good; and I say, God bless it!"

The clerk in the Tank involuntarily applauded. Becoming immediately sensible of the impropriety, he poked the fire, and extinguished the last frail spark for ever.

"Let me hear another sound from you," said Scrooge, "and you'll keep your Christmas by losing your situation! You're quite a powerful speaker, sir," he added, turning to his nephew. "I wonder you don't go into Parliament."

"Don't be angry, uncle. Come! Dine with us to-morrow."

Scrooge said that he would see him—yes, indeed he did. He went the whole length of the expression, and said that he would see him in that extremity first.

"But why?" cried Scrooge's nephew. "Why?"

"Why did you get married?" said Scrooge.

"Because I fell in love."

"Because you fell in love!" growled Scrooge, as if that were the only one thing in the world more ridiculous than a merry Christmas. "Good afternoon!"

"Nay, uncle, but you never came to see me before that happened. Why give it as a reason for not coming now?"

"Good afternoon," said Scrooge.

"I want nothing from you; I ask nothing of you; why cannot we be friends?"

"Good afternoon," said Scrooge.

"I am sorry, with all my heart, to find you so resolute. We have never had any quarrel, to which I have been a party. But I have made the trial in homage to Christmas, and I'll keep my Christmas humour to the last. So A Merry Christmas, uncle!"

"Good afternoon!" said Scrooge.

"And A Happy New Year!"

"Good afternoon!" said Scrooge.

His nephew left the room without an angry word, notwithstanding. He stopped at the outer door to bestow the greetings of the season on the clerk, who, cold as he was, was warmer than Scrooge; for he returned them cordially.

"There's another fellow," muttered Scrooge; who overheard him: "my clerk, with fifteen shillings a week, and a wife and family, talking about a merry Christmas. I'll retire to Bedlam."

This lunatic, in letting Scrooge's nephew out, had let two other people in. They were portly gentlemen, pleasant to behold, and now stood, with their hats off, in Scrooge's office. They had books and papers in their hands, and bowed to him.

"Scrooge and Marley's, I believe," said one of the gentlemen, referring to his list. "Have I the pleasure of addressing Mr. Scrooge, or Mr. Marley?"

"Mr. Marley has been dead these seven years," Scrooge replied. "He died seven years ago, this very night."

"We have no doubt his liberality is well represented by his surviving partner," said the gentleman, presenting his credentials.

It certainly was; for they had been two kindred spirits. At the ominous word "liberality," Scrooge frowned, and shook his head, and handed the credentials back.

"At this festive season of the year, Mr. Scrooge," said the gentleman, taking up a pen, "it is more than usually desirable that we should make some slight provision for the Poor and destitute, who suffer greatly at the present time. Many thousands are in want of common necessaries; hundreds of thousands are in want of common comforts, sir."

"Are there no prisons?" asked Scrooge.

"Plenty of prisons," said the gentleman, laying down the pen again.

"And the Union workhouses?" demanded Scrooge. "Are they still in operation?"

"They are. Still," returned the gentleman, "I wish I could say they were not."

"The Treadmill and the Poor Law are in full vigour, then?" said Scrooge.

"Both very busy, sir."

"Oh! I was afraid, from what you said at first, that something had occurred to stop them in their useful course," said Scrooge. "I'm very glad to hear it."

"Under the impression that they scarcely furnish Christian cheer of mind or body to the multitude," returned the gentleman, "a few of us are endeavouring to raise a fund to buy the Poor some meat and drink, and means of warmth. We choose this time, because it is a time, of all others, when Want is keenly felt, and Abundance rejoices. What shall I put you down for?"

"Nothing!" Scrooge replied.

"You wish to be anonymous?"

"I wish to be left alone," said Scrooge. "Since you ask me what I wish, gentlemen, that is my answer. I don't make merry myself at Christmas and I can't afford to make idle people merry. I help to support the establishments I have mentioned—they cost enough; and those who are badly off must go there."

"Many can't go there; and many would rather die."

"If they would rather die," said Scrooge, "they had better do it, and decrease the surplus population. Besides—excuse me—I don't know that."

"But you might know it," observed the gentleman.

"It's not my business," Scrooge returned. "It's enough for a man to understand his own business, and not to interfere with other people's. Mine occupies me constantly. Good afternoon, gentlemen!"

Seeing clearly that it would be useless to pursue their point, the gentlemen withdrew. Scrooge resumed his labours with an improved opinion of himself, and in a more facetious temper than was usual with him.

Meanwhile the fog and darkness thickened so, that people ran about with flaring links, proffering their services to go before horses in carriages, and conduct them on their way. The ancient tower of a church, whose gruff old bell was always peeping slily down at Scrooge out of a Gothic window in the wall, became invisible, and struck the hours and quarters in the clouds, with tremulous vibrations afterwards as if its teeth were chattering in its frozen head

up there. The cold became intense. In the main street, at the corner of the court, some labourers were repairing the gas-pipes, and had lighted a great fire in a brazier, round which a party of ragged men and boys were gathered: warming their hands and winking their eyes before the blaze in rapture. The water-plug being left in solitude, its overflowings sullenly congealed, and turned to misanthropic ice. The brightness of the shops where holly sprigs and berries crackled in the lamp heat of the windows, made pale faces ruddy as they passed. Poulterers' and grocers' trades became a splendid joke: a glorious pageant, with which it was next to impossible to believe that such dull principles as bargain and sale had anything to do. The Lord Mayor, in the stronghold of the mighty Mansion House, gave orders to his fifty cooks and butlers to keep Christmas as a Lord Mayor's household should; and even the little tailor, whom he had fined five shillings on the previous Monday for being drunk and bloodthirsty in the streets, stirred up to-morrow's pudding in his garret, while his lean wife and the baby sallied out to buy the beef.

Foggier yet, and colder. Piercing, searching, biting cold. If the good Saint Dunstan had but nipped the Evil Spirit's nose with a touch of such weather as that, instead of using his familiar weapons, then indeed he would have roared to lusty purpose. The owner of one scant young nose, gnawed and mumbled by the hungry cold as bones are gnawed by dogs, stooped down at Scrooge's keyhole to regale him with a Christmas carol: but at the first sound of

"God bless you, merry gentleman! May nothing you dismay!"

Scrooge seized the ruler with such energy of action, that the singer fled in terror, leaving the keyhole to the fog and even more congenial frost.

At length the hour of shutting up the counting-house arrived. With an ill-will Scrooge dismounted from his stool, and tacitly admitted the fact to the expectant clerk in the Tank, who instantly snuffed his candle out, and put on his hat.

"You'll want all day to-morrow, I suppose?" said Scrooge.

"If quite convenient, sir."

"It's not convenient," said Scrooge, "and it's not fair. If I was to stop half-a-crown for it, you'd think yourself ill-used, I'll be bound?"

The clerk smiled faintly.

"And yet," said Scrooge, "you don't think me ill-used, when I pay a day's wages for no work."

The clerk observed that it was only once a year.

"A poor excuse for picking a man's pocket every twenty-fifth of December!" said Scrooge, buttoning his great-coat to the chin. "But I suppose you must have the whole day. Be here all the earlier next morning."

The clerk promised that he would; and Scrooge walked out with a growl. The office was closed in a twinkling, and the clerk, with the long ends of his white comforter dangling below his waist (for he boasted no great-coat), went down a slide on Cornhill, at the end of a lane of boys, twenty times, in honour of its being Christmas Eve, and then ran home to Camden Town as hard as he could pelt, to play at blindman's-buff.

Scrooge took his melancholy dinner in his usual melancholy tavern; and having read all the newspapers, and beguiled the rest of the evening with his banker's-book, went home to bed. He lived in chambers which had once belonged to his deceased partner. They were a gloomy suite of rooms, in a lowering pile of building up a yard, where it had so little business to be, that one could scarcely help fancying it must have run there when it was a young house, playing at hide-and-seek with other houses, and forgotten the way out again. It was old enough now, and dreary enough, for nobody lived in it but Scrooge, the other rooms being all let out as offices. The yard was so dark that even Scrooge, who knew its every stone, was fain to grope with his hands. The fog and frost so hung about the black old gateway of the house, that it seemed as if the Genius of the Weather sat in mournful meditation on the threshold.

STAVE ONE, CONTINUED

Marley's Ghost

WORDS TO KNOW

apparition	A ghost or ghostlike figure.
incredulous	Unable or unwilling to believe something.
spectre	A ghost (British spelling).
fetter	A chain or shackle for the ankles.
ponderous	Very heavy and slow-moving.
penance	Suffering accepted to make up for wrongdoing.
benevolence	Kindness; the wish to do good for others.

Now, it is a fact, that there was nothing at all particular about the knocker on the door, except that it was very large. It is also a fact, that Scrooge had seen it, night and morning, during his whole residence in that place; also that Scrooge had as little of what is called fancy about him as any man in the city of London, even including—which is a bold word—the corporation, aldermen, and livery. Let it also be borne in mind that Scrooge had not bestowed one thought on Marley, since his last mention of his seven years' dead partner that afternoon. And then let any man explain to me, if he can, how it happened that Scrooge, having his key in the lock of the door, saw in the knocker, without its undergoing any intermediate process of change—not a knocker, but Marley's face.

Marley's face. It was not in impenetrable shadow as the other objects in the yard were, but had a dismal light about it, like a bad lobster in a dark cellar. It was not angry or ferocious, but looked at Scrooge as Marley used to look: with ghostly spectacles turned up on its ghostly forehead. The hair was curiously stirred, as if by breath or hot air; and, though the eyes were wide open, they were perfectly motionless. That, and its livid colour, made it horrible; but its horror seemed to be in spite of the face and beyond its control, rather than a part of its own expression.

As Scrooge looked fixedly at this phenomenon, it was a knocker again.

To say that he was not startled, or that his blood was not conscious of a terrible sensation to which it had been a stranger from infancy, would be untrue. But he put his hand upon the key he had relinquished, turned it sturdily, walked in, and lighted his candle.

He did pause, with a moment's irresolution, before he shut the door; and he did look cautiously behind it first, as if he half expected to be terrified with the sight of Marley's pigtail sticking out into the hall. But there was nothing on the back of the door, except the screws and nuts that held the knocker on, so he said "Pooh, pooh!" and closed it with a bang.

The sound resounded through the house like thunder. Every room above, and every cask in the wine-merchant's cellars below, appeared to have a separate peal of echoes of its own. Scrooge was not a man to be frightened by echoes. He fastened the door, and walked across the hall, and up the stairs; slowly too: trimming his candle as he went.

You may talk vaguely about driving a coach-and-six up a good old flight of stairs, or through a bad young Act of Parliament; but I mean to say you might have got a hearse up that staircase, and taken it broadwise, with the splinter-bar towards the wall and the door towards the balustrades: and done it easy. There was plenty of width for that, and room to spare; which is perhaps the reason why Scrooge thought he saw a locomotive hearse going on before him in the gloom. Half-a-dozen gas-lamps out of the street wouldn't have lighted the entry too well, so you may suppose that it was pretty dark with Scrooge's dip.

Up Scrooge went, not caring a button for that. Darkness is cheap, and Scrooge liked it. But before he shut his heavy door, he walked through his rooms to see that all was right. He had just enough recollection of the face to desire to do that.

Sitting-room, bedroom, lumber-room. All as they should be. Nobody under the table, nobody under the sofa; a small fire in the grate; spoon and basin ready; and the little saucepan of gruel (Scrooge had a cold in his head) upon the hob. Nobody under the bed; nobody in the closet; nobody in his dressing-gown, which was hanging up in a suspicious attitude against the wall. Lumber-room as usual. Old fire-guard, old shoes, two fish-baskets, washing-stand on three legs, and a poker.

Quite satisfied, he closed his door, and locked himself in; double-locked himself in, which was not his custom. Thus secured against surprise, he took off his cravat; put on his dressing-gown and slippers, and his nightcap; and sat down before the fire to take his gruel.

It was a very low fire indeed; nothing on such a bitter night. He was obliged to sit close to it, and brood over it, before he could extract the least sensation of warmth from such a handful of fuel. The fireplace was an old one, built by some Dutch merchant long ago, and paved all round with quaint Dutch tiles, designed to illustrate the Scriptures. There were Cains and Abels, Pharaoh's daughters; Queens of Sheba, Angelic messengers descending through the air on clouds like feather-beds, Abrahams, Belshazzars, Apostles putting off to sea in butter-boats, hundreds of figures to attract his thoughts; and yet that face of Marley, seven years dead, came like the ancient Prophet's rod, and swallowed up the whole. If each smooth

tile had been a blank at first, with power to shape some picture on its surface from the disjointed fragments of his thoughts, there would have been a copy of old Marley's head on every one.

"Humbug!" said Scrooge; and walked across the room.

After several turns, he sat down again. As he threw his head back in the chair, his glance happened to rest upon a bell, a disused bell, that hung in the room, and communicated for some purpose now forgotten with a chamber in the highest story of the building. It was with great astonishment, and with a strange, inexplicable dread, that as he looked, he saw this bell begin to swing. It swung so softly in the outset that it scarcely made a sound; but soon it rang out loudly, and so did every bell in the house.

This might have lasted half a minute, or a minute, but it seemed an hour. The bells ceased as they had begun, together. They were succeeded by a clanking noise, deep down below; as if some person were dragging a heavy chain over the casks in the wine-merchant's cellar. Scrooge then remembered to have heard that ghosts in haunted houses were described as dragging chains.

The cellar-door flew open with a booming sound, and then he heard the noise much louder, on the floors below; then coming up the stairs; then coming straight towards his door.

"It's humbug still!" said Scrooge. "I won't believe it."

His colour changed though, when, without a pause, it came on through the heavy door, and passed into the room before his eyes. Upon its coming in, the dying flame leaped up, as though it cried, "I know him; Marley's Ghost!" and fell again.

The same face: the very same. Marley in his pigtail, usual waistcoat, tights and boots; the tassels on the latter bristling, like his pigtail, and his coat-skirts, and the hair upon his head. The chain he drew was clasped about his middle. It was long, and wound about him like a tail; and it was made (for Scrooge observed it closely) of cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds, and heavy purses wrought in steel. His body was transparent; so that Scrooge, observing him, and looking through his waistcoat, could see the two buttons on his coat behind.

Scrooge had often heard it said that Marley had no bowels, but he had never believed it until now.

No, nor did he believe it even now. Though he looked the phantom through and through, and saw it standing before him; though he felt the chilling influence of its death-cold eyes; and marked the very texture of the folded kerchief bound about its head and chin, which wrapper he had not observed before; he was still incredulous, and fought against his senses.

"How now!" said Scrooge, caustic and cold as ever. "What do you want with me?"

"Much!"—Marley's voice, no doubt about it.

"Who are you?"

"Ask me who I was."

"Who were you then?" said Scrooge, raising his voice. "You're particular, for a shade." He was going to say "to a shade," but substituted this, as more appropriate.

"In life I was your partner, Jacob Marley."

"Can you—can you sit down?" asked Scrooge, looking doubtfully at him.

"I can."

"Do it, then."

Scrooge asked the question, because he didn't know whether a ghost so transparent might find himself in a condition to take a chair; and felt that in the event of its being impossible, it might involve the necessity of an embarrassing explanation. But the ghost sat down on the opposite side of the fireplace, as if he were quite used to it.

"You don't believe in me," observed the Ghost.

"I don't," said Scrooge.

"What evidence would you have of my reality beyond that of your senses?"

"I don't know," said Scrooge.

"Why do you doubt your senses?"

"Because," said Scrooge, "a little thing affects them. A slight disorder of the stomach makes them cheats. You may be an undigested bit of beef, a blot of mustard, a crumb of cheese, a fragment of an underdone potato. There's more of gravy than of grave about you, whatever you are!"

Scrooge was not much in the habit of cracking jokes, nor did he feel, in his heart, by any means waggish then. The truth is, that he tried to be smart, as a means of distracting his own attention, and keeping down his terror; for the spectre's voice disturbed the very marrow in his bones.

To sit, staring at those fixed glazed eyes, in silence for a moment, would play, Scrooge felt, the very deuce with him. There was something very awful, too, in the spectre's being provided with an infernal atmosphere of its own. Scrooge could not feel it himself, but this was clearly

the case; for though the Ghost sat perfectly motionless, its hair, and skirts, and tassels, were still agitated as by the hot vapour from an oven.

"You see this toothpick?" said Scrooge, returning quickly to the charge, for the reason just assigned; and wishing, though it were only for a second, to divert the vision's stony gaze from himself.

"I do," replied the Ghost.

"You are not looking at it," said Scrooge.

"But I see it," said the Ghost, "notwithstanding."

"Well!" returned Scrooge, "I have but to swallow this, and be for the rest of my days persecuted by a legion of goblins, all of my own creation. Humbug, I tell you! humbug!"

At this the spirit raised a frightful cry, and shook its chain with such a dismal and appalling noise, that Scrooge held on tight to his chair, to save himself from falling in a swoon. But how much greater was his horror, when the phantom taking off the bandage round its head, as if it were too warm to wear indoors, its lower jaw dropped down upon its breast!

Scrooge fell upon his knees, and clasped his hands before his face.

"Mercy!" he said. "Dreadful apparition, why do you trouble me?"

"Man of the worldly mind!" replied the Ghost, "do you believe in me or not?"

"I do," said Scrooge. "I must. But why do spirits walk the earth, and why do they come to me?"

"It is required of every man," the Ghost returned, "that the spirit within him should walk abroad among his fellowmen, and travel far and wide; and if that spirit goes not forth in life, it is condemned to do so after death. It is doomed to wander through the world—oh, woe is me!—and witness what it cannot share, but might have shared on earth, and turned to happiness!"

Again the spectre raised a cry, and shook its chain and wrung its shadowy hands.

"You are fettered," said Scrooge, trembling. "Tell me why?"

"I wear the chain I forged in life," replied the Ghost. "I made it link by link, and yard by yard; I girded it on of my own free will, and of my own free will I wore it. Is its pattern strange to you?"

Scrooge trembled more and more.

"Or would you know," pursued the Ghost, "the weight and length of the strong coil you bear yourself? It was full as heavy and as long as this, seven Christmas Eves ago. You have laboured on it, since. It is a ponderous chain!"

Scrooge glanced about him on the floor, in the expectation of finding himself surrounded by some fifty or sixty fathoms of iron cable: but he could see nothing.

"Jacob," he said, imploringly. "Old Jacob Marley, tell me more. Speak comfort to me, Jacob!"

"I have none to give," the Ghost replied. "It comes from other regions, Ebenezer Scrooge, and is conveyed by other ministers, to other kinds of men. Nor can I tell you what I would. A very little more is all permitted to me. I cannot rest, I cannot stay, I cannot linger anywhere. My spirit never walked beyond our counting-house—mark me!—in life my spirit never roved beyond the narrow limits of our money-changing hole; and weary journeys lie before me!"

It was a habit with Scrooge, whenever he became thoughtful, to put his hands in his breeches pockets. Pondering on what the Ghost had said, he did so now, but without lifting up his eyes, or getting off his knees.

"You must have been very slow about it, Jacob," Scrooge observed, in a business-like manner, though with humility and deference.

"Slow!" the Ghost repeated.

"Seven years dead," mused Scrooge. "And travelling all the time!"

"The whole time," said the Ghost. "No rest, no peace. Incessant torture of remorse."

"You travel fast?" said Scrooge.

"On the wings of the wind," replied the Ghost.

"You might have got over a great quantity of ground in seven years," said Scrooge.

The Ghost, on hearing this, set up another cry, and clanked its chain so hideously in the dead silence of the night, that the Ward would have been justified in indicting it for a nuisance.

"Oh! captive, bound, and double-ironed," cried the phantom, "not to know, that ages of incessant labour by immortal creatures, for this earth must pass into eternity before the good of which it is susceptible is all developed. Not to know that any Christian spirit working kindly in its little sphere, whatever it may be, will find its mortal life too short for its vast means of usefulness. Not to know that no space of regret can make amends for one life's opportunity misused! Yet such was I! Oh! such was I!"

"But you were always a good man of business, Jacob," faltered Scrooge, who now began to apply this to himself.

"Business!" cried the Ghost, wringing its hands again. "Mankind was my business. The common welfare was my business; charity, mercy, forbearance, and benevolence, were, all, my business. The dealings of my trade were but a drop of water in the comprehensive ocean of my business!"

It held up its chain at arm's length, as if that were the cause of all its unavailing grief, and flung it heavily upon the ground again.

"At this time of the rolling year," the spectre said, "I suffer most. Why did I walk through crowds of fellow-beings with my eyes turned down, and never raise them to that blessed Star which led the Wise Men to a poor abode! Were there no poor homes to which its light would have conducted me!"

Scrooge was very much dismayed to hear the spectre going on at this rate, and began to quake exceedingly.

"Hear me!" cried the Ghost. "My time is nearly gone."

"I will," said Scrooge. "But don't be hard upon me! Don't be flowery, Jacob! Pray!"

"How it is that I appear before you in a shape that you can see, I may not tell. I have sat invisible beside you many and many a day."

It was not an agreeable idea. Scrooge shivered, and wiped the perspiration from his brow.

"That is no light part of my penance," pursued the Ghost. "I am here to-night to warn you, that you have yet a chance and hope of escaping my fate. A chance and hope of my procuring, Ebenezer."

"You were always a good friend to me," said Scrooge. "Thank'ee!"

"You will be haunted," resumed the Ghost, "by Three Spirits."

Scrooge's countenance fell almost as low as the Ghost's had done.

"Is that the chance and hope you mentioned, Jacob?" he demanded, in a faltering voice.

"It is."

"I—I think I'd rather not," said Scrooge.

"Without their visits," said the Ghost, "you cannot hope to shun the path I tread. Expect the first to-morrow, when the bell tolls One."

"Couldn't I take 'em all at once, and have it over, Jacob?" hinted Scrooge.

"Expect the second on the next night at the same hour. The third upon the next night when the last stroke of Twelve has ceased to vibrate. Look to see me no more; and look that, for your own sake, you remember what has passed between us!"

When it had said these words, the spectre took its wrapper from the table, and bound it round its head, as before. Scrooge knew this, by the smart sound its teeth made, when the jaws were brought together by the bandage. He ventured to raise his eyes again, and found his supernatural visitor confronting him in an erect attitude, with its chain wound over and about its arm.

The apparition walked backward from him; and at every step it took, the window raised itself a little, so that when the spectre reached it, it was wide open.

It beckoned Scrooge to approach, which he did. When they were within two paces of each other, Marley's Ghost held up its hand, warning him to come no nearer. Scrooge stopped.

Not so much in obedience, as in surprise and fear: for on the raising of the hand, he became sensible of confused noises in the air; incoherent sounds of lamentation and regret; wailings inexpressibly sorrowful and self-accusatory. The spectre, after listening for a moment, joined in the mournful dirge; and floated out upon the bleak, dark night.

Scrooge followed to the window: desperate in his curiosity. He looked out.

The air was filled with phantoms, wandering hither and thither in restless haste, and moaning as they went. Every one of them wore chains like Marley's Ghost; some few (they might be guilty governments) were linked together; none were free. Many had been personally known to Scrooge in their lives. He had been quite familiar with one old ghost, in a white waistcoat, with a monstrous iron safe attached to its ankle, who cried piteously at being unable to assist a wretched woman with an infant, whom it saw below, upon a door-step. The misery with them all was, clearly, that they sought to interfere, for good, in human matters, and had lost the power for ever.

Whether these creatures faded into mist, or mist enshrouded them, he could not tell. But they and their spirit voices faded together; and the night became as it had been when he walked home.

Scrooge closed the window, and examined the door by which the Ghost had entered. It was double-locked, as he had locked it with his own hands, and the bolts were undisturbed. He tried to say "Humbug!" but stopped at the first syllable. And being, from the emotion he had undergone, or the fatigues of the day, or his glimpse of the Invisible World, or the dull conversation of the Ghost, or the lateness of the hour, much in need of repose; went straight

to bed, without undressing, and fell asleep upon the instant.

STAVE TWO

The First of the Three Spirits

WORDS TO KNOW

recollection	A memory.
apprentice	A young person learning a trade by working for a skilled master.
jovial	Cheerful and friendly.
idol	Something loved or worshipped too much.
dowerless	Without a dowry, the money or property a bride once brought to a marriage.
relentless	Never stopping or letting up.
melancholy	Sad and thoughtful.

WHEN Scrooge awoke, it was so dark, that looking out of bed, he could scarcely distinguish the transparent window from the opaque walls of his chamber. He was endeavouring to pierce the darkness with his ferret eyes, when the chimes of a neighbouring church struck the four quarters. So he listened for the hour.

To his great astonishment the heavy bell went on from six to seven, and from seven to eight, and regularly up to twelve; then stopped. Twelve! It was past two when he went to bed. The clock was wrong. An icicle must have got into the works. Twelve!

He touched the spring of his repeater, to correct this most preposterous clock. Its rapid little pulse beat twelve: and stopped.

“Why, it isn’t possible,” said Scrooge, “that I can have slept through a whole day and far into another night. It isn’t possible that anything has happened to the sun, and this is twelve at noon!”

The idea being an alarming one, he scrambled out of bed, and groped his way to the window. He was obliged to rub the frost off with the sleeve of his dressing-gown before he could see anything; and could see very little then. All he could make out was, that it was still very foggy and extremely cold, and that there was no noise of people running to and fro, and making a great stir, as there unquestionably would have been if night had beaten off bright day, and taken possession of the world. This was a great relief, because “three days after sight of this First of Exchange pay to Mr. Ebenezer Scrooge or his order,” and so forth, would

have become a mere United States' security if there were no days to count by.

Scrooge went to bed again, and thought, and thought, and thought it over and over and over, and could make nothing of it. The more he thought, the more perplexed he was; and the more he endeavoured not to think, the more he thought.

Marley's Ghost bothered him exceedingly. Every time he resolved within himself, after mature inquiry, that it was all a dream, his mind flew back again, like a strong spring released, to its first position, and presented the same problem to be worked all through, "Was it a dream or not?"

Scrooge lay in this state until the chime had gone three quarters more, when he remembered, on a sudden, that the Ghost had warned him of a visitation when the bell tolled one. He resolved to lie awake until the hour was passed; and, considering that he could no more go to sleep than go to Heaven, this was perhaps the wisest resolution in his power.

The quarter was so long, that he was more than once convinced he must have sunk into a doze unconsciously, and missed the clock. At length it broke upon his listening ear.

"Ding, dong!"

"A quarter past," said Scrooge, counting.

"Ding, dong!"

"Half-past!" said Scrooge.

"Ding, dong!"

"A quarter to it," said Scrooge.

"Ding, dong!"

"The hour itself," said Scrooge, triumphantly, "and nothing else!"

He spoke before the hour bell sounded, which it now did with a deep, dull, hollow, melancholy ONE. Light flashed up in the room upon the instant, and the curtains of his bed were drawn.

The curtains of his bed were drawn aside, I tell you, by a hand. Not the curtains at his feet, nor the curtains at his back, but those to which his face was addressed. The curtains of his bed were drawn aside; and Scrooge, starting up into a half-recumbent attitude, found himself face to face with the unearthly visitor who drew them: as close to it as I am now to you, and I am standing in the spirit at your elbow.

It was a strange figure—like a child: yet not so like a child as like an old man, viewed through some supernatural medium, which gave him the appearance of having receded from the view, and being diminished to a child's proportions. Its hair, which hung about its neck and down its back, was white as if with age; and yet the face had not a wrinkle in it, and the tenderest bloom was on the skin. The arms were very long and muscular; the hands the same, as if its hold were of uncommon strength. Its legs and feet, most delicately formed, were, like those upper members, bare. It wore a tunic of the purest white; and round its waist was bound a lustrous belt, the sheen of which was beautiful. It held a branch of fresh green holly in its hand; and, in singular contradiction of that wintry emblem, had its dress trimmed with summer flowers. But the strangest thing about it was, that from the crown of its head there sprung a bright clear jet of light, by which all this was visible; and which was doubtless the occasion of its using, in its duller moments, a great extinguisher for a cap, which it now held under its arm.

Even this, though, when Scrooge looked at it with increasing steadiness, was not its strangest quality. For as its belt sparkled and glittered now in one part and now in another, and what was light one instant, at another time was dark, so the figure itself fluctuated in its distinctness: being now a thing with one arm, now with one leg, now with twenty legs, now a pair of legs without a head, now a head without a body: of which dissolving parts, no outline would be visible in the dense gloom wherein they melted away. And in the very wonder of this, it would be itself again; distinct and clear as ever.

"Are you the Spirit, sir, whose coming was foretold to me?" asked Scrooge.

"I am!"

The voice was soft and gentle. Singularly low, as if instead of being so close beside him, it were at a distance.

"Who, and what are you?" Scrooge demanded.

"I am the Ghost of Christmas Past."

"Long Past?" inquired Scrooge: observant of its dwarfish stature.

"No. Your past."

Perhaps, Scrooge could not have told anybody why, if anybody could have asked him; but he had a special desire to see the Spirit in his cap; and begged him to be covered.

"What!" exclaimed the Ghost, "would you so soon put out, with worldly hands, the light I give? Is it not enough that you are one of those whose passions made this cap, and force me through whole trains of years to wear it low upon my brow!"

Scrooge reverently disclaimed all intention to offend or any knowledge of having wilfully "bonneted" the Spirit at any period of his life. He then made bold to inquire what business brought him there.

"Your welfare!" said the Ghost.

Scrooge expressed himself much obliged, but could not help thinking that a night of unbroken rest would have been more conducive to that end. The Spirit must have heard him thinking, for it said immediately:

"Your reclamation, then. Take heed!"

It put out its strong hand as it spoke, and clasped him gently by the arm.

"Rise! and walk with me!"

It would have been in vain for Scrooge to plead that the weather and the hour were not adapted to pedestrian purposes; that bed was warm, and the thermometer a long way below freezing; that he was clad but lightly in his slippers, dressing-gown, and nightcap; and that he had a cold upon him at that time. The grasp, though gentle as a woman's hand, was not to be resisted. He rose: but finding that the Spirit made towards the window, clasped his robe in supplication.

"I am a mortal," Scrooge remonstrated, "and liable to fall."

"Bear but a touch of my hand there," said the Spirit, laying it upon his heart, "and you shall be upheld in more than this!"

As the words were spoken, they passed through the wall, and stood upon an open country road, with fields on either hand. The city had entirely vanished. Not a vestige of it was to be seen. The darkness and the mist had vanished with it, for it was a clear, cold, winter day, with snow upon the ground.

"Good Heaven!" said Scrooge, clasping his hands together, as he looked about him. "I was bred in this place. I was a boy here!"

The Spirit gazed upon him mildly. Its gentle touch, though it had been light and instantaneous, appeared still present to the old man's sense of feeling. He was conscious of a thousand odours floating in the air, each one connected with a thousand thoughts, and hopes, and joys, and cares long, long, forgotten!

"Your lip is trembling," said the Ghost. "And what is that upon your cheek?"

Scrooge muttered, with an unusual catching in his voice, that it was a pimple; and begged the Ghost to lead him where he would.

"You recollect the way?" inquired the Spirit.

"Remember it!" cried Scrooge with fervour; "I could walk it blindfold."

"Strange to have forgotten it for so many years!" observed the Ghost. "Let us go on."

They walked along the road, Scrooge recognising every gate, and post, and tree; until a little market-town appeared in the distance, with its bridge, its church, and winding river. Some shaggy ponies now were seen trotting towards them with boys upon their backs, who called to other boys in country gigs and carts, driven by farmers. All these boys were in great spirits, and shouted to each other, until the broad fields were so full of merry music, that the crisp air laughed to hear it!

"These are but shadows of the things that have been," said the Ghost. "They have no consciousness of us."

The jocund travellers came on; and as they came, Scrooge knew and named them every one. Why was he rejoiced beyond all bounds to see them! Why did his cold eye glisten, and his heart leap up as they went past! Why was he filled with gladness when he heard them give each other Merry Christmas, as they parted at cross-roads and bye-ways, for their several homes! What was merry Christmas to Scrooge? Out upon merry Christmas! What good had it ever done to him?

"The school is not quite deserted," said the Ghost. "A solitary child, neglected by his friends, is left there still."

Scrooge said he knew it. And he sobbed.

They left the high-road, by a well-remembered lane, and soon approached a mansion of dull red brick, with a little weathercock-surmounted cupola, on the roof, and a bell hanging in it. It was a large house, but one of broken fortunes; for the spacious offices were little used, their walls were damp and mossy, their windows broken, and their gates decayed. Fowls clucked and strutted in the stables; and the coach-houses and sheds were over-run with grass. Nor was it more retentive of its ancient state, within; for entering the dreary hall, and glancing through the open doors of many rooms, they found them poorly furnished, cold, and vast. There was an earthy savour in the air, a chilly bareness in the place, which associated itself somehow with too much getting up by candle-light, and not too much to eat.

They went, the Ghost and Scrooge, across the hall, to a door at the back of the house. It opened before them, and disclosed a long, bare, melancholy room, made barer still by lines of plain deal forms and desks. At one of these a lonely boy was reading near a feeble fire; and Scrooge sat down upon a form, and wept to see his poor forgotten self as he used to be.

Not a latent echo in the house, not a squeak and scuffle from the mice behind the panelling, not a drip from the half-thawed water-spout in the dull yard behind, not a sigh among the leafless boughs of one despondent poplar, not the idle swinging of an empty store-house door, no, not a clicking in the fire, but fell upon the heart of Scrooge with a softening influence, and gave a freer passage to his tears.

The Spirit touched him on the arm, and pointed to his younger self, intent upon his reading. Suddenly a man, in foreign garments: wonderfully real and distinct to look at: stood outside the window, with an axe stuck in his belt, and leading by the bridle an ass laden with wood.

"Why, it's Ali Baba!" Scrooge exclaimed in ecstasy. "It's dear old honest Ali Baba! Yes, yes, I know! One Christmas time, when yonder solitary child was left here all alone, he did come, for the first time, just like that. Poor boy! And Valentine," said Scrooge, "and his wild brother, Orson; there they go! And what's his name, who was put down in his drawers, asleep, at the Gate of Damascus; don't you see him! And the Sultan's Groom turned upside down by the Genii; there he is upon his head! Serve him right. I'm glad of it. What business had he to be married to the Princess!"

To hear Scrooge expending all the earnestness of his nature on such subjects, in a most extraordinary voice between laughing and crying; and to see his heightened and excited face; would have been a surprise to his business friends in the city, indeed.

"There's the Parrot!" cried Scrooge. "Green body and yellow tail, with a thing like a lettuce growing out of the top of his head; there he is! Poor Robin Crusoe, he called him, when he came home again after sailing round the island. 'Poor Robin Crusoe, where have you been, Robin Crusoe?' The man thought he was dreaming, but he wasn't. It was the Parrot, you know. There goes Friday, running for his life to the little creek! Halloa! Hoop! Halloo!"

Then, with a rapidity of transition very foreign to his usual character, he said, in pity for his former self, "Poor boy!" and cried again.

"I wish," Scrooge muttered, putting his hand in his pocket, and looking about him, after drying his eyes with his cuff: "but it's too late now."

"What is the matter?" asked the Spirit.

"Nothing," said Scrooge. "Nothing. There was a boy singing a Christmas Carol at my door last night. I should like to have given him something: that's all."

The Ghost smiled thoughtfully, and waved its hand: saying as it did so, "Let us see another Christmas!"

Scrooge's former self grew larger at the words, and the room became a little darker and more dirty. The panels shrunk, the windows cracked; fragments of plaster fell out of the ceiling, and the naked laths were shown instead; but how all this was brought about, Scrooge knew no more than you do. He only knew that it was quite correct; that everything had happened so; that there he was, alone again, when all the other boys had gone home for the jolly holidays.

He was not reading now, but walking up and down despairingly. Scrooge looked at the Ghost, and with a mournful shaking of his head, glanced anxiously towards the door.

It opened; and a little girl, much younger than the boy, came darting in, and putting her arms about his neck, and often kissing him, addressed him as her "Dear, dear brother."

"I have come to bring you home, dear brother!" said the child, clapping her tiny hands, and bending down to laugh. "To bring you home, home, home!"

"Home, little Fan?" returned the boy.

"Yes!" said the child, brimful of glee. "Home, for good and all. Home, for ever and ever. Father is so much kinder than he used to be, that home's like Heaven! He spoke so gently to me one dear night when I was going to bed, that I was not afraid to ask him once more if you might come home; and he said Yes, you should; and sent me in a coach to bring you. And you're to be a man!" said the child, opening her eyes, "and are never to come back here; but first, we're to be together all the Christmas long, and have the merriest time in all the world."

"You are quite a woman, little Fan!" exclaimed the boy.

She clapped her hands and laughed, and tried to touch his head; but being too little, laughed again, and stood on tiptoe to embrace him. Then she began to drag him, in her childish eagerness, towards the door; and he, nothing loth to go, accompanied her.

A terrible voice in the hall cried, "Bring down Master Scrooge's box, there!" and in the hall appeared the schoolmaster himself, who glared on Master Scrooge with a ferocious condescension, and threw him into a dreadful state of mind by shaking hands with him. He then conveyed him and his sister into the veriest old well of a shivering best-parlour that ever was seen, where the maps upon the wall, and the celestial and terrestrial globes in the windows, were waxy with cold. Here he produced a decanter of curiously light wine, and a block of curiously heavy cake, and administered instalments of those dainties to the young people: at the same time, sending out a meagre servant to offer a glass of "something" to the postboy, who answered that he thanked the gentleman, but if it was the same tap as he had tasted before, he had rather not. Master Scrooge's trunk being by this time tied on to the top of the chaise, the children bade the schoolmaster good-bye right willingly; and getting into it,

drove gaily down the garden-sweep: the quick wheels dashing the hoar-frost and snow from off the dark leaves of the evergreens like spray.

"Always a delicate creature, whom a breath might have withered," said the Ghost. "But she had a large heart!"

"So she had," cried Scrooge. "You're right. I will not gainsay it, Spirit. God forbid!"

"She died a woman," said the Ghost, "and had, as I think, children."

"One child," Scrooge returned.

"True," said the Ghost. "Your nephew!"

Scrooge seemed uneasy in his mind; and answered briefly, "Yes."

Although they had but that moment left the school behind them, they were now in the busy thoroughfares of a city, where shadowy passengers passed and repassed; where shadowy carts and coaches battled for the way, and all the strife and tumult of a real city were. It was made plain enough, by the dressing of the shops, that here too it was Christmas time again; but it was evening, and the streets were lighted up.

The Ghost stopped at a certain warehouse door, and asked Scrooge if he knew it.

"Know it!" said Scrooge. "Was I apprenticed here!"

They went in. At sight of an old gentleman in a Welsh wig, sitting behind such a high desk, that if he had been two inches taller he must have knocked his head against the ceiling, Scrooge cried in great excitement:

"Why, it's old Fezziwig! Bless his heart; it's Fezziwig alive again!"

Old Fezziwig laid down his pen, and looked up at the clock, which pointed to the hour of seven. He rubbed his hands; adjusted his capacious waistcoat; laughed all over himself, from his shoes to his organ of benevolence; and called out in a comfortable, oily, rich, fat, jovial voice:

"Yo ho, there! Ebenezer! Dick!"

Scrooge's former self, now grown a young man, came briskly in, accompanied by his fellow-'prentice.

"Dick Wilkins, to be sure!" said Scrooge to the Ghost. "Bless me, yes. There he is. He was very much attached to me, was Dick. Poor Dick! Dear, dear!"

"Yo ho, my boys!" said Fezziwig. "No more work to-night. Christmas Eve, Dick. Christmas, Ebenezer! Let's have the shutters up," cried old Fezziwig, with a sharp clap of his hands, "before a man can say Jack Robinson!"

You wouldn't believe how those two fellows went at it! They charged into the street with the shutters—one, two, three—had 'em up in their places—four, five, six—barred 'em and pinned 'em—seven, eight, nine—and came back before you could have got to twelve, panting like race-horses.

"Hilli-ho!" cried old Fezziwig, skipping down from the high desk, with wonderful agility. "Clear away, my lads, and let's have lots of room here! Hilli-ho, Dick! Chirrup, Ebenezer!"

Clear away! There was nothing they wouldn't have cleared away, or couldn't have cleared away, with old Fezziwig looking on. It was done in a minute. Every movable was packed off, as if it were dismissed from public life for evermore; the floor was swept and watered, the lamps were trimmed, fuel was heaped upon the fire; and the warehouse was as snug, and warm, and dry, and bright a ball-room, as you would desire to see upon a winter's night.

In came a fiddler with a music-book, and went up to the lofty desk, and made an orchestra of it, and tuned like fifty stomach-aches. In came Mrs. Fezziwig, one vast substantial smile. In came the three Miss Fezziwigs, beaming and lovable. In came the six young followers whose hearts they broke. In came all the young men and women employed in the business. In came the housemaid, with her cousin, the baker. In came the cook, with her brother's particular friend, the milkman. In came the boy from over the way, who was suspected of not having board enough from his master; trying to hide himself behind the girl from next door but one, who was proved to have had her ears pulled by her mistress. In they all came, one after another; some shyly, some boldly, some gracefully, some awkwardly, some pushing, some pulling; in they all came, anyhow and everyhow. Away they all went, twenty couple at once; hands half round and back again the other way; down the middle and up again; round and round in various stages of affectionate grouping; old top couple always turning up in the wrong place; new top couple starting off again, as soon as they got there; all top couples at last, and not a bottom one to help them! When this result was brought about, old Fezziwig, clapping his hands to stop the dance, cried out, "Well done!" and the fiddler plunged his hot face into a pot of porter, especially provided for that purpose. But scorning rest, upon his reappearance, he instantly began again, though there were no dancers yet, as if the other fiddler had been carried home, exhausted, on a shutter, and he were a bran-new man resolved to beat him out of sight, or perish.

There were more dances, and there were forfeits, and more dances, and there was cake, and there was negus, and there was a great piece of Cold Roast, and there was a great piece

of Cold Boiled, and there were mince-pies, and plenty of beer. But the great effect of the evening came after the Roast and Boiled, when the fiddler (an artful dog, mind! The sort of man who knew his business better than you or I could have told it him!) struck up “Sir Roger de Coverley.” Then old Fezziwig stood out to dance with Mrs. Fezziwig. Top couple, too; with a good stiff piece of work cut out for them; three or four and twenty pair of partners; people who were not to be trifled with; people who would dance, and had no notion of walking.

But if they had been twice as many—ah, four times—old Fezziwig would have been a match for them, and so would Mrs. Fezziwig. As to her, she was worthy to be his partner in every sense of the term. If that’s not high praise, tell me higher, and I’ll use it. A positive light appeared to issue from Fezziwig’s calves. They shone in every part of the dance like moons. You couldn’t have predicted, at any given time, what would have become of them next. And when old Fezziwig and Mrs. Fezziwig had gone all through the dance; advance and retire, both hands to your partner, bow and curtsey, corkscrew, thread-the-needle, and back again to your place; Fezziwig “cut”—cut so deftly, that he appeared to wink with his legs, and came upon his feet again without a stagger.

When the clock struck eleven, this domestic ball broke up. Mr. and Mrs. Fezziwig took their stations, one on either side of the door, and shaking hands with every person individually as he or she went out, wished him or her a Merry Christmas. When everybody had retired but the two ‘prentices, they did the same to them; and thus the cheerful voices died away, and the lads were left to their beds; which were under a counter in the back-shop.

During the whole of this time, Scrooge had acted like a man out of his wits. His heart and soul were in the scene, and with his former self. He corroborated everything, remembered everything, enjoyed everything, and underwent the strangest agitation. It was not until now, when the bright faces of his former self and Dick were turned from them, that he remembered the Ghost, and became conscious that it was looking full upon him, while the light upon its head burnt very clear.

“A small matter,” said the Ghost, “to make these silly folks so full of gratitude.”

“Small!” echoed Scrooge.

The Spirit signed to him to listen to the two apprentices, who were pouring out their hearts in praise of Fezziwig: and when he had done so, said,

“Why! Is it not? He has spent but a few pounds of your mortal money: three or four perhaps. Is that so much that he deserves this praise?”

“It isn’t that,” said Scrooge, heated by the remark, and speaking unconsciously like his former, not his latter, self. “It isn’t that, Spirit. He has the power to render us happy or

unhappy; to make our service light or burdensome; a pleasure or a toil. Say that his power lies in words and looks; in things so slight and insignificant that it is impossible to add and count 'em up: what then? The happiness he gives, is quite as great as if it cost a fortune."

He felt the Spirit's glance, and stopped.

"What is the matter?" asked the Ghost.

"Nothing particular," said Scrooge.

"Something, I think?" the Ghost insisted.

"No," said Scrooge, "No. I should like to be able to say a word or two to my clerk just now. That's all."

His former self turned down the lamps as he gave utterance to the wish; and Scrooge and the Ghost again stood side by side in the open air.

"My time grows short," observed the Spirit. "Quick!"

This was not addressed to Scrooge, or to any one whom he could see, but it produced an immediate effect. For again Scrooge saw himself. He was older now; a man in the prime of life. His face had not the harsh and rigid lines of later years; but it had begun to wear the signs of care and avarice. There was an eager, greedy, restless motion in the eye, which showed the passion that had taken root, and where the shadow of the growing tree would fall.

He was not alone, but sat by the side of a fair young girl in a mourning-dress: in whose eyes there were tears, which sparkled in the light that shone out of the Ghost of Christmas Past.

"It matters little," she said, softly. "To you, very little. Another idol has displaced me; and if it can cheer and comfort you in time to come, as I would have tried to do, I have no just cause to grieve."

"What Idol has displaced you?" he rejoined.

"A golden one."

"This is the even-handed dealing of the world!" he said. "There is nothing on which it is so hard as poverty; and there is nothing it professes to condemn with such severity as the pursuit of wealth!"

"You fear the world too much," she answered, gently. "All your other hopes have merged into the hope of being beyond the chance of its sordid reproach. I have seen your nobler aspirations fall off one by one, until the master-passion, Gain, engrosses you. Have I not?"

"What then?" he retorted. "Even if I have grown so much wiser, what then? I am not changed towards you."

She shook her head.

"Am I?"

"Our contract is an old one. It was made when we were both poor and content to be so, until, in good season, we could improve our worldly fortune by our patient industry. You are changed. When it was made, you were another man."

"I was a boy," he said impatiently.

"Your own feeling tells you that you were not what you are," she returned. "I am. That which promised happiness when we were one in heart, is fraught with misery now that we are two. How often and how keenly I have thought of this, I will not say. It is enough that I have thought of it, and can release you."

"Have I ever sought release?"

"In words. No. Never."

"In what, then?"

"In a changed nature; in an altered spirit; in another atmosphere of life; another Hope as its great end. In everything that made my love of any worth or value in your sight. If this had never been between us," said the girl, looking mildly, but with steadiness, upon him; "tell me, would you seek me out and try to win me now? Ah, no!"

He seemed to yield to the justice of this supposition, in spite of himself. But he said with a struggle, "You think not."

"I would gladly think otherwise if I could," she answered, "Heaven knows! When I have learned a Truth like this, I know how strong and irresistible it must be. But if you were free to-day, to-morrow, yesterday, can even I believe that you would choose a dowerless girl—you who, in your very confidence with her, weigh everything by Gain: or, choosing her, if for a moment you were false enough to your one guiding principle to do so, do I not know that your repentance and regret would surely follow? I do; and I release you. With a full heart, for the love of him you once were."

He was about to speak; but with her head turned from him, she resumed.

"You may—the memory of what is past half makes me hope you will—have pain in this. A very, very brief time, and you will dismiss the recollection of it, gladly, as an unprofitable dream, from which it happened well that you awoke. May you be happy in the life you have

chosen!"

She left him, and they parted.

"Spirit!" said Scrooge, "show me no more! Conduct me home. Why do you delight to torture me?"

"One shadow more!" exclaimed the Ghost.

"No more!" cried Scrooge. "No more. I don't wish to see it. Show me no more!"

But the relentless Ghost pinioned him in both his arms, and forced him to observe what happened next.

They were in another scene and place; a room, not very large or handsome, but full of comfort. Near to the winter fire sat a beautiful young girl, so like that last that Scrooge believed it was the same, until he saw her, now a comely matron, sitting opposite her daughter. The noise in this room was perfectly tumultuous, for there were more children there, than Scrooge in his agitated state of mind could count; and, unlike the celebrated herd in the poem, they were not forty children conducting themselves like one, but every child was conducting itself like forty. The consequences were uproarious beyond belief; but no one seemed to care; on the contrary, the mother and daughter laughed heartily, and enjoyed it very much; and the latter, soon beginning to mingle in the sports, got pillaged by the young brigands most ruthlessly. What would I not have given to be one of them! Though I never could have been so rude, no, no! I wouldn't for the wealth of all the world have crushed that braided hair, and torn it down; and for the precious little shoe, I wouldn't have plucked it off, God bless my soul! to save my life. As to measuring her waist in sport, as they did, bold young brood, I couldn't have done it; I should have expected my arm to have grown round it for a punishment, and never come straight again. And yet I should have dearly liked, I own, to have touched her lips; to have questioned her, that she might have opened them; to have looked upon the lashes of her downcast eyes, and never raised a blush; to have let loose waves of hair, an inch of which would be a keepsake beyond price: in short, I should have liked, I do confess, to have had the lightest licence of a child, and yet to have been man enough to know its value.

But now a knocking at the door was heard, and such a rush immediately ensued that she with laughing face and plundered dress was borne towards it the centre of a flushed and boisterous group, just in time to greet the father, who came home attended by a man laden with Christmas toys and presents. Then the shouting and the struggling, and the onslaught that was made on the defenceless porter! The scaling him with chairs for ladders to dive into his pockets, despoil him of brown-paper parcels, hold on tight by his cravat, hug him round his neck, pommel his back, and kick his legs in irrepressible affection! The shouts of wonder and

delight with which the development of every package was received! The terrible announcement that the baby had been taken in the act of putting a doll's frying-pan into his mouth, and was more than suspected of having swallowed a fictitious turkey, glued on a wooden platter! The immense relief of finding this a false alarm! The joy, and gratitude, and ecstasy! They are all indescribable alike. It is enough that by degrees the children and their emotions got out of the parlour, and by one stair at a time, up to the top of the house; where they went to bed, and so subsided.

And now Scrooge looked on more attentively than ever, when the master of the house, having his daughter leaning fondly on him, sat down with her and her mother at his own fireside; and when he thought that such another creature, quite as graceful and as full of promise, might have called him father, and been a spring-time in the haggard winter of his life, his sight grew very dim indeed.

"Belle," said the husband, turning to his wife with a smile, "I saw an old friend of yours this afternoon."

"Who was it?"

"Guess!"

"How can I? Tut, don't I know?" she added in the same breath, laughing as he laughed. "Mr. Scrooge."

"Mr. Scrooge it was. I passed his office window; and as it was not shut up, and he had a candle inside, I could scarcely help seeing him. His partner lies upon the point of death, I hear; and there he sat alone. Quite alone in the world, I do believe."

"Spirit!" said Scrooge in a broken voice, "remove me from this place."

"I told you these were shadows of the things that have been," said the Ghost. "That they are what they are, do not blame me!"

"Remove me!" Scrooge exclaimed, "I cannot bear it!"

He turned upon the Ghost, and seeing that it looked upon him with a face, in which in some strange way there were fragments of all the faces it had shown him, wrestled with it.

"Leave me! Take me back. Haunt me no longer!"

In the struggle, if that can be called a struggle in which the Ghost with no visible resistance on its own part was undisturbed by any effort of its adversary, Scrooge observed that its light was burning high and bright; and dimly connecting that with its influence over him, he seized the extinguisher-cap, and by a sudden action pressed it down upon its head.

The Spirit dropped beneath it, so that the extinguisher covered its whole form; but though Scrooge pressed it down with all his force, he could not hide the light: which streamed from under it, in an unbroken flood upon the ground.

He was conscious of being exhausted, and overcome by an irresistible drowsiness; and, further, of being in his own bedroom. He gave the cap a parting squeeze, in which his hand relaxed; and had barely time to reel to bed, before he sank into a heavy sleep.

STAVE THREE

The Second of the Three Spirits

WORDS TO KNOW

poulterer	A seller of chickens, geese, and turkeys.
threadbare	Worn so thin the threads show.
brazier	A metal stand that holds burning coals.
odious	Hateful; disgusting.
pawn	To leave something with a lender in exchange for a loan.
plump	Pleasantly round and full.

AWAKING in the middle of a prodigiously tough snore, and sitting up in bed to get his thoughts together, Scrooge had no occasion to be told that the bell was again upon the stroke of One. He felt that he was restored to consciousness in the right nick of time, for the especial purpose of holding a conference with the second messenger despatched to him through Jacob Marley's intervention. But finding that he turned uncomfortably cold when he began to wonder which of his curtains this new spectre would draw back, he put them every one aside with his own hands; and lying down again, established a sharp look-out all round the bed. For he wished to challenge the Spirit on the moment of its appearance, and did not wish to be taken by surprise, and made nervous.

Gentlemen of the free-and-easy sort, who plume themselves on being acquainted with a move or two, and being usually equal to the time-of-day, express the wide range of their capacity for adventure by observing that they are good for anything from pitch-and-toss to manslaughter; between which opposite extremes, no doubt, there lies a tolerably wide and comprehensive range of subjects. Without venturing for Scrooge quite as hardily as this, I don't mind calling on you to believe that he was ready for a good broad field of strange appearances, and that nothing between a baby and rhinoceros would have astonished him very much.

Now, being prepared for almost anything, he was not by any means prepared for nothing; and, consequently, when the Bell struck One, and no shape appeared, he was taken with a violent fit of trembling. Five minutes, ten minutes, a quarter of an hour went by, yet nothing came. All this time, he lay upon his bed, the very core and centre of a blaze of ruddy light, which streamed upon it when the clock proclaimed the hour; and which, being only light, was

more alarming than a dozen ghosts, as he was powerless to make out what it meant, or would be at; and was sometimes apprehensive that he might be at that very moment an interesting case of spontaneous combustion, without having the consolation of knowing it. At last, however, he began to think—as you or I would have thought at first; for it is always the person not in the predicament who knows what ought to have been done in it, and would unquestionably have done it too—at last, I say, he began to think that the source and secret of this ghostly light might be in the adjoining room, from whence, on further tracing it, it seemed to shine. This idea taking full possession of his mind, he got up softly and shuffled in his slippers to the door.

The moment Scrooge's hand was on the lock, a strange voice called him by his name, and bade him enter. He obeyed.

It was his own room. There was no doubt about that. But it had undergone a surprising transformation. The walls and ceiling were so hung with living green, that it looked a perfect grove; from every part of which, bright gleaming berries glistened. The crisp leaves of holly, mistletoe, and ivy reflected back the light, as if so many little mirrors had been scattered there; and such a mighty blaze went roaring up the chimney, as that dull petrification of a hearth had never known in Scrooge's time, or Marley's, or for many and many a winter season gone. Heaped up on the floor, to form a kind of throne, were turkeys, geese, game, poultry, brawn, great joints of meat, sucking-pigs, long wreaths of sausages, mince-pies, plum-puddings, barrels of oysters, red-hot chestnuts, cherry-cheeked apples, juicy oranges, luscious pears, immense twelfth-cakes, and seething bowls of punch, that made the chamber dim with their delicious steam. In easy state upon this couch, there sat a jolly Giant, glorious to see; who bore a glowing torch, in shape not unlike Plenty's horn, and held it up, high up, to shed its light on Scrooge, as he came peeping round the door.

"Come in!" exclaimed the Ghost. "Come in! and know me better, man!"

Scrooge entered timidly, and hung his head before this Spirit. He was not the dogged Scrooge he had been; and though the Spirit's eyes were clear and kind, he did not like to meet them.

"I am the Ghost of Christmas Present," said the Spirit. "Look upon me!"

Scrooge reverently did so. It was clothed in one simple green robe, or mantle, bordered with white fur. This garment hung so loosely on the figure, that its capacious breast was bare, as if disdaining to be warded or concealed by any artifice. Its feet, observable beneath the ample folds of the garment, were also bare; and on its head it wore no other covering than a holly wreath, set here and there with shining icicles. Its dark brown curls were long and free; free as its genial face, its sparkling eye, its open hand, its cheery voice, its unconstrained

demeanour, and its joyful air. Girded round its middle was an antique scabbard; but no sword was in it, and the ancient sheath was eaten up with rust.

"You have never seen the like of me before!" exclaimed the Spirit.

"Never," Scrooge made answer to it.

"Have never walked forth with the younger members of my family; meaning (for I am very young) my elder brothers born in these later years?" pursued the Phantom.

"I don't think I have," said Scrooge. "I am afraid I have not. Have you had many brothers, Spirit?"

"More than eighteen hundred," said the Ghost.

"A tremendous family to provide for!" muttered Scrooge.

The Ghost of Christmas Present rose.

"Spirit," said Scrooge submissively, "conduct me where you will. I went forth last night on compulsion, and I learnt a lesson which is working now. To-night, if you have aught to teach me, let me profit by it."

"Touch my robe!"

Scrooge did as he was told, and held it fast.

Holly, mistletoe, red berries, ivy, turkeys, geese, game, poultry, brawn, meat, pigs, sausages, oysters, pies, puddings, fruit, and punch, all vanished instantly. So did the room, the fire, the ruddy glow, the hour of night, and they stood in the city streets on Christmas morning, where (for the weather was severe) the people made a rough, but brisk and not unpleasant kind of music, in scraping the snow from the pavement in front of their dwellings, and from the tops of their houses, whence it was mad delight to the boys to see it come plumping down into the road below, and splitting into artificial little snow-storms.

The house fronts looked black enough, and the windows blacker, contrasting with the smooth white sheet of snow upon the roofs, and with the dirtier snow upon the ground; which last deposit had been ploughed up in deep furrows by the heavy wheels of carts and waggons; furrows that crossed and re-crossed each other hundreds of times where the great streets branched off; and made intricate channels, hard to trace in the thick yellow mud and icy water. The sky was gloomy, and the shortest streets were choked up with a dingy mist, half thawed, half frozen, whose heavier particles descended in a shower of sooty atoms, as if all the chimneys in Great Britain had, by one consent, caught fire, and were blazing away to their dear hearts' content. There was nothing very cheerful in the climate or the town, and yet was

there an air of cheerfulness abroad that the clearest summer air and brightest summer sun might have endeavoured to diffuse in vain.

For, the people who were shovelling away on the housetops were jovial and full of glee; calling out to one another from the parapets, and now and then exchanging a facetious snowball—better-natured missile far than many a wordy jest— laughing heartily if it went right and not less heartily if it went wrong. The poulterers' shops were still half open, and the fruiterers' were radiant in their glory. There were great, round, pot-bellied baskets of chestnuts, shaped like the waistcoats of jolly old gentlemen, lolling at the doors, and tumbling out into the street in their apoplectic opulence. There were ruddy, brown-faced, broad-girthed Spanish Onions, shining in the fatness of their growth like Spanish Friars, and winking from their shelves in wanton slyness at the girls as they went by, and glanced demurely at the hung-up mistletoe. There were pears and apples, clustered high in blooming pyramids; there were bunches of grapes, made, in the shopkeepers' benevolence to dangle from conspicuous hooks, that people's mouths might water gratis as they passed; there were piles of filberts, mossy and brown, recalling, in their fragrance, ancient walks among the woods, and pleasant shufflings ankle deep through withered leaves; there were Norfolk Biffins, squat and swarthy, setting off the yellow of the oranges and lemons, and, in the great compactness of their juicy persons, urgently entreating and beseeching to be carried home in paper bags and eaten after dinner. The very gold and silver fish, set forth among these choice fruits in a bowl, though members of a dull and stagnant-blooded race, appeared to know that there was something going on; and, to a fish, went gasping round and round their little world in slow and passionless excitement.

The Grocers'! oh, the Grocers'! nearly closed, with perhaps two shutters down, or one; but through those gaps such glimpses! It was not alone that the scales descending on the counter made a merry sound, or that the twine and roller parted company so briskly, or that the canisters were rattled up and down like juggling tricks, or even that the blended scents of tea and coffee were so grateful to the nose, or even that the raisins were so plentiful and rare, the almonds so extremely white, the sticks of cinnamon so long and straight, the other spices so delicious, the candied fruits so caked and spotted with molten sugar as to make the coldest lookers-on feel faint and subsequently bilious. Nor was it that the figs were moist and pulpy, or that the French plums blushed in modest tartness from their highly-decorated boxes, or that everything was good to eat and in its Christmas dress; but the customers were all so hurried and so eager in the hopeful promise of the day, that they tumbled up against each other at the door, crashing their wicker baskets wildly, and left their purchases upon the counter, and came running back to fetch them, and committed hundreds of the like mistakes, in the best humour possible; while the Grocer and his people were so frank and fresh that the polished hearts with which they fastened their aprons behind might have been their own, worn outside

for general inspection, and for Christmas daws to peck at if they chose.

But soon the steeples called good people all, to church and chapel, and away they came, flocking through the streets in their best clothes, and with their gayest faces. And at the same time there emerged from scores of bye-streets, lanes, and nameless turnings, innumerable people, carrying their dinners to the bakers' shops. The sight of these poor revellers appeared to interest the Spirit very much, for he stood with Scrooge beside him in a baker's doorway, and taking off the covers as their bearers passed, sprinkled incense on their dinners from his torch. And it was a very uncommon kind of torch, for once or twice when there were angry words between some dinner-carriers who had jostled each other, he shed a few drops of water on them from it, and their good humour was restored directly. For they said, it was a shame to quarrel upon Christmas Day. And so it was! God love it, so it was!

In time the bells ceased, and the bakers were shut up; and yet there was a genial shadowing forth of all these dinners and the progress of their cooking, in the thawed blotch of wet above each baker's oven; where the pavement smoked as if its stones were cooking too.

"Is there a peculiar flavour in what you sprinkle from your torch?" asked Scrooge.

"There is. My own."

"Would it apply to any kind of dinner on this day?" asked Scrooge.

"To any kindly given. To a poor one most."

"Why to a poor one most?" asked Scrooge.

"Because it needs it most."

"Spirit," said Scrooge, after a moment's thought, "I wonder you, of all the beings in the many worlds about us, should desire to cramp these people's opportunities of innocent enjoyment."

"I!" cried the Spirit.

"You would deprive them of their means of dining every seventh day, often the only day on which they can be said to dine at all," said Scrooge. "Wouldn't you?"

"I!" cried the Spirit.

"You seek to close these places on the Seventh Day?" said Scrooge. "And it comes to the same thing."

"I seek!" exclaimed the Spirit.

"Forgive me if I am wrong. It has been done in your name, or at least in that of your family," said Scrooge.

"There are some upon this earth of yours," returned the Spirit, "who lay claim to know us, and who do their deeds of passion, pride, ill-will, hatred, envy, bigotry, and selfishness in our name, who are as strange to us and all our kith and kin, as if they had never lived. Remember that, and charge their doings on themselves, not us."

Scrooge promised that he would; and they went on, invisible, as they had been before, into the suburbs of the town. It was a remarkable quality of the Ghost (which Scrooge had observed at the baker's), that notwithstanding his gigantic size, he could accommodate himself to any place with ease; and that he stood beneath a low roof quite as gracefully and like a supernatural creature, as it was possible he could have done in any lofty hall.

And perhaps it was the pleasure the good Spirit had in showing off this power of his, or else it was his own kind, generous, hearty nature, and his sympathy with all poor men, that led him straight to Scrooge's clerk's; for there he went, and took Scrooge with him, holding to his robe; and on the threshold of the door the Spirit smiled, and stopped to bless Bob Cratchit's dwelling with the sprinkling of his torch. Think of that! Bob had but fifteen "Bob" a-week himself; he pocketed on Saturdays but fifteen copies of his Christian name; and yet the Ghost of Christmas Present blessed his four-roomed house!

Then up rose Mrs. Cratchit, Cratchit's wife, dressed out but poorly in a twice-turned gown, but brave in ribbons, which are cheap and make a goodly show for sixpence; and she laid the cloth, assisted by Belinda Cratchit, second of her daughters, also brave in ribbons; while Master Peter Cratchit plunged a fork into the saucepan of potatoes, and getting the corners of his monstrous shirt collar (Bob's private property, conferred upon his son and heir in honour of the day) into his mouth, rejoiced to find himself so gallantly attired, and yearned to show his linen in the fashionable Parks. And now two smaller Cratchits, boy and girl, came tearing in, screaming that outside the baker's they had smelt the goose, and known it for their own; and basking in luxurious thoughts of sage and onion, these young Cratchits danced about the table, and exalted Master Peter Cratchit to the skies, while he (not proud, although his collars nearly choked him) blew the fire, until the slow potatoes bubbling up, knocked loudly at the saucepan-lid to be let out and peeled.

"What has ever got your precious father then?" said Mrs. Cratchit. "And your brother, Tiny Tim! And Martha warn't as late last Christmas Day by half-an-hour?"

"Here's Martha, mother!" said a girl, appearing as she spoke.

“Here’s Martha, mother!” cried the two young Cratchits. “Hurrah! There’s such a goose, Martha!”

“Why, bless your heart alive, my dear, how late you are!” said Mrs. Cratchit, kissing her a dozen times, and taking off her shawl and bonnet for her with officious zeal.

“We’d a deal of work to finish up last night,” replied the girl, “and had to clear away this morning, mother!”

“Well! Never mind so long as you are come,” said Mrs. Cratchit. “Sit ye down before the fire, my dear, and have a warm, Lord bless ye!”

“No, no! There’s father coming,” cried the two young Cratchits, who were everywhere at once. “Hide, Martha, hide!”

So Martha hid herself, and in came little Bob, the father, with at least three feet of comforter exclusive of the fringe, hanging down before him; and his threadbare clothes darned up and brushed, to look seasonable; and Tiny Tim upon his shoulder. Alas for Tiny Tim, he bore a little crutch, and had his limbs supported by an iron frame!

“Why, where’s our Martha?” cried Bob Cratchit, looking round.

“Not coming,” said Mrs. Cratchit.

“Not coming!” said Bob, with a sudden declension in his high spirits; for he had been Tim’s blood horse all the way from church, and had come home rampant. “Not coming upon Christmas Day!”

Martha didn’t like to see him disappointed, if it were only in joke; so she came out prematurely from behind the closet door, and ran into his arms, while the two young Cratchits hustled Tiny Tim, and bore him off into the wash-house, that he might hear the pudding singing in the copper.

“And how did little Tim behave?” asked Mrs. Cratchit, when she had rallied Bob on his credulity, and Bob had hugged his daughter to his heart’s content.

“As good as gold,” said Bob, “and better. Somehow he gets thoughtful, sitting by himself so much, and thinks the strangest things you ever heard. He told me, coming home, that he hoped the people saw him in the church, because he was a cripple, and it might be pleasant to them to remember upon Christmas Day, who made lame beggars walk, and blind men see.”

Bob’s voice was tremulous when he told them this, and trembled more when he said that Tiny Tim was growing strong and hearty.

His active little crutch was heard upon the floor, and back came Tiny Tim before another word was spoken, escorted by his brother and sister to his stool before the fire; and while Bob, turning up his cuffs—as if, poor fellow, they were capable of being made more shabby—compounded some hot mixture in a jug with gin and lemons, and stirred it round and round and put it on the hob to simmer; Master Peter, and the two ubiquitous young Cratchits went to fetch the goose, with which they soon returned in high procession.

Such a bustle ensued that you might have thought a goose the rarest of all birds; a feathered phenomenon, to which a black swan was a matter of course—and in truth it was something very like it in that house. Mrs. Cratchit made the gravy (ready beforehand in a little saucepan) hissing hot; Master Peter mashed the potatoes with incredible vigour; Miss Belinda sweetened up the apple-sauce; Martha dusted the hot plates; Bob took Tiny Tim beside him in a tiny corner at the table; the two young Cratchits set chairs for everybody, not forgetting themselves, and mounting guard upon their posts, crammed spoons into their mouths, lest they should shriek for goose before their turn came to be helped. At last the dishes were set on, and grace was said. It was succeeded by a breathless pause, as Mrs. Cratchit, looking slowly all along the carving-knife, prepared to plunge it in the breast; but when she did, and when the long expected gush of stuffing issued forth, one murmur of delight arose all round the board, and even Tiny Tim, excited by the two young Cratchits, beat on the table with the handle of his knife, and feebly cried Hurrah!

There never was such a goose. Bob said he didn't believe there ever was such a goose cooked. Its tenderness and flavour, size and cheapness, were the themes of universal admiration. Eked out by apple-sauce and mashed potatoes, it was a sufficient dinner for the whole family; indeed, as Mrs. Cratchit said with great delight (surveying one small atom of a bone upon the dish), they hadn't ate it all at last! Yet every one had had enough, and the youngest Cratchits in particular, were steeped in sage and onion to the eyebrows! But now, the plates being changed by Miss Belinda, Mrs. Cratchit left the room alone—too nervous to bear witnesses—to take the pudding up and bring it in.

Suppose it should not be done enough! Suppose it should break in turning out! Suppose somebody should have got over the wall of the back-yard, and stolen it, while they were merry with the goose—a supposition at which the two young Cratchits became livid! All sorts of horrors were supposed.

Hallo! A great deal of steam! The pudding was out of the copper. A smell like a washing-day! That was the cloth. A smell like an eating-house and a pastrycook's next door to each other, with a laundress's next door to that! That was the pudding! In half a minute Mrs. Cratchit entered—flushed, but smiling proudly—with the pudding, like a speckled cannon-ball, so hard and firm, blazing in half of half-a-quartern of ignited brandy, and bedight with

Christmas holly stuck into the top.

Oh, a wonderful pudding! Bob Cratchit said, and calmly too, that he regarded it as the greatest success achieved by Mrs. Cratchit since their marriage. Mrs. Cratchit said that now the weight was off her mind, she would confess she had had her doubts about the quantity of flour. Everybody had something to say about it, but nobody said or thought it was at all a small pudding for a large family. It would have been flat heresy to do so. Any Cratchit would have blushed to hint at such a thing.

At last the dinner was all done, the cloth was cleared, the hearth swept, and the fire made up. The compound in the jug being tasted, and considered perfect, apples and oranges were put upon the table, and a shovel-full of chestnuts on the fire. Then all the Cratchit family drew round the hearth, in what Bob Cratchit called a circle, meaning half a one; and at Bob Cratchit's elbow stood the family display of glass. Two tumblers, and a custard-cup without a handle.

These held the hot stuff from the jug, however, as well as golden goblets would have done; and Bob served it out with beaming looks, while the chestnuts on the fire sputtered and cracked noisily. Then Bob proposed:

"A Merry Christmas to us all, my dears. God bless us!"

Which all the family re-echoed.

"God bless us every one!" said Tiny Tim, the last of all.

He sat very close to his father's side upon his little stool. Bob held his withered little hand in his, as if he loved the child, and wished to keep him by his side, and dreaded that he might be taken from him.

"Spirit," said Scrooge, with an interest he had never felt before, "tell me if Tiny Tim will live."

"I see a vacant seat," replied the Ghost, "in the poor chimney-corner, and a crutch without an owner, carefully preserved. If these shadows remain unaltered by the Future, the child will die."

"No, no," said Scrooge. "Oh, no, kind Spirit! say he will be spared."

"If these shadows remain unaltered by the Future, none other of my race," returned the Ghost, "will find him here. What then? If he be like to die, he had better do it, and decrease the surplus population."

Scrooge hung his head to hear his own words quoted by the Spirit, and was overcome with penitence and grief.

"Man," said the Ghost, "if man you be in heart, not adamant, forbear that wicked cant until you have discovered What the surplus is, and Where it is. Will you decide what men shall live, what men shall die? It may be, that in the sight of Heaven, you are more worthless and less fit to live than millions like this poor man's child. Oh God! to hear the Insect on the leaf pronouncing on the too much life among his hungry brothers in the dust!"

Scrooge bent before the Ghost's rebuke, and trembling cast his eyes upon the ground. But he raised them speedily, on hearing his own name.

"Mr. Scrooge!" said Bob; "I'll give you Mr. Scrooge, the Founder of the Feast!"

"The Founder of the Feast indeed!" cried Mrs. Cratchit, reddening. "I wish I had him here. I'd give him a piece of my mind to feast upon, and I hope he'd have a good appetite for it."

"My dear," said Bob, "the children! Christmas Day."

"It should be Christmas Day, I am sure," said she, "on which one drinks the health of such an odious, stingy, hard, unfeeling man as Mr. Scrooge. You know he is, Robert! Nobody knows it better than you do, poor fellow!"

"My dear," was Bob's mild answer, "Christmas Day."

"I'll drink his health for your sake and the Day's," said Mrs. Cratchit, "not for his. Long life to him! A merry Christmas and a happy new year! He'll be very merry and very happy, I have no doubt!"

The children drank the toast after her. It was the first of their proceedings which had no heartiness. Tiny Tim drank it last of all, but he didn't care twopence for it. Scrooge was the Ogre of the family. The mention of his name cast a dark shadow on the party, which was not dispelled for full five minutes.

After it had passed away, they were ten times merrier than before, from the mere relief of Scrooge the Baleful being done with. Bob Cratchit told them how he had a situation in his eye for Master Peter, which would bring in, if obtained, full five-and-sixpence weekly. The two young Cratchits laughed tremendously at the idea of Peter's being a man of business; and Peter himself looked thoughtfully at the fire from between his collars, as if he were deliberating what particular investments he should favour when he came into the receipt of that bewildering income. Martha, who was a poor apprentice at a milliner's, then told them what kind of work she had to do, and how many hours she worked at a stretch, and how she meant to lie abed to-morrow morning for a good long rest; to-morrow being a holiday she

passed at home. Also how she had seen a countess and a lord some days before, and how the lord “was much about as tall as Peter;” at which Peter pulled up his collars so high that you couldn’t have seen his head if you had been there. All this time the chestnuts and the jug went round and round; and by-and-bye they had a song, about a lost child travelling in the snow, from Tiny Tim, who had a plaintive little voice, and sang it very well indeed.

There was nothing of high mark in this. They were not a handsome family; they were not well dressed; their shoes were far from being water-proof; their clothes were scanty; and Peter might have known, and very likely did, the inside of a pawnbroker’s. But, they were happy, grateful, pleased with one another, and contented with the time; and when they faded, and looked happier yet in the bright sprinklings of the Spirit’s torch at parting, Scrooge had his eye upon them, and especially on Tiny Tim, until the last.

STAVE THREE, CONTINUED

The Second of the Three Spirits

WORDS TO KNOW

forfeits	A party game in which players pay small, silly penalties.
blind man's buff	A game in which a blindfolded player tries to catch the others.
wretched	Very unhappy or unfortunate.
meagre	Small in amount; not enough (British spelling of meager).
earnest	Serious and sincere.
Ignorance and Want	Lack of education and lack of food, money, and care, shown as two starving children.

By this time it was getting dark, and snowing pretty heavily; and as Scrooge and the Spirit went along the streets, the brightness of the roaring fires in kitchens, parlours, and all sorts of rooms, was wonderful. Here, the flickering of the blaze showed preparations for a cosy dinner, with hot plates baking through and through before the fire, and deep red curtains, ready to be drawn to shut out cold and darkness. There all the children of the house were running out into the snow to meet their married sisters, brothers, cousins, uncles, aunts, and be the first to greet them. Here, again, were shadows on the window-blind of guests assembling; and there a group of handsome girls, all hooded and fur-booted, and all chattering at once, tripped lightly off to some near neighbour's house; where, woe upon the single man who saw them enter—artful witches, well they knew it—in a glow!

But, if you had judged from the numbers of people on their way to friendly gatherings, you might have thought that no one was at home to give them welcome when they got there, instead of every house expecting company, and piling up its fires half-chimney high. Blessings on it, how the Ghost exulted! How it bared its breadth of breast, and opened its capacious palm, and floated on, outpouring, with a generous hand, its bright and harmless mirth on everything within its reach! The very lamplighter, who ran on before, dotting the dusky street with specks of light, and who was dressed to spend the evening somewhere, laughed out loudly as the Spirit passed, though little kenned the lamplighter that he had any company but Christmas!

And now, without a word of warning from the Ghost, they stood upon a bleak and desert moor, where monstrous masses of rude stone were cast about, as though it were the

burial-place of giants; and water spread itself wheresoever it listed, or would have done so, but for the frost that held it prisoner; and nothing grew but moss and furze, and coarse rank grass. Down in the west the setting sun had left a streak of fiery red, which glared upon the desolation for an instant, like a sullen eye, and frowning lower, lower, lower yet, was lost in the thick gloom of darkest night.

"What place is this?" asked Scrooge.

"A place where Miners live, who labour in the bowels of the earth," returned the Spirit. "But they know me. See!"

A light shone from the window of a hut, and swiftly they advanced towards it. Passing through the wall of mud and stone, they found a cheerful company assembled round a glowing fire. An old, old man and woman, with their children and their children's children, and another generation beyond that, all decked out gaily in their holiday attire. The old man, in a voice that seldom rose above the howling of the wind upon the barren waste, was singing them a Christmas song—it had been a very old song when he was a boy—and from time to time they all joined in the chorus. So surely as they raised their voices, the old man got quite blithe and loud; and so surely as they stopped, his vigour sank again.

The Spirit did not tarry here, but bade Scrooge hold his robe, and passing on above the moor, sped—whither? Not to sea? To sea. To Scrooge's horror, looking back, he saw the last of the land, a frightful range of rocks, behind them; and his ears were deafened by the thundering of water, as it rolled and roared, and raged among the dreadful caverns it had worn, and fiercely tried to undermine the earth.

Built upon a dismal reef of sunken rocks, some league or so from shore, on which the waters chafed and dashed, the wild year through, there stood a solitary lighthouse. Great heaps of sea-weed clung to its base, and storm-birds —born of the wind one might suppose, as sea-weed of the water—rose and fell about it, like the waves they skimmed.

But even here, two men who watched the light had made a fire, that through the loophole in the thick stone wall shed out a ray of brightness on the awful sea. Joining their horny hands over the rough table at which they sat, they wished each other Merry Christmas in their can of grog; and one of them: the elder, too, with his face all damaged and scarred with hard weather, as the figure-head of an old ship might be: struck up a sturdy song that was like a Gale in itself.

Again the Ghost sped on, above the black and heaving sea —on, on—until, being far away, as he told Scrooge, from any shore, they lighted on a ship. They stood beside the helmsman at the wheel, the look-out in the bow, the officers who had the watch; dark, ghostly figures in

their several stations; but every man among them hummed a Christmas tune, or had a Christmas thought, or spoke below his breath to his companion of some bygone Christmas Day, with homeward hopes belonging to it. And every man on board, waking or sleeping, good or bad, had had a kinder word for another on that day than on any day in the year; and had shared to some extent in its festivities; and had remembered those he cared for at a distance, and had known that they delighted to remember him.

It was a great surprise to Scrooge, while listening to the moaning of the wind, and thinking what a solemn thing it was to move on through the lonely darkness over an unknown abyss, whose depths were secrets as profound as Death: it was a great surprise to Scrooge, while thus engaged, to hear a hearty laugh. It was a much greater surprise to Scrooge to recognise it as his own nephew's and to find himself in a bright, dry, gleaming room, with the Spirit standing smiling by his side, and looking at that same nephew with approving affability!

"Ha, ha!" laughed Scrooge's nephew. "Ha, ha, ha!"

If you should happen, by any unlikely chance, to know a man more blest in a laugh than Scrooge's nephew, all I can say is, I should like to know him too. Introduce him to me, and I'll cultivate his acquaintance.

It is a fair, even-handed, noble adjustment of things, that while there is infection in disease and sorrow, there is nothing in the world so irresistibly contagious as laughter and good-humour. When Scrooge's nephew laughed in this way: holding his sides, rolling his head, and twisting his face into the most extravagant contortions: Scrooge's niece, by marriage, laughed as heartily as he. And their assembled friends being not a bit behindhand, roared out lustily.

"Ha, ha! Ha, ha, ha, ha!"

"He said that Christmas was a humbug, as I live!" cried Scrooge's nephew. "He believed it too!"

"More shame for him, Fred!" said Scrooge's niece, indignantly. Bless those women; they never do anything by halves. They are always in earnest.

She was very pretty: exceedingly pretty. With a dimpled, surprised-looking, capital face; a ripe little mouth, that seemed made to be kissed—as no doubt it was; all kinds of good little dots about her chin, that melted into one another when she laughed; and the sunniest pair of eyes you ever saw in any little creature's head. Altogether she was what you would have called provoking, you know; but satisfactory, too. Oh, perfectly satisfactory.

"He's a comical old fellow," said Scrooge's nephew, "that's the truth: and not so pleasant as he might be. However, his offences carry their own punishment, and I have nothing to say

against him."

"I'm sure he is very rich, Fred," hinted Scrooge's niece. "At least you always tell me so."

"What of that, my dear!" said Scrooge's nephew. "His wealth is of no use to him. He don't do any good with it. He don't make himself comfortable with it. He hasn't the satisfaction of thinking—ha, ha, ha!—that he is ever going to benefit US with it."

"I have no patience with him," observed Scrooge's niece. Scrooge's niece's sisters, and all the other ladies, expressed the same opinion.

"Oh, I have!" said Scrooge's nephew. "I am sorry for him; I couldn't be angry with him if I tried. Who suffers by his ill whims! Himself, always. Here, he takes it into his head to dislike us, and he won't come and dine with us. What's the consequence? He don't lose much of a dinner."

"Indeed, I think he loses a very good dinner," interrupted Scrooge's niece. Everybody else said the same, and they must be allowed to have been competent judges, because they had just had dinner; and, with the dessert upon the table, were clustered round the fire, by lamplight.

"Well! I'm very glad to hear it," said Scrooge's nephew, "because I haven't great faith in these young housekeepers. What do you say, Topper?"

Topper had clearly got his eye upon one of Scrooge's niece's sisters, for he answered that a bachelor was a wretched outcast, who had no right to express an opinion on the subject. Whereat Scrooge's niece's sister—the plump one with the lace tucker: not the one with the roses—blushed.

"Do go on, Fred," said Scrooge's niece, clapping her hands. "He never finishes what he begins to say! He is such a ridiculous fellow!"

Scrooge's nephew revelled in another laugh, and as it was impossible to keep the infection off; though the plump sister tried hard to do it with aromatic vinegar; his example was unanimously followed.

"I was only going to say," said Scrooge's nephew, "that the consequence of his taking a dislike to us, and not making merry with us, is, as I think, that he loses some pleasant moments, which could do him no harm. I am sure he loses pleasanter companions than he can find in his own thoughts, either in his mouldy old office, or his dusty chambers. I mean to give him the same chance every year, whether he likes it or not, for I pity him. He may rail at Christmas till he dies, but he can't help thinking better of it—I defy him—if he finds me going there, in good temper, year after year, and saying Uncle Scrooge, how are you? If it only puts him in the vein

to leave his poor clerk fifty pounds, that's something; and I think I shook him yesterday."

It was their turn to laugh now at the notion of his shaking Scrooge. But being thoroughly good-natured, and not much caring what they laughed at, so that they laughed at any rate, he encouraged them in their merriment, and passed the bottle joyously.

After tea, they had some music. For they were a musical family, and knew what they were about, when they sung a Glee or Catch, I can assure you: especially Topper, who could growl away in the bass like a good one, and never swell the large veins in his forehead, or get red in the face over it. Scrooge's niece played well upon the harp; and played among other tunes a simple little air (a mere nothing: you might learn to whistle it in two minutes), which had been familiar to the child who fetched Scrooge from the boarding-school, as he had been reminded by the Ghost of Christmas Past. When this strain of music sounded, all the things that Ghost had shown him, came upon his mind; he softened more and more; and thought that if he could have listened to it often, years ago, he might have cultivated the kindnesses of life for his own happiness with his own hands, without resorting to the sexton's spade that buried Jacob Marley.

But they didn't devote the whole evening to music. After a while they played at forfeits; for it is good to be children sometimes, and never better than at Christmas, when its mighty Founder was a child himself. Stop! There was first a game at blind-man's buff. Of course there was. And I no more believe Topper was really blind than I believe he had eyes in his boots. My opinion is, that it was a done thing between him and Scrooge's nephew; and that the Ghost of Christmas Present knew it. The way he went after that plump sister in the lace tucker, was an outrage on the credulity of human nature. Knocking down the fire-irons, tumbling over the chairs, bumping against the piano, smothering himself among the curtains, wherever she went, there went he! He always knew where the plump sister was. He wouldn't catch anybody else. If you had fallen up against him (as some of them did), on purpose, he would have made a feint of endeavouring to seize you, which would have been an affront to your understanding, and would instantly have sidled off in the direction of the plump sister. She often cried out that it wasn't fair; and it really was not. But when at last, he caught her; when, in spite of all her silken rustlings, and her rapid flutterings past him, he got her into a corner whence there was no escape; then his conduct was the most execrable. For his pretending not to know her; his pretending that it was necessary to touch her head-dress, and further to assure himself of her identity by pressing a certain ring upon her finger, and a certain chain about her neck; was vile, monstrous! No doubt she told him her opinion of it, when, another blind-man being in office, they were so very confidential together, behind the curtains.

Scrooge's niece was not one of the blind-man's buff party, but was made comfortable with a large chair and a footstool, in a snug corner, where the Ghost and Scrooge were close

behind her. But she joined in the forfeits, and loved her love to admiration with all the letters of the alphabet. Likewise at the game of How, When, and Where, she was very great, and to the secret joy of Scrooge's nephew, beat her sisters hollow: though they were sharp girls too, as Topper could have told you. There might have been twenty people there, young and old, but they all played, and so did Scrooge; for wholly forgetting in the interest he had in what was going on, that his voice made no sound in their ears, he sometimes came out with his guess quite loud, and very often guessed quite right, too; for the sharpest needle, best Whitechapel, warranted not to cut in the eye, was not sharper than Scrooge; blunt as he took it in his head to be.

The Ghost was greatly pleased to find him in this mood, and looked upon him with such favour, that he begged like a boy to be allowed to stay until the guests departed. But this the Spirit said could not be done.

"Here is a new game," said Scrooge. "One half hour, Spirit, only one!"

It was a Game called Yes and No, where Scrooge's nephew had to think of something, and the rest must find out what; he only answering to their questions yes or no, as the case was. The brisk fire of questioning to which he was exposed, elicited from him that he was thinking of an animal, a live animal, rather a disagreeable animal, a savage animal, an animal that growled and grunted sometimes, and talked sometimes, and lived in London, and walked about the streets, and wasn't made a show of, and wasn't led by anybody, and didn't live in a menagerie, and was never killed in a market, and was not a horse, or an ass, or a cow, or a bull, or a tiger, or a dog, or a pig, or a cat, or a bear. At every fresh question that was put to him, this nephew burst into a fresh roar of laughter; and was so inexpressibly tickled, that he was obliged to get up off the sofa and stamp. At last the plump sister, falling into a similar state, cried out:

"I have found it out! I know what it is, Fred! I know what it is!"

"What is it?" cried Fred.

"It's your Uncle Scro-o-o-o-oge!"

Which it certainly was. Admiration was the universal sentiment, though some objected that the reply to "Is it a bear?" ought to have been "Yes;" inasmuch as an answer in the negative was sufficient to have diverted their thoughts from Mr. Scrooge, supposing they had ever had any tendency that way.

"He has given us plenty of merriment, I am sure," said Fred, "and it would be ungrateful not to drink his health. Here is a glass of mulled wine ready to our hand at the moment; and I say, 'Uncle Scrooge!'"

"Well! Uncle Scrooge!" they cried.

"A Merry Christmas and a Happy New Year to the old man, whatever he is!" said Scrooge's nephew. "He wouldn't take it from me, but may he have it, nevertheless. Uncle Scrooge!"

Uncle Scrooge had imperceptibly become so gay and light of heart, that he would have pledged the unconscious company in return, and thanked them in an inaudible speech, if the Ghost had given him time. But the whole scene passed off in the breath of the last word spoken by his nephew; and he and the Spirit were again upon their travels.

Much they saw, and far they went, and many homes they visited, but always with a happy end. The Spirit stood beside sick beds, and they were cheerful; on foreign lands, and they were close at home; by struggling men, and they were patient in their greater hope; by poverty, and it was rich. In almshouse, hospital, and jail, in misery's every refuge, where vain man in his little brief authority had not made fast the door, and barred the Spirit out, he left his blessing, and taught Scrooge his precepts.

It was a long night, if it were only a night; but Scrooge had his doubts of this, because the Christmas Holidays appeared to be condensed into the space of time they passed together. It was strange, too, that while Scrooge remained unaltered in his outward form, the Ghost grew older, clearly older. Scrooge had observed this change, but never spoke of it, until they left a children's Twelfth Night party, when, looking at the Spirit as they stood together in an open place, he noticed that its hair was grey.

"Are spirits' lives so short?" asked Scrooge.

"My life upon this globe, is very brief," replied the Ghost. "It ends to-night."

"To-night!" cried Scrooge.

"To-night at midnight. Hark! The time is drawing near."

The chimes were ringing the three quarters past eleven at that moment.

"Forgive me if I am not justified in what I ask," said Scrooge, looking intently at the Spirit's robe, "but I see something strange, and not belonging to yourself, protruding from your skirts. Is it a foot or a claw?"

"It might be a claw, for the flesh there is upon it," was the Spirit's sorrowful reply. "Look here."

From the foldings of its robe, it brought two children; wretched, abject, frightful, hideous, miserable. They knelt down at its feet, and clung upon the outside of its garment.

"Oh, Man! look here. Look, look, down here!" exclaimed the Ghost.

They were a boy and girl. Yellow, meagre, ragged, scowling, wolfish; but prostrate, too, in their humility. Where graceful youth should have filled their features out, and touched them with its freshest tints, a stale and shrivelled hand, like that of age, had pinched, and twisted them, and pulled them into shreds. Where angels might have sat enthroned, devils lurked, and glared out menacing. No change, no degradation, no perversion of humanity, in any grade, through all the mysteries of wonderful creation, has monsters half so horrible and dread.

Scrooge started back, appalled. Having them shown to him in this way, he tried to say they were fine children, but the words choked themselves, rather than be parties to a lie of such enormous magnitude.

“Spirit! are they yours?” Scrooge could say no more.

“They are Man’s,” said the Spirit, looking down upon them. “And they cling to me, appealing from their fathers. This boy is Ignorance. This girl is Want. Beware them both, and all of their degree, but most of all beware this boy, for on his brow I see that written which is Doom, unless the writing be erased. Deny it!” cried the Spirit, stretching out its hand towards the city. “Slander those who tell it ye! Admit it for your factious purposes, and make it worse. And bide the end!”

“Have they no refuge or resource?” cried Scrooge.

“Are there no prisons?” said the Spirit, turning on him for the last time with his own words. “Are there no workhouses?”

The bell struck twelve.

Scrooge looked about him for the Ghost, and saw it not. As the last stroke ceased to vibrate, he remembered the prediction of old Jacob Marley, and lifting up his eyes, beheld a solemn Phantom, draped and hooded, coming, like a mist along the ground, towards him.

STAVE FOUR

The Last of the Spirits

WORDS TO KNOW

shrouded	Wrapped or covered, as a body is wrapped for burial.
solemn	Serious and grave.
spectral	Ghostly.
obscure	Hidden or hard to see.
plunder	Stolen goods.
intercede	To plead on someone else's behalf.
neglected	Not cared for.

THE Phantom slowly, gravely, silently, approached. When it came near him, Scrooge bent down upon his knee; for in the very air through which this Spirit moved it seemed to scatter gloom and mystery.

It was shrouded in a deep black garment, which concealed its head, its face, its form, and left nothing of it visible save one outstretched hand. But for this it would have been difficult to detach its figure from the night, and separate it from the darkness by which it was surrounded.

He felt that it was tall and stately when it came beside him, and that its mysterious presence filled him with a solemn dread. He knew no more, for the Spirit neither spoke nor moved.

“I am in the presence of the Ghost of Christmas Yet To Come?” said Scrooge.

The Spirit answered not, but pointed onward with its hand.

“You are about to show me shadows of the things that have not happened, but will happen in the time before us,” Scrooge pursued. “Is that so, Spirit?”

The upper portion of the garment was contracted for an instant in its folds, as if the Spirit had inclined its head. That was the only answer he received.

Although well used to ghostly company by this time, Scrooge feared the silent shape so much that his legs trembled beneath him, and he found that he could hardly stand when he

prepared to follow it. The Spirit paused a moment, as observing his condition, and giving him time to recover.

But Scrooge was all the worse for this. It thrilled him with a vague uncertain horror, to know that behind the dusky shroud, there were ghostly eyes intently fixed upon him, while he, though he stretched his own to the utmost, could see nothing but a spectral hand and one great heap of black.

"Ghost of the Future!" he exclaimed, "I fear you more than any spectre I have seen. But as I know your purpose is to do me good, and as I hope to live to be another man from what I was, I am prepared to bear you company, and do it with a thankful heart. Will you not speak to me?"

It gave him no reply. The hand was pointed straight before them.

"Lead on!" said Scrooge. "Lead on! The night is waning fast, and it is precious time to me, I know. Lead on, Spirit!"

The Phantom moved away as it had come towards him. Scrooge followed in the shadow of its dress, which bore him up, he thought, and carried him along.

They scarcely seemed to enter the city; for the city rather seemed to spring up about them, and encompass them of its own act. But there they were, in the heart of it; on 'Change, amongst the merchants; who hurried up and down, and chinked the money in their pockets, and conversed in groups, and looked at their watches, and trifled thoughtfully with their great gold seals; and so forth, as Scrooge had seen them often.

The Spirit stopped beside one little knot of business men. Observing that the hand was pointed to them, Scrooge advanced to listen to their talk.

"No," said a great fat man with a monstrous chin, "I don't know much about it, either way. I only know he's dead."

"When did he die?" inquired another.

"Last night, I believe."

"Why, what was the matter with him?" asked a third, taking a vast quantity of snuff out of a very large snuff-box. "I thought he'd never die."

"God knows," said the first, with a yawn.

"What has he done with his money?" asked a red-faced gentleman with a pendulous excrescence on the end of his nose, that shook like the gills of a turkey-cock.

"I haven't heard," said the man with the large chin, yawning again. "Left it to his company, perhaps. He hasn't left it to me. That's all I know."

This pleasantry was received with a general laugh.

"It's likely to be a very cheap funeral," said the same speaker; "for upon my life I don't know of anybody to go to it. Suppose we make up a party and volunteer?"

"I don't mind going if a lunch is provided," observed the gentleman with the excrescence on his nose. "But I must be fed, if I make one."

Another laugh.

"Well, I am the most disinterested among you, after all," said the first speaker, "for I never wear black gloves, and I never eat lunch. But I'll offer to go, if anybody else will. When I come to think of it, I'm not at all sure that I wasn't his most particular friend; for we used to stop and speak whenever we met. Bye, bye!"

Speakers and listeners strolled away, and mixed with other groups. Scrooge knew the men, and looked towards the Spirit for an explanation.

The Phantom glided on into a street. Its finger pointed to two persons meeting. Scrooge listened again, thinking that the explanation might lie here.

He knew these men, also, perfectly. They were men of business: very wealthy, and of great importance. He had made a point always of standing well in their esteem: in a business point of view, that is; strictly in a business point of view.

"How are you?" said one.

"How are you?" returned the other.

"Well!" said the first. "Old Scratch has got his own at last, hey?"

"So I am told," returned the second. "Cold, isn't it?"

"Seasonable for Christmas time. You're not a skater, I suppose?"

"No. No. Something else to think of. Good morning!"

Not another word. That was their meeting, their conversation, and their parting.

Scrooge was at first inclined to be surprised that the Spirit should attach importance to conversations apparently so trivial; but feeling assured that they must have some hidden purpose, he set himself to consider what it was likely to be. They could scarcely be supposed to have any bearing on the death of Jacob, his old partner, for that was Past, and this Ghost's

province was the Future. Nor could he think of any one immediately connected with himself, to whom he could apply them. But nothing doubting that to whomsoever they applied they had some latent moral for his own improvement, he resolved to treasure up every word he heard, and everything he saw; and especially to observe the shadow of himself when it appeared. For he had an expectation that the conduct of his future self would give him the clue he missed, and would render the solution of these riddles easy.

He looked about in that very place for his own image; but another man stood in his accustomed corner, and though the clock pointed to his usual time of day for being there, he saw no likeness of himself among the multitudes that poured in through the Porch. It gave him little surprise, however; for he had been revolving in his mind a change of life, and thought and hoped he saw his new-born resolutions carried out in this.

Quiet and dark, beside him stood the Phantom, with its outstretched hand. When he roused himself from his thoughtful quest, he fancied from the turn of the hand, and its situation in reference to himself, that the Unseen Eyes were looking at him keenly. It made him shudder, and feel very cold.

They left the busy scene, and went into an obscure part of the town, where Scrooge had never penetrated before, although he recognised its situation, and its bad repute. The ways were foul and narrow; the shops and houses wretched; the people half-naked, drunken, slipshod, ugly. Alleys and archways, like so many cesspools, disgorged their offences of smell, and dirt, and life, upon the straggling streets; and the whole quarter reeked with crime, with filth, and misery.

Far in this den of infamous resort, there was a low-browed, beetling shop, below a pent-house roof, where iron, old rags, bottles, bones, and greasy offal, were bought. Upon the floor within, were piled up heaps of rusty keys, nails, chains, hinges, files, scales, weights, and refuse iron of all kinds. Secrets that few would like to scrutinise were bred and hidden in mountains of unseemly rags, masses of corrupted fat, and sepulchres of bones. Sitting in among the wares he dealt in, by a charcoal stove, made of old bricks, was a grey-haired rascal, nearly seventy years of age; who had screened himself from the cold air without, by a frousy curtaining of miscellaneous tatters, hung upon a line; and smoked his pipe in all the luxury of calm retirement.

Scrooge and the Phantom came into the presence of this man, just as a woman with a heavy bundle slunk into the shop. But she had scarcely entered, when another woman, similarly laden, came in too; and she was closely followed by a man in faded black, who was no less startled by the sight of them, than they had been upon the recognition of each other. After a short period of blank astonishment, in which the old man with the pipe had joined

them, they all three burst into a laugh.

"Let the charwoman alone to be the first!" cried she who had entered first. "Let the laundress alone to be the second; and let the undertaker's man alone to be the third. Look here, old Joe, here's a chance! If we haven't all three met here without meaning it!"

"You couldn't have met in a better place," said old Joe, removing his pipe from his mouth. "Come into the parlour. You were made free of it long ago, you know; and the other two an't strangers. Stop till I shut the door of the shop. Ah! How it skreeks! There an't such a rusty bit of metal in the place as its own hinges, I believe; and I'm sure there's no such old bones here, as mine. Ha, ha! We're all suitable to our calling, we're well matched. Come into the parlour. Come into the parlour."

The parlour was the space behind the screen of rags. The old man raked the fire together with an old stair-rod, and having trimmed his smoky lamp (for it was night), with the stem of his pipe, put it in his mouth again.

While he did this, the woman who had already spoken threw her bundle on the floor, and sat down in a flaunting manner on a stool; crossing her elbows on her knees, and looking with a bold defiance at the other two.

"What odds then! What odds, Mrs. Dilber?" said the woman. "Every person has a right to take care of themselves. He always did."

"That's true, indeed!" said the laundress. "No man more so."

"Why then, don't stand staring as if you was afraid, woman; who's the wiser? We're not going to pick holes in each other's coats, I suppose?"

"No, indeed!" said Mrs. Dilber and the man together. "We should hope not."

"Very well, then!" cried the woman. "That's enough. Who's the worse for the loss of a few things like these? Not a dead man, I suppose."

"No, indeed," said Mrs. Dilber, laughing.

"If he wanted to keep 'em after he was dead, a wicked old screw," pursued the woman, "why wasn't he natural in his lifetime? If he had been, he'd have had somebody to look after him when he was struck with Death, instead of lying gasping out his last there, alone by himself."

"It's the truest word that ever was spoke," said Mrs. Dilber. "It's a judgment on him."

"I wish it was a little heavier judgment," replied the woman; "and it should have been, you may depend upon it, if I could have laid my hands on anything else. Open that bundle, old Joe,

and let me know the value of it. Speak out plain. I'm not afraid to be the first, nor afraid for them to see it. We know pretty well that we were helping ourselves, before we met here, I believe. It's no sin. Open the bundle, Joe."

But the gallantry of her friends would not allow of this; and the man in faded black, mounting the breach first, produced his plunder. It was not extensive. A seal or two, a pencil-case, a pair of sleeve-buttons, and a brooch of no great value, were all. They were severally examined and appraised by old Joe, who chalked the sums he was disposed to give for each, upon the wall, and added them up into a total when he found there was nothing more to come.

"That's your account," said Joe, "and I wouldn't give another sixpence, if I was to be boiled for not doing it. Who's next?"

Mrs. Dilber was next. Sheets and towels, a little wearing apparel, two old-fashioned silver teaspoons, a pair of sugar-tongs, and a few boots. Her account was stated on the wall in the same manner.

"I always give too much to ladies. It's a weakness of mine, and that's the way I ruin myself," said old Joe. "That's your account. If you asked me for another penny, and made it an open question, I'd repent of being so liberal and knock off half-a-crown."

"And now undo my bundle, Joe," said the first woman.

Joe went down on his knees for the greater convenience of opening it, and having unfastened a great many knots, dragged out a large and heavy roll of some dark stuff.

"What do you call this?" said Joe. "Bed-curtains!"

"Ah!" returned the woman, laughing and leaning forward on her crossed arms. "Bed-curtains!"

"You don't mean to say you took 'em down, rings and all, with him lying there?" said Joe.

"Yes I do," replied the woman. "Why not?"

"You were born to make your fortune," said Joe, "and you'll certainly do it."

"I certainly shan't hold my hand, when I can get anything in it by reaching it out, for the sake of such a man as He was, I promise you, Joe," returned the woman coolly. "Don't drop that oil upon the blankets, now."

"His blankets?" asked Joe.

"Whose else's do you think?" replied the woman. "He isn't likely to take cold without 'em, I dare say."

"I hope he didn't die of anything catching? Eh?" said old Joe, stopping in his work, and looking up.

"Don't you be afraid of that," returned the woman. "I an't so fond of his company that I'd loiter about him for such things, if he did. Ah! you may look through that shirt till your eyes ache; but you won't find a hole in it, nor a threadbare place. It's the best he had, and a fine one too. They'd have wasted it, if it hadn't been for me."

"What do you call wasting of it?" asked old Joe.

"Putting it on him to be buried in, to be sure," replied the woman with a laugh. "Somebody was fool enough to do it, but I took it off again. If calico an't good enough for such a purpose, it isn't good enough for anything. It's quite as becoming to the body. He can't look uglier than he did in that one."

Scrooge listened to this dialogue in horror. As they sat grouped about their spoil, in the scanty light afforded by the old man's lamp, he viewed them with a detestation and disgust, which could hardly have been greater, though they had been obscene demons, marketing the corpse itself.

"Ha, ha!" laughed the same woman, when old Joe, producing a flannel bag with money in it, told out their several gains upon the ground. "This is the end of it, you see! He frightened every one away from him when he was alive, to profit us when he was dead! Ha, ha, ha!"

"Spirit!" said Scrooge, shuddering from head to foot. "I see, I see. The case of this unhappy man might be my own. My life tends that way, now. Merciful Heaven, what is this!"

He recoiled in terror, for the scene had changed, and now he almost touched a bed: a bare, uncurtained bed: on which, beneath a ragged sheet, there lay a something covered up, which, though it was dumb, announced itself in awful language.

The room was very dark, too dark to be observed with any accuracy, though Scrooge glanced round it in obedience to a secret impulse, anxious to know what kind of room it was. A pale light, rising in the outer air, fell straight upon the bed; and on it, plundered and bereft, unwatched, unwept, uncared for, was the body of this man.

Scrooge glanced towards the Phantom. Its steady hand was pointed to the head. The cover was so carelessly adjusted that the slightest raising of it, the motion of a finger upon Scrooge's part, would have disclosed the face. He thought of it, felt how easy it would be to do, and longed to do it; but had no more power to withdraw the veil than to dismiss the spectre at

his side.

Oh cold, cold, rigid, dreadful Death, set up thine altar here, and dress it with such terrors as thou hast at thy command: for this is thy dominion! But of the loved, revered, and honoured head, thou canst not turn one hair to thy dread purposes, or make one feature odious. It is not that the hand is heavy and will fall down when released; it is not that the heart and pulse are still; but that the hand WAS open, generous, and true; the heart brave, warm, and tender; and the pulse a man's. Strike, Shadow, strike! And see his good deeds springing from the wound, to sow the world with life immortal!

No voice pronounced these words in Scrooge's ears, and yet he heard them when he looked upon the bed. He thought, if this man could be raised up now, what would be his foremost thoughts? Avarice, hard-dealing, griping cares? They have brought him to a rich end, truly!

He lay, in the dark empty house, with not a man, a woman, or a child, to say that he was kind to me in this or that, and for the memory of one kind word I will be kind to him. A cat was tearing at the door, and there was a sound of gnawing rats beneath the hearth-stone. What they wanted in the room of death, and why they were so restless and disturbed, Scrooge did not dare to think.

"Spirit!" he said, "this is a fearful place. In leaving it, I shall not leave its lesson, trust me. Let us go!"

Still the Ghost pointed with an unmoved finger to the head.

"I understand you," Scrooge returned, "and I would do it, if I could. But I have not the power, Spirit. I have not the power."

Again it seemed to look upon him.

"If there is any person in the town, who feels emotion caused by this man's death," said Scrooge quite agonised, "show that person to me, Spirit, I beseech you!"

The Phantom spread its dark robe before him for a moment, like a wing; and withdrawing it, revealed a room by daylight, where a mother and her children were.

She was expecting some one, and with anxious eagerness; for she walked up and down the room; started at every sound; looked out from the window; glanced at the clock; tried, but in vain, to work with her needle; and could hardly bear the voices of the children in their play.

At length the long-expected knock was heard. She hurried to the door, and met her husband; a man whose face was careworn and depressed, though he was young. There was a remarkable expression in it now; a kind of serious delight of which he felt ashamed, and which he struggled to repress.

He sat down to the dinner that had been hoarding for him by the fire; and when she asked him faintly what news (which was not until after a long silence), he appeared embarrassed how to answer.

"Is it good?" she said, "or bad?"—to help him.

"Bad," he answered.

"We are quite ruined?"

"No. There is hope yet, Caroline."

"If he relents," she said, amazed, "there is! Nothing is past hope, if such a miracle has happened."

"He is past relenting," said her husband. "He is dead."

She was a mild and patient creature if her face spoke truth; but she was thankful in her soul to hear it, and she said so, with clasped hands. She prayed forgiveness the next moment, and was sorry; but the first was the emotion of her heart.

"What the half-drunken woman whom I told you of last night, said to me, when I tried to see him and obtain a week's delay; and what I thought was a mere excuse to avoid me; turns out to have been quite true. He was not only very ill, but dying, then."

"To whom will our debt be transferred?"

"I don't know. But before that time we shall be ready with the money; and even though we were not, it would be a bad fortune indeed to find so merciless a creditor in his successor. We may sleep to-night with light hearts, Caroline!"

Yes. Soften it as they would, their hearts were lighter. The children's faces, hushed and clustered round to hear what they so little understood, were brighter; and it was a happier house for this man's death! The only emotion that the Ghost could show him, caused by the event, was one of pleasure.

"Let me see some tenderness connected with a death," said Scrooge; "or that dark chamber, Spirit, which we left just now, will be for ever present to me."

The Ghost conducted him through several streets familiar to his feet; and as they went along, Scrooge looked here and there to find himself, but nowhere was he to be seen. They entered poor Bob Cratchit's house; the dwelling he had visited before; and found the mother and the children seated round the fire.

Quiet. Very quiet. The noisy little Cratchits were as still as statues in one corner, and sat looking up at Peter, who had a book before him. The mother and her daughters were engaged in sewing. But surely they were very quiet!

"'And He took a child, and set him in the midst of them.'"

Where had Scrooge heard those words? He had not dreamed them. The boy must have read them out, as he and the Spirit crossed the threshold. Why did he not go on?

The mother laid her work upon the table, and put her hand up to her face.

"The colour hurts my eyes," she said.

The colour? Ah, poor Tiny Tim!

"They're better now again," said Cratchit's wife. "It makes them weak by candle-light; and I wouldn't show weak eyes to your father when he comes home, for the world. It must be near his time."

"Past it rather," Peter answered, shutting up his book. "But I think he has walked a little slower than he used, these few last evenings, mother."

They were very quiet again. At last she said, and in a steady, cheerful voice, that only faltered once:

"I have known him walk with—I have known him walk with Tiny Tim upon his shoulder, very fast indeed."

"And so have I," cried Peter. "Often."

"And so have I," exclaimed another. So had all.

"But he was very light to carry," she resumed, intent upon her work, "and his father loved him so, that it was no trouble: no trouble. And there is your father at the door!"

She hurried out to meet him; and little Bob in his comforter —he had need of it, poor fellow—came in. His tea was ready for him on the hob, and they all tried who should help him to it most. Then the two young Cratchits got upon his knees and laid, each child a little cheek, against his face, as if they said, "Don't mind it, father. Don't be grieved!"

Bob was very cheerful with them, and spoke pleasantly to all the family. He looked at the work upon the table, and praised the industry and speed of Mrs. Cratchit and the girls. They would be done long before Sunday, he said.

"Sunday! You went to-day, then, Robert?" said his wife.

"Yes, my dear," returned Bob. "I wish you could have gone. It would have done you good to see how green a place it is. But you'll see it often. I promised him that I would walk there on a Sunday. My little, little child!" cried Bob. "My little child!"

He broke down all at once. He couldn't help it. If he could have helped it, he and his child would have been farther apart perhaps than they were.

He left the room, and went up-stairs into the room above, which was lighted cheerfully, and hung with Christmas. There was a chair set close beside the child, and there were signs of some one having been there, lately. Poor Bob sat down in it, and when he had thought a little and composed himself, he kissed the little face. He was reconciled to what had happened, and went down again quite happy.

They drew about the fire, and talked; the girls and mother working still. Bob told them of the extraordinary kindness of Mr. Scrooge's nephew, whom he had scarcely seen but once, and who, meeting him in the street that day, and seeing that he looked a little—"just a little down you know," said Bob, inquired what had happened to distress him. "On which," said Bob, "for he is the pleasantest-spoken gentleman you ever heard, I told him. 'I am heartily sorry for it, Mr. Cratchit,' he said, 'and heartily sorry for your good wife.' By the bye, how he ever knew that, I don't know."

"Knew what, my dear?"

"Why, that you were a good wife," replied Bob.

"Everybody knows that!" said Peter.

"Very well observed, my boy!" cried Bob. "I hope they do. 'Heartily sorry,' he said, 'for your good wife. If I can be of service to you in any way,' he said, giving me his card, 'that's where I live. Pray come to me.' Now, it wasn't," cried Bob, "for the sake of anything he might be able to do for us, so much as for his kind way, that this was quite delightful. It really seemed as if he had known our Tiny Tim, and felt with us."

"I'm sure he's a good soul!" said Mrs. Cratchit.

"You would be surer of it, my dear," returned Bob, "if you saw and spoke to him. I shouldn't be at all surprised— mark what I say!—if he got Peter a better situation."

"Only hear that, Peter," said Mrs. Cratchit.

"And then," cried one of the girls, "Peter will be keeping company with some one, and setting up for himself."

"Get along with you!" retorted Peter, grinning.

"It's just as likely as not," said Bob, "one of these days; though there's plenty of time for that, my dear. But however and whenever we part from one another, I am sure we shall none of us forget poor Tiny Tim—shall we—or this first parting that there was among us?"

"Never, father!" cried they all.

"And I know," said Bob, "I know, my dears, that when we recollect how patient and how mild he was; although he was a little, little child; we shall not quarrel easily among ourselves, and forget poor Tiny Tim in doing it."

"No, never, father!" they all cried again.

"I am very happy," said little Bob, "I am very happy!"

Mrs. Cratchit kissed him, his daughters kissed him, the two young Cratchits kissed him, and Peter and himself shook hands. Spirit of Tiny Tim, thy childish essence was from God!

"Spectre," said Scrooge, "something informs me that our parting moment is at hand. I know it, but I know not how. Tell me what man that was whom we saw lying dead?"

The Ghost of Christmas Yet To Come conveyed him, as before—though at a different time, he thought: indeed, there seemed no order in these latter visions, save that they were in the Future—into the resorts of business men, but showed him not himself. Indeed, the Spirit did not stay for anything, but went straight on, as to the end just now desired, until besought by Scrooge to tarry for a moment.

"This court," said Scrooge, "through which we hurry now, is where my place of occupation is, and has been for a length of time. I see the house. Let me behold what I shall be, in days to come!"

The Spirit stopped; the hand was pointed elsewhere.

"The house is yonder," Scrooge exclaimed. "Why do you point away?"

The inexorable finger underwent no change.

Scrooge hastened to the window of his office, and looked in. It was an office still, but not his. The furniture was not the same, and the figure in the chair was not himself. The Phantom pointed as before.

He joined it once again, and wondering why and whither he had gone, accompanied it until they reached an iron gate. He paused to look round before entering.

A churchyard. Here, then; the wretched man whose name he had now to learn, lay underneath the ground. It was a worthy place. Walled in by houses; overrun by grass and

weeds, the growth of vegetation's death, not life; choked up with too much burying; fat with repleted appetite. A worthy place!

The Spirit stood among the graves, and pointed down to One. He advanced towards it trembling. The Phantom was exactly as it had been, but he dreaded that he saw new meaning in its solemn shape.

"Before I draw nearer to that stone to which you point," said Scrooge, "answer me one question. Are these the shadows of the things that Will be, or are they shadows of things that May be, only?"

Still the Ghost pointed downward to the grave by which it stood.

"Men's courses will foreshadow certain ends, to which, if persevered in, they must lead," said Scrooge. "But if the courses be departed from, the ends will change. Say it is thus with what you show me!"

The Spirit was immovable as ever.

Scrooge crept towards it, trembling as he went; and following the finger, read upon the stone of the neglected grave his own name, EBENEZER SCROOGE.

"Am I that man who lay upon the bed?" he cried, upon his knees.

The finger pointed from the grave to him, and back again.

"No, Spirit! Oh no, no!"

The finger still was there.

"Spirit!" he cried, tight clutching at its robe, "hear me! I am not the man I was. I will not be the man I must have been but for this intercourse. Why show me this, if I am past all hope!"

For the first time the hand appeared to shake.

"Good Spirit," he pursued, as down upon the ground he fell before it: "Your nature intercedes for me, and pities me. Assure me that I yet may change these shadows you have shown me, by an altered life!"

The kind hand trembled.

"I will honour Christmas in my heart, and try to keep it all the year. I will live in the Past, the Present, and the Future. The Spirits of all Three shall strive within me. I will not shut out the lessons that they teach. Oh, tell me I may sponge away the writing on this stone!"

In his agony, he caught the spectral hand. It sought to free itself, but he was strong in his entreaty, and detained it. The Spirit, stronger yet, repulsed him.

Holding up his hands in a last prayer to have his fate reversed, he saw an alteration in the Phantom's hood and dress. It shrunk, collapsed, and dwindled down into a bedpost.

STAVE FIVE

The End of It

WORDS TO KNOW

transported	Overwhelmed with joy.
Hallo	An old spelling of hello, often shouted.
gruel	A thin, watery porridge.
earnest	Serious and sincere.
idle	Lazy; not working.

YES! and the bedpost was his own. The bed was his own, the room was his own. Best and happiest of all, the Time before him was his own, to make amends in!

"I will live in the Past, the Present, and the Future!" Scrooge repeated, as he scrambled out of bed. "The Spirits of all Three shall strive within me. Oh Jacob Marley! Heaven, and the Christmas Time be praised for this! I say it on my knees, old Jacob; on my knees!"

He was so fluttered and so glowing with his good intentions, that his broken voice would scarcely answer to his call. He had been sobbing violently in his conflict with the Spirit, and his face was wet with tears.

"They are not torn down," cried Scrooge, folding one of his bed-curtains in his arms, "they are not torn down, rings and all. They are here—I am here—the shadows of the things that would have been, may be dispelled. They will be. I know they will!"

His hands were busy with his garments all this time; turning them inside out, putting them on upside down, tearing them, mislaying them, making them parties to every kind of extravagance.

"I don't know what to do!" cried Scrooge, laughing and crying in the same breath; and making a perfect Laocoön of himself with his stockings. "I am as light as a feather, I am as happy as an angel, I am as merry as a schoolboy. I am as giddy as a drunken man. A merry Christmas to everybody! A happy New Year to all the world. Hallo here! Whoop! Hallo!"

He had frisked into the sitting-room, and was now standing there: perfectly winded.

"There's the saucepan that the gruel was in!" cried Scrooge, starting off again, and going round the fireplace. "There's the door, by which the Ghost of Jacob Marley entered! There's

the corner where the Ghost of Christmas Present, sat! There's the window where I saw the wandering Spirits! It's all right, it's all true, it all happened. Ha ha ha!"

Really, for a man who had been out of practice for so many years, it was a splendid laugh, a most illustrious laugh. The father of a long, long line of brilliant laughs!

"I don't know what day of the month it is!" said Scrooge. "I don't know how long I've been among the Spirits. I don't know anything. I'm quite a baby. Never mind. I don't care. I'd rather be a baby. Hallo! Whoop! Hallo here!"

He was checked in his transports by the churches ringing out the lustiest peals he had ever heard. Clash, clang, hammer; ding, dong, bell. Bell, dong, ding; hammer, clang, clash! Oh, glorious, glorious!

Running to the window, he opened it, and put out his head. No fog, no mist; clear, bright, jovial, stirring, cold; cold, piping for the blood to dance to; Golden sunlight; Heavenly sky; sweet fresh air; merry bells. Oh, glorious! Glorious!

"What's to-day!" cried Scrooge, calling downward to a boy in Sunday clothes, who perhaps had loitered in to look about him.

"EH?" returned the boy, with all his might of wonder.

"What's to-day, my fine fellow?" said Scrooge.

"To-day!" replied the boy. "Why, CHRISTMAS DAY."

"It's Christmas Day!" said Scrooge to himself. "I haven't missed it. The Spirits have done it all in one night. They can do anything they like. Of course they can. Of course they can. Hallo, my fine fellow!"

"Hallo!" returned the boy.

"Do you know the Poulterer's, in the next street but one, at the corner?" Scrooge inquired.

"I should hope I did," replied the lad.

"An intelligent boy!" said Scrooge. "A remarkable boy! Do you know whether they've sold the prize Turkey that was hanging up there?—Not the little prize Turkey: the big one?"

"What, the one as big as me?" returned the boy.

"What a delightful boy!" said Scrooge. "It's a pleasure to talk to him. Yes, my buck!"

"It's hanging there now," replied the boy.

"Is it?" said Scrooge. "Go and buy it."

"Walk-ER!" exclaimed the boy.

"No, no," said Scrooge, "I am in earnest. Go and buy it, and tell 'em to bring it here, that I may give them the direction where to take it. Come back with the man, and I'll give you a shilling. Come back with him in less than five minutes and I'll give you half-a-crown!"

The boy was off like a shot. He must have had a steady hand at a trigger who could have got a shot off half so fast.

"I'll send it to Bob Cratchit's!" whispered Scrooge, rubbing his hands, and splitting with a laugh. "He sha'n't know who sends it. It's twice the size of Tiny Tim. Joe Miller never made such a joke as sending it to Bob's will be!"

The hand in which he wrote the address was not a steady one, but write it he did, somehow, and went down-stairs to open the street door, ready for the coming of the poulterer's man. As he stood there, waiting his arrival, the knocker caught his eye.

"I shall love it, as long as I live!" cried Scrooge, patting it with his hand. "I scarcely ever looked at it before. What an honest expression it has in its face! It's a wonderful knocker!—Here's the Turkey! Hallo! Whoop! How are you! Merry Christmas!"

It was a Turkey! He never could have stood upon his legs, that bird. He would have snapped 'em short off in a minute, like sticks of sealing-wax.

"Why, it's impossible to carry that to Camden Town," said Scrooge. "You must have a cab."

The chuckle with which he said this, and the chuckle with which he paid for the Turkey, and the chuckle with which he paid for the cab, and the chuckle with which he recompensed the boy, were only to be exceeded by the chuckle with which he sat down breathless in his chair again, and chuckled till he cried.

Shaving was not an easy task, for his hand continued to shake very much; and shaving requires attention, even when you don't dance while you are at it. But if he had cut the end of his nose off, he would have put a piece of sticking-plaister over it, and been quite satisfied.

He dressed himself "all in his best," and at last got out into the streets. The people were by this time pouring forth, as he had seen them with the Ghost of Christmas Present; and walking with his hands behind him, Scrooge regarded every one with a delighted smile. He looked so irresistibly pleasant, in a word, that three or four good-humoured fellows said, "Good morning, sir! A merry Christmas to you!" And Scrooge said often afterwards, that of all the blithe sounds he had ever heard, those were the blithest in his ears.

He had not gone far, when coming on towards him he beheld the portly gentleman, who had walked into his counting-house the day before, and said, "Scrooge and Marley's, I

believe?" It sent a pang across his heart to think how this old gentleman would look upon him when they met; but he knew what path lay straight before him, and he took it.

"My dear sir," said Scrooge, quickening his pace, and taking the old gentleman by both his hands. "How do you do? I hope you succeeded yesterday. It was very kind of you. A merry Christmas to you, sir!"

"Mr. Scrooge?"

"Yes," said Scrooge. "That is my name, and I fear it may not be pleasant to you. Allow me to ask your pardon. And will you have the goodness"—here Scrooge whispered in his ear.

"Lord bless me!" cried the gentleman, as if his breath were taken away. "My dear Mr. Scrooge, are you serious?"

"If you please," said Scrooge. "Not a farthing less. A great many back-payments are included in it, I assure you. Will you do me that favour?"

"My dear sir," said the other, shaking hands with him. "I don't know what to say to such munifi—"

"Don't say anything, please," retorted Scrooge. "Come and see me. Will you come and see me?"

"I will!" cried the old gentleman. And it was clear he meant to do it.

"Thank'ee," said Scrooge. "I am much obliged to you. I thank you fifty times. Bless you!"

He went to church, and walked about the streets, and watched the people hurrying to and fro, and patted children on the head, and questioned beggars, and looked down into the kitchens of houses, and up to the windows, and found that everything could yield him pleasure. He had never dreamed that any walk—that anything—could give him so much happiness. In the afternoon he turned his steps towards his nephew's house.

He passed the door a dozen times, before he had the courage to go up and knock. But he made a dash, and did it:

"Is your master at home, my dear?" said Scrooge to the girl. Nice girl! Very.

"Yes, sir."

"Where is he, my love?" said Scrooge.

"He's in the dining-room, sir, along with mistress. I'll show you up-stairs, if you please."

"Thank'ee. He knows me," said Scrooge, with his hand already on the dining-room lock. "I'll go in here, my dear."

He turned it gently, and sidled his face in, round the door. They were looking at the table (which was spread out in great array); for these young housekeepers are always nervous on such points, and like to see that everything is right.

"Fred!" said Scrooge.

Dear heart alive, how his niece by marriage started! Scrooge had forgotten, for the moment, about her sitting in the corner with the footstool, or he wouldn't have done it, on any account.

"Why bless my soul!" cried Fred, "who's that?"

"It's I. Your uncle Scrooge. I have come to dinner. Will you let me in, Fred?"

Let him in! It is a mercy he didn't shake his arm off. He was at home in five minutes. Nothing could be heartier. His niece looked just the same. So did Topper when he came. So did the plump sister when she came. So did every one when they came. Wonderful party, wonderful games, wonderful unanimity, won-der-ful happiness!

But he was early at the office next morning. Oh, he was early there. If he could only be there first, and catch Bob Cratchit coming late! That was the thing he had set his heart upon.

And he did it; yes, he did! The clock struck nine. No Bob. A quarter past. No Bob. He was full eighteen minutes and a half behind his time. Scrooge sat with his door wide open, that he might see him come into the Tank.

His hat was off, before he opened the door; his comforter too. He was on his stool in a jiffy; driving away with his pen, as if he were trying to overtake nine o'clock.

"Hallo!" growled Scrooge, in his accustomed voice, as near as he could feign it. "What do you mean by coming here at this time of day?"

"I am very sorry, sir," said Bob. "I am behind my time."

"You are?" repeated Scrooge. "Yes. I think you are. Step this way, sir, if you please."

"It's only once a year, sir," pleaded Bob, appearing from the Tank. "It shall not be repeated. I was making rather merry yesterday, sir."

"Now, I'll tell you what, my friend," said Scrooge, "I am not going to stand this sort of thing any longer. And therefore," he continued, leaping from his stool, and giving Bob such a dig in the waistcoat that he staggered back into the Tank again; "and therefore I am about to raise

your salary!”

Bob trembled, and got a little nearer to the ruler. He had a momentary idea of knocking Scrooge down with it, holding him, and calling to the people in the court for help and a strait-waistcoat.

“A merry Christmas, Bob!” said Scrooge, with an earnestness that could not be mistaken, as he clapped him on the back. “A merrier Christmas, Bob, my good fellow, than I have given you, for many a year! I’ll raise your salary, and endeavour to assist your struggling family, and we will discuss your affairs this very afternoon, over a Christmas bowl of smoking bishop, Bob! Make up the fires, and buy another coal-scuttle before you dot another i, Bob Cratchit!”

Scrooge was better than his word. He did it all, and infinitely more; and to Tiny Tim, who did NOT die, he was a second father. He became as good a friend, as good a master, and as good a man, as the good old city knew, or any other good old city, town, or borough, in the good old world. Some people laughed to see the alteration in him, but he let them laugh, and little heeded them; for he was wise enough to know that nothing ever happened on this globe, for good, at which some people did not have their fill of laughter in the outset; and knowing that such as these would be blind anyway, he thought it quite as well that they should wrinkle up their eyes in grins, as have the malady in less attractive forms. His own heart laughed: and that was quite enough for him.

He had no further intercourse with Spirits, but lived upon the Total Abstinence Principle, ever afterwards; and it was always said of him, that he knew how to keep Christmas well, if any man alive possessed the knowledge. May that be truly said of us, and all of us! And so, as Tiny Tim observed, God bless Us, Every One!

ABOUT THIS TEXT

A Christmas Carol was first published in London by Chapman and Hall on December 19, 1843, and is in the public domain. This part reprints Dickens's complete text, including his short preface, with modern quotation marks. British spellings (colour, spectre, meagre) are kept.

The introduction, character list, and Words to Know were written for VenvLearning.

Want more? Dickens's public reading version, which he cut down to perform on stage, and many illustrated editions are free in the public domain, and there are many stage and film versions to compare with the book.

PART TWO

Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde

Robert Louis Stevenson

Read in Units 3–4: the complete novella, chapter by chapter.

From the Core Classics: Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde Reader (Core Knowledge Language Arts, Grade 7, Unit 3). © Core Knowledge Foundation. CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. This part keeps its original page numbers.



Core Classics

Abridged for Young Readers

Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde

by Robert Louis Stevenson

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Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde

by

Robert Louis Stevenson

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CORE KNOWLEDGE FOUNDATION
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INTRODUCTION

You may know Robert Louis Stevenson as the author of *Treasure Island*, a rousing tale of a young boy's adventures as he grows up among a band of pirates. You may also know Stevenson as the writer of a delightful collection of poetry for children, *A Child's Garden of Verses*. One of those poems, "A Good Boy," begins like this:

I woke before the morning, I was happy all the day,
I never said an ugly word, but smiled and stuck to play.

And now at last the sun is going down behind the wood,
And I am very happy, for I know that I've been good.

The boy is "very happy" because he knows he has "been good." Stevenson says more about being good in a poem titled "The Whole Duty of Children":

A child should always say what's true
And speak when he is spoken to,
And behave mannerly at table;
At least as far as he is able.

In that final line—"At least as far as he is able"—Stevenson is smiling. He knows that it's not easy to always be honest and self-controlled and polite. It's not easy to be good all the time.

About a year after that poem was published, Stevenson wrote a book that again recognizes how hard it is to be good—but this time he wasn't writing for children, and he wasn't smiling. Indeed, this book sprang from a nightmare. His wife, Fanny, recalled that very early one morning she was "awakened by cries of horror" from her husband—and, "thinking he had a nightmare, I awakened him. He said angrily: 'Why did you wake me? I was dreaming a fine bogey tale.'"

What's a "bogey tale"? Think of how children are sometimes told, "The bogeyman will get you!" Stevenson was dreaming a scary story, a tale of horror. From his feverish nightmare came the book published in 1886 as *Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*. (Stevenson did not use *The* in the title.)

In the character of Dr. Jekyll, Stevenson not only shows how hard it is to be good, he also explores *why* it is so hard, especially when powerful impulses inside a person strain to be released—impulses that must be kept down and hidden in order to be a respected member of society. Stevenson's story dramatizes how these dark impulses, once they are allowed to run free,

can grow stronger and stronger—and then the issue is no longer how hard it is to be good but how easy it is to do evil.

Those who have heard of *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* but haven't read the book sometimes assume the two men named in the title represent a clash between good on one side and evil on the other. But Stevenson's story is not a clear case of good versus evil. Rather, it is (as the full title tells us) a "strange case"—troubling and shadowy, like the murky fog that often blankets the London streets where the story is set.

A mix of horror tale, science fiction, and detective story, *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* was an immediate success when it was first published. The story was quickly adapted as a play for the stage. Many years later, it was made into movies, and even into a Bugs Bunny cartoon. Something about the story—something beyond the thrill of a good scare or the pull of a good mystery—keeps readers returning to it even after many generations.

After writing *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*, Stevenson said that he had "long been trying to write a story on this … strong sense of man's double being which must at times come in upon and overwhelm the mind of every thinking creature." As you read this book, think about what Stevenson meant by "man's double being." What is he suggesting

about the nature of the individual self, and about human nature? And what is it about this story that continues to fascinate readers to this day?

Editor's Note
This Core Classics edition of *Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* is abridged and adapted for young readers. Some passages have been left out of the original text, and some have been rewritten to make them more readily understandable. Any adaption is also an interpretation—in choosing what to leave out and what to rewrite, we have tried to be guided by the goal of remaining faithful to the themes, style, and spirit of the original novel.

VICTORIAN LONDON
The Setting of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde

Robert Louis Stevenson set his *Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* in his own time, the late 1880s, in London, the capital city of England.

Late 19th century London was the world's largest city. It was thickly crowded. The city's population had grown from about a million people in 1800 to about six million in 1890.

There were no cars in Stevenson's London; instead, people either walked or, if they were in a hurry, rode in a horse-drawn carriage or a cab called a hansom. By 1890, there were about 300,000 horses in London, and their droppings left the busy main streets filthy indeed.

In late 19th century London, you could look up from filthy streets to breathe filthy air. The Industrial Revolution had brought many factories and railroads to London, all belching smoke into the city's atmosphere. In this time before the widespread use of electricity, the streets were lit by gas-burning lamps. Most people used gas lanterns



Horse-drawn carriages clog this street in late 19TH century London.

and candles for lighting, and heated their homes with coal-burning fireplaces, which thickened the air with coal dust and soot. On many days, London was covered by a thick, brown, choking fog, which Stevenson describes vividly in *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*.

Like many cities, London was home to both great wealth and extreme poverty. Rich factory owners lived with their families in large, luxurious mansions. A comfortable middle class of businessmen, lawyers, doctors (like Dr. Jekyll), and other professionals lived in well-furnished



Thick fog blankets a horse-drawn carriage and a passing chimney sweep on a London street.

houses, with cooks and servants to attend to their needs. The workers who toiled in the factories or on the docks, however, often lived in crowded and dirty slums, in parts of the city troubled by crime and disease. Stevenson's novel offers glimpses of these contrasting parts of London. Dr. Jekyll's own neighborhood embodies social contrast and change—he lives in "a square of ancient, handsome houses, now for the most part decayed from their high estate."



Children crowd the street of a London slum in 1870.

The action of *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* takes place during what is known as the Victorian era in England, after Queen Victoria, who reigned from 1837 to 1901. In Queen Victoria's time, English power and wealth



Queen Victoria in 1887

grew as the British Empire extended its reach across the world. Victoria also shaped the values of her time. Her name has become associated with duty, seriousness, hard work, and self-control. To describe someone as "Victorian" also suggests proper behavior bordering on stiffness, as well as strict morality bordering on prudishness.

In Victorian England, middle-class men and women had different social roles. Men worked and participated in politics. Their wives were expected to raise the children and manage the household. This distinction between men's and women's social roles is not, however, a matter of concern in *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* because Stevenson's main characters are all older unmarried men. They are gentlemen and bachelors who, in accordance with Victorian social standards, are expected to act in a dignified, respectable, and restrained manner—much like the character that Stevenson introduces to us first in the novel, the lawyer Mr. Utterson.



Portrait of a Victorian gentleman

MAIN CHARACTERS IN THE NOVEL

Gabriel John Utterson
A trusted lawyer who is a friend to Dr. Jekyll

Richard Enfield
A "man about town" who is a distant cousin and friend of Mr. Utterson

Dr. Henry Jekyll
A well-known, respected, and wealthy doctor and scientist

Edward Hyde
A mysterious and violent stranger who appears to be deformed in some way

Dr. Hastie Lanyon
A respected doctor and old friend of both Mr. Utterson and Dr. Jekyll, who objects to Jekyll's scientific ideas

Poole
The butler in charge of Dr. Jekyll's household

Sir Danvers Carew
A kind old gentleman and Member of Parliament

Mr. Guest
A law clerk and handwriting expert employed by Mr. Utterson

Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde

by

Robert Louis Stevenson

STRANGE CASE

OF

DR JEKYLL AND MR HYDE

BY

ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON



LONDON
LONGMANS, GREEN, AND CO.
1886

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THE TITLE PAGE OF THE FIRST EDITION (1886)

STORY OF THE DOOR

Mr. Utterson the lawyer was a man whose face was never lighted by a smile; cold, of few words, embarrassed in conversation; lean, long, dusty, dreary, and yet somehow lovable. At friendly meetings, something eminently human beaconed from his eye; something indeed which never found its way into his talk, but which spoke more often and loudly in the acts of his life. He was austere with himself, but he had a tolerance for others—sometimes wondering, almost with envy, at the high spirits involved in their misdeeds—and in any extremity ready to help rather than to reprove. Because of these characteristics, he was

---

lean: thin
dreary: gloomy; not cheerful
eminently: very; completely; greatly
beaconed: shone out
austere: strict; self-disciplined
tolerance: open and accepting attitude, especially toward beliefs or practices different from one's own
envy: the feeling of wanting what someone else has, or of wanting to be like someone else
misdeeds: actions that break the law or go against moral standards
extremity: extreme circumstance; occasion of great difficulty [slang: a scrape, a jam]
reprove: scold; criticize; express disapproval



Mr. Utterson the lawyer was lean, long, dusty, dreary, and yet somehow lovable.

often the last reputable acquaintance and the last good influence in the lives of downgoing men.

Mr. Utterson did not openly show his emotions. He was good-natured to all and, like many a modest man, accepted his friends ready-made as opportunity allowed. His friends were his relatives or those whom he had known the longest; his affections, like ivy, were the growth of time—they did not suggest anything special in the object.

Who Is Mr. Utterson? How does Robert Louis Stevenson describe Mr. Utterson? What qualities might make people like and trust him? How does he relate to other people?

Such was the bond that united him to Mr. Richard Enfield, his distant kinsman, the well-known man about town. It was a nut to crack for many, what these two could see in each other, or

reputable: widely respected and trusted
acquaintance: someone you know but who is not a close friend
downgoing men: men who are experiencing difficulties (such as punishment by the law) as a result of their poor choices, bad acts, or bad luck
good-natured: pleasant and kind
modest: not pretentious or boastful
opportunity: favorable times or conditions
bond: something that binds or holds together
kinsman: relative
man about town: a socially active man who might often be seen at parties, restaurants, theaters, etc.
a nut to crack: a difficult puzzle to figure out

what subject they could find in common. It was reported by those who encountered them in their Sunday walks, that they said nothing and looked very dull. Still, the two men greatly valued these excursions, and counted them the chief delight of each week.

It chanced on one of these rambles that their way led them down a side street in a busy quarter of London. The street was small and quiet, but the shops were busy on the weekdays. The shop fronts stood along that thoroughfare with an air of invitation, like rows of smiling saleswomen. Even on Sunday, when it lay comparatively empty, the street shone out in contrast to its dingy neighborhood, like a fire in a forest; and with its freshly painted shutters, well-polished brasses, and general cleanliness, instantly caught and pleased the eye.

---

in common: shared (between them)
excursions: short trips
rambles: walks taken for pleasure, without a definite destination
thoroughfare: a street that, on either end, opens onto another street
comparatively: considered in comparison to (in this case, to the busy weekdays)
dingy: dirty; run-down; shabby
brasses: shiny hardware on houses and storefronts [Brass is made from two metals, copper and zinc.]

Two doors from one corner, a certain sinister block of building thrust forward on the street. It was two stories high; showed no window, nothing but a door on the lower story and a discolored wall on the upper; and bore in every feature the marks of prolonged and sordid negligence. The door, which had neither bell nor knocker, was blistered and stained. Tramps slouched by the door and struck matches on the panels; children played upon the steps; a schoolboy had tried his knife on the moldings; and for many years, no one had appeared to drive away these random visitors or to repair their ravages.

Mr. Enfield and the lawyer were on the other side of the street. When they came near the door, Mr. Enfield lifted up his cane and pointed.

---

sinister: threatening; menacing
prolonged: extended in time
sordid: unclean (morally or physically); filthy; nasty
negligence: complete lack of care
blistered: marked by cracking and peeling areas
tramps: poor homeless people
slouched: stood in a bent and lazy-looking way
moldings: decorated strips of wood around the edges of the door frame
random: without any plan or pattern
ravages: damaging and destructive actions

"Did you ever notice that door?" he asked. "It is connected in my mind," he added, "with a very odd story."

"Indeed?" said Mr. Utterson, with a slight change of voice, "and what was that?"

"Well," returned Mr. Enfield, "I was coming home from some place at the end of the world, about three o'clock of a black winter morning, and my way lay through a part of town where there was nothing to be seen but lamps. Street after street and all the folks asleep—street after street, all lighted up and all empty—till at last I got into that state of mind when a man listens and listens and begins to long for the sight of a policeman.

"All at once, I saw two figures: one a little man who was stumping along eastward at a good walk, and the other a girl of maybe eight or ten who was running as hard as she was able down a cross street. Well, sir, the two ran into one another at the corner; and then came the horrible part of the thing; for the man trampled calmly over the

---

long: have a strong desire
stumping: walking heavily
trampled: stepped heavily and roughly in a way to crush or injure

child's body and left her screaming on the ground.

"It was hellish to see. It wasn't like a man; it was like some juggernaut. I took to my heels, collared my gentleman, and brought him back to where there was already quite a group about the screaming child. He was perfectly cool and made no resistance, but he gave me one look so ugly that it brought out the sweat on me. The people who had turned out were the girl's own family; and pretty soon, the doctor, for whom she had earlier been sent, appeared. Well, the child was not much the worse, more frightened, according to the sawbones; and there you might have supposed would be an end to it.

"But there was one curious matter. I had taken a loathing to my gentleman at first sight. So had the child's family, which was only natural.

---

juggernaut: an overpowering force or object that smashes or pushes aside everything in its path
took to my heels: ran quickly
collared: grabbed by the collar or neck
cool: calm; showing no excitement or emotion
not much the worse: not seriously hurt
sawbones: slang term for a doctor or surgeon
loathing: strong feeling of hatred and disgust



The man trampled calmly over the child's body and left her screaming on the ground.

But the doctor's case was what struck me. He was the usual cut and dried medical type, about as emotional as a brick. Well, sir, he was like the rest of us; every time he looked at my prisoner, I saw that sawbones turn sick and white with the desire to kill him.

"I knew what was in his mind, just as he knew what was in mine; and killing being out of the question, we did the next best. We told the man we would make such a scandal out of this that his name would stink from one end of London to the other. And all the time, we were keeping the women off him as best we could, for they were as wild as harpies. I never saw a circle of such hateful faces; and there was the man in the middle, with a kind of sneering coolness—frightened too, I could see that—but carrying it off, sir, really like Satan.

"'Any gentleman would wish to avoid a scene,' says he. 'Name your figure.' Well, we got him up

cut and dried: an expression meaning, ordinary, commonplace, nothing special about
scandal: public disgrace and shaming for immoral actions
harpies: from mythology, vicious creatures who were part woman and part bird
sneering: making a facial expression that shows dislike and disrespect
scene: a loud public incident that draws attention
'Name your figure.': How much money do you want?

to a hundred pounds for the child's family. The next thing was to get the money; and where do you think he took us but to that place with the door? —whipped out a key, went in, and soon came back with ten pounds in gold and a check for the balance from Coutts, signed with a name that I can't mention, though it's one of the points of my story, but it was a very well known name at least.

"I pointed out to my gentleman that a man does not, in real life, walk into a cellar door at four in the morning and come out with another man's check for close upon a hundred pounds. But he was quite easy and sneering. 'Set your mind at rest,' says he, 'I will stay with you till the banks open and cash the check myself.' So we all set off, the doctor, and the child's father, and our friend and myself, and passed the rest of the night at my place, and later, we all went to the bank. I handed over the check myself, and said I had every reason to believe it was a fake. Not a bit of it. The check was genuine."

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pounds: also called pounds sterling, a unit of money used in the United Kingdom (which includes England)
Coutts: an exclusive British bank for very rich people

"Tut-tut!" said Mr. Utterson.

"I see you feel as I do," said Mr. Enfield. "Yes, it's a bad story. For my man was a fellow that nobody could stand, a really horrible man; and the person that wrote the check is the very peak of propriety, well-known too, and one of those fellows who do what they call good. Blackmail, I suppose; an honest man paying through the nose for some of the capers of his youth. So, Black Mail House is what I call the place with the door. Though even that, you know, is far from explaining all," he added.

Mr. Utterson asked rather suddenly: "And you don't know if the drawer of the check lives there?"

"So you might think," returned Mr. Enfield. "But I happen to have noticed his address on the check; he lives in some square or other."

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propriety: good manners; accepted standards of polite behavior
blackmail: to force a person to pay money by threatening to reveal the person's secrets or bad actions
paying through the nose: paying way too much; paying much more than something is worth
capers: pranks; mischievous acts
drawer: the person whose name is on the check, from whose account the money was drawn
square: an open area in a city formed where two or more streets meet

"And you never asked about the—place with the door?" said Mr. Utterson.

"No, sir," was the reply. "I feel very strongly about putting questions; it's too much of the style of the day of judgment. You start a question, and it's like starting a stone. You sit quietly on the top of a hill; and away the stone goes, starting others; and presently some pleasant old fellow is knocked on the head in his own back garden. No sir, I make it a rule of mine: the stranger it looks, the less I ask."

"A very good rule, too," said the lawyer.

"But I have studied the place for myself," continued Mr. Enfield. "It seems scarcely a house. There is no other door, and nobody goes in or out of that one but, once in a great while, the gentleman of my adventure. And then there is a chimney which is generally smoking, so somebody must live there. And yet it's not so sure, for the buildings are so packed together about the court, that it's hard to say where one ends and another begins."

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day of judgment: what will happen, some people believe, at the end of the world when the dead will rise and God will judge each individual on what they did in their earthly lives
scarcely: barely; hardly
court: a courtyard; an open space surrounded by walls or buildings

The pair walked on again for a while in silence; and then, "Enfield," said Mr. Utterson, "that's a good rule of yours."

"Yes, I think it is," returned Enfield.

"But," continued the lawyer, "there's one point I want to ask. I want to ask the name of that man who walked over the child."

"Well," said Mr. Enfield, "I can't see what harm it would do. It was a man of the name of Hyde."

"Hm," said Mr. Utterson. "What sort of a man is he to see?"

"He is not easy to describe. There is something wrong with his appearance; something displeasing, something downright detestable. I never saw a man I so disliked, and yet I hardly know why. He gives a strong feeling of deformity, although I couldn't specify in what way. He's an extraordinary looking man, and yet I really can name nothing out of the way. No, sir; I can't describe him. And it's not want of memory; for I declare I can see him this moment."

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detestable: causing extreme dislike; hateful; disgusting
want: lack

Mr. Utterson again walked some way in silence and obviously under a weight of careful thought. "You are sure he used a key?" he inquired at last.

"My dear sir..." began Enfield, surprised.

"Yes, I know," said Utterson; "I know it must seem strange. The fact is, if I do not ask you the name of the man whose name was on the check, it is because I know it already. Richard, if you have been inexact in any point you had better correct it."

"I have been exact in every detail," returned the other with a touch of irritation. "The fellow had a key; and, he has it still. I saw him use it not a week ago."

Mr. Utterson sighed deeply but said nothing. The young man resumed. "Here is another lesson to say nothing," said he. "Let us make a bargain never to refer to this again."

"With all my heart," said the lawyer. "I shake hands on that, Richard."

Our First Look at Mr. Hyde
We get our first look at Mr. Hyde through the story told by Mr. Enfield. How does Enfield describe Hyde? What effect does Hyde have on other people?

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inquired: asked

SEARCH FOR MR. HYDE

That evening Mr. Utterson came home to his bachelor house in somber spirits. He took up a candle and went into his business room. There he opened his safe, took from the most private part of it a document with *Dr. Jekyll's Will* written on the envelope, and sat down with a clouded brow to study its contents.

The will was in Dr. Jekyll's own handwriting, for Mr. Utterson had refused to provide the least assistance in the making of it. It stated not only that, in case of the decease of Henry Jekyll, M.D., D.C.L., L.L.D., F.R.S., etc., all his possessions

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somber: dark and gloomy
will: a legal document that states who should receive a person's wealth and property after that person's death
decease: death
M.D.: from the Latin term for Doctor of Medicine [This and the other initials after Jekyll's name show that he has many professional degrees and honors.]
D.C.L.: Doctor of Civil Law
L.L.D: from the Latin term for Doctor of Laws
F.R.S.: Fellow of the Royal Society (an organization of scientists, based in London)
etc.: an abbreviation for *et cetera*, a Latin phrase meaning, and so forth; and other things

were to pass into the hands of his "friend and benefactor Edward Hyde," but that in case of Dr. Jekyll's "disappearance or unexplained absence for any period exceeding three calendar months," Edward Hyde should step into Henry Jekyll's shoes without further delay and free from any obligation beyond the payment of a few small sums to the members of the doctor's household.

This document had long offended Mr. Utterson both as a lawyer and as one who loved the sane and regular sides of life. Hitherto it was his ignorance of Mr. Hyde that had displeased and upset him; now, suddenly, it was his knowledge. It was bad enough when he could learn nothing of Hyde beyond the name, but it was worse when the name began to be clothed with detestable characteristics; and out of the shifting mists that had so long baffled his eye, there leaped up the sudden, definite image of a fiend.

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benefactor: a person who helps another
exceeding: going beyond
step into … shoes: an expression meaning, to take a person's place
obligation: a duty or requirement; something that must be done
hitherto: up to this time
detestable: hateful; disgusting
baffled: confused
fiend: evil spirit; devil

"I thought it was madness," he said, as he replaced the obnoxious paper in the safe, "and now I begin to fear it is disgrace."

With that he blew out his candle, put on a coat, and set forth in the direction of Cavendish Square, where his friend, the great Dr. Lanyon, had his house and received his many patients. "If anyone knows, it will be Lanyon," he thought.

Dr. Jekyll's Will
Mr. Utterson, as Dr. Jekyll's lawyer, would normally have taken on the task of preparing the doctor's will. Jekyll, however, wrote his own will, and Utterson refused to have anything to do with it. Why does the lawyer so strongly object to the will?

Up to this point, Utterson thought that it was "madness" for Jekyll to leave everything to Hyde, a man about whom Utterson knew nothing but the name. But now Utterson has learned something about Mr. Hyde—and what he has learned makes him think of Hyde as a "fiend."

You recall that Mr. Enfield told Mr. Utterson that he suspected Hyde might be blackmailing the man whose name was on the check. Utterson now begins to suspect that the will is part of the possible blackmail scheme. Utterson now thinks that the will is not an act of "madness" on Jekyll's part, but is instead related to some "disgrace"—some fear of the great public shame Jekyll might experience if Hyde were to reveal something shameful that Jekyll has tried to keep hidden.

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obnoxious: extremely unpleasant; offensive
disgrace: public shame and complete loss of respect from others

The solemn butler welcomed him and ushered him direct from the door to the dining room where Dr. Lanyon sat alone. He was a hearty, healthy, dapper, red-faced gentleman, with hair prematurely white, and a boisterous and decided manner. At sight of Mr. Utterson, he sprang up from his chair and welcomed him with both hands. These two were old friends both at school and college, who thoroughly enjoyed each other's company.

After a little rambling talk, the lawyer led up to the subject which so disagreeably filled his mind.

"I suppose, Lanyon," said he, "you and I must be the two oldest friends that Henry Jekyll has?"

"I wish the friends were younger," chuckled Dr. Lanyon. "But I suppose we are. Though I see little of him now."

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solemn: very serious
butler: the chief male servant in the household, usually in charge of the other servants
dapper: neat; stylish
prematurely: in a way that was earlier than expected
boisterous: rowdy; loud and lively
decided: unhesitatingly self-confident
rambling: wandering with no definite direction or purpose



Dr. Lanyon sprang up from his chair and welcomed Mr. Utterson with both hands.

"Indeed?" said Utterson. "I thought you had a bond of common interest."

"We had," was the reply. "But it is more than ten years since Henry Jekyll became too fanciful for me. He began to go wrong, wrong in mind; and though of course I continue to take an interest in him for old time's sake, I have seen devilish little of the man. Such unscientific balderdash," added the doctor, flushing suddenly purple, "would have estranged Damon and Pythias."

Two Doctors and a Lawyer
What is the relationship between Mr. Utterson, Dr. Lanyon, and Dr. Jekyll? How has Lanyon's relationship to Jekyll changed?

This little spirit of temper was somewhat of a relief to Mr. Utterson. "They have only differed on some point of science," he thought; "It is nothing worse than that!" He gave his friend a few seconds to recover his composure, and then approached

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common: shared
fanciful: quirky; wildly imaginative; impulsive and unpredictable in thought
balderdash: nonsense
flushing: showing color in the face from physical activity or a rush of emotion
estranged: separated and turned against (each other)
Damon and Pythias: in the ancient Greek legend, two great friends who were willing to sacrifice themselves for each other
composure: calm; self-control

the question he had come to put. "Did you ever come across a young acquaintance of his—named Hyde?" he asked.

"Hyde?" repeated Lanyon. "No. Never heard of him."

That was the amount of information that the lawyer carried back with him to the dark bed on which he tossed to and fro. It was a night of little ease to his toiling mind, troubled by questions.

Six o'clock struck on the bells of the church near to Mr. Utterson's dwelling, and still he was digging at the problem as he lay and tossed in the thick darkness. Mr. Enfield's tale went by before his mind in a scroll of lighted pictures: he saw the great field of lamps of a nocturnal city; then the figure of a man walking swiftly; then a child running; and then these met, and that human juggernaut trod the child down and passed on regardless of her screams. Or he would see a room in a rich house, where his friend lay asleep, dreaming and smiling at his dreams; and then the

to and fro: back and forth
toiling: working very hard
nocturnal: at night
trod: past tense of *tread*, to step on; to press or crush with the feet

door of that room would be opened, and there would stand by his side a figure to whom power was given, and even at that dead hour, he must rise and do its bidding.

The figure in these two phases haunted the lawyer all night; and if at any time he dozed, he would see it glide more stealthily through sleeping houses, or move more swiftly through wider labyrinths of lamplighted city, and at every street corner crush a child and leave her screaming.

And still the figure had no face by which he might know it; even in his dreams, it had no face, or one that baffled him and melted before his eyes; and thus there sprang up in the lawyer's mind a strong, almost an inordinate, curiosity to behold the features of the real Mr. Hyde. If he could only set eyes on him, he thought the mystery would lighten and perhaps roll altogether away, as was the habit of mysterious things when well examined. He might see a reason for his friend's strange

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do its bidding: follow its orders
stealthily: in a quiet, sneaky way
labyrinths: puzzling mix of pathways (like a maze)
inordinate: excessive; going beyond reasonable limits

preference or bondage (call it which you please) and even for the startling will. At least it would be a face worth seeing: the face of a man who was without mercy, a face which had but to show itself to raise up, in the mind of the unimpressionable Enfield, a spirit of enduring hatred.

From that time forward, Mr. Utterson began to haunt the door in the side street of shops. In the morning before office hours, at noon when business was plenty, at night under the face of the fogged city moon, by all lights and at all hours, the lawyer was to be found on his chosen post.

"If he be Mr. Hyde," he thought, "I shall be Mr. Seek."

And at last his patience was rewarded. It was a fine dry night; frost in the air; the lamps, unshaken by any wind, drawing a regular pattern of light and shadow. By ten o'clock, when the shops were closed, the side street was very solitary and, in spite of the low growl of London from all

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bondage: being subject to another person's control
unimpressionable: not easily moved to strong feeling
enduring: lasting
post: the place where a soldier stands on guard
solitary: without anyone around



Mr. Utterson could soon see the man he had to deal with.

round, very silent. Small sounds carried far, and the approach of any passerby could be heard well in advance. Mr. Utterson had been some minutes at his post, when he was aware of an odd light footstep drawing near. In the course of his nightly patrols, he had long grown accustomed to the effect with which the footfalls of a single person, while still a great way off, suddenly spring out distinct from the vast hum and clatter of the city. Yet his attention had never before been so sharply engaged; and it was with a strong, superstitious expectation of success that he withdrew into the entry of the court.

The steps drew swiftly nearer, and swelled out suddenly louder as they turned the end of the street. The lawyer, looking forth from the entry, could soon see the man he had to deal with. He was small and very plainly dressed and the look of him, even at that distance, went somehow strongly against the watcher's liking. But he made straight for the door, crossing the roadway to save time; and as he came, he drew a key from his pocket like one approaching home.

distinct: separate and clearly noticeable

Mr. Utterson stepped out and touched him on the shoulder as he passed. "Mr. Hyde, I think?"

Mr. Hyde shrank back with a hissing intake of the breath. But his fear was only momentary; and though he did not look the lawyer in the face, he answered coolly enough: "That is my name. What do you want?"

"I see you are going in," returned the lawyer. "I am an old friend of Dr. Jekyll's—Mr. Utterson of Gaunt Street—you must have heard of my name; and meeting you so conveniently, I thought you might admit me."

"You will not find Dr. Jekyll; he is away from home," replied Mr. Hyde. And then suddenly, but still without looking up, "How did you know me?" he asked.

"Will you do me a favor?" returned Mr. Utterson.

"With pleasure," replied the other. "What shall it be?"

"Will you let me see your face?" asked the lawyer.

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admit me: allow me to enter

Mr. Hyde appeared to hesitate, and then, as if upon some sudden thought, turned about with an air of defiance; and the pair stared at each other for a few seconds. "Now I shall know you again," said Mr. Utterson. "It may be useful."

"Yes," returned Mr. Hyde, "And since we have met, you should have my address." And he gave a number of a street in Soho.

"Good God!" thought Mr. Utterson, "can he, too, have been thinking of the will?" But he kept his feelings to himself and only grunted in acknowledgment of the address.

"And now," said the other, "how did you know me?"

"By description," was the reply.

"Whose description?"

"We have friends in common," said Mr. Utterson.

"Friends in common," echoed Mr. Hyde, a little hoarsely. "Who are they?"

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defiance: bold refusal to obey
again: the next time we meet
Soho: an area in the city of London that, by the mid-19th century, was full of bars and small theaters, and known for its disreputable night life

"Jekyll, for instance," said the lawyer.

"He never told you," cried Mr. Hyde, with a flush of anger. "I did not think you would have lied."

"Come," said Mr. Utterson, "that is not fitting language."

The other snarled aloud into a savage laugh; and the next moment, with extraordinary quickness, he had unlocked the door and disappeared into the house.

The lawyer stood uneasily awhile when Mr. Hyde had left him. Then he began slowly to make his way up the street, pausing every step or two and putting his hand to his brow like a man in mental perplexity, thinking as he walked: Mr. Hyde was pale and dwarfish, he gave an impression of deformity without any nameable malformation, he had a displeasing smile, he had behaved to the lawyer with a sort of murderous mixture of timidity and boldness, and he spoke with a husky, whispering, and somewhat broken

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fitting: acceptable; appropriate
perplexity: great confusion
malformation: misshaping of the body
timidity: fearfulness; shyness
husky: [when used to describe a voice] rough and hoarse



The lawyer stood uneasily awhile when Mr. Hyde had left him.

voice. All these were points against him, but not all of these together could explain the hitherto unknown disgust, loathing, and fear with which Mr. Utterson regarded him. "There must be something else," said the perplexed gentleman. "There is something more, if I could find a name for it. God bless me, the man seems hardly human! Something troglodytic, shall we say? Or is it the radiance of a foul soul that is revealed through and transforms its clay container? Oh, my poor old Harry Jekyll, if ever I read Satan's signature upon a face, it is on that of your new friend."

Round the corner from the side street, there was a square of ancient, handsome houses, now for the most part decayed from their high estate and divided into rooms for rent to all sorts and conditions of men, from mapmakers and architects to shady lawyers and the agents of obscure enterprises. One

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troglodytic: like a prehistoric caveman
clay container: Utterson imagines Hyde's body as the "clay container" of his "foul soul," and wonders if Hyde's deformed outward appearance reflects his corrupt inner state.
Harry: a nickname for Henry
architects: designers of buildings
shady: suspicious; probably dishonest
agents of obscure enterprises: people who engage in shadowy and possibly immoral or illegal dealings

house, however, second from the corner, still wore a great air of wealth and comfort, though it was now plunged in darkness. Mr. Utterson stopped and knocked. A well-dressed, elderly servant opened the door.

"Is Dr. Jekyll at home, Poole?" asked the lawyer.

"I will see, Mr. Utterson," said Poole, admitting the visitor, as he spoke, into a large comfortable hall warmed by a bright, open fire, and furnished with costly cabinets of oak. "Will you wait here by the fire, sir? Or shall I give you a light in the dining-room?"

"Here, thank you," said the lawyer. This hall was a favorite of his friend the doctor's, and Utterson himself often spoke of it as the pleasantest room in London. But tonight there was a shudder in his blood; the face of Hyde sat heavy on his memory; he felt (what was rare with him) a nausea and distaste of life; and in the gloom

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servant: a person employed to do household duties
costly: expensive; of great value
shudder: a shaking or trembling, usually in response to fear or cold
nausea: a feeling of sickness in the stomach; extreme disgust

of his spirits, he seemed to read a menace in the flickering of the firelight on the polished cabinets and the uneasy starting of the shadow on the roof. He was ashamed of his relief when Poole returned to announce that Dr. Jekyll was gone out.

"I saw Mr. Hyde go in by the old dissecting room, Poole," he said. "Is that right, when Dr. Jekyll is away from home?"

"Quite right, Mr. Utterson, sir," replied the servant. "Mr. Hyde has a key."

"Your master seems to place a great deal of trust in that young man, Poole," resumed the other.

"Yes, sir, he does indeed," said Poole. "We have all orders to obey him."

"I do not think I ever met Mr. Hyde?" asked Utterson.

"O, dear no, sir. He never dines here," replied the butler. "Indeed we see very little of him on this side

The Door and the House
The previous chapter is titled "Story of the Door." Now, in this chapter, you have learned that the door leads into a laboratory with an old dissecting room, which is part of Dr. Jekyll's house. Poole, the butler, says that Mr. Hyde is often in Dr. Jekyll's house, and that Hyde enters and leaves by this door to the laboratory. Why do you think Hyde uses this door instead of the main entrance?

menace: something threatening
dissecting room: a space in which a scientist cuts apart and examines animal bodies in order to learn more about them

of the house; he mostly comes and goes by the laboratory."

"Well, good-night, Poole."

"Good-night, Mr. Utterson."

And the lawyer set out homeward with a very heavy heart. "Poor Harry Jekyll," he thought, "I fear he is in deep waters! He was wild when he was young; a long while ago to be sure; but in the law of God, there is no statute of limitations. Ay, it must be the ghost of some old sin, the cancer of some concealed disgrace, with punishment coming years after the fault."

The Statute of Limitations
The statute of limitations is a law that limits how much time can pass after which you can no longer take legal action to try to punish someone for a wrong done long ago. Utterson thinks Jekyll might have done bad things when he was a "wild" young man. But many years have passed, and Jekyll is now older. The lawyer knows that under British law Jekyll cannot be punished for what he did when he was young, since the statute of limitations has run out.

But Utterson also thinks that "in the law of God" there is no time limit on having to accept the consequences of our bad actions. Utterson imagines that Mr. Hyde (who might be blackmailing Jekyll) is like a "ghost" that has come back to haunt the doctor, or like a "cancer" making the doctor suffer for the wrongs he might have done long ago.

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in deep waters: an expression meaning, to be in serious trouble
ay [pronounced "eye"]**:** yes (often used as an expression of emphasis, like saying "indeed")
concealed: hidden

And the lawyer, scared by the thought, brooded awhile on his own past, searching the corners of memory for any old iniquity that might, like a jack-in-the-box, leap to light. His past was fairly blameless; yet he was humbled to the dust by the many ill things he had done, and raised up again into a fearful gratitude by the many he had come so near to doing yet avoided. And then he conceived a spark of hope. "This Mr. Hyde, if he were studied," thought he, "must have secrets of his own—secrets compared to which poor Jekyll's worst would be like sunshine. Things cannot continue as they are. It turns me cold to think of this creature stealing like a thief to Harry's bedside; poor Harry, what a wakening! And the danger of it; for if this Hyde suspects the existence of the will, he may grow impatient to inherit. Ay, I must put my shoulders to the wheel—if Jekyll

brooded: thought about in an anxious and unhappy way
iniquity: wickedness; sin
blameless: free of crime or guilt
humbled: made to feel low and shameful
ill: wicked, bad
gratitude: feeling of thankfulness
conceived: imagined; formed in the mind
put my shoulders to the wheel: an expression meaning, get busy; start to work with great energy and focus

will only let me," he added. For once more he saw clearly before his mind's eye the strange clauses of the will.

Impatient to Inherit
Utterson thinks, "If this Hyde suspects the existence of the will, he may grow impatient to inherit." If Hyde is in fact "impatient to inherit," how does that endanger the doctor?

Think back to the will. If Dr. Jekyll should die or "disappear," who would inherit the doctor's wealth? So, if this person wants to come into possession of the doctor's wealth more quickly, what would he have to do?

mind's eye: a figure of speech referring to how you "see" things in your imagination or memory
clauses: statements in a will (or other legal document) that say what is to be done

DR. JEKYLL WAS QUITE AT EASE

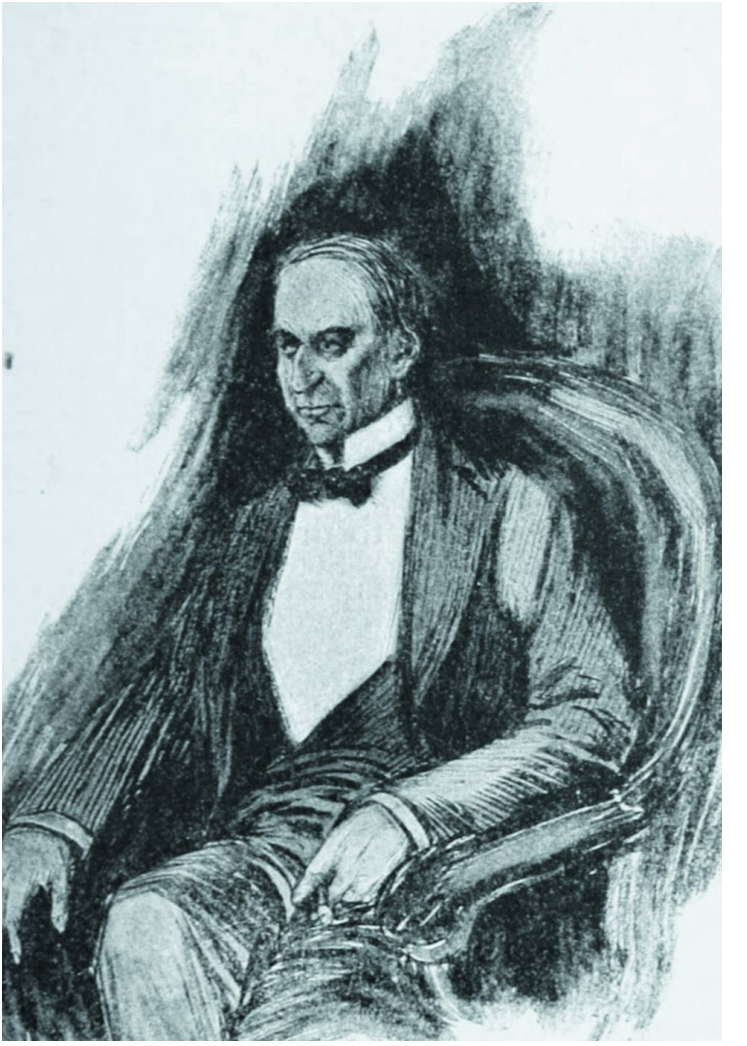
A fortnight later, the doctor gave one of his pleasant dinners to some five or six old friends, all intelligent, reputable men. Mr. Utterson remained behind after the others had departed, a thing that had occurred many times before. Where Utterson was liked, he was liked well. When the light-hearted and loose-tongued guests were already out the door, hosts liked the lawyer to stay behind, to sit a while in his quiet company. To this rule, Dr. Jekyll was no exception. The doctor now sat on the opposite side of the fire—a large, well-made, smooth-faced man of fifty, a bit stylish perhaps, but with every mark of kindness. You could see by his looks that he felt for Mr. Utterson a sincere and warm affection.

"I have been wanting to speak to you, Jekyll," began the lawyer. "You know that will of yours?"

A close observer might have gathered that

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fortnight: a period of two weeks
stylish: following the latest styles; fashionable



Dr. Henry Jekyll was a large, well-made, smooth-faced man of fifty, with every mark of kindness.

the topic was distasteful, but the doctor carried it off lightly. "My poor Utterson," said he, "I never saw a man so distressed as you were by my will; unless it were that hidebound pedant, Lanyon, at what he called my scientific heresies. Oh, I know he's a good fellow—you needn't frown—an excellent fellow, and I always mean to see more of him; but a hidebound, ignorant, pedant for all that. I was never more disappointed in any man than Lanyon."

"You know I never approved of it," pursued Utterson, disregarding the fresh topic.

"My will? Yes, certainly, I know that," said the doctor, a trifle sharply. "You have told me so."

"Well, I tell you so again," continued the lawyer. "I have been learning something of young Hyde."

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distressed: very upset about; greatly troubled by
hidebound: stubbornly holding onto old ideas and unwilling to accept new ones
pedant: a person who acts like a know-it-all and emphasizes minor details over important ideas
heresies: opinions or actions that go against accepted beliefs or standards
needn't: need not (don't need to)
trifle: a very small amount

The large handsome face of Dr. Jekyll grew pale to the very lips, and there came a blackness about his eyes. "I do not care to hear more," said he. "This is a matter I thought we had agreed to drop."

"What I heard was abominable," said Utterson.

"It can make no change. You do not understand my position," returned the doctor, with a certain incoherency. "My situation is painful, Utterson; my position is a very strange—a very strange one. It is one of those affairs that cannot be mended by talking."

"Jekyll," said Utterson, "you know me: I am a man to be trusted. Make a clean breast of this in confidence; and I have no doubt I can get you out of it."

"My good Utterson," said the doctor, "this is very good of you, this is downright good of you,

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abominable: awful; horrible
incoherency: lack of logic or clarity
mended: repaired; fixed; corrected
make a clean breast of: tell the truth and admit what you have done
in confidence: knowing that whatever you say will not be revealed but will be kept private
downright: completely; absolutely

and I cannot find words to thank you. I believe you fully; I would trust you before any man alive, ay, before myself, if I could make the choice; but indeed it isn't what you imagine; it is not as bad as that. And just to put your good heart at rest, I will tell you one thing: the moment I choose, I can be rid of Mr. Hyde. I give you my hand upon that; and I thank you again and again. And I will just add one little word, Utterson, that I'm sure you'll go along with: this is a private matter, and I beg of you to let it sleep."

Utterson reflected a little, looking in the fire.

"I have no doubt you are perfectly right," he said at last, getting to his feet.

"Well, but since we have touched upon this business, and for the last time I hope," continued the doctor, "there is one point I should like you to understand. I have really a very great interest in poor Hyde. I know you have seen him; he told me so; and I fear he was rude. But I do sincerely take

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give you my hand: an expression meaning, to pledge, to promise
let it sleep: an expression meaning, don't bother it, leave it alone
reflected: thought carefully

a great, a very great interest in that young man; and if I am taken away, Utterson, I wish you to promise me that you will bear with him and get his rights for him. I think you would, if you knew all; and it would be a weight off my mind if you would promise."

"I can't pretend that I shall ever like him," said the lawyer.

"I don't ask that," pleaded Jekyll, laying his hand upon the other's arm; "I only ask for justice; I only ask you to help him for my sake, when I am no longer here."

Utterson heaved a sigh. "Well," said he, "I promise."

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get his rights for him: make sure Hyde gets what he legally deserves [according to the terms of Jekyll's will]

THE CAREW MURDER CASE

Nearly a year later, in the month of October, 18—, London was startled by a crime of singular ferocity, made all the more notable by the high social position of the victim. The details were few and startling. A maidservant living alone in a house not far from the river had gone upstairs to bed about eleven. Although a fog rolled over the city in the small hours, the early part of the night was cloudless, and the lane, which the maid's window overlooked, was brilliantly lit by the full moon. She sat down by the window and fell into a dreamy, thoughtful state. Never (she used to say, with streaming tears, when she narrated that experience), never had she felt more at peace or thought more kindly of the world. And as she sat she became aware of an aged beautiful gentleman with white hair, drawing near along the lane; and advancing to meet him, another and

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startled: surprised and frightened
singular: exceptional; extraordinary
ferocity: extreme fierceness
narrated: told the story of

very small gentleman, to whom at first she paid less attention. Just under the maid's eyes, the older man bowed and approached the other very politely. It appeared as if he were only inquiring his way. The moon shone on his face as he spoke, and the girl was pleased to watch it, it seemed to breathe such an innocent kindness.

Her eye wandered to the other, and she was surprised to recognize a certain Mr. Hyde, who had once visited her master and for whom she had conceived a dislike. He had in his hand a heavy cane, but he answered never a word, and seemed to listen with impatience. And then all of a sudden he broke out in a great flame of anger, stamping with his foot, brandishing the cane, and carrying on (as the maid described it) like a madman. The old gentleman took a step back, with the air of one very much surprised and a trifle hurt; and at that Mr. Hyde broke out of all bounds and clubbed him to the earth. And next moment, with ape-like fury, he was trampling his victim under foot and hailing down a storm of blows, under which

her master: the maidservant's employer
brandishing: waving in a threatening way
blows: hard hits



Mr. Hyde broke out of all bounds and clubbed him to the earth.

the bones were audibly shattered and the body jumped upon the roadway. At the horror of these sights and sounds, the maid fainted.

It was two o'clock when she came to herself and called for the police. The murderer was gone long ago; but there lay his victim in the middle of the lane, incredibly mangled. The stick with which the deed had been done, although it was of some rare and very tough and heavy wood, had broken in the middle under the stress of this cruelty; and one splintered half had rolled in the neighboring gutter—the other, without doubt, had been carried away by the murderer. A purse and gold watch were found upon the victim, but no cards or papers, except a sealed and stamped envelope, which he had been probably carrying to the post office, and which bore the name and address of Mr. Utterson.

This envelope was brought to the lawyer the next morning. "I shall say nothing till I have seen

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audibly: in a way loud enough to be heard
mangled: disfigured by violent means; severely twisted, torn, and crushed

the body," said he. And with a grave countenance he hurried to the police station, where the body had been carried.

"Yes," said he, "I recognize him. I am sorry to say that this is Sir Danvers Carew."

"Good God, sir," exclaimed the officer, "is it possible?" And the next moment his eye lighted up with professional ambition. "This will make a deal of noise," he said. "And perhaps you can help us to find the man." And he briefly narrated what the maid had seen, and showed the broken stick.

Mr. Utterson had already shuddered at the name of Hyde; but when the stick was laid before him, he could doubt no longer; broken and battered as it was, he recognized it as one that he had himself presented many years before to Henry Jekyll.

"Is this Mr. Hyde a person of small stature?" he inquired.

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grave: deeply serious
countenance: expression of a person's face
Sir: a title used to address certain men who have been honored in Great Britain
ambition: the desire to succeed, gain power, or get ahead
make a deal of noise: cause a lot of talk; attract much attention
stature: height

"Particularly small and particularly wicked-looking, is what the maid calls him," said the officer.

Mr. Utterson reflected; and then, "If you will come with me in my cab," he said, "I think I can take you to his house."

It was by this time about nine in the morning, and the first fog of the season. A great chocolate-colored pall lowered over heaven. As the cab crawled from street to street, Mr. Utterson beheld a marvelous number of degrees and hues of twilight; for here it would be dark like the back-end of evening; and there would be a glow of a rich, lurid brown, like the light of some strange conflagration; and here, for a moment, the fog would be quite broken up, and a haggard shaft of daylight would glance in between the swirling wreaths. The dismal section of Soho, with its muddy ways and shabby people, and its lamps

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pall: something that covers and darkens
hues: colors or shades of colors
lurid: shining with an unnatural, ugly glow
conflagration: a large and destructive fire
haggard: looking thin and tired from long hunger or pain
dismal: gloomy; miserable

kindled to combat this mournful reinvasion of darkness, seemed, in the lawyer's eyes, like part of some city in a nightmare. The thoughts of his mind, besides, were of the gloomiest dye; and when he glanced at the companion of his drive, he was conscious of some touch of that terror of the law and the law's officers, which may at times assail even the most honest persons.

As the cab drew up before the address, the fog lifted a little and showed him a dingy street, a gin palace, a cheap French restaurant, and a shop for the sale of penny numbers, with many ragged children huddled in the doorways,

Description and Character
Writers can use the description of a place to affect how we feel about a character.

Look again at the description of the part of London called Soho, where Hyde lives.

How does Stevenson describe this area? What does it look like? How does the description influence your sense of who Mr. Hyde is?

kindled: lit
combat: fight against
mournful: sorrowful; causing grief and sadness
dye: coloring / **conscious:** aware
assail: violently attack
gin palace: a large bar designed to serve crowds of people alcoholic drinks quickly and cheaply
penny numbers: cheap magazines
huddled: crowded together

and many women of many different nationalities passing out, key in hand, to have a morning glass. And the next moment the brown fog settled down again and cut him off from his grim surroundings. This was the home of Henry Jekyll's favorite—of a man who was heir to a quarter of a million pounds sterling.

An ivory-faced and silvery-haired old woman opened the door. She had an evil face, smoothed by hypocrisy, but her manners were excellent. Yes, she said, this was Mr. Hyde's, but he was not at home; he had been in that night very late, but he had gone away again in less than an hour; there was nothing strange in that; his habits were very irregular, and he was often absent; for instance, it was nearly two months since she had seen him till yesterday.

"Very well, then, we wish to see his rooms," said the lawyer; and when the woman began to declare it was impossible, "I had better tell you who this person is," he added. "This is Inspector Newcomen of Scotland Yard."

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heir [pronounced *air*]**:** a person who will inherit property
hypocrisy: pretending to practice good manners or hold virtuous beliefs that you don't really have



She had an evil face, smoothed by hypocrisy,
but her manners were excellent.

A flash of odious joy appeared upon the woman's face. "Ah!" said she, "he is in trouble! What has he done?"

Mr. Utterson and the inspector exchanged glances. "He don't seem a very popular character," observed the inspector. "And now, my good woman, just let me and this gentleman have a look about us."

In the whole house, which except for the old woman was empty, Mr. Hyde had only used a couple of rooms; but these were furnished with luxury and good taste, with silver plates, good pictures on the walls, and thick, colorful carpets. At this moment, however, the rooms bore every mark of having been recently and hurriedly ransacked; clothes lay about the floor, with their pockets inside out; drawers stood open; and on the hearth there lay a pile of grey ashes, as though many papers had been burned. From these the inspector pulled out the end of a green checkbook, which had resisted the action of the fire; the other

odious: hateful
ransacked: searched roughly in a way that leaves a place a mess
hearth: the floor of a fireplace, especially the part that extends out into the room

half of the stick was found behind the door; and as this clinched his suspicions, the officer declared himself delighted. A visit to the bank, where several thousand pounds were found to be lying in an account in the murderer's name, completed his satisfaction.

"You may depend upon it, sir," he told Mr. Utterson: "I have him in my hand. He must have lost his head, or he never would have left the stick or, above all, burned the checkbook. We have nothing to do but wait for him at the bank, and get out the handbills."

The handbills, however, proved not so easy to produce, for few people were familiar with Mr. Hyde. His family could nowhere be traced; he had never been photographed; and the few who could describe him differed widely. Only on one point were they agreed—and that was the haunting sense of unexpressed deformity with which the fugitive impressed those who saw him.

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clinched: confirmed
handbills: small printed notices [in this case, to post a picture of Hyde and announce him as a wanted criminal]
fugitive: a person running away from something [in Hyde's case, from being caught by the police]

INCIDENT OF THE LETTER

Late in the afternoon, Mr. Utterson found his way to Dr. Jekyll's door. He was at once admitted by Poole, and taken down by the kitchen offices and across a yard to the building known as the laboratory or dissecting rooms. The doctor had bought the house from the heirs of a celebrated surgeon, and had changed the building at the bottom of the garden to suit his own interests, which were chemical rather than anatomical.

It was the first time that the lawyer had been received in that part of his friend's quarters; and he eyed the dingy, windowless structure with curiosity, and gazed round with a distasteful sense of strangeness as he crossed the theater, once crowded with eager students and now lying gloomy and silent, the tables laden with chemical apparatus, the floor

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anatomical: relating to anatomy, the science concerned with the structure of living things

theater: a surgical theater, a room with rows of seats from which medical students could observe an experienced surgeon at work

apparatus: materials and equipment for a specific purpose (in this case, for conducting experiments in chemistry)

strewn with crates and littered with packing straw. At the further end, a flight of stairs mounted to a red door, and through this Mr. Utterson was at last received into the doctor's private study. It was a large room with cabinets with glass doors all round, and furnished with, among other things, a cheval glass and a business table, and looking out upon the court by three dusty windows barred with iron. The fire burned in the grate; a lamp was set lighted on the chimney shelf, for even in the houses the fog began to lie thickly; and there, close up to the warmth, sat Dr. Jekyll, looking deathly sick. He did not rise to meet his visitor, but held out a cold hand and welcomed him in a changed voice.

"And now," said Mr. Utterson, as soon as Poole had left them, "you have heard the news?"

The doctor shuddered. "They were crying it in the square," he said. "I heard them in my dining-room."

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strewn with: covered with items scattered here and there
cheval glass: a long mirror mounted on an upright frame that allows the mirror to be tilted backward and forward
grate: a framework of metal bars, used to hold fuel in a fireplace

"Carew was my client," said the lawyer, "but so are you. You have not been mad enough to hide this fellow?"

"Utterson, I swear to God," cried the doctor, "I swear to God I will never set eyes on him again. On my honor I am done with him in this world. It is all at an end. And indeed he does not want my help; you do not know him as I do. Mark my words, he will never more be heard of."

The lawyer listened gloomily; he did not like his friend's feverish manner. "You seem pretty sure of him," said he; "and for your sake, I hope you may be right. If it came to a trial, your name might be mentioned."

"I am quite sure of him," replied Jekyll, "for reasons that I cannot share with anyone. But there is one thing on which you may advise me. I have—I have received a letter; and I am at a loss whether I should show it to the police. I should like to leave

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client: a person or group that engages the services of a professional advisor, such as a lawyer

this fellow: Utterson means Hyde, who is being sought as the murderer of Sir Danvers Carew.

Mark my words: an expression meaning, Listen to what I say because it is true and important.

it in your hands, Utterson; you would judge wisely, I am sure; I have so great a trust in you."

"You fear, I suppose, that it might lead to his detection?" asked the lawyer.

"No," said the other. "I cannot say that I care what becomes of Hyde; I am quite done with him. I was thinking of my own character, which this hateful business has rather exposed."

Utterson was surprised at his friend's selfishness, and yet relieved by it. "Well," said he, at last, "let me see the letter."

The letter was written in an odd, upright hand and signed "Edward Hyde." It said, briefly enough, that Hyde was unworthy of Dr. Jekyll's generosity, and that the doctor did not need to be alarmed for Hyde or for his safety, as he had a sure means of escape.

The lawyer liked this letter, for he thought it put a better light on Jekyll's familiarity with Hyde, and he blamed himself for some of his past suspicions.

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his detection: to Hyde's being found by the police
exposed: opened to risk or danger
alarmed: feeling fear and anxiety because of the sense of some coming danger

"Have you the envelope?" he asked.

"I burned it," replied Jekyll, "before I thought what I was about. But it bore no postmark. The note was delivered by hand."

"Shall I keep this and decide later what to do with it?" asked Utterson.

"I wish you to judge for me entirely," was the reply. "I have lost confidence in myself."

"Well, I shall consider," returned the lawyer. "And now one word more: it was Hyde who demanded the terms in your will about that disappearance?"

The doctor seemed seized with a sudden feeling of faintness; he shut his mouth tight and nodded.

"I knew it," said Utterson. "He meant to murder you. You had a close escape."

"I have had what is far more to the purpose," returned the doctor solemnly: "I have had a lesson — oh God, Utterson, what a lesson I have had!" And he covered his face for a moment with his hands.

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postmark: an official mark placed over a postage stamp, showing the date on which the letter was mailed and where it was mailed from

consider: think carefully

On his way out, the lawyer stopped and had a word with the butler. "Poole," he said, "there was a letter given to you by hand today. What was the messenger like?" But Poole was positive nothing had come except by the regular mail, and nothing important in that.

This news sent off the lawyer with his fears renewed. Plainly the letter had been delivered to the laboratory door; possibly, indeed, it had been written in the study; and if that were so, it must be judged differently, and handled with more caution. The newsboys, as he went, were crying themselves hoarse: "Special edition. Shocking murder of an M.P." That was how one friend and client might be remembered; and he could not help worrying that the good name of another would be pulled down by scandal. It was a difficult decision that he had to make about the letter that Dr. Jekyll had given him; and self-reliant as he was, he began to long for advice.

M.P.: Member of Parliament (the legislative governing body of Great Britain, like the Congress in the U.S.)
one friend and client [of Mr. Utterson]**:** refers to the late Sir Danvers Carew
another [friend and client]**:** refers to Dr. Jekyll
long: have a strong desire

Soon, he sat on one side of his own fireplace, with Mr. Guest, his head clerk, upon the other. The fog still slept on the drowned city, and through the muffle and smother of these fallen clouds, the procession of the town's life was still rolling in with a sound as of a mighty wind. But the room was gay with firelight, and a bottle of a particular old wine that had long been in the cellar of the house was ready to disperse the fogs of London. Gradually, the lawyer melted.

There was no man from whom the lawyer kept fewer secrets than Mr. Guest; and he was not always sure that he kept as many as he meant. Guest had often been on business to the doctor's; he knew Poole; he could hardly have failed to hear of Mr. Hyde's frequent presence about the doctor's house—about which Guest might draw the wrong conclusions. Was it not right, then, that he should see a letter which cleared up that mystery? And above all, Guest was a great expert on handwriting: he could not read so strange a

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clerk: in law, a less experienced lawyer who assists a judge or a more experienced lawyer
disperse: to scatter

document without dropping a remark; and that remark might help Mr. Utterson decide what to do about the letter.

"This is a sad business about Sir Danvers," he said.

"Yes, sir, indeed. It has elicited a great deal of public feeling," returned Guest. "The man, of course, was mad."

"I should like to hear your views on that," replied Utterson. "I have a document here in his handwriting; it is between ourselves, for I hardly know what to do about it; it is an ugly business at the best. But there it is: a murderer's autograph."

Guest's eyes brightened, and he sat down at once and studied it enthusiastically. "No sir," he said: "not mad; but it is an odd handwriting."

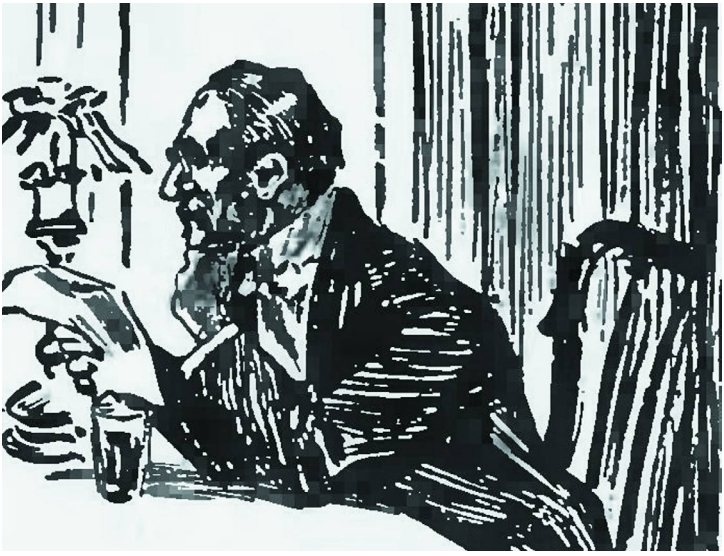
"And by all accounts a very odd writer," added the lawyer.

Just then the servant entered with a note.

"Is that from Dr. Jekyll, sir?" inquired the clerk. "I thought I knew the writing. Anything private, Mr. Utterson?"

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elicited: brought forth
between ourselves: to be kept as a secret between us



"I have a document here in his handwriting."

"Only an invitation to dinner. Why? Do you want to see it?"

"Yes, for one moment. I thank you, sir." The clerk laid the two sheets of paper alongside and carefully compared their contents. "Thank you, sir," he said at last, returning both; "it's a very interesting autograph."

There was a pause, during which Mr. Utterson struggled with himself. "Why did you compare them, Guest?" he inquired suddenly.

"Well, sir," returned the clerk, "there's a

rather remarkable resemblance; the two hands are in many points identical: only differently slanted."

"Rather odd," said Utterson.

"It is, as you say, rather odd," returned Guest.

"I wouldn't speak of this note, you know," said the older lawyer.

"No, sir," said the clerk. "I understand."

But no sooner was Mr. Utterson alone that night, than he locked the note into his safe, where it remained from that time forward. "What!" he thought. "Henry Jekyll commit forgery for a murderer!" And his blood ran cold in his veins.

A Handwriting Mystery
Utterson's clerk, Mr. Guest, makes certain observations about the handwriting in Hyde's letter compared to the handwriting in the invitation from Dr. Jekyll. What does Mr. Guest notice? What do these observations lead Utterson to conclude about the letter that Jekyll gave him?

If Dr. Jekyll has in fact written the letter that he claimed to be from Mr. Hyde, why would the doctor want to hide a murderer?

Why does Utterson hide the letter in his safe? Is that the right thing to do?

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forgery: the crime of falsely writing or copying something in order to trick people into thinking it is the real thing

REMARKABLE INCIDENT OF DR. LANYON

Time ran on; thousands of pounds were offered in reward, but Mr. Hyde had disappeared out of the reach of the police as though he had never existed. Tales came out of the man's cruelty, at once so callous and violent; of his vile life, of the hatred that seemed to have surrounded his career; but of his present whereabouts, not a whisper. From the time he had left the house in Soho on the morning of the murder, he was simply blotted out.

Gradually, as time drew on, Mr. Utterson began to recover from his alarm and to grow more at quiet with himself. The death of Sir Danvers was, to his way of thinking, more than made up for by the disappearance of Mr. Hyde. Now that that evil influence had been withdrawn, a new life began for Dr. Jekyll. He came out of his seclusion, renewed relations with his friends, became once

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callous: insensitive; uncaring about the feelings of others
vile: immoral; evil
whereabouts: the place where a thing or person is
seclusion: the condition of being apart and alone

more their familiar guest and entertainer; and while he had always been known for charities, he was now equally well known for religion. He was busy, he was much in the open air, he did good; his face seemed to open and brighten, as if with an inward consciousness of service. And for more than two months, the doctor was at peace.

On the 8th of January, Utterson dined at the doctor's; Lanyon was there, and the face of the host had looked from one to the other as in the old days when the trio were inseparable friends. On the 12th, and again on the 14th, the door was shut against the lawyer. "The doctor is confined to the house," Poole said, "and sees no one." On the 15th, he tried again, and was again refused. Having seen his friend for the last two months almost daily, he found this return of solitude to weigh upon his spirits. The fifth night Utterson invited Guest to dine with him; and the sixth he went to Dr. Lanyon's.

When Utterson came in, he was shocked at the change which had taken place in the doctor's

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consciousness: awareness
trio: a group of three

appearance. His face seemed to have death written on it. The rosy man had grown pale; his flesh had fallen away; he was visibly balder and older. And yet the lawyer was struck most not so much by these signs of swift physical decay as by a look in the doctor's eye and by behaviors that seemed to reveal some deep terror of the mind. When Utterson remarked on his ill looks, Dr. Lanyon declared himself a doomed man.

"I have had a shock," he said, "and I shall never recover. It is a question of weeks. Well, life has been pleasant; I liked it; yes, sir, I used to like it. I sometimes think if we knew all, we should be more glad to get away."

"Jekyll is ill, too," observed Utterson. "Have you seen him?"

But Lanyon's face changed, and he held up a trembling hand. "I wish to see or hear no more of Dr. Jekyll," he said in a loud, unsteady voice. "I am quite done with that person; and I beg that you will never again speak of one whom I think of as dead."

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doomed: certain to die soon



"I HAVE HAD A SHOCK," SAID DR. LANYON, "AND I SHALL NEVER RECOVER."

After a considerable pause, Mr. Utterson inquired, "Can't I do anything? We are three very old friends, Lanyon; we shall not live to make others."

"Nothing can be done," returned Lanyon; "ask him."

"He will not see me," said the lawyer.

"I am not surprised at that," was the reply. "Someday, Utterson, after I am dead, you may perhaps come to learn the right and wrong of this. I cannot tell you. And in the meantime, if you can sit and talk with me of other things, for God's sake, stay and do so; but if you cannot keep clear of this awful topic, then in God's name, go, for I cannot bear it."

As soon as he got home, Utterson sat down and wrote to Jekyll, complaining that he was not allowed to enter the house, and asking the cause of this unhappy break with Lanyon. The next day brought him a long answer, often full of sadness and sometimes darkly mysterious. The quarrel with Lanyon was incurable. "I do not blame our

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incurable: unable to be cured or fixed

old friend," Jekyll wrote, "but I share his view that we must never meet. I mean from now on to lead a life of extreme seclusion; you must not be surprised, nor must you doubt my friendship, if my door is often shut even to you. You must allow me to go my own dark way. I have brought on myself a punishment and a danger that I cannot name. If I am the chief of sinners, I am the chief of sufferers also. I could not think that this earth contained a place for such sufferings and terrors; and you can do but one thing, Utterson, to lighten this destiny, and that is to respect my silence."

Utterson was amazed; the dark influence of Hyde had been withdrawn, the doctor had returned to his old tasks and friendships; a week ago, his future seemed to promise a cheerful and an honored age; and now in a moment, friendship, and peace of mind, and the whole course of his life were wrecked. So great and unprepared a change pointed to madness; but in view of Lanyon's manner and words, the cause must lie in some deeper ground.

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destiny: fate; what will happen

A week afterwards, Dr. Lanyon took to his bed, and in something less than a fortnight he was dead. The night after the funeral, Utterson locked the door of his business room, and sitting there by the light of a melancholy candle, set before him an envelope addressed by the hand of his dead friend: "PRIVATE: for the hands of G. J. Utterson ALONE, and in case of his predecease to be destroyed unread."

The lawyer dreaded to behold the contents. He broke the seal. Within there was another envelope, also sealed, and marked "Not to be opened till the death or disappearance of Dr. Henry Jekyll." Utterson could not trust his eyes. Yes, it was *disappearance*. Here again, as in the mad will which he had long ago returned to its author, here again was the idea of a disappearance linked to the name of Henry Jekyll. But in the will, that idea had sprung from the sinister suggestion of the man Hyde; it was set there with a purpose

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melancholy: sad and gloomy
predecease: to die before [in case Utterson were to die before Lanyon]
dreaded: greatly feared something bad might happen
its author: the author of the will, Dr. Jekyll

all too plain and horrible. Written by the hand of Lanyon, what did it mean?

The Will Again
From the time that Utterson first saw Dr. Jekyll's will, he has been troubled by the document. Normally, as a lawyer, Utterson would have written the will for his client, but he had so strongly objected to the terms of the will that he had refused to take any part in writing it. Utterson must have objected strongly to the will's mysterious words about the doctor's possible "disappearance or unexplained absence."

Utterson thinks Hyde must have made the "sinister suggestion" that guided Jekyll to say in his will that if the doctor were to "disappear," then Hyde would inherit Jekyll's wealth. And Utterson has come to believe that Hyde's "plain and horrible" purpose was to make Jekyll "disappear" by murdering him.

Utterson understands why Hyde would refer to Jekyll's "disappearance" as a way to hide his "plain and horrible" plan to murder the doctor. But why should *Lanyon* mention Jekyll's possible "disappearance"? As far as Utterson knows (and as far as we readers know), Lanyon has not seen the will. So why does Lanyon mention the "death or *disappearance*" of Jekyll? At this point, Utterson can only ask, "What did it mean?"

A great curiosity came on the lawyer; he wanted to ignore the writing on the sealed envelope that forbid him to open it and dive at once to the bottom of these mysteries. But professional honor and faith to his dead friend were strict obligations, and he placed the packet deep in his private safe.

From that day forth, Utterson did not desire the society of Dr. Jekyll with the same eagerness. He thought of him kindly, but his thoughts were uneasy and fearful. He went to visit his friend, but he was perhaps relieved to be told he could not enter; perhaps, in his heart, he preferred to speak with Poole upon the doorstep, surrounded by the air and sounds of the open city, rather than to enter the house and speak with its inscrutable recluse. Poole had no pleasant news to communicate. The doctor now more than ever confined himself to his study over the laboratory, where he would sometimes even sleep; he was out of spirits, he had grown very silent, he did not read; it seemed as if he had something on his mind. As Utterson became used to these unchanging reports, he visited less and less.

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inscrutable: mysterious; very difficult to understand or make sense of

recluse: a person who lives alone and avoids others; a hermit

INCIDENT AT THE WINDOW

It chanced on Sunday, when Mr. Utterson was on his usual walk with Mr. Enfield, that their way lay once again through the side street; and when they came in front of the door, both stopped to gaze on it.

"Well," said Enfield, "that story's at an end at least. We shall never see more of Mr. Hyde."

"I hope not," said Utterson. "Did I ever tell you that I once saw him, and shared your feeling of repulsion?"

"It was impossible not to," returned Enfield. "And by the way, what a fool I was not to know that this door was a back way into Dr. Jekyll's!"

"So you found it out, did you?" said Utterson. "So, we may step into the court and take a look at the windows, for to tell you the truth, I am uneasy about poor Jekyll; and even outside, I feel as if the presence of a friend might do him good."

The court was very cool and a little damp, and full of premature twilight, although the sky

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repulsion: strong dislike; disgust

was still bright with sunset. The middle one of the three windows was halfway open; and sitting close beside it, taking the air with an infinite sadness, like some hopeless prisoner, Utterson saw Dr. Jekyll.

"What! Jekyll!" he cried. "I trust you are better."

"I am very low, Utterson," replied the doctor drearily, "very low. It will not last long, thank God."

"You stay too much indoors," said the lawyer. "You should be out, getting some fresh air like Mr. Enfield and me. (This is my cousin—Mr. Enfield—Dr. Jekyll.) Come now; get your hat and take a quick turn with us."

"You are very good," sighed the other. "I should like to very much; but no, no, no, it is quite impossible; I dare not. But indeed, Utterson, I am very glad to see you; this is really a great pleasure; I would ask you and Mr. Enfield up, but the place is really not fit."

"Why, then," said the lawyer, good-naturedly,

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drearily: gloomily; very sadly

"the best thing we can do is to stay down here and speak with you from where we are."

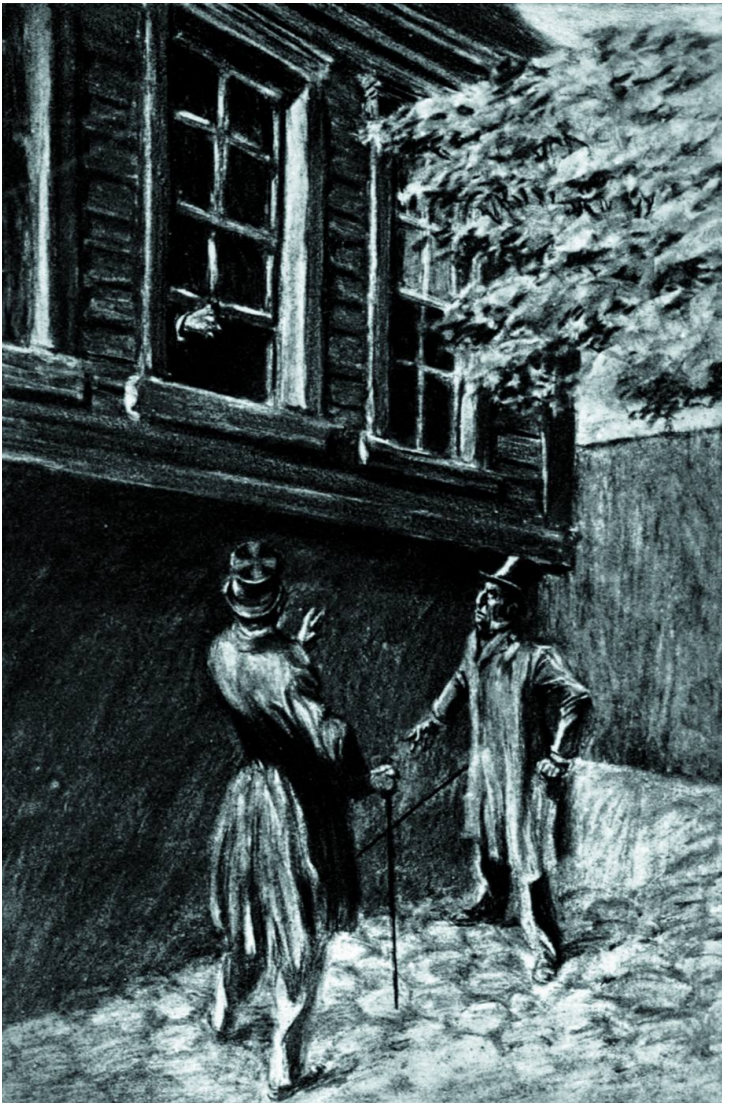
"That is just what I was about to propose," returned the doctor with a smile. But the words were hardly spoken before the smile was struck out of his face and followed by an expression of such extreme terror and despair that it froze the very blood of the two gentlemen below. They saw it only for a glimpse for the window was instantly thrust down; but that glimpse had been sufficient, and they turned and left the court without a word. In silence, they walked down the side street, and it was not until they had come into a neighboring street, where even upon a Sunday there were still some stirrings of life, that Mr. Utterson at last turned and looked at his companion. They were both pale, and there was horror in their eyes.

"God forgive us, God forgive us," said Mr. Utterson.

But Mr. Enfield only nodded his head very seriously, and walked on once more in silence.

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despair: hopelessness
sufficient: enough



They saw it only for a glimpse.

THE LAST NIGHT

Mr. Utterson was sitting by his fireside one evening after dinner, when he was surprised to receive a visit from Poole.

"Bless me, Poole, what brings you here?" he cried; and then taking a second look at him, "What ails you?" he added. "Is the doctor ill?"

"Mr. Utterson," said the man, "there is something wrong."

"Take a seat," said the lawyer. "Now, take your time, and tell me plainly what you want."

"You know the doctor's ways, sir," replied Poole, "and how he shuts himself up. Well, he's shut up again in his study; and I don't like it, sir. Mr. Utterson, sir, I'm afraid."

"Now, my good man," said the lawyer, "be clear. What are you afraid of?"

"I've been afraid for about a week," returned Poole, disregarding the question, "and I can bear it no more."

What ails you?: What is causing you pain? What is troubling you?



"Mr. Utterson," said Poole, "there is something wrong."

The man's appearance was changed for the worse, and except for the moment when he had first announced his terror, he had not once looked the lawyer in the face. Even now, he sat with his eyes directed to a corner of the floor. "I can bear it no more," he repeated.

"Come," said the lawyer, "I see you have some good reason, Poole; I see there is something seriously wrong. Try to tell me what it is."

"I think there's been foul play," said Poole, hoarsely.

"Foul play!" cried the lawyer. "Foul play! What do you mean?"

"I dare not say, sir," was the answer. "But will you come along with me and see for yourself?"

As Mr. Utterson got his hat and coat, he observed with wonder the great relief that appeared upon the butler's face.

It was a wild, cold night of March, with a pale moon. The wind made talking difficult, and seemed to have swept the streets unusually bare of people. Mr. Utterson thought he had never

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foul play: an expression meaning, a violent crime, especially murder

seen that part of London so deserted. Never in his life had he felt so strong a wish to see his fellow creatures; for struggle as he might, there pressed upon his mind a crushing anticipation of calamity.

The square, when they got there, was full of wind and dust, and the thin trees in the garden were lashing themselves along the railing. Poole, who had kept all the way a pace or two ahead, now pulled up in the middle of the pavement, and in spite of the biting weather, took off his hat and mopped his brow with a red handkerchief. His face was white and his voice, when he spoke, harsh and broken.

"Well, sir," he said, "here we are, and God grant there be nothing wrong."

"Amen, Poole," said the lawyer.

The servant knocked in a very guarded manner; the door was opened on the chain; and a voice asked from within, "Is that you, Poole?"

"It's all right," said Poole. "Open the door."

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deserted: empty of people; left behind; abandoned
anticipation: expectation; a sense that something is going to happen
calamity: disaster; an event that brings great pain and misery

The hall, when they entered it, was brightly lighted up; the fire was built high; and about the hearth all the servants, men and women, stood huddled together like a flock of sheep. At the sight of Mr. Utterson, the housemaid broke into uncontrolled sobbing; and the cook, crying out "Bless God! It's Mr. Utterson," ran forward as if to take him in her arms.

"What, are you all here?" said the lawyer crossly. "Very irregular, very inappropriate; your master would be far from pleased."

"They're all afraid," said Poole.

Blank silence followed, no one disagreeing; only the maid lifted her voice and now wept loudly.

"Hold your tongue!" Poole said to her fiercely, which revealed his own rattled nerves. They all started and turned towards the inner door with faces of dreadful expectation. "And now," continued the butler, taking up a candle, "we'll deal with this at once." And then he begged Mr. Utterson to follow him, and led the way to the back garden.

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started: moved suddenly

"Now, sir," said he, "I want you to hear, and I don't want you to be heard. And see here, sir, if by any chance he was to ask you in, don't go."

Mr. Utterson's nerves gave a jerk that nearly threw him from his balance; but he recollected his courage and followed the butler into the laboratory building through the surgical theater to the foot of the stair. Here Poole motioned him to stand on one side and listen, while he himself set down the candle, mounted the steps, and knocked with a somewhat uncertain hand on the red door to the study.

"Mr. Utterson, sir, asking to see you," he called, once more violently making signs to the lawyer to listen closely.

A voice answered from within: "Tell him I cannot see anyone," it said complainingly.

"Thank you, sir," said Poole; and taking up his candle, he led Mr. Utterson back across the yard and into the great kitchen.

"Sir," he said, looking Mr. Utterson in the eyes, "was that my master's voice?"

"It seems much changed," replied the lawyer, very pale.

"Changed? Well, yes, I think so," said the butler. "Have I been twenty years in this man's house, to be fooled about his voice? No, sir; master's made away with; he was made away with eight days ago, when we heard him cry out upon the name of God; and, Mr. Utterson, who's in there instead of him, and why does it stay there?"

"This is a very strange tale, Poole; this is rather a wild tale," said Mr. Utterson, biting his finger. "Suppose it were as you suppose, supposing Dr. Jekyll to have been—well, murdered, what could cause the murderer to stay? That won't hold water; it doesn't commend itself to reason."

"Well, Mr. Utterson, you are a hard man to satisfy, but I'll do it yet," said Poole. "All this last week, whatever it is that lives in the study has been crying night and day for some sort of medicine and cannot get it. It was sometimes his way—the master's, that is—to write his orders on a sheet of paper and throw it on the stair. We've

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made away with: an expression meaning, killed, destroyed
won't hold water: an expression meaning, not reasonable; not believable; won't stand up to examination
doesn't commend itself to reason: doesn't make sense

had nothing else this week but papers, and a closed door, and the meals left there to be smuggled in when nobody was looking. Well, sir, every day, ay, and twice and thrice in the same day, there have been orders and complaints, and I have been sent flying to all the chemists in town. Every time I brought the stuff back, there would be another paper telling me to return it, because it was not pure, and another order to a different firm. This drug is wanted bitter bad, sir, whatever for."

"Have you any of these papers?" asked Mr. Utterson.

Poole felt in his pocket and handed out a crumpled note, which the lawyer carefully examined. It said: "Dr. Jekyll sends best wishes to Mr. Maw and Company. He assures them that their last sample is impure and quite useless for his present purpose. In the year 18—, Dr. J. purchased a large quantity from Maw and Co. He now begs them to search most carefully, and

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thrice: three times
chemists: term used in England for pharmacists, those who prepare and sell drugs and medicines
bitter bad: very badly

should any of the same quality be left, forward it to him at once. Expense is no consideration. The importance of this to Dr. J. cannot be stated too strongly." So far the letter had seemed calm enough, but here the writer's emotion had broken loose. "For God's sake," he added, "find me some of the old."

"This is a strange note," said Mr. Utterson; and then sharply, "How do you come to have it open?"

"The man at Maw's was angry, sir, and he threw it back to me like so much dirt," returned Poole.

"This is unquestionably the doctor's handwriting?" asked the lawyer.

"I thought it looked like it," said the servant rather sulkily; and then, with another voice, "But why does the handwriting matter?" he said. "I've seen him!"

"Seen him?" repeated Mr. Utterson.

"It happened this way," said Poole. "I came suddenly into the theater from the garden. It

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sulkily: grumpily

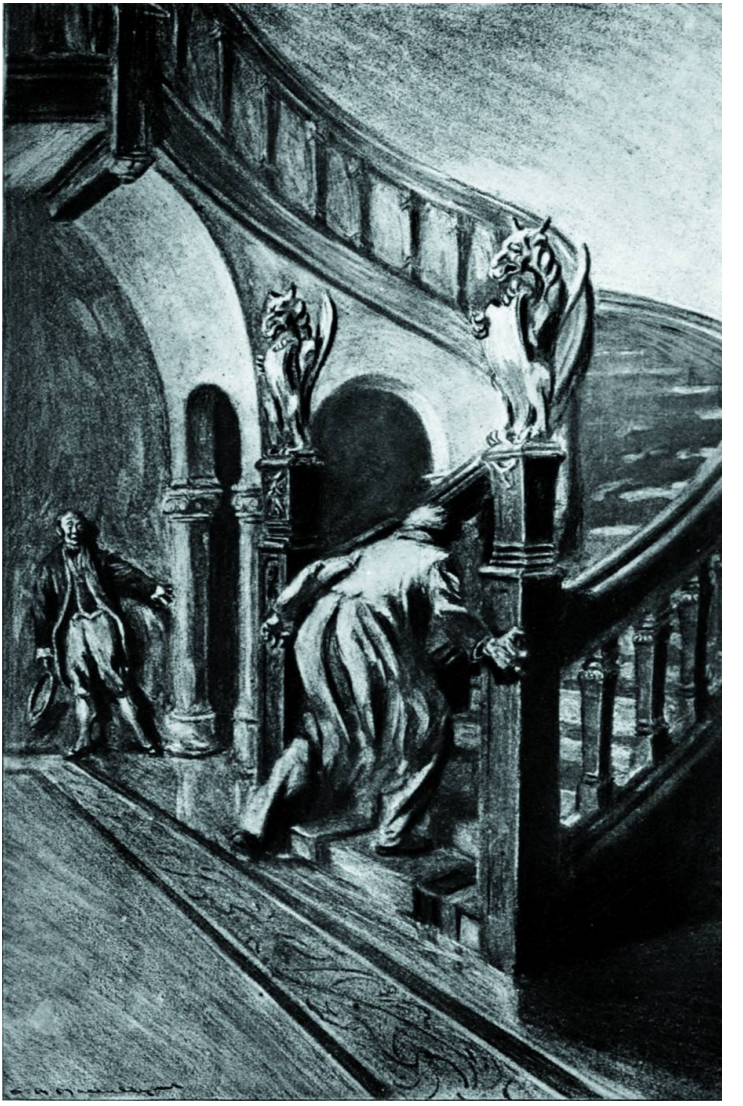
seems he had slipped out to look for this drug or whatever it is, for the study door was open, and there he was at the far end of the room digging among the crates. He looked up when I came in, gave a kind of cry, and whipped upstairs into the study. It was but for one minute that I saw him, but the hair stood upon my head like quills. Sir, if that was my master, why did he have a mask upon his face? If it was my master, why did he cry out like a rat, and run from me?"

"I think," said Mr. Utterson, "your master, Poole, is plainly seized with one of those illnesses that both torture and deform the sufferer: that is why his voice is changed; that is why he wears the mask and avoids his friends; that is why he is so eager to find this drug, by means of which the poor soul holds onto some hope of recovery! There is my explanation; it is sad enough, Poole, ay, and appalling to consider, but it is plain and natural, hangs well together, and delivers us from excessive alarms."

"Sir," said the butler, turning pale, "that thing

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appalling: shocking; horrifying



He gave a kind of cry and whipped upstairs into the study.

was not my master, and there's the truth. My master"—here he looked round him and began to whisper—"is a tall, fine build of a man, and this was more of a dwarf." Utterson attempted to protest. "Oh, sir," cried Poole, "do you think I do not know my master after twenty years? No, sir, that thing in the mask was never Dr. Jekyll—God knows what it was, but it was never Dr. Jekyll; and it is the belief of my heart that there was murder done."

"Poole," replied the lawyer, "it is my duty to make certain. Much as I desire to spare your master's feelings, much as I am puzzled by this note which seems to prove him to be still alive, I consider it my duty to break in that door."

"Ah, Mr. Utterson, that's talking!" cried the butler.

"And now comes the second question," resumed Utterson: "Who is going to do it?"

"Why, you and me, sir," was the undaunted reply.

"That's very well said," returned the lawyer.

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undaunted: unafraid in spite of great risks or challenges

"There is an axe in the theater," continued Poole, "and you might take the kitchen poker for yourself."

The lawyer took the heavy rod into his hand, and balanced it. "Do you know, Poole," he said, "that you and I are about to place ourselves in a position of some peril?"

"You may say so, sir, indeed," returned the butler.

"It is well, then, that we should be frank," said the other. "We both think more than we have said. This masked figure that you saw, did you recognize it?"

"Well, sir, it went so quick, and the creature was so doubled up, that I could hardly swear to that," was the answer. "But if you mean, was it Mr. Hyde?—why, yes, I think it was! You see, it was much of the same bigness; and it had the same quick, light way with it; and then who else could have got in by the laboratory door? But that's not all. I don't know, Mr. Utterson, if you ever met this Mr. Hyde?"

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poker: a metal rod used to stir or poke a fire
peril: danger
frank: direct and open in speech

"Yes," said the lawyer, "I once spoke with him."

"Then you must know as well as the rest of us that there was something strange about that gentleman—something that gave a man a turn—I don't know rightly how to say it, sir, beyond this: that you felt in your marrow kind of cold and thin."

"I felt something of what you describe," said Mr. Utterson.

"Quite so, sir," returned Poole. "Well, when that masked thing jumped like a monkey from among the chemicals and whipped into the study, it went down my spine like ice. Oh, I know it's not evidence, Mr. Utterson; but a man has his feelings, and I give you my bible-word it was Mr. Hyde!"

"Ay, ay," said the lawyer. "I share your fears. Evil was sure to come of that connection. Ay truly, I believe you; I believe poor Harry is killed; and I believe his murderer (for what purpose, God alone can tell) is still lurking in his victim's room."

Taking the poker under his arm, Mr. Utterson led the way into the yard. It was now quite dark. The wind tossed the light of the candle about

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gave a man a turn: scared or disturbed a person
marrow: substance inside the bones



Mr. Utterson and Poole make their way in the dark.

their steps, until they came into the shelter of the theater, where they sat down silently to wait. London hummed solemnly all around, but nearer at hand, the stillness was only broken by the sounds of a footfall moving to and fro along the study floor.

"So it will walk all day, sir," whispered Poole; "ay, and the better part of the night. But hark again, a little closer—put your heart in your ears, Mr. Utterson, and tell me, is that the doctor's foot?"

The steps fell lightly and oddly, different indeed from the heavy tread of Henry Jekyll. Utterson sighed. "Is there never anything else?" he asked.

Poole nodded. "Once," he said. "Once I heard it weeping!"

"Weeping?" said the lawyer, with a sudden chill of horror.

"Weeping like a lost soul," said the butler.

Poole pulled the axe from under a stack of packing straw; the candle was set upon the nearest

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hark: listen closely

table to light them to the attack; and they drew near to where that patient foot was still going up and down, up and down, in the quiet of the night.

"Jekyll," cried Utterson, with a loud voice, "I demand to see you." He paused a moment, but there came no reply. "I give you fair warning, I must and shall see you," he resumed; "if not by your consent, then by force!"

"Utterson," said the voice, "for God's sake, have mercy!"

"Ah, that's not Jekyll's voice—it's Hyde's!" cried Utterson. "Down with the door, Poole!"

Poole swung the axe over his shoulder; the blow shook the building, and the red door leaped against the lock and hinges. A dismal screech, as of pure animal terror, rang from the study. Up went the axe again, and again the panels crashed; four times the axe fell; but the wood was tough, and it was not until the fifth blow that the lock burst and the wreck of the door fell inwards on the carpet.

They peered in. There lay the study before their eyes in the quiet lamplight, a good fire

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consent: permission; approval; agreement

glowing, a drawer or two open, papers neatly set forth on the business table, and nearer the fire, the things laid out for tea; the quietest room, you would have said, and, except for the cabinets full of chemicals behind glass doors, the most ordinary that night in London.

Right in the middle there lay the body of a man painfully twisted and still twitching. They drew near, turned it on its back, and beheld the face of Edward Hyde. He was dressed in clothes far too large for him, clothes of the doctor's bigness; his face still moved with the appearance of life, but life was quite gone; and by the crushed small bottle in the hand and the strong smell that hung upon the air, Utterson knew that he was looking on the body of a self-destroyer.

"We have come too late," he said sternly, "whether to save or punish. Hyde is gone to his judgment, and all that is left for us is to find the body of your master."

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twitching: making sharp, jerky movements
strong smell: probably the bitter almond scent of a poison called cyanide
self-destroyer: a suicide

The theater, the study, a few dark closets, and a spacious cellar: all these they now thoroughly examined. Nowhere was there any trace of Henry Jekyll, dead or alive.

Poole stamped on the floor of the corridor. "He must be buried here," he said, listening to the sound.

"Or he may have fled," said Utterson, and he turned to examine the door to the side street. It was locked; and lying nearby on the floor, they found the key, already stained with rust.

"This does not look like it has been used often," observed the lawyer.

"Do you not see, sir," returned Poole, "it is broken? Much as if a man had stamped on it."

"Ay," continued Utterson, and the two men looked at each other with a scare. "This is beyond me, Poole," said the lawyer. "Let us go back to the study."

They mounted the stair in silence, and still with an occasional fearful glance at the dead body, proceeded more thoroughly to examine the contents of the study. At one table, there were

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corridor: hallway
fled: past tense of *flee*, to run away

traces of chemical work, various measured heaps of some white salt on glass saucers, as though for an experiment in which the unhappy man had been interrupted.

"That is the same drug that I was always bringing him," said Poole; and even as he spoke, the kettle with a startling noise boiled over.

This brought them to the fireside, where the easy-chair and the tea things stood ready, the very sugar in the cup. There were several books on a shelf; one lay beside the tea things open, and Utterson was amazed to find it a copy of a religious work for which Jekyll had several times expressed a great esteem, with notes on the pages in the doctor's own handwriting, full of startling blasphemies.

Next, the searchers came to the cheval glass, into whose depths they looked with an involuntary horror. It showed them nothing but the rosy glow of the fire playing on the roof, and their own pale and fearful countenances stooping to look in.

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esteem: respect and admiration
blasphemies: remarks that are disrespectful of religion and holy matters

"This mirror has seen some strange things, sir," whispered Poole.

"Surely," answered the lawyer. "For what did Jekyll"—he caught himself with a start, and then conquering the weakness—"what could Jekyll want with it?" he said.

Next they turned to the business table. On the desk, among the neatly arranged papers, there lay a large envelope which bore, in the doctor's handwriting, the name of Mr. Utterson. The lawyer unsealed it, and several enclosures fell to the floor. The first was a will, with the same strange terms as the one which he had returned six months before, but in place of the name of Edward Hyde, the lawyer, with indescribable amazement, read the name of Gabriel John Utterson. He looked at Poole, and then back at the paper, and last of all at the dead malefactor stretched upon the carpet.

"My head goes round," he said. "Hyde has been all these days in possession of this will; he had no cause to like me; he must have raged to see his name replaced with mine; and he has not destroyed this document."

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malefactor: evildoer; criminal; villain

He looked at the next paper; it was a brief note written in the doctor's handwriting and dated at the top. "Oh, Poole!" the lawyer cried, "he was alive and here this day. He must be still alive, he must have fled! But why? And how? And in that case, can we dare to declare this suicide? Oh, we must be careful. I foresee that we may yet involve your master in some dire catastrophe."

Suicide or Murder? Up to this moment of finding the note, Utterson had feared that Hyde (dead on the floor, an apparent suicide) has murdered Dr. Jekyll. Now, however, Utterson fears that Hyde did not kill himself but instead might have been killed by the doctor. What do you think?

"Why don't you read the note, sir?" asked Poole.

"Because I fear," replied the lawyer solemnly. "God grant I have no cause for it!" And with that he brought the paper to his eyes and read as follows:

> *My dear Utterson,—When this note shall fall into your hands, I shall have disappeared, under what circumstances I cannot foresee, but my instinct and my situation tell me that the end*

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dire: terrible
catastrophe: awful disaster
circumstances: the conditions surrounding an event
foresee: see in advance

is sure and must be soon. Go then, and first read the narrative which Lanyon warned me he was to place in your hands; and if you care to hear more, turn to the confession of

Your unworthy and unhappy friend,
Henry Jekyll

"There was a third enclosure?" asked Utterson.

"Here, sir," said Poole, and put into his hands a thick packet sealed in several places.

The lawyer put it in his pocket. "I would say nothing of this paper. If your master has fled or is dead, we may at least save his reputation. It is now ten; I must go home and read these documents in quiet, but I shall be back before midnight, when we shall send for the police."

They went out, locking the door of the theater behind them; and Utterson trudged back to his office to read the two narratives in which this mystery was now to be explained.

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reputation: public opinion about someone
trudged: walked in a slow, tired, heavy way

DR. LANYON'S NARRATIVE

On the ninth of January, now four days ago, I received by the evening delivery an envelope, addressed in the handwriting of my colleague and old school companion, Henry Jekyll. I was a good deal surprised by this, for we were by no means in the habit of correspondence. I had seen the man, dined with him, indeed, the night before. The contents increased my wonder; for this is how the letter ran:

The Sealed Letter
This chapter, called "Dr. Lanyon's Narrative," is the letter that Dr. Lanyon, near death, gave to Mr. Utterson, with this instruction written on the sealed envelope: "Not to be opened till the death or disappearance of Dr. Henry Jekyll."

10th December, 18—

Dear Lanyon,

You are one of my oldest friends; and although we may have differed at times on scientific questions, I cannot remember, at least on my side,

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colleague: a fellow worker; a fellow member of a profession [In this case, Lanyon and Jekyll are both doctors.]
correspondence: writing letters to each other

any break in our friendship. There was never a day when, if you had said to me, "Jekyll, my life, my honor, my reason, depend upon you," I would not have sacrificed my left hand to help you. Lanyon, my life, my honor, my reason, are all at your mercy; if you fail me tonight, I am lost. You might suppose that I am going to ask you to do something dishonorable. Judge for yourself.

I want you to postpone all other engagements for tonight, and with this letter in your hand, to drive straight to my house. Poole, my butler, has his orders; you will find him waiting your arrival with a locksmith. The door of my study is then to be forced open. You are to go in alone, to open the cabinet with glass doors (letter E) on the left, breaking the lock if it be shut, and to draw out, with all its contents as they stand, the fourth drawer from the top or (which is the same thing) the third from the bottom. In my extreme distress of mind, I have an extreme fear of misdirecting you; but even if I am in error, you may know the right drawer by its contents: some powders, a small

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postpone: put off till later
distress: feelings of great worry, sadness, anxiety, or pain

bottle, and a paper book. This drawer I beg you to carry back with you to Cavendish Square exactly as it stands.

That is the first part of the service: now for the second. A time when your servants are in bed is best for what remains to do. At midnight, then, I ask you to be alone in your consulting room, to admit with your own hand into the house a man who will present himself in my name, and to place in his hands the drawer from my study. Then you will have played your part and earned my gratitude completely. Five minutes afterwards, you will see that these arrangements, strange as they must seem, are of the highest importance, and that to neglect one of them, fantastic as they must appear, is to burden your conscience with my death or the shipwreck of my sanity.

I am confident that you will not deal lightly with what I ask, though my heart sinks and my hand trembles at the bare thought of such a possibility. Think of me at this hour, in a strange

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consulting room: the room in which a doctor meets with a patient

fantastic: extremely strange and remarkable

place, in dark distress, and yet well aware that, if you will but punctually serve me, my troubles will roll away like a story that is told. Serve me, my dear Lanyon, and save

Your friend,
H.J.

Upon the reading of this letter, I was sure my colleague was insane; but till that was proved beyond doubt, I felt I must do as he requested. I got into a hansom and drove straight to Jekyll's house. The butler was awaiting my arrival; he had received a letter of instruction, and had sent at once for a locksmith and a carpenter, who both came while we were speaking. We went as a group to the old surgical theatre, from which (as you are doubtless aware) Jekyll's private study is most conveniently entered. The door was very strong, the lock excellent; the carpenter declared he would have to do much damage, and the locksmith was near despair. But this locksmith was a handy fellow, and after two hour's work, the door stood

punctually: precisely on time
hansom: a two-wheeled horse-drawn cab

open. The cabinet marked E was unlocked; and I took out the drawer, tied it in a sheet, and returned with it to Cavendish Square.

Here I proceeded to examine its contents. It was plain to see that the powders were made by Jekyll himself, and when I opened one of the wrappers I found what seemed to me a simple crystalline salt of a white color. I next turned my attention to a small bottle, about half full of a blood-red liquid with a strong, sharp smell. At the other ingredients I could make no guess. The book was an ordinary notebook and contained little but a series of dates. These covered a period of many years, but I observed that the entries ceased nearly a year ago and quite abruptly. Here and there a brief remark was written by a date, usually no more than a single word, "double," occurring perhaps six times in a total of several hundred entries; and once, very early in the list and followed by several exclamation marks, "total failure!!!"

All this, though it made me curious, told

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ceased: stopped; came to an end
abruptly: in a sudden and unexpected way

me little that was definite. Here were a bottle, some kind of salt, and the record of a series of experiments that had led (like too many of Jekyll's investigations) to no practical usefulness. How could the presence of these articles in my house affect either the honor, the sanity, or the life of my colleague? And why was his messenger to be received by me in secret? The more I reflected, the more convinced I grew that I was dealing with a case of brain disease; and I loaded an old revolver for self-defense.

Twelve o'clock had scarce rung out over London when the knocker sounded very gently on the door. I went myself and found a small man crouching against the pillars of the porch.

"Are you come from Dr. Jekyll?" I asked.

He told me "yes" by a strained gesture; and when I told him to enter, he first cast a searching backward glance into the darkness of the square. There was a policeman not far off, and at the sight, I thought my visitor started and made greater haste.

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revolver: a type of handgun
pillars: upright supporting columns
made greater haste: hurried even more

As I followed him into the bright light of the consulting room, I kept my hand ready on my weapon. Here, at last, I had a chance of clearly seeing him. I had never set eyes on him before—that much was certain. He was small, as I have said. I was struck besides with the shocking expression of his face, with his remarkable combination of great muscular activity and great apparent weakness, and—last but not least—with the odd feeling of disturbance caused by his nearness, accompanied by a marked sinking of the pulse—which, at the time, I thought must be due to some strong personal dislike on my part. But I have since had reason to believe the cause to lie much deeper in the nature of man, and to arise from something nobler than the principle of hatred.

From the first moment of his entrance, I felt for this person what I can only describe as a disgustful curiosity. He was dressed in a fashion that would have made an ordinary person

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marked: noticeable

pulse: the regular movement of blood through the body, caused by the beating of your heart [A "sinking" of the pulse suggests that the heartbeat is slowing down or growing weaker.]

laughable; his clothes, although they were of fine fabric, were enormously too large for him in every measurement—the trousers hanging on his legs and rolled up to keep them from the ground, the waist of the coat below his haunches, and the collar sprawling wide upon his shoulders. Far from moving me to laughter, there was rather something abnormal in the very essence of the creature that now faced me—something seizing, surprising, and revolting—so that to my interest in the man's nature and character, there was added a curiosity as to his origin, his life, and place in the world.

"Have you got it?" he cried, on fire with excitement. "Have you got it?" In his impatience he even laid his hand upon my arm and sought to shake me.

I put him back, conscious at his touch of a certain icy pang along my blood. "Come, sir," said I.

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haunches: the upper parts of the legs
sprawling: spreading out awkwardly
essence: the basic nature of a thing or person
revolting: disgusting; extremely offensive
origin: beginnings
pang: a sudden, sharp, painful feeling

"Be seated, if you please." And I sat down myself in my usual seat, trying to act as I would with any ordinary patient as much as the horror I had of my visitor would allow.

"I beg your pardon, Dr. Lanyon," he replied politely enough. "I come here at the urging of your colleague, Dr. Henry Jekyll, on a piece of business of some importance; and I understood..." He paused and put his hand to his throat, and I could see, in spite of his calm manner, that he was wrestling against the approaches of hysteria—"I understood, a drawer..."

But here I took pity on my visitor's suspense, and some perhaps on my own growing curiosity.

"There it is, sir," said I, pointing to the drawer, where it lay on the floor behind a table and still covered with the sheet.

He sprang to it, and then paused, and laid his hand upon his heart; I could hear his teeth grinding, and his face was so ghastly to see that I grew alarmed both for his life and reason.

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hysteria: a state in which extreme emotions are out of control
suspense: feelings of anxious excitement as you wait to find out what will happen
ghastly: extremely frightening; horrifying; shocking

"Calm yourself," said I.

He turned an awful smile to me, and as if with the decision of despair, pulled away the sheet. At sight of the contents, he uttered one loud sob of such immense relief that I sat petrified. And the next moment, in a voice that was already fairly well under control, he asked, "Have you a graduated glass?"

I rose from my place with something of an effort and gave him what he asked.

He thanked me with a smiling nod, measured out a small amount of the red liquid, and added one of the powders. The mixture, which was at first of a reddish hue, began, as the crystals melted, to brighten in color, to effervesce audibly, and to throw off small fumes of vapor. Suddenly the bubbling ceased and the compound changed to a dark purple, which faded again more slowly

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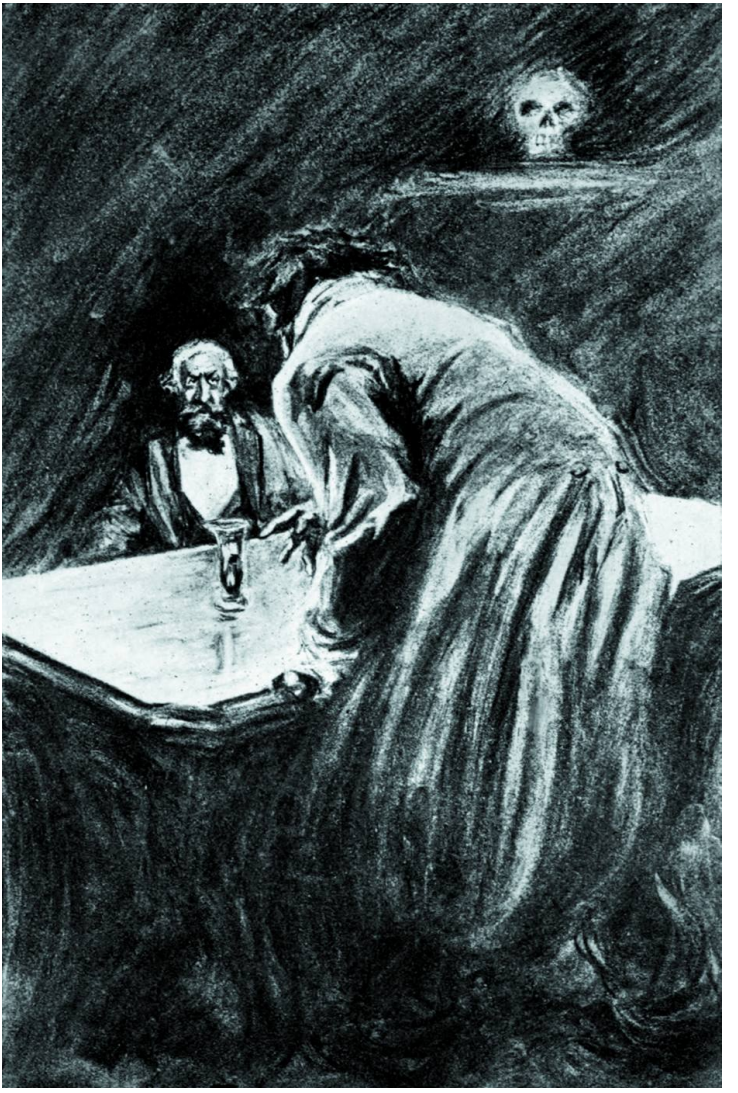
uttered: made a sound with the voice
immense: huge; great
petrified: still like a stone
graduated glass: a glass cylinder with markings on the side used to measure liquids
effervesce: to bubble and foam
compound: a substance formed by the combination of two or more parts

to a watery green. My visitor, who had closely watched these changes, smiled, set down the glass upon the table, and then turned and looked upon me with an air of scrutiny.

"And now," said he, "to settle what remains. Will you be wise? Will you be guided? Will you allow me to take this glass in my hand and to go forth from your house without further discussion? Or has the greed of curiosity too much command of you? Think before you answer, for it shall be done as you decide. As you decide, you shall either be left as you were before, and neither richer nor wiser, unless service to a man in distress may be counted as a kind of riches of the soul; or, if you so choose, new knowledge and new avenues to fame and power shall be laid open to you, here, in this room, upon the instant; and your sight shall be blasted by a prodigy to stagger the unbelief of Satan."

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scrutiny: close and careful examination
upon the instant: immediately
blasted: struck with extreme force
prodigy: a wonder; something extremely out of the ordinary
stagger: to shock or surprise; to amaze or astonish



"Will you allow me to take this glass in my hand?"

"Sir," said I, pretending a calmness I did not truly possess, "you speak riddles, and you will perhaps not wonder that I hear you with little belief. But I have gone too far to pause before I see the end."

"It is well," replied my visitor. "Lanyon, you remember your vows: what follows is under the seal of our profession. And now, Lanyon, you who have so long been bound to the most narrow and

A Pledge of Secrecy
By now, you have recognized the man whom Lanyon calls "my visitor" as Mr. Hyde. When Mr. Hyde tells Lanyon that "what follows is under the seal of our profession," he is telling Lanyon that it his duty as a doctor to say nothing about what he is about to see. That is because the "vows" that doctors make include a promise to respect the privacy of their patients and not speak about them in public.

Mr. Hyde's words—"under the seal of our profession"—borrow a term used in law. In law, a document that is "under seal" is in a sealed envelope and cannot be seen by the public. So, Mr. Hyde is telling Lanyon that his pledge as a doctor requires him to tell no one about the new knowledge he is about to gain.

You might have noticed something curious here: It is *Mr. Hyde* who tells Lanyon that "what follows is under the seal of our profession"—but to whom does "our" refer? Mr. Hyde does not share a profession with Dr. Lanyon. Who does?

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vows: promises; pledges
bound to: tied down to
narrow: limited and small-minded

material views, you who have denied the virtue of transcendental medicine, you who have derided your superiors—behold!"

He put the glass to his lips and drank at one gulp. A cry followed; he reeled, staggered, clutched at the table and held on, staring with bloodshot eyes, gasping with open mouth; and as I looked there came, I thought, a change—he seemed to swell—his face became suddenly black and the features seemed to melt and alter—and the next moment, I had sprung to my feet and leaped back against the wall, my arms raised to shield me, my mind flooded by terror.

"O God!" I screamed, and "O God!" again and again; for there before my eyes—pale and shaken, and half fainting, and groping before him with his hands, like a man restored from death—there stood Henry Jekyll!

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material: relating to the physical (rather than to matters of the mind or soul)
virtue: power; goodness
transcendental: going beyond ordinary experience
derided: scorned; mocked; laughed at
reeled: fell back suddenly (as from a shock)
staggered: moved unsteadily
bloodshot: marked by many red lines
alter: change
groping: reaching uncertainly



"Like a man restored from death—there stood Henry Jekyll!"

What he told me in the next hour, I cannot bring my mind to set on paper. I saw what I saw, I heard what I heard, and my soul sickened at it; and yet now when that sight has faded from my eyes, I ask myself if I believe it, and I cannot answer. My life is shaken to its roots; sleep has left me; the deadliest terror sits by me at all hours of the day and night; and I feel that my days are numbered, and that I must die; and yet I shall die incredulous. As for the moral wickedness that man revealed to me, even with tears of penitence, I cannot, even in memory, think of it without horror. I will say but one thing, Utterson, and that (if you can bring your mind to believe it) will be more than enough. The creature who crept into my house that night was, as Jekyll himself confessed, known by the name of Hyde and hunted for in every corner of the land as the murderer of Carew.

Hastie Lanyon

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incredulous: unbelieving
penitence: sorrow and regret for the wrongs a person has done

HENRY JEKYLL'S FULL STATEMENT OF THE CASE

The Doctor's Confession
You recall that (in the chapter titled "The Last Night") Poole and Utterson broke into Dr. Jekyll's study, where they found the dead body of Mr. Hyde, and also found a large envelope addressed to Mr. Utterson. The envelope contained three things: (1) a revised will, (2) a note to Utterson from Dr. Jekyll, and (3) another sealed envelope containing the doctor's written "confession."

In the note, the doctor told Mr. Utterson to read Lanyon's narrative first, and only afterward to read the "confession" in the sealed envelope. In the previous chapter, you read Lanyon's narrative. And now, this concluding chapter presents the doctor's confession—his own narrative of what happened.

I was born in the year 18—to a large fortune. Naturally hard-working, I wished to be respected by the wise and good. As such, it might be supposed that I was sure to enjoy an honorable and distinguished future. And indeed the worst of my faults was a certain impatient liveliness of character, which I found it hard to reconcile with my desire to carry my

large fortune: great wealth; plenty of money
distinguished: well-known and respected
reconcile: to bring into agreement two ideas or beliefs that seem to be in conflict

head high and wear a more than commonly grave countenance before the public. And so I concealed my pleasures; and when I reached an age at which I began to look round me and think carefully about my progress and position in the world, I stood already committed to a profound duplicity of life.

Many a man would have boasted of such irregularities as I was guilty of, but because of the high views that I had set before me, I hid them with an almost sickly sense of shame. It was thus the exacting nature of my aspirations, rather than any particular shame in my faults, that made me what I was, and, even more than in most men, severed in me those provinces of good and ill which divide and compound man's dual nature.

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concealed: hid
profound: deep; thorough; complete
duplicity: deceitful doubleness
irregularities: improper or dishonest acts
exacting: very difficult and demanding; requiring precise and careful attention
aspirations: hopes for achievement; strongly desired goals
severed: divided; cut into separate parts
provinces: large areas
ill: bad; evil
compound: to form from separate parts
dual: made up of two parts

I was in no sense a hypocrite. I was no more myself when I plunged in shame than when I labored to advance knowledge or relieve sorrow and suffering. And it chanced that my scientific studies, which led wholly towards the mystic and the transcendental, shed a strong light on this ongoing war within me. With every day, I thus drew steadily nearer to that truth: that man is not truly one, but truly two.

I say two, because my own knowledge does not pass beyond that point. Others will follow, others will go beyond me; and I hazard the guess that a person may ultimately be understood to be a mere collection of diverse, incongruous, and independent inhabitants.

I, for my part, from the nature of my life, advanced steadily in one direction and in one direction only, on the moral side. In my own

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hypocrite: a person who pretends to virtues and morals that he or she does not actually have
mystic: having to do with mysteries beyond the ordinary and earthly
hazard: take a chance to offer
ultimately: in the end; finally
incongruous: conflicting; made up of different parts that do not work well together

person, I learned to recognize the thorough and primitive duality of man. I saw that, of the two natures that contended in my consciousness, if I could be said to be one or the other, it was only because I was radically both; and before my scientific discoveries had begun to suggest even the barest possibility of such a miracle, I had learned to dream with pleasure of the thought of the separation of these elements. If each, I told myself, could be housed in separate identities, life would be relieved of all that was unbearable; the unjust might go his way, freed from the aspirations and remorse of his more upright twin; and the just could walk steadily on his upward path, doing the good things in which he found his pleasure, and no longer exposed to disgrace and penitence by the hands of this external evil.

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primitive: from the very earliest stages of human development
contended: struggled against each other
consciousness: a person's mind, with all its thoughts and feelings
radically: in the most basic and fundamental way
the unjust: the dishonest, immoral, wrongdoing part of the self
remorse: feelings of guilt, sadness, and regret for things you have done wrong
upright: honest and trustworthy
the just: the part of the self that is guided by what is right, fair, and true

It was the curse of mankind that these incongruous parts were bound together —that in the agonized consciousness, these polar twins should be continuously struggling. How, then, were they separated?

Not One But Two
Dr. Jekyll speaks of "man's dual nature" and "the duality of man." He says that he has come to understand "the truth" that the individual self is "not truly one, but truly two."

What do you think Jekyll means by this? Do you agree?

Jekyll says it is a "curse" that these two parts are "bound together." Why does Jekyll want to separate them? What does he think would be gained by this separation?

As I have said, a light began to shine upon the subject from the laboratory table. I began to perceive more deeply than it has ever yet been stated, that the body in which we walk, and which seems so solid, is instead a trembling, mistlike garment. I found that certain chemicals have the power to shake and pluck back that fleshly garment, as a wind might toss the curtains. I will not enter deeply into this scientific branch of my

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agonized: in extreme pain or sadness
polar: completely opposite
perceive: to become aware of; to understand
trembling: shaking quickly; unsteady
garment: piece of clothing
pluck: to pull off quickly

confession, because, as my narrative will sadly reveal, my discoveries were incomplete. Still, I not only recognized my natural body as the mere outward radiance of certain powers that made up my spirit, but managed to compound a drug to dethrone these powers from their supremacy and substitute a second form and countenance that were none the less natural to me because they were the expression of the lower elements in my soul.

I hesitated long before I put this theory to the test of practice. I knew well that I risked death from any drug that so powerfully controlled and shook the very fortress of identity. But the temptation of a discovery so singular and profound at last overcame my fear. I had long since begun to prepare my potion; I purchased at once, from a firm of chemists, a large quantity of a particular salt which I knew, from my experiments, to be the last ingredient required. And late one accursed night,

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dethrone: to take away the power of (usually, of a king or queen)
supremacy: the condition of having the most power and authority
fortress: a strong, well-protected building
accursed: under a curse; doomed

I mixed together the elements, watched them boil and smoke together in the glass, and, with a strong glow of courage, drank off the potion.

The most racking pangs followed: a grinding in the bones, deadly nausea, and a horror of the spirit that cannot be exceeded at the hour of birth or death. Then these agonies began swiftly to subside, and I came to myself as if out of a great sickness. There was something strange in my sensations, something indescribably new and incredibly sweet. I felt younger, lighter, happier in body. I was conscious of a thrilling recklessness, a current of exciting images flooding my imagination, a dissolving of the bonds of obligation, an unknown but not an innocent freedom of the soul. I knew myself, at the first breath of this new life, to be more wicked, tenfold more wicked, a slave to my original evil; and the thought, in that moment, energized and delighted me like wine. I stretched out my hands, exulting in

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racking: causing great pain
agonies: extreme pains
subside: to become less strong
tenfold: ten times
exulting: feeling great joy and excitement, mixed with a boastful feeling of victory

The Bonds of Obligation
After the painful effects of drinking the potion have passed, what does Dr. Jekyll feel?

One of the effects that Jekyll feels after swallowing the potion is "a dissolving of the bonds of obligation." What does he mean by that?

We all have obligations—duties we must fulfill, and rules we must follow. By fulfilling our obligations, we make it possible for people to live and work together in a civilized society.

Jekyll calls these obligations "bonds." In one sense, bonds can be things that join people together in a shared experience, such as bonds of friendship. In another sense, bonds can be things that tie us down or restrict us, like the ropes tied around a prisoner's wrists. For Jekyll, the "dissolving" of these "bonds of obligation" means that he no longer feels any sense of duty toward others nor any human connection with others.

the freshness of these sensations; and in the act, I was suddenly aware that I had lost in stature.

At that time there was no mirror in my room; the one that stands beside me as I write was brought there later on and for the very purpose of these transformations. Filled with hope and triumph, I crossed the yard, where the constellations looked down upon me, I could have thought, with wonder, the first creature of that sort

lost in stature: become shorter
triumph: victory, and the feeling of excited joy that comes with it

that their unsleeping vigilance had yet disclosed to them. I stole through the corridors, a stranger in my own house, and, coming to my bedroom, I saw for the first time the appearance of Edward Hyde.

Here I must say not that which I know, but that which I suppose to be most probable. The evil side of my nature, to which I had now transferred the power of formation, was less robust and less developed than the good which I had just overthrown. In the course of my life, which had been nine tenths a life of effort, virtue, and control, it had been much less exercised and much less exhausted. And so, I think, it came about that Edward Hyde was so much smaller, slighter, and younger than Henry Jekyll. Even as good shone upon the countenance of the one, evil was written broadly and plainly on the face of the other. Evil (which I must still believe to be the lethal side of man) had also left on that body

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vigilance: watchfulness
disclosed: revealed; made known
probable: likely to be true
power of formation: the power to form and give shape
robust: strong and healthy
virtue: good and moral conduct
exhausted: used up; tired out
lethal: deadly

an imprint of deformity and decay. And yet when I looked upon that ugly idol in the mirror, I was conscious of no repugnance, rather of a leap of welcome. This, too, was myself. It seemed natural and human. In my eyes it bore a livelier image of the spirit, it seemed more definite and single, than the imperfect and divided countenance I had been hitherto accustomed to call mine.

I have observed that when I wore the semblance of Edward Hyde, none could come near to me at first without a visible misgiving of the flesh. This, as I understand it, was because all human beings, as we meet them, are commingled out of good and evil: and Edward Hyde, alone in all of mankind, was pure evil.

I lingered only a moment at the mirror. The second experiment had yet to be attempted.

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imprint: a mark made by pressure
idol: an object or image of worship
repugnance: extreme dislike or hatred
semblance: outward appearance
misgiving: feeling of mistrust, suspicion, doubt
the flesh: the body [Jekyll is saying that when people came near Hyde, they felt a trembling sense of doubt and suspicion that you could see even in their bodies ("the flesh").]
commingled: combined; mixed together
lingered: stayed in place (usually, longer than expected)

It remained to be seen if I had lost my identity beyond redemption. Hurrying back to my study, I once more prepared and drank the cup, once more suffered the pangs of transformation, and came to myself once more with the character, the stature, and the face of Henry Jekyll.

That night I had come to the fateful crossroads. If I had approached my discovery in a more noble spirit, had I risked the experiment while ruled by generous or pious aspirations, then from these agonies of death and birth I would have come forth an angel instead of a fiend. The drug was neither diabolical nor divine; it merely shook the doors of the prison-house of my character, and that which stood within ran forth. At that time my virtue slumbered; my evil, kept awake by ambition, was alert and swift to seize the occasion; and the thing that came forth was Edward Hyde. Hence,

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redemption: recovery; rescue
fateful: critically important in shaping what is to come
crossroads: where roads meet (and where one can choose which path to follow)
pious: very religious and moral
diabolical: devilish; wicked; evil
divine: heavenly; from God
slumbered: slept

although I had now two characters as well as two appearances, one was wholly evil, and the other was still the old Henry Jekyll, that incongruous compound for whom I had already lost hope of any change for the better. The movement was thus wholly toward the worse.

Even at that time, I had not overcome my great dislike for the dullness of a life of study. As my pleasures were (to say the least) undignified, and I was not only well known and highly thought of, but growing towards the elderly man, this incoherence of my life was daily growing more unwelcome. It was on this side that my new power tempted me until I fell in slavery. I simply had to drink the cup, to throw off the body of the noted professor, and to assume, like a thick cloak, that of Edward Hyde.

It seemed to me at the time to be humorous. I smiled as I carefully made my preparations. I took and furnished that house in Soho, to which Hyde was tracked by the police; and I hired as

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undignified: embarrassing; inappropriate; shameful
elderly: old
cloak: a garment that covers the body, like a large coat or cape

a housekeeper an unscrupulous creature whom I knew would keep silent. On the other side, I announced to my servants that a Mr. Hyde (whom I described) was to have complete freedom and power about my house in the square; and to avoid any accidents, I even visited as Mr. Hyde and made myself a familiar guest in my second character. I next prepared that will to which you so much objected, so that if anything happened to me in the person of Dr. Jekyll, I could go on as Edward Hyde without loss of wealth.

Men have before hired bandits and assassins to commit their crimes, while protecting their own reputation. I was the first that ever did so for his pleasures. I was the first that could walk in the public eye with respectability, and in a moment, like a schoolboy, strip off these borrowed garments and spring headlong into the sea of liberty. My safety was complete. Think of it—I did not even exist! Let me escape into my laboratory door, give

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unscrupulous: having no moral standards; willing to do things that are illegal or dishonest

respectability: the state of being worthy of respect, of being considered to be good and decent and honorable

me a second or two to mix and swallow the potion that I had always standing ready, and whatever he had done, Edward Hyde would pass away like the stain of breath upon a mirror; and there in his place, quietly at home in his study, a man who could laugh at suspicion, would be Henry Jekyll.

The pleasures which I made haste to seek in my disguise were, as I have said, undignified; but in the hands of Edward Hyde, they soon began to turn toward the monstrous. This being that I called out of my own soul, and sent forth alone to do his pleasure, was a being inherently malign and villainous, his every act and thought centered on self, greedily drinking pleasure from any degree of torture to another, merciless like a man of stone. Henry Jekyll stood at times aghast before the acts of Edward Hyde; but the situation was apart from ordinary laws, and gradually relaxed the grasp of conscience. It was

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inherently: naturally; in a way that is basic to and inseparable from who someone is
malign: evil; wicked
torture: the act of causing another to feel great pain and suffering (both physical and mental)
aghast: horrified

Hyde, after all, and Hyde alone, that was guilty. Jekyll was no worse; he woke again to his good qualities seemingly undamaged; he would even rush, when possible, to undo the evil done by Hyde. And thus his conscience slumbered.

Who Is Guilty?
Here in his confession, Dr. Jekyll describes Hyde as a person separate from the doctor himself. Jekyll says that he is horrified when he thinks of what Hyde has done. Jekyll also claims, "It was Hyde, after all, and Hyde alone, that was guilty." Do you agree with that claim? Why or why not?

I have no intention of going into the details of my evil acts (for even now I can scarce admit that I committed them). I only mean to point out the warnings and the steps with which my punishment approached. I met with one accident which I shall briefly mention. An act of cruelty to a child aroused against me the anger of a passerby, whom I recognized the other day as your kinsman. The doctor and the child's family joined him; there were moments when I feared for my life; and at last, in order to calm their anger, Edward Hyde had to bring them to the door and pay them in a check drawn in the name of Henry Jekyll. Later I avoided this danger by



It was Hyde, after all, and Hyde alone, that was guilty.

opening an account at another bank in the name of Edward Hyde himself; and when, by slanting my own handwriting backward, I supplied my double with a signature, I thought I sat beyond the reach of fate.

Some two months before the murder of Sir Danvers, I had been out for one of my adventures, had returned at a late hour, and woke the next day in bed with odd sensations. I looked about me, saw the decent furniture and tall proportions of my room, recognized the design of the mahogany frame—but something still kept insisting that I was not where I was, that I had not wakened where I seemed to be, but in the little room in Soho where I slept in the body of Edward Hyde. I smiled to myself, and in my psychological way, began lazily to examine this illusion, occasionally dropping back into a comfortable morning doze. I was still so engaged when, in one of my more wakeful moments, my eyes fell upon my hand.

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fate: the power believed to control what will happen
mahogany: a hard, reddish-brown wood
psychological: relating to psychology, the science that studies the mind and behavior
doze: a light sleep; a nap

As you have remarked, the hand of Henry Jekyll was professional in shape and size, large, firm, and pleasing in appearance. But the hand which I now saw clearly in the yellow light of a mid-London morning was lean, corded, knuckly, and thickly shaded with a dark growth of hair. It was the hand of Edward Hyde.

I must have stared upon it for near half a minute, sunk in wonder, before terror startled me like the sudden crash of cymbals. Bounding from my bed, I rushed to the mirror. At the sight that met my eyes, my blood changed into something thin and icy. Yes, I had gone to bed Henry Jekyll, I had awakened Edward Hyde.

How was this to be explained? I asked myself. And then, with another bound of terror—how was it to be remedied? It was well on in the morning; the servants were up; all my drugs were in the study. From where I was then standing horrified, it was a long journey down two pairs of stairs, through the back passage, across the open

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corded: tough and stringy
bounding: jumping up; leaping
remedied: cured; healed; fixed

court and through the anatomical theater. It might be possible to cover my face; but of what use was that, when I was unable to conceal the alteration in my stature? And then with an overpowering sweetness of relief, it came back upon my mind that the servants were already used to the coming and going of my second self. I soon dressed, as well as I was able, in clothes of my own size, passed through the house, and ten minutes later, Dr. Jekyll returned to his own shape and was sitting down to breakfast.

Small indeed was my appetite. After this inexplicable incident, a reversal of my previous experience, I began to reflect more seriously than ever before on my double existence. It seemed to me as though the body of Edward Hyde, which had lately been much exercised and nourished, had grown in stature. I began to spy a danger that, if this were to continue, the balance of my nature might be permanently overthrown. I might lose the power of voluntary change, and the character of Edward Hyde become irrevocably mine. The

alteration: change
inexplicable: impossible to explain
irrevocably: irreversibly; in a way that cannot be changed back

drug had not always been equally effective. Once, very early, it had totally failed me; since then, on more than one occasion, I had to double, and once, with infinite risk of death, to triple the amount. In the beginning, the difficulty had been to throw off the body of Jekyll, but in the light of that morning's accident, all things seemed to point to this: that I was slowly losing hold of my original and better self, and becoming slowly incorporated with my second and worse.

Between these two, I now felt I had to choose. My two natures had memory in common, but all other abilities were unequally shared between them. Jekyll (who was composite), sometimes with great doubts and fears, sometimes with greedy delight, shared in the pleasures and adventures of Hyde; but Hyde was indifferent to Jekyll, or remembered him as the mountain bandit remembers the cavern in which he conceals himself from pursuit. To choose Jekyll was to die to those appetites which I had long secretly indulged; to choose Hyde was

composite: made up of separate parts
indifferent: without care or concern; completely uninterested
pursuit: a chase in order to capture
indulged: allowed yourself to do or have things you enjoy (often said of things that may not be good or good for you)

to die to a thousand interests and aspirations, and to become, at once and forever, despised and friendless. There was more to consider, for while Jekyll would suffer sharply in the fires of self-denial, Hyde would be not even conscious of all that he had lost. Strange as my circumstances were, the terms of this debate are as old and commonplace as mankind, with similar attractions and fears for any tempted and trembling sinner. It happened with me as it does with so vast a majority of my fellows, that I chose the better part and was found lacking in the strength to keep to it.

Good, Evil, and Composite
In creating the characters of Jekyll and Hyde, Stevenson has not created simple opposites. Hyde has been described as "pure evil," but Jekyll is not pure good. Earlier, the doctor called himself an "incongruous compound," and here he describes himself as "composite"—as a mixture of various qualities and characteristics.

Why do you think Stevenson keeps reminding us that the doctor is not purely good but a mixture of qualities, good and bad?

Yes, I preferred the elderly and discontented doctor, surrounded by friends and holding onto honest hopes. I said a firm farewell to the liberty, the youth, the light step, leaping impulses, and

despised: hated; looked down on with disgust
discontented: not satisfied; restless and unhappy

secret pleasures that I had enjoyed in the disguise of Hyde. Even as I made this choice, I neither gave up the house in Soho nor destroyed the clothes of Edward Hyde, which still lay ready in my study. For two months, however, I was true to my determination; for two months, I led a life of such severity as I had never before achieved, and enjoyed the rewards of an approving conscience. But time began at last to wear down my fear; the praises of conscience began to grow dull; I began to be tortured with longings, as though Hyde were struggling after freedom; and at last, in an hour of moral weakness, I once again compounded and swallowed the transforming potion.

Long as I had considered my position, I had not recognized enough the complete moral insensibility and the unfeeling readiness to evil which were the leading characteristics of Edward Hyde. Yet it was by these that I was punished. My devil had been long caged, he came out roaring. I was conscious, even when I took the potion, of a more uncontrolled, a more furious readiness to

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severity: moral strictness; harsh self-discipline
insensibility: lack of feeling or awareness

do evil. It must have been this, I suppose, that stirred in my soul that tempest of impatience with which I listened to the polite remarks of my unfortunate victim, Sir Danvers; I declare before God, no morally sane man could have been guilty of that crime with so little cause. I struck him in no more reasonable spirit than that in which a sick child may break a plaything. But I had voluntarily stripped myself of all those balancing instincts by which even the worst of us continues to walk with some degree of steadiness among temptations; and in my case, to be tempted, however slightly, was to fall.

Instantly the spirit of hell awoke in me and raged. With a thrill of glee, I mauled the unresisting body, tasting delight from every blow; and it was not till weariness set in that I was suddenly, at the height of my delirium, struck through the heart by a cold thrill of terror. A mist dispersed; I saw my life to be lost, and fled from the scene of these excesses, at once glorying and trembling,

tempest: violent storm
glee: great delight; excited joy
mauled: attacked and injured by beating, cutting, or tearing
delirium: a state of wildly excited emotion
excesses: extreme actions; actions that go beyond accepted limits

my appetite for evil gratified and stimulated, my love of life at its highest point. I ran to the house in Soho and destroyed my papers; from there I set out through the lamplit streets, in the same divided wildness of mind, gloating on my crime, imagining others in the future, and yet still hurrying and still listening for the steps of the avenger.

Hyde sang a song as he mixed the potion, and as he drank it, pledged the dead man. The pangs of transformation had not finished tearing him before Henry Jekyll, with streaming tears of gratitude and remorse, fell upon his knees and lifted his clasped hands to God. The veil of self-indulgence was torn from head to foot. I saw my life as a whole: I followed it up from the days of childhood, when I had walked with my father's

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gratified: pleased and satisfied
stimulated: made more active
gloating: taking excessive pleasure and pride in what you have done
avenger: one who punishes a wrongdoer
pledged: made a toast (that is, expressed good wishes for someone and then took a drink)
veil: a piece of cloth through which you can see partially, worn to cover or hide part or all of the wearer
self-indulgence: selfishly giving in to your own desires; allowing yourself to do whatever you want no matter how it might affect or harm others

hand, and through the self-denying toils of my professional life, to arrive again and again, with the same sense of unreality, at the horrors of the evening. I could have screamed aloud; I sought with tears and prayers to smother down the crowd of hideous images and sounds with which my memory swarmed against me; and still, the ugly face of my iniquity stared into my soul. As this remorse began to die away, it was followed by a sense of joy. The problem of my conduct was solved. From that moment forward, Hyde was impossible. I must now be confined to the better part of my existence; and oh, how I rejoiced to think of it! With willing humility I embraced once more the restrictions of natural life! With what sincere renunciation I locked the door by which I had so often gone and come, and ground the key under my heel!

self-denying: being unselfish; not allowing yourself to do what you want
toils: hard labors; difficult tasks
smother down: to cover completely (in order to keep something from growing or spreading)
hideous: disgusting; horrible; shocking
confined: limited or restricted to
humility: the quality of being humble, not being proud
restrictions: limits; rules that say what is and is not allowed
renunciation: the act of giving up or sacrificing something

The next day came the news that the murder had been seen by an observer, that the guilt of Hyde was known to the world, and that the victim was a highly respected man. It was not only a crime, it had been a tragic folly. I think I was glad to know it; I think I was glad to have my better impulses reinforced by the terrors of the scaffold. Jekyll was now my refuge; let Hyde peep out even an instant, and the hands of all men would be raised to take and slay him.

I resolved in my future conduct to make up for the past. You know yourself how earnestly , in the last months of the last year, I labored to relieve suffering; you know that the days passed quietly, almost happily for me. I think that I daily enjoyed this good and innocent life more completely; but I was still cursed with my duality of purpose; and as the first edge of my penitence wore off, the

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folly: foolish action
impulses: feelings; motivations; desires to do something
scaffold: a raised platform on which a criminal is executed by hanging
refuge: shelter; a place of protection and safety
take: capture / **slay:** kill
resolved: determined; made up [his] mind
earnestly: with great sincerity

lower side of me, so long indulged, so recently chained down, began to growl for release. Not that I dreamed of bringing Hyde back to life; the bare idea of that would startle me to frenzy. No, it was in my own person, as Dr. Jekyll, that I was once more tempted to trifle with my conscience; and it was as an ordinary secret sinner that I at last fell to temptation.

There comes an end to all things; the largest cup is filled at last; and this brief giving in to my evil finally destroyed the balance of my soul. And yet I was not alarmed; the fall seemed natural, like a return to the old days before I had made my discovery.

It was a fine, clear, January day, wet under foot where the frost had melted, but cloudless overhead. I sat in the sun on a park bench, promising to be better, but not yet moved to begin. After all, I reflected, I was like my neighbors; and then I smiled, comparing myself with other men, comparing my active goodwill with the lazy cruelty

frenzy: a state of wild mental excitement and disturbance, near madness
trifle: to treat without respect or seriousness
goodwill: helpfulness; kindness

of their indifference. And at the very moment of that proud thought, a sickly feeling came over me, a horrid nausea and the most deadly shuddering. These passed away, and left me faint; and then as the faintness subsided, I began to be aware of a change in the nature of my thoughts, a greater boldness, a recklessness, a dissolving of the bonds of obligation. I looked down; my clothes hung formlessly on my shrunken limbs; the hand that lay on my knee was corded and hairy. I was once more Edward Hyde. A moment before I had been sure of all men's respect, wealthy, beloved—and now I was the common quarry of mankind, hunted, houseless, a known murderer.

My reason wavered, but it did not fail me completely. Where Jekyll might have broken down, Hyde rose to the moment. My drugs were in my study; how was I to reach them? That was the problem that I set myself to solve. I had closed the laboratory door. If I tried to enter by the house, my own servants would send me to the gallows.

formlessly: without a regular shape
limbs: arms and legs
quarry: a hunted animal
wavered: became unsteady; weakened
gallows: an upright frame from which criminals are hanged



I was once more Edward Hyde.

I saw I must have help from another, and thought of Lanyon. How was he to be reached? How persuaded? Supposing that I escaped capture in the streets, how was I to make my way into his presence? And how should I, an unknown and displeasing visitor, convince the famous physician to rob the study of his colleague, Dr. Jekyll? Then I remembered that I could still write in my own handwriting, and that spark lighted the way that I must follow.

I arranged my clothes as best I could, called a passing hansom, and drove to a hotel in Portland Street. At my appearance the driver could not conceal his mirth. I bared my teeth at him with devilish fury, and the smile faded from his face—luckily for him, for in another instant I would have certainly dragged him from his seat.

At the hotel, as I entered, I looked about me so fiercely that the attendants trembled. They obediently took my orders, led me to a private room, and brought me supplies for writing. Hyde in danger of his life was a creature new to me—

physician: a medical doctor
mirth: amusement; laughter
bared: showed; exposed

shaken with extreme anger, ready to murder, eager to inflict pain. Yet the creature was clever, and, mastering his fury with a great effort of the will, composed his two important letters, one to Lanyon and one to Poole. Then he sat all day over the fire in the private room, gnawing his nails, sitting alone with his fears. When night came, he set forth in a closed cab, and was driven to and fro about the streets of the city. He, I say—I cannot say, I. That child of Hell had nothing human; nothing lived in him but fear and hatred. And when at last, thinking the driver had begun to grow suspicious, he left the cab and set out on foot, dressed in his misfitting clothes, an object marked out for observation, these two base passions raged within him like a tempest. He walked fast, hunted by his fears, muttering to himself, skulking through the less crowded streets, counting the minutes that still divided him from midnight. Once a woman spoke to him; he struck her in the face, and she fled.

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misfitting: badly fitting
base: mean and low; lacking all decency and honesty
skulking: moving in a sneaky way, as though trying not be seen or to hide something

When I came to myself at Lanyon's, the horror of my old friend perhaps affected me somewhat: I do not know. A change had come over me. It was no longer the fear of the gallows, it was the horror of being Hyde that racked me. After leaving Lanyon, it was partly in a dream that I came home to my own house and got into bed. I slept with a profound slumber which not even the nightmares that wrung me could break. I awoke in the morning shaken, weakened, but refreshed. I still hated and feared the thought of the brute that slept within me, and I had not of course forgotten the appalling dangers of the day before; but I was once more at home, in my own house and close to my drugs; and gratitude for my escape shone so strong in my soul that it almost equaled the brightness of hope.

I was stepping leisurely across the court after breakfast, drinking the chill of the air with pleasure, when I was seized again with those indescribable sensations that heralded the change;

racked: caused great pain in
wrung: twisted and squeezed
appalling: horrifying, shocking; awful
leisurely: in a calm, relaxed way, without hurrying
heralded: announced the coming of

and I barely had the time to gain the shelter of my study before I was once again raging and freezing with the passions of Hyde. It took on this occasion a double dose to recall me to myself; and alas! six hours after, as I sat looking sadly in the fire, the pangs returned, and the drug had to be taken again. In short, from that day forth it seemed only by a great effort, and only under the immediate stimulation of the drug, that I was able to wear the countenance of Jekyll. At all hours of the day and night, I would be taken with the warning shudder; above all, if I slept, or even dozed for a moment in my chair, it was always as Hyde that I awakened.

Under the strain of this constant threat, as well as sleeplessness beyond what I had thought possible to man, I became, in my own person, a creature eaten up and emptied by fever, weak both in body and mind, and occupied by one thought: the horror of my other self. But when I slept, or when the medicine wore off, I would leap almost without transition into an imagination brimming with images of terror, a soul boiling with causeless

alas: an expression of sadness, pity, or concern
transition: change from one state or condition to another
brimming: filled almost to the point of overflowing

hatreds, and a body that seemed not strong enough to contain the raging energies of life.

The powers of Hyde seemed to grow with the sickness of Jekyll. And certainly the hate that now divided them was equal on each side. Jekyll had now seen the full deformity of that creature that shared some consciousness with him, and was with him to death; and beyond these links, he thought of Hyde, for all his energy of life, as of something not only hellish but unalive. This was the shocking thing: that the slime of the pit seemed to utter cries and voices; that the shapeless dust moved and sinned; that what was dead, and had no shape, should forcibly seize the powers of life. And that rebellious horror lay caged in his flesh, where he heard it mutter and felt it struggle to be born; and at every hour of weakness or slumber, overcame him, and deposed him out of life.

The hatred of Hyde for Jekyll was different. His terror of the gallows drove him to return to his lesser role as a part instead of a person; but he

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the pit: another name for Hell
deposed: displaced; removed from a position of power



I became occupied by one thought: the horror of my other self.

loathed the necessity, he loathed the despondency into which Jekyll had now fallen, and he resented the dislike with which he was himself regarded. Hence the ape-like tricks that he would play me, scrawling blasphemies on the pages of my books, burning the letters, and destroying the portrait of my father; and indeed, had it not been for his fear of death, he would long ago have ruined himself in order to involve me in the ruin. But his love of life is wonderful: I sicken and freeze at the mere thought of him, but when I know how he fears my power to cut him off by suicide, I find it in my heart to pity him.

It is useless to prolong this description; no one has ever suffered such torments, let that be enough. My punishment might have gone on for years, but for the last calamity which has now fallen, and which has finally severed me from my own face and nature. My supply of the salt, which had never been renewed since the date of the first experiment,

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loathed: hated intensely
despondency: hopeless sadness
resented: felt upset and hurt by
prolong: make something go on for a longer time
torments: terrible emotional or physical pains

began to run low. I sent out for a fresh supply and mixed the potion; the bubbling followed, and the first change of color, not the second; I drank it and it had no effect. You will learn from Poole how I have had London ransacked; it was in vain; and I now think that my first supply was impure, and that it was that unknown impurity which gave the potion its power.

About a week has passed, and I am now finishing this statement under the influence of the last of the old powders. This, then, is the last time, short of a miracle, that Henry Jekyll can think his own thoughts or see his own face (now how sadly altered!) in the mirror. Nor must I delay too long to bring my writing to an end; for if my narrative has so far escaped destruction, it has been by a combination of great caution and great good luck. Should the transformation take me in the act of writing, Hyde will tear it in pieces. But the doom that is closing on us both has already changed and crushed him. Half an hour from now, when I shall

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in vain: useless; completely without success
short of: unless (something happens)
doom: certainty of some bad outcome on the way; unavoidable ruin

again and forever put on that hated personality, I know how I shall sit shuddering and weeping in my chair, or continue, with the most strained and fearstruck frenzy of listening, to pace up and down this room (my last earthly refuge) and give ear to every sound of menace.

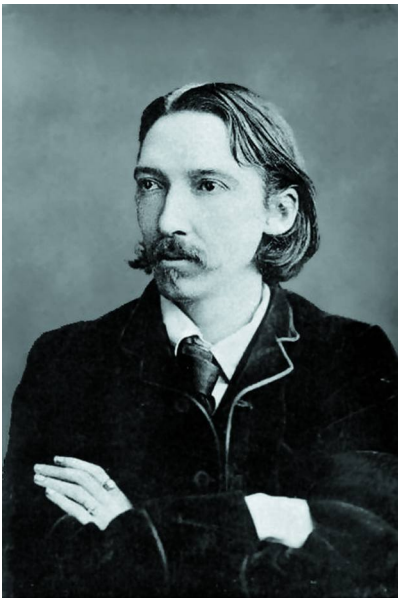
Will Hyde die upon the scaffold? Or will he find courage to release himself at the last moment? God knows; I am beyond caring; this is my true hour of death, and what is to follow concerns another than myself. Here then, as I lay down the pen and proceed to seal up my confession, I bring the life of that unhappy Henry Jekyll to an end.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Robert Louis Stevenson

Robert Louis Stevenson was born in Edinburgh, Scotland, the son of an engineer who built lighthouses. He was an only child and passed many days sick in bed, making up stories with his nurse, to whom he dedicated his famous book of poetry, *A Child's Garden of Verses*. All his life he was skinny and prone to illness, usually in his lungs. As an adult he wandered over half the world in search of a place that favored his health.



He studied at the University of Edinburgh, first to be an engineer, and then a lawyer. But he turned instead to writing essays, plays, and stories.

For a while, he took up the pose of a rebellious artist, wearing long hair, floppy hats, and velvet jackets, and convinced his parents that he had become a vagabond.

While hanging out at an artists' colony near Paris, he met Fanny Osborne, an American ten years older than himself. Fanny had left her husband in California and was grieving over the death of her youngest son. Stevenson was crushed when she decided to return to San Francisco, and when she wrote to tell him that she was ill, he immediately went to her. But by the time he arrived in California he was very sick and she instead took care of him.

Fanny divorced her husband and married Stevenson in 1880. They honeymooned at an abandoned silver mine and then went back to England. From there they went to health resorts in Switzerland and the south of France.

In 1888, they sailed for Polynesia, in the warm South Pacific, hoping the tropics would be good for Stevenson's health. For a year-and-a-half they roamed the scattered islands. Stevenson even visited a leper colony in Hawaii. Finally they

settled on one of the islands in Samoa, where they built a plantation house they named Vailima.

The Samoans called Stevenson *Tusitala*, or "storyteller." He sided with them against the colonial schemes of Europeans, and the Samoans, in thanks, built a road to his house that they named the Road of the Loving Heart.

Wherever he went, Stevenson was liked for his graceful, charming ways and his sincerity. Though his health was better, the cares of his household were heavy. Fanny had a nervous breakdown in 1893. The next year, Stevenson, frail and alive mainly out of determination, died of a burst blood vessel in his brain.

In his own time, his wandering life itself seemed a romantic adventure. Besides *Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*, his other famous novels include *Treasure Island* and *Kidnapped*.

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Asleep and dreaming, Robert Louis Stevenson cried out in horror—and from his feverish nightmare came the book published in 1886 as *Strange Case of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*. An immediate success, *Jekyll and Hyde* has been turned into a stage play, movies, and even cartoons. This story of what Stevenson called "man's double being" is presented here in abridged form, adapted for young readers.

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PART THREE

The Time Machine

H. G. Wells

Read in Units 5–6 and 8: the novel from the Inventor to the Epilogue.

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ABRIDGED FOR YOUNG READERS

The Time Machine

BY H. G. WELLS

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The Time Machine

An Invention

by

H. G. Wells

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This Core Classics edition of *The Time Machine* uses the chapter divisions and titles from the first British edition published by the William Heinemann company in May 1895, with the exception of Chapter 1, which uses the chapter title as it appeared in January 1895 in the journal called the *New Review*. In later editions, the author divided the book into twelve chapters and an Epilogue, and removed the chapter titles.

INTRODUCTION

The Time Machine, the first novel by the British writer H. G. Wells, is one of the pioneering works of science fiction. When the book was first published in 1895, people didn't refer to it as science fiction—that term only came into use some decades later in the twentieth century. Instead, they often called such novels "scientific romances." In this case, *romance* doesn't mean a love story but a story full of imaginative adventures.

Science fiction stories use facts and ideas from science and technology to make the fantastical seem possible. Some science fiction writers strive to be technically accurate and highly believable; others use science as a starting point to take off into realms of fantasy. H. G. Wells, who is sometimes called "the father of science fiction," showed how science fiction can entertain while also examining moral questions about human behavior, identity, and destiny.

The Time Machine was so successful that Wells quickly went on to write more science fiction novels, including some you may know, such as *The War of the Worlds* and *The Invisible Man*.

Those stories remain popular to this day. *The Time Machine* has been turned into movies, comic books, graphic novels, and even a (very loosely adapted) musical.

Why has *The Time Machine* remained so popular? Partly because it's a thrilling adventure, full of mystery, suspense, and narrow escapes. Or maybe it has something to do with the deep emotional appeal of the idea of time travel—even if you don't (as H. G. Wells did) imagine the details of a machine to take you through time, whenever you think, "If only I could go back and change what I did," or, "If only I could go forward and see what's going to happen," you are, in a way, wishing to time travel.

H. G. Wells, however, wasn't much interested in how time travel might personally affect an individual. His main character, known simply as the Time Traveler, does not go back to his childhood, nor does he go ahead to see how his life turns out. Instead, in his invention, the Time Machine, he leaps far, far ahead, past the year 800,000.

Why go so far ahead in time? There's a clue in a comment that Wells made about forty years after writing *The Time Machine*. In a radio interview, he said, "The more you go ahead, the more you

seem to get entangled with the burning questions of your own time."

When *The Time Machine* first came out as a novel, Wells's "own time" was the late Victorian era in England, named after Queen Victoria, who reigned from 1837 to 1901. The Victorian era was a time of great technological change. New factories churned out new products. Steam-powered railroads transformed trips that once took days into hours. The telegraph made it possible to communicate across long distances almost instantaneously.

These innovations and others led to many changes in society, not all of them good. Cities suffered from overcrowding, pollution, and disease. There was a growing gap between wealth and poverty—the rich got richer, the poor got poorer. Despite these social problems, many people in Victorian England held a confident faith in progress and looked forward to an ever-brighter future.

Was this progress real or an illusion? Were people making the world a better place or worse? Was humanity headed toward a bright future or something darker? These are some of the "burning questions" that fueled the imagination of H. G. Wells as he wrote *The Time Machine*.

While shaping the story, Wells's mind was buzzing with the ideas of various thinkers of the Victorian era. Before you jump into the adventure of *The Time Machine*, let's very briefly meet some of those thinkers, including two—Karl Marx and Charles Darwin—whose ideas remain influential and controversial to this day. We'll begin, however, with Henry George, a writer who is less remembered now but whose work was talked about around the world in Wells's time.

Henry George: Progress and Poverty

In 1879, the American writer Henry George published *Progress and Poverty*, a book that had a great influence around the world, and on the young H. G. Wells.

In *Progress and Poverty*, Henry George asked why great technological advances brought not only great wealth but also great poverty. In the modern world, he said, "It is true that wealth has been greatly increased, and that the average of comfort, leisure, and refinement has been raised." But not everyone shared in this progress. Instead, he said, "It is as though an immense wedge were being forced . . . through society. Those who are above the point of separation are elevated, but those who

are below are crushed down." The result, he said, was that "material progress does not merely fail to relieve poverty—it actually produces it."

As Henry George saw it, "This association of poverty with progress is the great enigma of our times . . . . It is the riddle which the Sphinx of Fate puts to our civilization." (You might recall that in mythology, the Sphinx—a creature with a lion's body and a human head—posed a riddle to all who came near, and killed anyone who could not answer correctly.)

Henry George questioned whether the many improvements achieved by modern civilization could really be thought of as progress. He said, "So long as all the increased wealth which modern progress brings goes but to build up great fortunes, to increase luxury and make sharper the contrast between the House of Have and the House of Want, progress is not real and cannot be permanent."

When he first encountered Henry George's ideas, H. G. Wells was a young man struggling to make a living. Every day he was confronted by the frustrating reality of the gap between the Haves and Have-Nots. As Wells later recalled, *Progress and Poverty* gave him an "extremely simplified and

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enigma: riddle; mystery; something very hard to understand or explain

plausible story" that helped answer his question, "Why was . . . every advantage secured against me before I came into the world?" Such ideas and feelings fed the imagination of H. G. Wells as he wrote *The Time Machine*.

Karl Marx: Class Struggle

Some passages in *The Time Machine* recall the ideas of Karl Marx, a German scholar who moved to London in 1849, and who saw the course of human history as a constant struggle between the social classes. In modern industrial societies, said Marx, on one side of this struggle were the *bourgeoisie* (BOOR-zhwa-zee), the people wealthy enough to own property and control factories and other means of production. On the other side were the proletariat, the workers in the lower classes. Marx said that the bourgeoisie, who had property and power, exploited the proletariat—that is, they took advantage of the workers, for example, by forcing them to work long hours in dangerous conditions, or by paying them less than their labor was worth.

In 1848, Marx published a short book called *The Communist Manifesto*. In it he predicted that the struggle between the classes would eventually

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manifesto: a public statement of one's objectives and opinions

lead to a great revolution in which the workers would overthrow the upper class and establish a communist society—a society that would abolish the private ownership of property and be based instead on community ownership. In a communist society, the people would cooperatively own and control all property and businesses, and so there would be no rich or poor; everyone would be equal. (In the twentieth century, Communist revolutions took place in Russia and China, but the resulting oppressive societies were far from the ideal that Marx had envisioned.)

Ideas about class struggle come up in *The Time Machine*, and at one point the Time Traveler sees what he thinks is a communist community. Wells, however, was not promoting Marx's ideas but indirectly questioning them through his fiction. (Later in his life, Wells argued strongly against Marxism, which he summed up as based on the "dangerous idea of reconstituting the world on a basis of mere resentment and destruction.")

Charles Darwin: Evolution and Social Darwinism

While Karl Marx examined the struggle between social classes, the English scientist Charles Darwin examined a different kind of struggle—the struggle of living things to survive as they

adapt to changing conditions over time. Darwin's ideas were very much on Wells's mind as he wrote *The Time Machine*.

In the 1830s, Darwin sailed around the world and filled many notebooks with his observations of various plants and animals. In the Galápagos Islands in the Pacific Ocean, he made a careful study of the beaks of certain birds. From these studies, he developed his theory of evolution, which explained how, over the course of many generations, animals and plants can develop into new species.

Darwin's theory of evolution is built on the idea of natural selection. In his groundbreaking 1859 book, *On the Origin of Species by Means of Natural Selection*, Darwin explained how natural selection works. He observed that living things pass on various traits to their offspring. He noted that the offspring with traits that made them better suited to compete for food and other limited resources tend to survive and pass on those beneficial traits to their offspring. And so through this process of natural selection, said Darwin, living things develop and change over many generations, sometimes evolving in ways that lead to new species.

Darwin is often associated with the idea of "survival of the fittest," though he did not invent the phrase. Nor did he apply the idea of "survival

of the fittest" to human society, though others in the Victorian era were quick to do so. These Social Darwinists, as they are known, believed that in a world of competition for limited resources, the strong would survive and the weak would die out. They saw rich and powerful people as "the fittest," whose success proved their superiority. They argued against any government regulation of business or any social programs to help the poor, because they believed that unrestricted competition was the key to progress. They thought that over time, as "the fittest" survived and thrived, the human race would keep on evolving and improving. Their ideas had no basis in science, and were mainly a way to justify their own power and privilege, while letting them see less fortunate people as weak and deserving of their fate.

Darwin's ideas provoked heated debates, and not just among scientists. In Victorian society, many people were shaken by this theory that seemed to contradict their religious beliefs. But others took a much more optimistic view of evolution. They saw in it a promise of continuous progress. They paid little attention to Darwin's ideas about biology and instead embraced evolution as nature's guarantee that everything—individual people, nations, the human race—must be developing for the better.

Thomas Henry Huxley: Evolution and Progress

As a young student, H. G. Wells learned much about Darwin from a course taught by Thomas Henry Huxley, a scientist and writer who championed Darwin's theory of evolution. Huxley rejected the claims of the Social Darwinists. As for the popular notion that evolution promised progress—that, said Huxley, was a "fallacy," a mistaken belief. "I suspect," said Huxley, "that this fallacy has arisen out of the unfortunate ambiguity of the phrase 'survival of the fittest.' 'Fittest' has a connotation of 'best'; and about 'best' there hangs a moral flavor." Human beings who considered themselves nature's best achievement assumed that the evolutionary process would "help them towards perfection"—but in nature, said Huxley, "what is 'fittest' depends upon the conditions."

For example, said Huxley, if the earth were to undergo a great cooling, then in the plant kingdom, "the 'fittest' that survived might be nothing but lichens, diatoms, and such [other] microscopic organisms. . . ." And if instead the earth were to grow much hotter, then in time "the pleasant valleys . . .

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ambiguity: uncertainty of meaning
connotation: an idea or quality that a word suggests beyond its main meaning
diatoms: single-celled algae

might be uninhabitable by any animated beings save those that flourish in a tropical jungle. They, as the fittest, the best adapted to changed conditions, would survive." In short, insisted Huxley, nature had no special obligation to favor humanity, and evolution made no promise of eventual human perfection.

As H. G. Wells developed his own thinking about Darwin's ideas, he too opposed the idea that human evolution would necessarily lead to progress and improvement. A few decades after the publication of *The Time Machine*, Wells described his novel as an "assault on human self-satisfaction." Wells used the imaginary device of time travel to leap far ahead in the slow evolutionary process and give, in his words, "a glimpse of the future that ran counter to the placid assumption . . . that Evolution was a pro-human force making things better and better for mankind."

Social inequality, class struggle, Social Darwinism—*The Time Machine* gets us to think about these and other big ideas while also engaging us in an exciting and imaginative adventure. In *The Time Machine*—the book that launched his long and varied career—H. G Wells blazed the

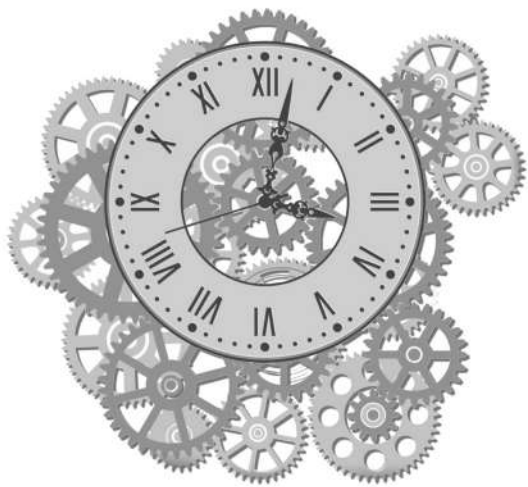
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save: except
placid: calm and untroubled

way for many writers to come by showing how science fiction can take us far away in time or space while also making us think deeply about the here and now.

Editor's Note

This Core Classics edition of *The Time Machine* is abridged and adapted for young readers. Some passages have been left out of the original text, and some have been rewritten to make them more readily understandable. Any adaptation is also an interpretation—in choosing what to leave out and what to rewrite, we have tried to be guided by the goal of remaining faithful to the themes, style, and spirit of the original novel.



The Time Machine

An Invention

by

H. G. Wells

THE INVENTOR

The Time Traveler (for so it will be convenient to speak of him) was explaining a recondite matter to us. His pale grey eyes shone and twinkled, and his usually pale face was flushed and animated. The fire burnt brightly, and the soft radiance of the incandescent lights caught the bubbles that flashed and passed in our glasses. Our chairs, which he had designed, caressed us rather than submitted to be sat upon. There was that luxurious after-dinner atmosphere, when thought runs gracefully free. And he put it to us in this way—marking the points with a lean forefinger—

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recondite: little-known; beyond ordinary understanding
flushed: red from strong feeling
incandescent: glowing with heat [Note that reliable electric lights bulbs had been only recently invented, around 1880, and that in the Time Traveler's time, around 1895, electric lighting in homes was still fairly new. As you will see, in his home, the Time Traveler still uses candles as well as electricity for lighting.]
bubbles: These bubbles are in the sparkling wine (such as Champagne) that the men are drinking.
caressed: touched gently
lean: thin

as we sat and lazily admired his earnestness over this new paradox (as we thought it).

"You must follow me carefully. I shall have to contradict one or two ideas that are almost universally accepted. The geometry, for instance, they taught you at school is founded on a misconception."

"Is not that rather a large thing to expect us to begin upon?" said Filby, an argumentative person with red hair.

"I do not mean to ask you to accept anything without reasonable ground for it. You know of course that a mathematical line, a line of thickness *nil*, has no real existence. They taught you that? Neither has a mathematical plane. These things are mere abstractions."

"That is all right," said the Psychologist.

"Nor, having only length, breadth, and thickness, can a cube have a real existence."

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earnestness: deep sincerity and seriousness
paradox: a statement that seems to contradict itself but may nevertheless be true, for example, "Less is more."
nil: zero; nothing
psychologist: a scientist who studies the mind and behavior
breadth: width; the measurement of something from side to side

"There I object," said Filby. "Of course a solid body may exist. All real things—"

"So most people think. But wait a moment. Can an instantaneous cube exist?"

"Don't follow you," said Filby.

"Can a cube that does not last for any time at all, have a real existence?"

Filby became pensive. "Clearly," the Time Traveler proceeded, "any real body must have extension in *four* directions: it must have Length, Breadth, Thickness, and—Duration. But we tend to overlook this fact. There are really four dimensions, three which we call the three planes of Space, and a fourth, Time. There is, however, a tendency to draw an unreal distinction between the former three dimensions and the latter, because our consciousness moves in one direction along the latter from the beginning to the end of our lives."

"That," said a very young man, "that is . . . very clear indeed."

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pensive: thoughtful

latter: Used with *former* earlier in the sentence, the *former* refers to things or people mentioned first, while the *latter* refers to things or people mentioned second. (In this case, "the latter" refers to what the Time Traveler calls the fourth dimension, Time.)

"Really," continued the Time Traveler, "this is what is meant by the Fourth Dimension. It is only another way of looking at Time. *There is no difference between Time and any of the three dimensions of Space except that our consciousness moves along it*. But some foolish people have got hold of the wrong side of that idea. You have all heard what they have to say about this Fourth Dimension?"

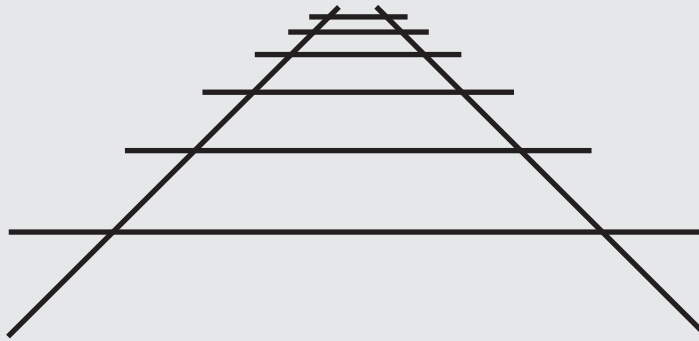
"I have not," said the Mayor.

"It is simply this. That Space, as our mathematicians have it, is spoken of as having three dimensions, which one may call Length, Breadth, and Thickness, and is always definable by reference to three planes, each at right angles to the others. But some philosophical people have been asking why three dimensions particularly? Why not another direction at right angles to the other three? They have even tried to construct a Four-Dimensional geometry. You know how on a flat surface, which has only two dimensions, we can represent a figure of a three-dimensional solid, and similarly they think that by models of three dimensions they could represent one of four—if they could master the perspective of the thing. See?"

From 2-D to 3-D . . . to 4-D?

The Time Traveler points out that "on a flat surface, which has only two dimensions, we can represent a figure of a three-dimensional solid." A flat surface—such as a piece of paper, or a painter's canvas—has length and width. On such a surface, how can we create the illusion of a third dimension—of depth?

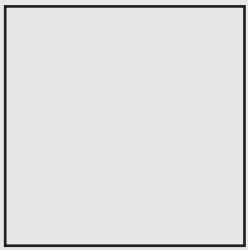
In the early 1400s, during the period of brilliant artistic innovation in Italy called the Renaissance, artists began using *perspective* to make two-dimensional images look three-dimensional. They gave their paintings an illusion of depth by making the people or objects in the foreground of a painting look bigger than those in the background. The artists also noticed that if you stand between two parallel lines that stretch into the distance, the lines seem to get closer together. For example, look at the drawing here representing railway tracks. The 2-D drawing looks 3-D because of the illusion created by perspective, as the lines get closer together.



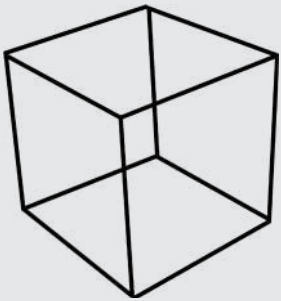
The Time Traveler says that mathematicians have "tried to construct a Four-Dimensional geometry," and that "they think that by models of three dimensions they could represent one of four—if they could master the perspective of the thing." Since the time of H. G. Wells, mathematicians have developed a 4-D model of a cube, called a *tesseract*. If you have read Madeline L'Engle's novel *A Wrinkle in Time*, you might recall how she used the idea of a tesseract. Search the Internet to see animated models of a tesseract and for more discussion of possible dimensions beyond the three that we can perceive.



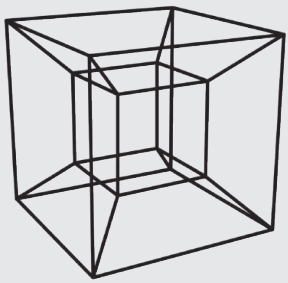
Line
1-D



Square
2-D



Cube
3-D



Tesseract
4-D

"I think so," murmured the Mayor, knitting his brows. "Yes, I think I see it now," he said after some time, brightening briefly.

"Well, I do not mind telling you I have been at work upon this geometry of Four Dimensions for some time. Some of my results are curious. For instance, here is a portrait of a man at eight years old, another at fifteen, another at seventeen, another at twenty-three, and so on. All these are evidently sections, as it were, Three-Dimensional representations of his Four-Dimensioned being, which is a fixed and unalterable thing.

"Scientific people," proceeded the Time Traveler, "know very well that Time is only a kind of Space. Here is a popular scientific diagram, a weather record. This line I trace with my finger shows the movement of the barometer. Yesterday it was so high, yesterday night it fell, then this morning it rose again, and so gently upward to here. Surely the mercury did not trace this line in any of the dimensions of Space generally recognized? But certainly it traced such a line, and

knitting his brows: tightening his eyebrows in a frown
as it were: an expression meaning, in a way
unalterable: not able to be changed

that line, therefore, we must conclude, was along the Time-Dimension."

"But," said the Medical Man, staring hard at a coal in the fire, "if Time is really only a fourth dimension of Space, why is it, and why has it always been, regarded as something different? And why cannot we move in Time as we move about in the other dimensions of Space?"

The Time Traveler smiled. "Are you so sure we can move freely in Space? Right and left we can go, backward and forward freely enough, and men always have done so. I admit we move freely in two dimensions. But how about up and down? Gravitation limits us there."

"Not exactly," said the Medical Man. "There are balloons."

"But before the balloons, except for jumping, man had no freedom of vertical movement."

"Still they could move a little up and down," said the Medical Man.

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balloons: The Medical Man is referring to hot air balloons, a method of transportation consisting of a large basket connected to a large bag. The balloon rises when the bag is filled with heated air. (*The Time Machine* was published in 1895, before the invention of the airplane.)

"Far easier down than up."

"And you cannot move at all in Time," said the Medical Man, "you cannot get away from the present moment."

"My dear sir, that is just where you are wrong. That is just where the whole world has gone wrong. We are always getting away from the present moment. Our mental existences, which are immaterial and have no dimensions, are passing along the Time-Dimension with a uniform velocity from the cradle to the grave. Just as we should travel *down* if we began our existence fifty miles above the earth's surface—"

"But the great difficulty is this," interrupted the Psychologist. "You can move about in all directions of Space, but you cannot move about in Time."

"That is my great discovery. You are wrong to say that we cannot move about in Time. For instance, if I am recalling an incident very vividly I go back to the instant of its occurrence: I become absent-minded, as you say. I jump back

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immaterial: without physical substance; bodiless
uniform: unchanging; remaining the same

for a moment. Of course we have no means of staying back for any length of Time, any more than an animal has of staying six feet above the ground. But a man can go up against gravitation in a balloon, and why should he not hope that ultimately he may be able to stop or accelerate his drift along the Time-Dimension, or even turn about and travel the other way?"

"Oh, *this*," began Filby, "is all—"

"Why not?" said the Time Traveler.

"It's against reason," said Filby.

"What reason?" said the Time Traveler.

"You can show black is white by argument," said Filby, "but you will never convince me."

"Possibly not," said the Time Traveler. "But now you begin to see the object of my investigations into the geometry of Four Dimensions. Long ago I had a vague idea of a machine—"

"To travel through Time!" exclaimed the Very Young Man.

"That shall travel in any direction of Space and Time, as the driver determines."

Filby laughed.

"But I have experimental verification," said the Time Traveler.

"It would be remarkably convenient for the historian," the Psychologist suggested. "One might travel back and verify the accepted account of a great battle, for instance!"

"Then there is the future," said the Very Young Man. "Just think! One might invest all one's money and—"

"Of all the wild extravagant theories!" began the Psychologist.

"Yes, so it seemed to me, and so I never talked of it until—"

"Experimental verification!" I cried.

"The experiment!" cried Filby, who was getting brain-weary.

"Let's see your experiment anyhow," said the Psychologist, "though it's all humbug, you know."

The Time Traveler smiled round at us. Then, still smiling faintly, and with his hands deep in

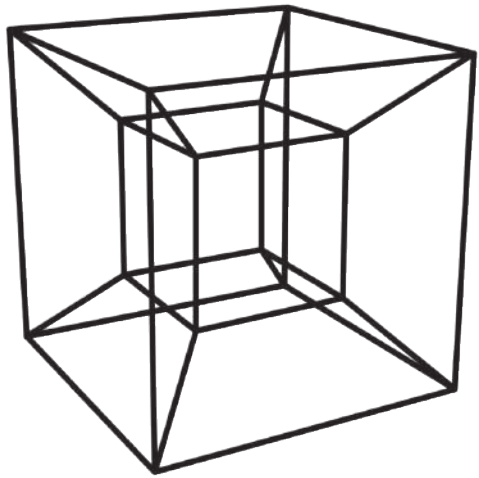
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verification: proof; confirmation of something as true or accurate
verify: to prove that something is true or accurate
extravagant: going beyond reason
humbug: nonsense; something intended to deceive or trick

his trousers pockets, he walked slowly out of the room, and we heard his slippers shuffling down the long passage to his laboratory.

The Psychologist looked at us. "I wonder what he's got?"

"Some clever trick or other," said the Medical Man, and Filby tried to tell us about a magician he had once seen, but before he had finished the Time Traveler came back.



THE MACHINE

The thing the Time Traveler held in his hand was a glittering metallic framework, scarcely larger than a small clock, and very delicately made. There was ivory in it, and some transparent crystalline substance. And now I must be explicit, for what follows—unless his explanation is to be accepted—is an absolutely unaccountable thing.

He took one of the small tables scattered about the room and set it in front of the fire. On this table he placed the mechanism. Then he drew up a chair and sat down. The only other object on the table was a small shaded lamp, the bright light of which fell upon the model. There were also perhaps a dozen candles about, so that the room was brilliantly illuminated. I sat in a low arm-chair nearest the fire, and I drew this forward so as to be almost between the Time Traveler and the fireplace. Filby sat behind him, looking over

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explicit: clear, precise, and detailed in expression
unaccountable: unable to be explained

his shoulder. The Medical Man and the Mayor watched him from the right, the Psychologist from the left. The Very Young Man stood behind the Psychologist. We were all on the alert. It appears incredible to me that any kind of trick could have been played upon us under these conditions.

The Time Traveler looked at us, and then at the mechanism. "Well?" said the Psychologist.

"This little affair," said the Time Traveler, resting his elbows upon the table and pressing his hands together above the apparatus, "is only a model. It is my plan for a machine to travel through time. You will notice that there is an odd twinkling appearance about this bar, as though it was in some way unreal." He pointed to the part with his finger. "Also, here is one little white lever, and here is another."

The Medical Man got up out of his chair and peered into the thing. "It's beautifully made," he said.

"It took two years to make," said the Time Traveler. "Now I want you clearly to understand that this lever, being pressed over, sends the

apparatus: device; mechanism



The Medical Man peered into the thing.
"It's beautifully made," he said.

machine gliding into the future, and this other reverses the motion. This saddle represents the seat of a time traveler. I am going to press the lever, and off the machine will go. It will vanish, pass into future Time, and disappear. Have a good look at the thing. Look at the table too, and satisfy yourselves there is no trickery. I don't want to waste this model, and then be told I'm a quack."

There was a minute's pause perhaps. The Psychologist seemed about to speak to me, but changed his mind. Then the Time Traveler put forth his finger towards the lever. "No," he said suddenly. "Lend me your hand." And turning to the Psychologist, he took that individual's hand in his own and told him to put out his forefinger. So it was the Psychologist himself who sent forth the model Time Machine on its interminable voyage. We all saw the lever turn. I am absolutely certain there was no trickery. There was a breath of wind, and the lamp flame jumped. One of the candles was blown out, and the little machine suddenly

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quack: faker; phony; fraud
interminable: endless

swung round, became indistinct, was seen as a ghost for a second perhaps, as an eddy of faintly glittering brass and ivory; and it was gone—vanished! Except for the lamp the table was bare.

Everyone was silent for a minute.

The Psychologist recovered from his stupor, and suddenly looked under the table. At that the Time Traveler laughed cheerfully. "Well?" he said. Then, getting up, he began to fill his pipe.

We stared at each other. "Look here," said the Medical Man, "do you seriously believe that that machine has traveled into time?"

"Certainly," said the Time Traveler. Then he turned, lighting his pipe. "What is more, I have a big machine nearly finished in there"—he indicated the laboratory—"and when that is put together I mean to have a journey on my own account."

"You mean to say that that machine has traveled into the future?" said Filby.

"Into the future or the past—I don't, for certain, know which."

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indistinct: blurry; unclear
eddy: a current traveling in a circular motion; a whirlpool
stupor: daze

After a pause the Psychologist had an inspiration. "It must have gone into the past if it has gone anywhere," he said.

"Why?" said the Time Traveler.

"Because I presume that it has not moved in space, and if it traveled into the future it would still be here all this time, since it must have traveled through this time."

"But," said I, "if it traveled into the past it would have been visible when we came first into this room; and last Thursday when we were here; and the Thursday before that; and so forth!"

"Serious objections," remarked the Mayor, turning towards the Time Traveler.

"Not a bit," said the Time Traveler, and, to the Psychologist: "*You* can explain that."

"Of course," said the Psychologist, and reassured us. "I should have thought of it. We cannot see it any more than the spoke of a wheel spinning, or a bullet flying through the air. If it is traveling through time fifty times or a hundred times faster than we are, if it gets through a minute while we get through a second, the impression it creates will of course be only one-fiftieth or one-

hundredth of what it would make if it were not traveling in time. That's plain enough." He passed his hand through the space in which the machine had been. "You see?" he said, laughing.

We sat and stared at the vacant table for a minute or so. Then the Time Traveler asked us what we thought of it all.

"It sounds plausible enough tonight," said the Medical Man, "but wait until tomorrow. Wait for the common sense of the morning."

"Would you like to see the Time Machine itself?" asked the Time Traveler. And, taking the lamp in his hand, he led the way down the long corridor to his laboratory. I remember vividly the flickering light, the dance of the shadows, how we all followed him, puzzled but incredulous, and how there in the laboratory we beheld a larger edition of the little mechanism which we had seen vanish from before our eyes. Parts were of nickel, parts of ivory, parts had certainly been filed or sawn out of rock crystal. The thing was generally complete,

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plausible: reasonable; believable
corridor: hallway
incredulous: unwilling or unable to believe

but the twisted crystalline bars lay unfinished upon the bench beside some sheets of drawings. I picked one up for a better look at it. It seemed to be made of quartz.

"Look here," said the Medical Man, "are you perfectly serious? Or is this a trick—like that ghost you showed us last Christmas?"

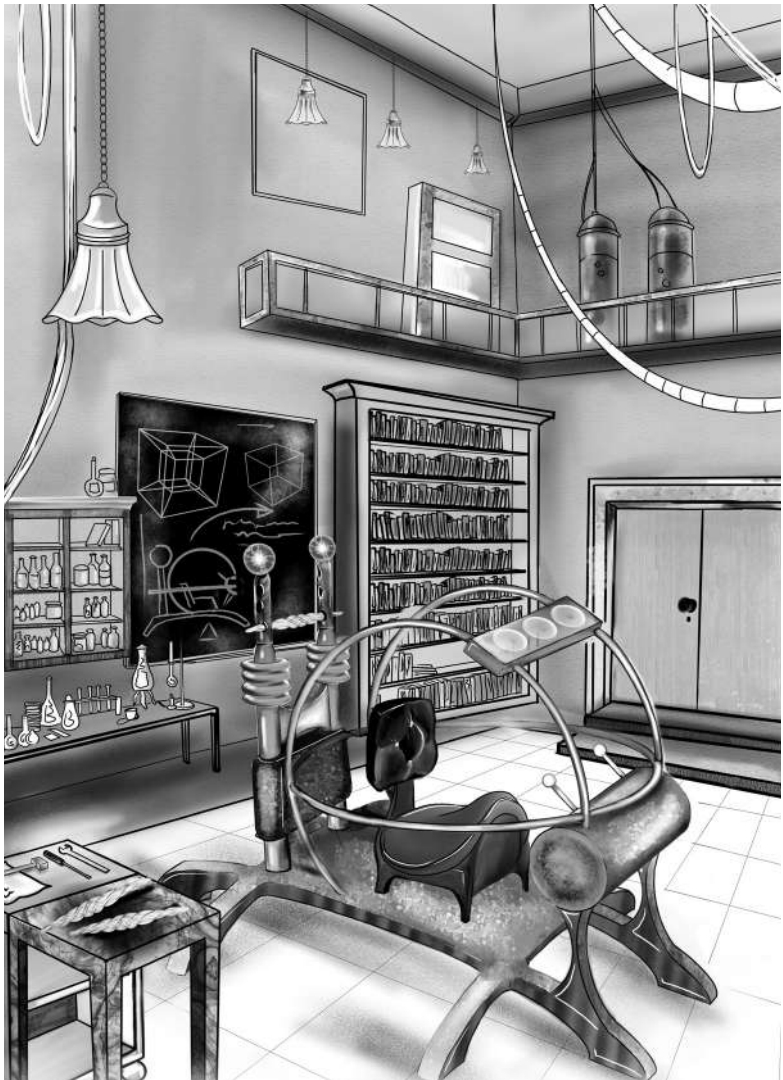
"Upon that machine," said the Time Traveler, "I intend to explore time. Is that plain? I was never more serious in my life."

None of us quite knew how to take it.

I caught Filby's eye over the shoulder of the Medical Man, and he winked at me.

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quartz: a hard crystalline mineral, sometimes used in making clocks and watches



There in the laboratory we beheld a larger edition of the little mechanism which we had seen vanish from before our eyes.

THE TIME TRAVELER RETURNS

I think that at that time none of us quite believed in the Time Machine. The fact is, the Time Traveler was one of those men who are too clever to be believed. Things that would have made the fame of a less clever man seemed tricks in his hands. The serious people who took him seriously never felt quite sure of him. So I don't think any of us said very much about time traveling between that Thursday and the next, though it ran in most of our minds: its plausibility, its incredibleness, the curious possibilities of anachronism and of utter confusion it suggested. For my own part, I was particularly preoccupied with the trick of the model, which I remember discussing with the Medical Man. He said he had once seen a similar thing, and emphasized the blowing-out of the candle. But how the trick was done he could not explain.

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plausibility: the quality of seeming reasonable or believable
incredibleness: impossibility; un-believability
anachronism: something (or someone) placed in a time period in which it does not belong
utter: complete; total

"The Curious Possibilities of Anachronism"

The narrator of *The Time Machine* says that while thinking about time travel, he considered "the curious possibilities of anachronism." The word *anachronism comes* from the Greek *ana*, meaning "back" or "against," and *chronos*, meaning "time." So, an *anachronism* is something against time, or out of its proper time—it's a thing, person, or event placed in a time period in which it does not belong. For example, if you're watching a movie about a Civil War battle, and you catch a glimpse of an American flag with 50 stars, that flag would be an anachronism.

Imagine you could time travel back to the year 1776—in what ways would you appear anachronistic? Your clothes, to begin with. Perhaps you have a cell phone with you and you show it to the people of 1776—you snap a group selfie and show them the photo. You play some music stored on your phone—maybe a favorite pop, rock, or hip-hop song. How do you think the people of 1776 would respond to these anachronisms?

What other "curious possibilities of anachronism" can you imagine if you were to travel backward or forward in time?

The next Thursday I again visited the Time Traveler—I suppose I was one of his most constant guests. Arriving late, I found four or five men already assembled in his drawing-room. The Medical Man was standing before the fire with a sheet of paper in one hand and his watch in the

drawing-room: a room in a house where guests are received and entertained

other. I looked round for the Time Traveler, and—
"It's half-past seven now," said the Medical Man. "I suppose we'd better have dinner?"

"Where's——?" said I, naming our host.

"You've just come? It's rather odd. He's unavoidably detained. He asks me in this note to lead off with dinner at seven if he's not back. Says he'll explain when he comes."

"It seems a pity to let the dinner spoil," said the Editor of a well-known daily paper; and so the Doctor rang the bell.

The Psychologist was the only person besides the Doctor and myself who had attended the previous dinner. The other men were the Editor just mentioned, a certain journalist, and a quiet, shy man with a beard, whom I didn't know. There was some speculation at the dinner-table about the Time Traveler's absence, and, half-joking, I suggested he might be time traveling. The Editor wanted that explained to him. The Psychologist

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detained: held back; delayed
Doctor: also called the Medical Man
rang the bell: the signal to the household staff that dinner is to be served
speculation: forming opinions without firm evidence; guessing

began to describe the "ingenious paradox and trick" we had witnessed a week ago, when the door from the corridor opened slowly and without noise. I was facing the door, and saw it first.

"At last!" I said.

The door opened wider, and the Time Traveler stood before us. I gave a cry of surprise. "Good heavens, man, what's the matter?" cried the Medical Man, who saw him next. And the whole tableful turned towards the door.

He was in an amazing plight. His coat was dusty and dirty, and smeared with green down the sleeves; his hair disordered, and seemed to me greyer—either with dust and dirt or because its color had actually faded. His face was ghastly pale; his chin had a brown cut on it—a cut half-healed; his expression was haggard and drawn, as by intense suffering. For a moment he hesitated in the doorway, as if he had been dazzled by the light. Then he came into the room. He walked with a limp. We stared at him in silence, expecting him to speak.

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plight: a difficult or troubled situation
ghastly: frighteningly; or, in a way resembling a ghost
haggard: looking worn out and unwell
drawn: looking strained and worn from exhaustion or pain

He said not a word, but came painfully to the table.

"What on earth have you been up to, man?" said the Doctor. The Time Traveler did not seem to hear. "Don't let me disturb you," he said, with a certain hesitation in his speech. "I'm all right." His glance flickered over our faces and then went round the warm and comfortable room. Then he spoke again, as though he were feeling his way among his words. "I'm going to wash and dress, and then I'll come down and explain things. . . . Save me some of that mutton. I'm starving for a bit of meat."

The Editor began a question. "Tell you shortly," said the Time Traveler. "I'm feeling—strange. Be all right in a minute."

He walked towards the staircase door. Again I remarked his lameness and the soft padding sound of his footsteps. As he went out, I saw he had nothing on his feet but a pair of tattered, blood-stained socks. Then the door closed upon him. I thought I might follow him, till I remembered how he detested any fuss about himself.

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mutton: sheep flesh, prepared as food
detested: strongly disliked

"Remarkable Behavior of an Eminent Scientist," I heard the Editor say, thinking in headlines. And this brought my attention back to the bright dinner-table.

"What's his game?" said the Journalist. "I don't follow." I met the eye of the Psychologist, and read my own interpretation in his face. I thought of the Time Traveler limping painfully upstairs. I don't think anyone else had noticed his lameness.

The first to recover completely from this surprise was the Medical Man, who rang the bell for a hot plate—the Time Traveler hated to have servants waiting at dinner. The Editor turned to his knife and fork with a grunt, and the Silent Man did the same. The dinner was resumed.

"I feel sure it's this business of the Time Machine," I said, and took up the Psychologist's account of our previous meeting. The new guests were incredulous. The Editor raised objections. "What was this time traveling? A man couldn't cover himself with dust by rolling in a paradox,

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eminent: well-known and respected
interpretation: explanation of what something means
servants: In Victorian England, many upper and middle class households employed servants, who performed household duties such as cleaning and cooking.

could he? Hadn't they any clothes-brushes in the Future?" The Journalist too, would not believe, and joined the Editor in the easy work of heaping ridicule on the whole thing.

The Time Traveler came back. He was dressed in ordinary evening clothes, and nothing but his haggard look remained of the change that had startled me.

"I say," said the Editor hilariously, "these chaps here say you have been traveling into the middle of next week!"

The Time Traveler smiled quietly, in his old way. "Where's my mutton?" he said. "What a treat it is to stick a fork into meat again!"

"Story!" cried the Editor.

"I want something to eat," said the Time Traveler. "I won't say a word until I get some protein into my arteries. Thanks. And the salt."

"One word," said I. "Have you been time traveling?"

"Yes," said the Time Traveler, with his mouth full, nodding his head.

The rest of the dinner was uncomfortable. The Journalist tried to relieve the tension by telling

anecdotes. The Time Traveler devoted his attention to his dinner, and displayed the appetite of a tramp. The Medical Man watched the Time Traveler through his eyelashes. The Silent Man seemed quite nervous.

At last the Time Traveler pushed his plate away. "I suppose I must apologize," he said. "I was simply starving. I've had a most amazing time. But come into the next room. It's too long a story to tell over greasy plates." And ringing the bell in passing, he led the way into the adjoining room.

"You have told them about the machine?" he said to me, leaning back in his easy-chair and looking at the new guests.

"But the thing's a mere paradox," said the Editor.

"I can't argue tonight. I don't mind telling you the story, but I can't argue. I will," he went on, "tell you the story of what has happened to me, if you

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anecdotes: brief stories, often amusing or entertaining
tramp: hobo; a person who travels from place to place in search of work (and so would not be likely to enjoy regular meals)
ringing the bell: a signal to let the household staff know that dinner is over and the dishes ready to be cleared
adjoining: next to; connected to

like, but you must refrain from interruptions. I want to tell it. Badly. Most of it will sound like lying. So be it! It's true—every word of it, all the same. I was in my laboratory at four o'clock, and since then . . . I've lived eight days . . . such days as no human being ever lived before! I'm nearly worn out, but I shall not sleep till I've told this to you. Then I shall go to bed. But no interruptions! Is it agreed?"

"Agreed," said the Editor, and the rest of us echoed "Agreed." And with that the Time Traveler began his story as I have set it forth. He sat back in his chair at first, and spoke like a weary man. Afterwards he got more animated. In writing it down I feel the inadequacy of pen and ink—you cannot see the speaker's sincere face in the bright circle of the little lamp, nor hear his voice. You cannot know how his expression followed the turns of his story! Most of us hearers were in shadow, for the candles in the room had not been lighted, and only the face of the Journalist and the legs of the Silent Man from the knees downward were

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refrain: hold back from doing something
inadequacy: the state of not being enough or not being good enough

illuminated. At first we glanced now and again at each other. After a time we ceased to do that, and looked only at the Time Traveler's face.

What Is a Frame Story?

H. G. Wells's novel *The Time Machine* is a frame story, also called a frame narrative. A frame surrounds a picture; in a frame story, one story surrounds another. A frame story tells a story within a story.

The Time Machine begins with the story told by the narrator, who introduces us to the Time Traveler and his dinner guests. In the chapters you've read so far, the narrator has described what went on during two evening gatherings at the Time Traveler's house.

Why do you think H. G. Wells went to the trouble of setting up this outer story? Why introduce the various dinner guests, who sometimes express their disbelief and make skeptical remarks? How is your attitude toward the Time Traveler affected by his answers and explanations to his guests? How is your attitude toward the Time Traveler affected by what the narrator says about him?

Beginning with the next chapter, we get the story within the story. The Time Traveler takes over as narrator, telling the story in his own words—or, to be precise, his words as recalled and written down by our original narrator. You will notice that all the following chapters are in quotation marks, because our original narrator is quoting the story told by the Time Traveler. In most of the remaining chapters, then, the Time Traveler is telling his own story to his invited guests—and, by extension, to us as readers.

TIME TRAVELING

"I told some of you last Thursday of the principles of the Time Machine, and showed you the actual thing itself, incomplete in the workshop. There it is now, a little travel-worn, truly; and one of the ivory bars is cracked, and a brass rail bent; but the rest of it's sound enough. I expected to finish it on Friday; but on Friday, when the putting together was nearly done, I found that one of the nickel bars was exactly one inch too short, and this I had to get remade; so that the thing was not complete until this morning. It was at ten o'clock today that the first of all Time Machines began its career. I gave it a last tap, tried all the screws again, put one more drop of oil on the quartz rod, and sat myself in the saddle.

"I took the starting lever in one hand and the stopping one in the other, pressed the first, and almost immediately the second. I seemed to reel; I felt a nightmare sensation of falling; and, looking round, I saw the laboratory exactly as before.

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sound: in good condition

Had anything happened? For a moment I suspected that my intellect had tricked me. Then I noted the clock. A moment before, as it seemed, it had stood at a minute or so past ten; now it was nearly half-past three!

"I drew a breath, set my teeth, gripped the starting lever with both hands, and went off with a thud. The laboratory got hazy and went dark. Mrs. Watchett came in and walked, apparently without seeing me, towards the garden door. I suppose it took her a minute or so to move along, but to me she seemed to shoot across the room like a rocket. I pressed the lever over to its extreme position. The night came like the turning out of a lamp, and in another moment came tomorrow. The laboratory grew faint and hazy, then fainter and ever fainter. Tomorrow night came black, then day again, night again, day again, faster and faster still. A swirling murmur filled my ears, and a strange, dumb confusedness descended on my mind.

"I am afraid I cannot convey the peculiar sensations of time traveling. They are excessively

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Mrs. Watchett: the Time Traveler's housekeeper
faint: pale and unclear in appearance

unpleasant. There is a feeling exactly like that one has upon a switchback—of a helpless headlong motion! I felt the same horrible anticipation, too, of an imminent smash. Night followed day like the flapping of a black wing. The dim suggestion of the laboratory seemed to fall away from me, and I saw the sun hopping swiftly across the sky, leaping it every minute, and every minute marking a day. I supposed the laboratory had been destroyed and I had come into the open air. I was already going too fast to be conscious of any moving things. The slowest snail that ever crawled dashed by too fast for me. The twinkling succession of darkness and light was excessively painful to the eye. I saw the moon spinning swiftly through her quarters from new to full, and had a faint glimpse of the circling stars. As I went on, still gaining velocity, night and day merged into one continuous greyness; the sky took on a wonderful deepness of blue, a splendid luminous color like that of early twilight;

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switchback: a road or railway that zigzags as it goes up and down steep hills; or, a roller coaster
anticipation: strong expectation that something will happen
imminent: about to happen
smash: crash; violent collision
luminous: shining

the jerking sun became a streak of fire, a brilliant arch, in space; the moon a fainter fluctuating band; and I could see nothing of the stars, except now and then a brighter circle flickering in the blue.

"The landscape was misty and vague. I was still on the hillside upon which this house now stands. I saw trees growing and changing like puffs of vapor, now brown, now green; they grew, spread, shivered, and passed away. I saw huge buildings rise up and pass like dreams. The whole surface of the earth seemed changed—melting and flowing under my eyes. The little hands upon the dials that registered my speed raced round faster and faster. I noted that my pace was over a year a minute; and minute by minute the white snow flashed across the world, and vanished, and was followed by the bright, brief green of spring.

"The unpleasant sensations of the start merged into a kind of hysterical exhilaration. I felt a clumsy swaying of the machine, but my mind was too confused to attend to it, so with a kind of madness growing upon me, I flung myself into futurity. At

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fluctuating: continually shifting or changing
hysterical: emotionally out of control
exhilaration: extreme excitement or delight

first I hardly thought of stopping or of anything but these new sensations. But soon a certain curiosity and a certain dread grew in my mind until at last they took complete possession of me. I thought, what strange developments of humanity, what wonderful advances upon our rudimentary civilization, might appear when I came to look closely into the world that raced before my eyes! I saw great and splendid architecture rising about me, more massive than any buildings of our own time, and yet, as it seemed, built of glimmer and mist. I saw a richer green flow up the hillside, and remain there, without ever changing to winter. Even through the veil of my confusion the earth seemed very fair. And so my mind came round to the business of stopping.

"The risk lay in the possibility of my finding some substance in the space which I, or the machine, occupied. So long as I traveled at a high velocity through time, this scarcely mattered: I was slipping like a vapor through the interstices

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dread: great fear that something will happen
rudimentary: basic; undeveloped, or in an early stage of development
interstices: very small gaps or spaces

of intervening substances! But to come to a stop involved the jamming of myself, molecule by molecule, into whatever lay in my way, bringing my atoms into such contact with those of the obstacle that a far-reaching chemical reaction—possibly an explosion—would result, and blow myself and my apparatus out of all possible dimensions into the Unknown. This possibility had occurred to me again and again while I was making the machine; but then I had cheerfully accepted it as one of the risks a man has got to take! Now that the risk was inevitable, I no longer saw it in the same cheerful light. The absolute strangeness of everything, the sickly jarring and swaying of the machine, above all, the feeling of prolonged falling, had absolutely upset my nerves. I told myself that I could never stop, and with a burst of petulance I pulled the lever, and the thing went reeling over, and I was flung headlong through the air.

"There was the sound of a clap of thunder in my ears. I may have been stunned for a moment.

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intervening: existing between two things
inevitable: unavoidable; sure to happen
jarring: rough bumping and shaking
petulance: impatient irritation

A pitiless hail was hissing round me, and I was sitting on soft turf in front of the overturned machine. Everything still seemed grey, but I soon noticed that the confusion in my ears was gone. I looked round me. I was on what seemed to be a little lawn in a garden, surrounded by rhododendron bushes, and I noticed that their purple blossoms were dropping under the beating of the hailstones. The rebounding, dancing hail hung in a little cloud over the machine, and drove along the ground like smoke. In a moment I was wet to the skin. 'Fine hospitality,' said I, 'to a man who has traveled innumerable years to see you.'

"Then I thought what a fool I was to get wet. I stood up and looked round me. A colossal figure, carved apparently in some white stone, loomed beyond the rhododendrons through the hazy downpour. But all else of the world was invisible.

"As the columns of hail grew thinner, I saw the white figure more distinctly. It was very large, for a silver birch tree touched its shoulder. It was of white marble, in shape something like a winged sphinx.

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rhododendron: a flowering shrub
innumerable: too many to be counted
loomed: appeared in a shadowy way, often looking large or threatening

The wings were spread so that it seemed to hover. The pedestal, it appeared to me, was of bronze, and was thick with verdigris. It chanced that the face was towards me; the sightless eyes seemed to watch me; there was the faint shadow of a smile on the lips. It was greatly weather-worn, which gave it an unpleasant suggestion of disease. I stood looking at it for half a minute, perhaps, or half an hour. At last I tore my eyes from it for a moment, and saw that the sky was lightening with the promise of the sun.

The Figure of the Sphinx

In traveling to the future, one of the first things the Time Traveler sees is something we usually associate with the past—a sphinx. The sphinx is a mythological creature with a lion's body and a human head. You might have seen a sphinx in ancient Egyptian art, or read about one in legends from long ago.

The well-known Greek myth of Oedipus tells how a terrible winged sphinx sat perched on a cliff near the city of Thebes. To people who came near, it would pose a riddle: "What walks on four feet in the morning, on two feet at noon, and on three feet in the evening?" If they could not answer, the sphinx would swoop down and eat them. Finally, the riddle was solved by Oedipus,

pedestal: the base that supports a statue
bronze: an alloy mainly composed of copper and tin
verdigris: a blue-greenish crust that forms on copper (or bronze) when exposed to the atmosphere for a long time



The sightless eyes seemed to watch me; there was the faint shadow of a smile on the lips.

who answered, "Man, who crawls on hands and knees as a baby, then goes on two legs as an adult, and walks with a cane in old age."

Why did H. G. Wells choose to to have the Time Traveler come upon the figure of a giant winged sphinx? Perhaps Wells was thinking of the myth that associates the sphinx with riddles, mystery, and deadly threats—all of which the Time Traveler confronts, as you will see in the chapters ahead.

Or perhaps the sphinx was suggested, if only indirectly, by Wells's memory of a passage from a book he had read, called *Progress and Poverty*. The author of that book, Henry George, asked: Why do great technological advances bring not only great wealth but also great poverty? That question, he said, "is the riddle which the Sphinx of Fate puts to our civilization, and which not to answer is to be destroyed." (For information on Henry George's ideas, see the Introduction to this book, page 4.)

"I looked up again at the crouching white shape, and the full temerity of my voyage came suddenly upon me. What might appear when that hazy curtain of hail was withdrawn? What might have happened to men? What if cruelty had grown into a common passion? What if the human race had had developed into something inhuman, unsympathetic, and overwhelmingly powerful? I might seem some old-world savage animal, dreadful and disgusting, a foul creature to be slain.

temerity: reckless boldness; excessive overconfidence
slain: killed

"Already I saw other vast shapes—huge buildings with tall columns, with a wooded hillside dimly creeping in upon me through the lessening storm. I was seized with a panic fear. I turned frantically to the Time Machine, and struggled to readjust it. As I did so the shafts of the sun broke through the thunderstorm. The grey downpour was swept aside and vanished like the trailing garments of a ghost. Above me, in the intense blue of the summer sky, some faint brown shreds of cloud whirled into nothingness. The great buildings about me stood out clearly, shining with the wet of the thunderstorm and the white unmelted hailstones.

"I felt naked in a strange world. I felt as perhaps a bird may feel in the clear air, knowing the hawk flies above and will swoop. My fear grew to frenzy. I took a breathing space, set my teeth, and again grappled fiercely, wrist and knee, with the machine. It turned over and struck my chin violently. One hand on the saddle, the other on the lever, I stood panting heavily, ready to mount again.

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frantically: in a way showing wild excitement or panic
frenzy: a state of wild mental excitement and disturbance

"My courage recovered. I looked more curiously and less fearfully at this world of the remote future. In a circular opening, high up in the wall of a nearby building, I saw a group of figures clad in rich soft robes. They had seen me, and their faces were directed towards me.

"Then I heard voices approaching me. Coming through the bushes by the White Sphinx were the heads and shoulders of men running. One of these emerged in a pathway leading straight to the little lawn upon which I stood with my machine. He was a slight creature—perhaps four feet high—clad in a purple tunic, tied at the waist with a leather belt. Sandals were on his feet; his legs were bare to the knees, and his head was bare. Noticing that, I noticed for the first time how warm the air was.

"He struck me as being a very beautiful and graceful creature, but extremely frail. At the sight of him I suddenly regained confidence. I took my hands from the machine.

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remote: distant; very far away
clad: clothed; dressed
tunic: a loose garment like a short robe
frail: weak and fragile

IN THE GOLDEN AGE

"In another moment we were standing face to face, I and this fragile thing of the future. He came straight up to me and laughed into my eyes. The absence of any sign of fear struck me at once. Then he turned to the two others who were following him and spoke to them in a strange and very sweet and flowing language.

"There were others coming, and soon a little group of perhaps eight or ten of these exquisite creatures were about me. One of them addressed me. I thought my voice might be too harsh and deep for them, so I shook my head, and, pointing to my ears, shook it again. He came a step forward, hesitated, and then touched my hand. Then I felt other soft little touches upon my back and shoulders. They wanted to make sure I was real.

"There was nothing in this at all alarming. Indeed, there was something in these pretty

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Golden Age: a time of widespread peace, plenty, and happiness
exquisite: beautiful and delicate

little people that inspired confidence—a graceful gentleness, a certain childlike ease. And besides, they looked so frail that I could imagine myself flinging the whole dozen of them about like bowling pins. But I made a sudden motion to warn them when I saw their little pink hands feeling at the Time Machine. Happily, before it was not too late, I thought of a danger I had forgotten, and reaching over the bars of the machine I unscrewed the little levers that would set it in motion, and put these in my pocket. Then I turned again to see what I could do in the way of communication.

"And then, looking more nearly into their features, I saw some further peculiarities in their delicate prettiness. Their hair, which was uniformly curly, came to a sharp end at the neck and cheek; there was not the faintest suggestion of it on the face, and their ears were singularly minute. The mouths were small, with bright red, rather thin lips, and the little chins ran to a point. The eyes were large and mild; and it seemed that

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uniformly: identically; in a way without difference
singularly: extraordinarily; in a remarkable and noticeable way
minute [pronounced *my-NOOT*]: tiny

there was a certain lack of the interest I might have expected in them.

"As they made no effort to communicate with me, but simply stood round me smiling and speaking in soft cooing notes to each other, I began the conversation. I pointed to the Time Machine and to myself. Then, hesitating for a moment how to express Time, I pointed to the sun. At once a quaintly pretty little figure in checkered purple and white followed my gesture, and then astonished me by imitating the sound of thunder.

"For a moment I was surprised, though the meaning of his gesture was plain enough. I thought: were these creatures fools? I had always anticipated that the people of the year Eight Hundred and Two Thousand odd would be incredibly ahead of us in knowledge, art, everything. Then one of them suddenly asked me a question that showed him to be on the intellectual level of one of our five-year-old children—asked me, in fact, if I had come from the sun in a thunderstorm! It let loose the judgment I had held

odd: Used in this way, with a number, *odd* means a little more than that number.

back upon their clothes, their frail light limbs, and fragile features. A flow of disappointment rushed across my mind. For a moment I felt that I had built the Time Machine in vain.

The Time Traveler's Disappointment

After he encounters the people of the distant future, the Time Traveler says, "A flow of disappointment rushed across my mind." Why is he disappointed? What did the Time Traveler expect the people of the future to be like? How did the people he encountered in the future differ from his expectations?

The Time Traveler admits that he has always assumed that the future will bring progress, that things and people will evolve to some higher and better state. Do you share this attitude? Do you think the future will bring progress? Why or why not?

"I nodded, pointed to the sun, and gave them such a vivid rendering of a thunderclap as startled them. They all withdrew a pace or so and bowed. Then came one laughing towards me, carrying a chain of beautiful flowers altogether new to me, and put it about my neck. In a moment they were all running to and fro for flowers, and

in vain: uselessly
rendering: a performance (as of a song or play)
to and fro: back and forth

laughingly flinging them upon me until I was almost smothered with blossom. You who have never seen the like can scarcely imagine what delicate and wonderful flowers countless years of culture had created. Then someone suggested that their plaything should be exhibited in the nearest building, and so I was led past the sphinx of white marble, which had seemed to watch me all the while with a smile at my astonishment, towards a vast grey edifice of ridged stone. As I went with them the memory of my confident anticipations of a deeply serious and intellectual posterity came, with irresistible merriment, to my mind.

"The colossal building had a huge entry. I was naturally most occupied with the growing crowd of little people, and with the big open portals that yawned before me shadowy and mysterious. My general impression of the world I saw over their heads was a tangle of beautiful bushes and flowers, a long neglected and yet weedless garden. I saw a

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culture: cultivation, the act of growing and caring for plants
edifice: a building, especially a large and impressive one
posterity: the people of future generations
colossal: gigantic; huge
portals: doorways; entrances

number of tall spikes of strange white flowers, measuring a foot perhaps across the spread of the waxen petals. They grew scattered, as if wild, among the shrubs, but I did not examine them closely at this time. The Time Machine was left deserted on the turf among the rhododendrons.

"The arch of the doorway was richly carved, but it struck me as very badly broken and weather-worn. Several more brightly clad people met me in the doorway, and so we entered, I, dressed in dingy nineteenth-century garments, wreathed with flowers, and surrounded by a mass of bright, soft-colored robes and shining white limbs, in a melodious whirl of laughter and laughing speech.

"The big doorway opened into a great hall hung with brown. The windows admitted a softened light. The floor was made up of huge blocks of some very hard white metal, much worn by the going to and fro of past generations. There were innumerable tables made of slabs of polished stone, raised a foot from the floor, and upon these were heaps of fruits. Some I recognized as a kind of overgrown raspberry and orange, but for the most part they were strange.

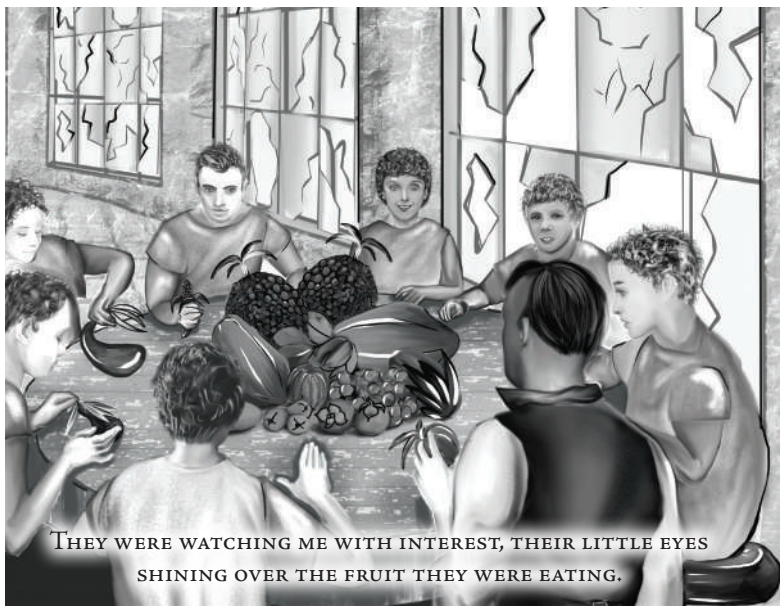
"My guides seated themselves upon a great number of cushions scattered between the tables, and signed for me to do likewise. With a pretty absence of ceremony they began to eat the fruit with their hands, flinging peel and stalks, and so forth, into the round openings in the sides of the tables. I did not hesitate to follow their example, for I felt thirsty and hungry. As I did so I surveyed the hall.

"And perhaps the thing that struck me most was its dilapidated look. The stained-glass windows, which displayed only a geometrical pattern, were broken in many places, and the curtains that hung across the lower end were thick with dust. And it caught my eye that the corner of the marble table near me was fractured. Nevertheless, the general effect was extremely rich and picturesque. There were, perhaps, a couple of hundred people dining in the hall, and most of them, seated as near to me as they could come, were watching me with interest, their eyes shining over the fruit they were eating. All were clad in the same soft, and yet strong, silky material.

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dilapidated: run down; worn out with age and lack of care
picturesque: pretty and charming

"Fruit, by the way, was all their diet. These people of the remote future were strict vegetarians, and while I was with them, in spite of some cravings, I had to be also. Indeed, I found afterwards that horses, cattle, sheep, dogs, had followed the dinosaurs into extinction. But the fruits were very delightful; one, in particular, that seemed to be in season all the time I was there—a floury thing in a three-sided husk—was especially good, and I made it my staple.



They were watching me with interest, their little eyes shining over the fruit they were eating.

staple: A *staple* food is a main or important part of one's diet.

"As soon as my appetite was a little satisfied, I determined to attempt to learn the speech of these new men of mine. The fruits seemed a convenient thing to begin upon, and holding one of these up I began a series of questioning sounds and gestures. I had some difficulty in conveying my meaning. At first my efforts met with a stare of surprise or laughter, but soon a fair-haired little creature seemed to grasp my intention and repeated a name. They had to chatter and explain the business at great length to each other, and my first attempts to make the exquisite little sounds of their language caused an immense amount of amusement. I felt like a schoolmaster among children, and persisted, and soon I had a number of nouns at my command; and then I got to pronouns, and even the verb 'to eat.' But it was slow work, and the little people soon tired and wanted to get away from my interrogations, so I decided to let them give their lessons in little doses when they felt inclined. And very little doses I found they were, for I never met people more indolent or more easily fatigued.

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persisted: kept on despite difficulties
interrogations: questionings
indolent: lazy; tending to avoid activity
fatigued: tired out

THE SUNSET OF MANKIND

"A strange thing I soon discovered about my little hosts, and that was their lack of interest. They would come to me with eager cries of astonishment, like children, but, like children they would soon stop examining me, and wander away after some other toy. After the dinner and my conversational beginnings ended, I noted for the first time that almost all those who had surrounded me at first were gone. It is odd, too, how speedily I came to disregard these little people. I went out through the portal into the sunlit world again as soon as my hunger was satisfied. I was continually meeting more of these people of the future, who would follow me a little distance, chatter and laugh about me, and, having smiled and gestured in a friendly way, leave me on my own.

"The calm of evening was upon the world as I emerged from the great hall, and the scene was lit by the warm glow of the setting sun. At first things were very confusing. Everything was so entirely different from the world I had known—even the

flowers. The big building I had left sat on the slope of a broad river valley, but the Thames had shifted, perhaps, a mile from its present position. I resolved to mount to the summit of a hill, perhaps a mile and a half away, from which I could get a wider view of this our planet in the year Eight Hundred and Two Thousand Seven Hundred and One, A.D. For that, I should explain, was the date the little dials of my machine recorded.

"As I walked I was watching for anything that could possibly help to explain the condition of broken-down splendor in which I found the world—for in ruins it was. A little way up the hill, for instance, was a great heap of granite, bound together by masses of aluminum, a maze of steep walls and crumpled heaps, with thick heaps of very beautiful plants tinted brown about the leaves. It was evidently the abandoned remains of some vast structure, but for what purpose it had been built I could not determine. It was here that I was later to have a very strange experience—the first hint of a still stranger discovery—but I will

Thames [pronounced *tehmz*]: a major river in England that flows through the city of London

summit: the highest point of a hill or mountain

speak of that in its proper place.

"Looking round, with a sudden thought I realized that there were no small houses to be seen. Apparently the single house, and possibly even the household, had vanished. Here and there among the greenery were palace-like buildings, but the house and the cottage, which form such characteristic features of our own English landscape, had disappeared.

"'Communism,' said I to myself.

"Communism" in the Distant Future?

Communism is an economic system based on community ownership of property. Communists support the principle that the people should own and control everything together, as a community—hence the name, *communism*.

When a family owns a house, that is private ownership of property. When the Time Traveler sees no houses anywhere, he thinks that this future world might have changed over to a communist economic system.

Keep in mind that the Time Traveler is using the word "communism" simply to name the economic system he thinks he sees. He is making a neutral observation, not passing a judgment. Since 1895, when *The Time Machine* was first published, world-shaking events have made it difficult for many people to hear the word "communism" in a neutral way. In the Time Traveler's day, however, the world had not yet experienced the violent upheavals

household: the people living together in a house

in Russia, China, and elsewhere that led to societies in which harsh totalitarian governments claimed to pursue economic equality through communism but crushed individual freedom and destroyed many lives in the process.

(See the Introduction to this book, page 6, for a brief account of the influence of the ideas of Karl Marx, who hoped for a communist society.)

"I looked at the half-dozen little figures that were following me. Then, in a flash, I perceived that all had the same form of costume, the same soft hairless appearance, and the same roundness of limb. It may seem strange, perhaps, that I had not noticed this before. But everything was so strange. Now, I saw the fact plainly enough. In dress and in all the outward differences that now mark off the sexes from each other, these people of the future were alike. And the children seemed to my eyes to be but the miniatures of their parents.

"Seeing the ease and security in which these people were living, I felt that this close resemblance of the sexes was after all what one would expect; where violence comes but rarely and offspring are secure, the specialization of the sexes with reference to their children's needs disappears. This, I must remind you, was my speculation at

the time. Later, I was to appreciate how far it fell short of the reality.

"My attention was attracted by a pretty little structure, like a well under a cupola. I thought for a moment of the oddness of wells still existing. There were no large buildings towards the top of the hill, and I was soon left alone for the first time. With a strange sense of freedom and adventure I pushed on up to the crest.

"There I found a seat of some yellow metal that I did not recognize, corroded in places with a kind of pinkish rust and half smothered in soft moss, the arm-rests shaped into the resemblance of griffins' heads. I sat down on it, and I surveyed the broad view of our old world under the sunset of that long day. It was as sweet and pleasing a view as I have ever seen. The sun had already gone below the horizon and the west was flaming gold, touched with some horizontal bars of purple and crimson. Below was the valley of the Thames, in

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cupola [pronounced *KYOO-puh-luh*]: a dome or rounded roof (or part of a roof)

crest: top of a hill or mountain

griffin: in mythology, a creature with a lion's body and the head and wings of an eagle



My attention was attracted by a pretty little structure, like a well under a cupola.

which the river lay like a band of burnished steel. I have already spoken of the great palaces dotted about among the greenery, some in ruins and some still occupied. Here and there rose a white or silvery figure. There were no hedges, no signs of proprietary rights, no evidences of agriculture; the whole earth had become a garden.

"I began to put my interpretation upon the things I had seen, something in this way. (Afterwards I found I had got only a half truth—or only a glimpse of the truth.)

The Time Traveler as Storyteller: Wrong Theories and Half-Truths

The Time Traveler tells us his first impressions and early explanations for what he sees in the distant future; at the same time, he tells us that those explanations later turn out to be wrong. He says things like:

> *"This . . . was my speculation at the time. Later, I was to appreciate how far it fell short of the reality."*

> *"I began to put my interpretation upon the things I had seen . . . . Afterwards I found I had got only a half truth."*

The Time Traveler tells us his first ideas were based on "half truth," and he hints that later we will get the whole truth. But in telling his story, he holds back and makes us wait for the whole truth. Why? Is he trying to keep us in suspense by making us experience the same confusion and mystery that he felt? What do you think about the way he tells the story?

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burnished: polished till smooth and bright
proprietary rights: rights of private ownership

"It seemed to me that I had happened upon humanity upon the wane. The ruddy sunset set me thinking of the sunset of mankind. For the first time I began to realize an odd consequence of the social effort in which we are at present engaged. And yet it is a logical consequence. Strength is the outcome of need; security sets a premium on feebleness. The work of improving the conditions of life—the true civilizing process that makes life more and more secure—had gone steadily on to a climax. One triumph of a united humanity over Nature had followed another. Things that are now mere dreams had become projects purposefully carried forward. And the harvest was what I saw!

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upon the wane: in a state of decline; growing weaker in strength or importance

ruddy: reddish in color

security: a state of safety, protected from risks or threats

sets a premium on: To "set [or put] a premium on" something means to consider it as especially important or valuable. For example, "Our coach put a premium on cooperation—she told us, 'There is no *I* in *teamwork*.'"

triumph: great victory

harvest: The word *harvest* usually refers to crops, but the Time Traveler is using it in a general sense that means, the product or result of an action.

"After all, the sanitation and the agriculture of today are still in the rudimentary stage. The science of our time has only begun to attack the field of human diseases. Our agriculture and horticulture destroy a weed just here and there and cultivate perhaps a score or so of wholesome plants, leaving the greater number to fight out a balance as they can. We improve our favorite plants and animals gradually by selective breeding; now a new and better peach, now a seedless grape, now a sweeter and larger flower, now a more convenient breed of cattle. We improve them gradually, because our knowledge is very limited. Someday all this will be better organized, and still better. The whole world will be intelligent, educated, and cooperating; things will move faster and faster towards the subjugation of Nature. In the end, wisely and

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horticulture: the practice of promoting and improving the growth of fruits, vegetables, and flowers

cultivate: to promote or improve the growth of a plant or crop

score: twenty

selective breeding: the scientific practice of bringing together specific plants or animals so that when they reproduce, the offspring develop specific traits (such as crops that can resist drought, or dogs with a certain size or appearance)

subjugation: the act of overpowering and taking control of someone or something

carefully we shall readjust the balance of animal and vegetable life to suit our human needs.

"This adjustment, I say, must have been done, and done well, in the space of Time across which my machine had leapt. The air was free from gnats, the earth from weeds or fungi; everywhere were fruits and sweet and delightful flowers; brilliant butterflies flew here and there. Diseases had been stamped out. I saw no evidence of any contagious diseases during all my stay.

"Social triumphs, too, had been achieved. I saw mankind housed in splendid shelters, gloriously clothed, and as yet I had found them engaged in no toil. There were no signs of struggle, neither social nor economical struggle. The shop, the advertisement, traffic, all that commerce which makes up the body of our world, was gone. It was natural on that golden evening that I should jump at the idea of a social paradise.

"But with this change in condition comes inevitably adaptations to the change. Unless biological science is a mass of errors, what is the

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toil: hard work
commerce: buying and selling of goods and services

cause of human intelligence and vigor? Hardship and freedom: conditions under which the active, strong, and subtle survive and the weaker fail or fall; conditions that put a premium upon the loyal alliance of capable men, upon self-restraint, patience, and decision.

"I thought of the physical slightness of the people, their lack of intelligence, and those big ruins, and it strengthened my belief in a perfect conquest of Nature. For after the battle comes Quiet. Humanity had been strong, energetic, and intelligent, and had used all its abundant vitality to alter the conditions under which it lived. And now came the reaction of the altered conditions.

"Under the new conditions of perfect comfort and security, that restless energy, that with us is strength, would become weakness. Even in our own time certain tendencies and desires, once necessary to survival, are a constant source of failure. Physical courage and the love of battle, for instance, are no great help—may even be hindrances—

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subtle: clever; highly perceptive
self-restraint: self-control; self-discipline
abundant: plentiful; more than enough
hindrances: obstacles that hold back or delay progress

to a civilized man. And in a state of physical balance and security, power, intellectual as well as physical, would be out of place. I reasoned that for countless years there had been no danger of war or individual violence, no danger from wild beasts, no disease to require strength of constitution, no need of toil. For such a life, what we should call the weak are as well-equipped as the strong, are indeed no longer weak. Indeed they are better equipped, for the strong would be disturbed by an energy for which there was no outlet.

"Even the artistic impulse had almost died in the Time I saw. To adorn themselves with flowers, to dance, to sing in the sunlight: so much was left of the artistic spirit, and no more. Even that would fade in the end into a contented inactivity. We are kept keen on the grindstone of pain and necessity, and it seemed to me that here that hateful grindstone was broken at last!

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constitution: one's overall physical health and condition
impulse: urge or need to do something
adorn: decorate; make more attractive
keen: sharp; or, highly perceptive and responsive
grindstone: a rotating stone wheel used for sharpening

"As I stood there in the gathering dark I thought that in this simple explanation I had mastered the problem of the world—mastered the whole secret of these delicious people. Very simple was my explanation, and plausible enough—as most wrong theories are!

On Strength and Security: The Time Traveler's Theory

Why have the people of the year 802,701 become small, childlike, and weak? To answer that question, the Time Traveler, being a good scientist, comes up with a theory. He begins by stating a principle: "Strength is the outcome of need; security sets a premium on feebleness." What does he mean by that? Let's work through his thinking.

The Time Traveler theorizes that over the course of hundreds of thousands of years, the human race, through their strength and ingenuity, must have gone on making life "more and more secure" by achieving a "perfect conquest of Nature." In the absence of hunger and disease, people no longer needed to struggle against the natural world, and eventually, they no longer struggled against each other, as war and violence disappeared. With all of humanity's basic needs fulfilled, there was no need to struggle to survive.

Once humanity achieved this complete security, what happened? With all their needs met, and with no natural threats or social competition, people no longer needed

delicious: delightful; charming

to be strong, energetic, or clever. Indeed, says the Time Traveler, such qualities might even be disturbing in a time of complete security.

"What . . . is the cause of human intelligence and vigor?" the Time Traveler asks. He promptly answers, "Hardship and freedom: conditions under which the active, strong, and subtle survive and the weaker fail or fall." In these thoughts, the Time Traveler, like many people in the Victorian era, is taking the ideas of the evolutionary biologist Charles Darwin and using them to explain human and social developments. (For more about Darwin, see the Introduction to this book, page 8.)

According to the Time Traveler, competition and struggle are necessary to build character and intellect. In his view, when life was harder and humans had to struggle, they developed intelligence and strength to enable them to meet their needs. But, the Time Traveler theorizes, when life got softer, so did humans. And by the year 802,701, no longer facing "pain and necessity," the human race has grown smaller, weaker, and less intelligent

The Time Traveler admits that he will later discover this theory to be "wrong," which invites us to question the theory and the assumptions behind it. Does the Time Traveler's theory make sense to you? Do you agree that "strength is the outcome of need"? Do you think competition and struggle make us stronger and smarter? Is human progress mainly a matter of making life "more and more secure"? Does progress depend on the "conquest of nature"? Can progress go so far that it becomes the opposite, leading to a great decline?

A SUDDEN SHOCK

"As I stood there musing over this too perfect triumph of man, the full moon came up out of an overflow of silver light in the northeast. The bright little figures ceased to move about below, a noiseless owl flitted by, and I shivered with the chill of the night. I determined to descend and find where I could sleep.

"I looked for the building I knew. Then my eye traveled along to the figure of the White Sphinx upon the pedestal of bronze, growing clearer as the light of the rising moon grew brighter. I could see the silver birch tree against it. There was the tangle of rhododendron bushes, black in the pale light, and there was the little lawn. I looked at the lawn again. A doubt chilled me. 'No,' said I firmly to myself, 'that is not the lawn.'

"But it *was* the lawn. For the white face of the sphinx was towards it. Can you imagine what I

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musing: thinking deeply or carefully about

triumph of man: For the meaning of this phrase, revisit the previous chapter, especially the references to the "triumph of a united humanity over Nature" and "the subjugation of Nature."

felt as this realization came home to me? But you cannot. The Time Machine was gone!

"At once came the possibility of losing my own time, of being left helpless in this strange new world. I could feel the bare thought of it grip me at the throat and stop my breathing. In another moment I was in a passion of fear and running with great leaping strides down the slope. Once I fell headlong and cut my face; I jumped up and ran on, with a warm trickle down my cheek and chin. All the time I ran I was saying to myself: 'They have moved it a little, pushed it under the bushes out of the way.' Nevertheless, I ran with all my might. All the time, with the certainty that sometimes comes with great fear, I knew that such assurance was folly, knew that the machine was removed out of my reach. My breath came with pain. I suppose I covered the whole distance from the hill crest to the little lawn, two miles perhaps, in ten minutes. And I am not a young man. I cursed my confident folly in leaving the machine. I cried aloud, and none answered. Not a creature seemed to be stirring in that moonlit world.

folly: foolishness

"When I reached the lawn my worst fears were realized. Not a trace of the thing was to be seen. I felt faint and cold when I faced the empty space among the black tangle of bushes. I ran round it furiously, as if the thing might be hidden in a corner, and then stopped abruptly, with my hands clutching my hair. Above me towered the sphinx upon the bronze pedestal, white, shining, sickly, in the light of the rising moon. It seemed to smile in mockery of me.

"I might have consoled myself by imagining the little people had put the mechanism in some shelter for me, had I not felt sure they were physically and intellectually incapable of doing so. That is what dismayed me: the sense of some unsuspected power, through whose action my invention had vanished. Yet, I felt assured that the machine could not have moved in time. The attachment of the levers—I will show you the method later—prevented anyone from tampering with the machine when they were removed. It had moved, and was hid, only in space. But then, where could it be?

consoled: calmed and comforted
dismayed: discouraged; filled with distress

"I think I must have had a kind of frenzy. I remember running violently in and out among the moonlit bushes all round the sphinx, and startling some white animal that, in the dim light, I took for a small deer. I remember, too, late that night, beating the bushes with my clenched fist until my knuckles were gashed and bleeding from the broken twigs. Then, sobbing and raving in my anguish of mind, I went down to the great building of stone. The big hall was dark, silent, and deserted. I slipped on the uneven floor, and fell over one of the tables, almost breaking my shin. I lit a match and went on past the dusty curtains.

"There I found a second great hall covered with cushions, upon which, perhaps, a score or so of the little people were sleeping. No doubt I seemed strange to them, coming suddenly out of the quiet darkness with the flare of a match, for they knew nothing about matches.

"'Where is my Time Machine?' I began, bawling like an angry child, laying hands upon them and shaking them up together. It must have been very strange to them. Some laughed, most of

raving: talking loudly in a wild and angry way
anguish: extreme mental or physical pain

them looked frightened. When I saw them standing round me, I realized I was doing a very foolish thing in trying to scare them. For, reasoning from their daylight behavior, I thought they must have forgotten the sensation of fear.

"Abruptly, I dashed down the match, and knocking one of the people over in my course, went blundering across the big dining-hall again, out under the moonlight. I heard cries of terror and their little feet running and stumbling this way and that. I do not remember all I did as the moon crept up the sky. I suppose it was the unexpected nature of my loss that maddened me. I felt hopelessly cut off from my own kind—a strange animal in an unknown world. I must have raved to and fro, screaming and crying upon God and Fate. I have a memory of horrible fatigue, as the long night of despair wore away; of looking in this impossible place and that; of groping among moonlit ruins and touching strange creatures in the black shadows; at last, of lying on the ground near the sphinx and weeping with absolute

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fatigue: extreme tiredness; exhaustion
despair: hopelessness

wretchedness. I had nothing left but misery. Then I slept, and when I woke again it was full day, and a couple of sparrows were hopping round me on the turf within reach of my arm.

"I sat up in the freshness of the morning, trying to remember how I had got there, and why I had such a deep sense of despair. Then things came clear in my mind. With the plain, reasonable daylight, I could look my circumstances fairly in the face. I saw the wild folly of my frenzy overnight, and I reasoned with myself. 'Suppose the worst?' I said. 'Suppose the machine altogether lost—perhaps destroyed? It is necessary for me to be calm and patient, to learn the way of the people, to get a clear idea of the method of my loss, and the means of getting materials and tools; so that in the end, perhaps, I may make another.' That would be my only hope, a poor hope, perhaps, but better than despair. And, after all, it was a beautiful and curious world.

"Probably the machine had only been taken away. Still, I must be calm and patient, find its hiding-place, and recover it by force or cunning.

wretchedness: state of extreme sadness
cunning: clever trickiness

And with that I scrambled to my feet and looked about me, wondering where I could bathe. I felt weary, stiff, and travel-soiled. The freshness of the morning made me desire an equal freshness. I had exhausted my emotion. Indeed, as I went about my business, I found myself wondering at my intense excitement overnight. I made a careful examination of the ground about the little lawn. I wasted some time in futile questionings to the little people that came by. They all failed to understand my gestures; some made no response, some thought it was a jest and laughed at me. I had the hardest task in the world to keep my hands off their pretty laughing faces. It was a foolish impulse, but the devil born of fear and blind anger was still eager to take advantage of my perplexity.

"I got better guidance from the ground of the lawn. I found a groove ripped in it, about midway between the pedestal of the sphinx and the marks of my feet where, on arrival, I had struggled with the overturned machine. There were other signs of removal about, with odd narrow footprints

futile: useless; pointless
jest: joke
perplexity: a state of confusion or bewilderment

like those I could imagine made by a sloth. This directed my closer attention to the pedestal. It was, as I think I have said, made of bronze. It was not a mere block, but highly decorated with deep framed panels on either side. I went and rapped at these. The pedestal was hollow. Examining the panels with care, I found no handles or keyholes. But if these panels were doors, as I supposed, possibly they opened from within. One thing was clear enough. It took no very great mental effort to infer that my Time Machine was inside that pedestal. But how it got there was a different problem.

"I saw the heads of two orange-clad people coming through the bushes and under some blossom-covered apple-trees towards me. I turned smiling to them, and beckoned them to me. They came, and then, pointing to the bronze pedestal, I tried to make known my wish to open it. But at my first gesture they behaved very oddly. I don't know how to convey their expression to you. Suppose you were to use a grossly improper gesture to a delicate-minded woman—it is how she would look.

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infer: to figure out based on reasoning and evidence
beckoned: gestured with the hand or head to signal someone to follow or come closer

They went off as if they had received the worst possible insult. I tried a sweet-looking little chap in white next, with exactly the same result. Somehow, his manner made me feel ashamed of myself. But, as you know, I wanted the Time Machine, and I tried him once more. As he turned off, like the others, my temper got the better of me. In three strides I was after him, had him by the loose part of his robe round the neck, and began dragging him towards the sphinx. Then I saw the horror on his face, and all of a sudden I let him go.

"But I was not beaten yet. I banged with my fist at the bronze panels. I thought I heard something stir inside—I thought I heard a sound like a chuckle—but I must have been mistaken. Then I got a rock from the river, and came and hammered at the panels. The delicate little people must have heard me hammering a mile away on either hand, but nothing came of it. I saw a crowd of them upon the slopes, sneaking quick looks at me. At last, hot and tired, I sat down to watch the place. But I was too restless to watch long. I could work at a problem for years, but to wait inactive for twenty-four hours—that is another matter.

"I got up after a time, and began walking aimlessly through the bushes towards the hill again. 'Patience,' said I to myself. 'If you want your machine again you must leave that sphinx alone. If they mean to take your machine away, it's little good wrecking their bronze panels, and if they don't, you will get it back as soon as you can ask for it. To sit before a puzzle like that is hopeless. That way lies madness. Face this world. Learn its ways, watch it, be careful of too hasty guesses at its meaning. In the end you will find clues to it all.' Then suddenly the humor of the situation came into my mind: the thought of the years I had spent in study and toil to get into the future age, and now my anxious desire to get out of it. I had made myself the most complicated and the most hopeless trap that ever a man devised. I could not help myself—I laughed aloud.

"Going through the big palace, it seemed to me that the little people avoided me. It may have had something to do with my hammering at the gates of bronze. Yet I felt fairly sure of the avoidance. I was careful, however, to show no concern and to hold back from any pursuit of them, and in the course of

pursuit: the act of following or chasing someone or something

a day or two things got back as they were.

"I made what progress I could in the language, and in addition I pushed my explorations here and there. Either I missed some subtle point or their language was excessively simple—almost entirely composed of concrete nouns and verbs. There seemed to be few, if any, abstract terms, or little use of figurative language. Their sentences were usually simple and of two words, and I failed to convey or understand any but the simplest statements. I determined to put the thought of my Time Machine and the mystery of the bronze doors under the sphinx as much as possible in a corner of memory, until my growing knowledge would lead me back to them in a natural way. Yet a certain feeling, you understand, kept me in a circle of a few miles round the point of my arrival.

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subtle: not obvious; difficult to notice [The word *subtle* has various meanings; previously, on page 77, it was used to mean "clever, highly perceptive."]

abstract terms: In contrast to concrete nouns—which refer to a specific person, place or thing, such as *flag*—abstract terms refer to a general idea or quality, such as *freedom*.

figurative language: In contrast to literal language—words used to say exactly what you mean—figurative language uses words in imaginative and colorful ways. *Literal*: The bird flew away. *Figurative*: I feel free as a bird. *Literal*: I'm happy. *Figurative:* I'm on top of the world!

EXPLANATION

"So far as I could see, all the world displayed the same fertile richness as the Thames valley. From every hill I climbed I saw the same abundance of splendid buildings, endlessly varied in material and style, the same clustering thickets of evergreens, the same blossom-laden trees and tree ferns. Here and there water shone like silver, and beyond, the land rose into blue undulating hills, and so faded into the serenity of the sky.

"A peculiar feature was the presence of certain circular wells. Several, it seemed to me, were of a very great depth. One lay by the path up the hill which I had followed during my first walk. Like the others, it was rimmed with bronze, and protected by a little cupola from the rain. Sitting by the side of these wells, and peering down into the darkness, I could see no gleam of water, nor could I start any reflection with a lighted match.

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thickets: closely-spaced groups of trees or bushes
undulating: rising and falling
serenity: state of peaceful calm

But in all of them I heard a certain sound: a thud—thud—thud, like the beating of some big engine; and I discovered, from the flaring of my matches, that a steady current of air set down the shafts. Further, I threw in a scrap of paper and, instead of fluttering slowly down, it was at once sucked swiftly out of sight.

"After a time, I came to connect these wells with tall towers standing here and there upon the slopes; for above them there was often just such a flicker in the air as one sees on a hot day above a sun-scorched beach. Putting things together, I reached a strong suggestion of an extensive system of subterranean ventilation, whose true significance it was difficult to imagine. I was at first inclined to associate it with the sanitary apparatus of these people. It was an obvious conclusion, but it was absolutely wrong.

"I have read some visions of Utopia and coming times in which there is a vast amount of detail about building, and social arrangements, and

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subterranean: underground
sanitary apparatus: equipment for the disposal of waste; sewage system
Utopia: an imaginary perfect society

so forth. But while such details are easy enough to obtain when the whole world is contained in one's imagination, they are altogether inaccessible to a real traveler in such realities as I found here. I was aware of much unseen, which contributed to my comfort; but except for a general impression of automatic organization, I fear I can convey very little of the difference to your mind.

Visions of Utopia

The Time Traveler says he has read a number of books that present "visions of Utopias and coming times." The word *Utopia* comes from the title of a book from 1516 by Sir Thomas More, which describes his vision of a perfect society on an imaginary island. He made up the word *utopia* from the Greek words *ou* (meaning "no") and *topos* (meaning "place")—so, a utopia is "no place," a place that doesn't exist.

The word *utopia* has come to be used for any imaginary vision of a perfect society. In H. G. Wells's time, during the late 1800s, many writers were offering their optimistic visions of ideal societies in the future. As the Time Traveler notes, these utopian writings often provided detailed descriptions of modes of government, kinds of housing, systems of transportation and manufacturing, and more. In this way, while these utopian

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inaccessible: out of reach; beyond understanding

general impression of automatic organization: The Time Traveler refers here to his vague sense that in the distant future, technology has advanced to the point that the basic needs of the people are automatically filled—though the Time Traveler cannot see how this is achieved.

writings optimistically predicted progress and improvement in the future, they also indirectly criticized present-day social arrangements by showing how far they were from the visions of future perfection.

Two utopian novels were especially popular in H. G. Wells's time: *Looking Backward* by the American writer Edward Bellamy (published in 1888), and *News from Nowhere* by the English writer William Morris (published in 1890). In *The Time Machine*, published in 1895, Wells casts doubt on the optimistic visions of those novels and other utopian writings. Later, in 1905, Wells published a book titled *A Modern Utopia*, a curious work in which he both offers a utopian vision and constantly questions it.

In recent times, a new word, *dystopia*, has been used to suggest the opposite of *utopia*. (The prefix *dys* comes from a Greek term meaning "ill" or "bad.") Modern-day dystopian novels and movies imagine a world gone terribly wrong. Dystopian fictions warn us that unless we change our ways, we might be heading toward dystopia sooner than we think.

Think about your own vision of utopia. What are the top three features of your perfect society?

"For instance, I could see no signs of crematories nor cemeteries nor anything like tombs. But it occurred to me that these might be somewhere beyond the range of my exploring. And this puzzled me still more: among this people none were aged or infirm.

crematories: place where the bodies of the dead are cremated (burned into ashes)

infirm: sickly; physically weakened by old age or illness

"My first theories of an automatic civilization did not last long, yet I could think of no other. Let me explain my difficulties. The several big palaces I had explored were mere living places, great dining-halls and sleeping apartments. I could find no machinery, no appliances of any kind. Yet these people were clothed in pleasant fabrics that must at times need renewal, and their sandals, though undecorated, were fairly complex specimens of metalwork. Somehow such things must be made. And the little people displayed no trace of a creative tendency. There were no shops, no workshops. They spent all their time in playing gently, in bathing in the river, in eating fruit, and sleeping. I could not see how things were kept going.

"Then, again, about the Time Machine: something had taken it into the hollow pedestal of the White Sphinx. Why? For the life of me I could not imagine. Those waterless wells, too, those flickering pillars. I felt I lacked a clue.

"On the third day of my visit to the world of Eight Hundred and Two Thousand Seven Hundred and One, I made a friend—of a sort.

of a sort: an expression meaning, not quite of the usual kind

It happened that, as I was watching some of the little people bathing in a shallow part of the river, one of them was seized with cramp and began drifting downstream. The main current ran rather swiftly, but not too strongly for even a moderate swimmer. It will give you an idea, therefore, of the strange deficiency in these creatures, when I tell you that none made the slightest attempt to rescue the weakly crying little thing that was drowning before their eyes. When I realized this, I hurriedly waded in at a point lower down, where I caught the poor mite and drew her safe to land. A little rubbing of the limbs soon brought her round, and I had the satisfaction of seeing she was all right before I left her.

"This happened in the morning. I did not expect any gratitude from her, but I was wrong. In the afternoon I met my little woman, as I believe it was, as I was returning from an exploration, and she received me with cries of delight and presented me with a big garland of flowers—

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deficiency: a state in which there is not enough of something, or something is lacking in a way that causes a problem
mite: a small person or thing
garland: wreath; a ring of flowers and leaves worn as a decoration

evidently made for me and me alone. The thing took my imagination. Very possibly I had been feeling desolate. At any rate I did my best to display my appreciation of the gift. We were soon seated together, engaged in conversation, chiefly of smiles. The creature's friendliness affected me exactly as a child's might have done. We passed each other flowers, and she kissed my hands. I did the same to hers. Then I tried talk, and found that her name was Weena, which, though I don't know what it meant, somehow seemed appropriate enough. That was the beginning of an unusual friendship which lasted a week, and ended—as I will tell you!

"She was exactly like a child. She wanted to be with me always. She tried to follow me everywhere, and on my next journey out and about it touched my heart to tire her down and leave her exhausted, calling after me rather plaintively. But the problems of the world had to be mastered.

"Her distress when I left her was very great, sometimes frantic, and I think I had as much

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desolate: deeply sad and alone
at any rate: in any case; anyway
plaintively: pitifully; sadly and mournfully



She received me with cries of delight and presented me with a big garland of flowers.

trouble as comfort from her devotion. Nevertheless she was, somehow, a very great comfort. I thought it was mere childish affection that made her cling to me. Until it was too late, I did not clearly know what I had inflicted upon her when I left her. Nor until it was too late did I clearly understand what she was to me. For, by merely seeming fond of me, and showing in her weak, ineffective way that she cared for me, the little doll of a creature soon gave my return to the neighborhood of the White Sphinx almost the feeling of coming home; and I would watch for her tiny figure of white and gold so soon as I came over the hill.

"It was from her, too, that I learned that fear had not yet left the world. She was fearless enough in the daylight; once, in a foolish moment, I made threatening grimaces at her, and she simply laughed at them. But she dreaded the dark and shadows. Darkness to her was the one thing dreadful. It was a remarkably intense emotion, and it set me thinking and observing. I discovered then, among other things, that these little people

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grimaces: twisted or ugly facial expressions

gathered into the great houses after dark, and slept in large groups. To enter upon them without a light was to put them into great fear and alarm. I never found one outdoors, or one sleeping alone inside, after dark. Yet I was still such a blockhead that I missed the lesson of that fear, and in spite of Weena's distress, I insisted upon sleeping away from these slumbering multitudes.

"It troubled her greatly, but in the end her odd affection for me triumphed, and for five of the nights of our acquaintance, including the last night of all, she slept with her head pillowed on my arm. But my story slips away from me as I speak of her.

"It must have been the night before her rescue that I was awakened about dawn. I had been restless, dreaming that I was drowned, and that sea anemones were feeling over my face with their soft tentacles. I woke with a start, and with an odd sense that some greyish animal had just rushed out. I tried to get to sleep again, but I felt restless and uncomfortable. It was that dim grey hour when things are just creeping out of darkness,

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sea anemones: small, colorful sea animals that look like flowers

when everything is colorless and clear cut, and yet unreal. I got up, and went down into the great hall, and so out upon the flat stone walkway in front of the palace. I thought I would make a virtue of necessity, and see the sunrise.

"The dying moonlight and the first pale glow of dawn were mingled in a ghastly half-light. The bushes were inky black, the ground a dull grey, the sky colorless and cheerless. And up the hill I thought I could see ghosts. Three times, as I scanned the slope, I saw white figures. Twice I thought I saw a solitary white, ape-like creature running quickly up the hill, and once near the ruins I saw a few of them carrying some dark body. They moved hastily. I did not see what became of them. It seemed that they vanished among the bushes. The dawn was still indistinct, you must understand. I was feeling that chill, uncertain, early-morning feeling you may have known. I doubted my eyes.

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make a virtue of necessity: an expression meaning, to make the best out of a situation in which you have no choice, or you have to do something

scanned: looked carefully at all parts of

"As the eastern sky grew brighter, and the light of the day came on and its vivid coloring returned upon the world once more, I again looked closely at the hillside. But I saw no traces of the white figures. They were mere creatures of the half-light. 'They must have been ghosts,' I said. But the joke was unsatisfying, and I was thinking of these figures all that morning until Weena's rescue drove them out of my head. I associated them in some indefinite way with the white animal I had startled in my first search for the Time Machine. They were soon destined to take far deadlier possession of my mind.

"I think I have said how much hotter than our own was the weather of this Golden Age. I cannot account for it. It may be that the sun was hotter, or the earth nearer the sun. Whatever the reason, the fact remains that the sun was very much hotter than we know it.

"Well, one very hot morning—my fourth, I think—as I was seeking shelter from the heat and glare in a colossal ruin near the great house

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account for: give a satisfactory explanation of
glare: a harsh, bright light

where I slept and fed, a strange thing happened. Clambering among these heaps of masonry, I found a narrow gallery, whose end and side windows were blocked by fallen masses of stone. By contrast with the brilliant light outside, it seemed at first impenetrably dark to me. I entered it groping, for the change from light to blackness made spots of color swim before me. Suddenly I halted spellbound. A pair of eyes, luminous by reflection of the daylight outside, was watching me out of the darkness.

"The old instinctive dread of wild beasts came upon me. I clenched my hands and firmly looked into the glaring eyeballs. I was afraid to turn. Then the thought of the absolute security in which humanity appeared to be living came to my mind. And then I remembered that strange terror

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clambering: climbing or crawling in an awkward way
masonry: stone and brick
gallery: a long, narrow room
impenetrably: in a way that is impossible to see through or pass through
spellbound: held in fixed attention, as though hypnotized or under a spell
luminous: shining in the dark
glaring: shining with a harsh light

of the dark. Overcoming my fear to some extent, I advanced a step and spoke. I will admit that my voice was harsh and ill-controlled. I put out my hand and touched something soft. At once the eyes darted sideways, and something white ran past me. I turned with my heart in my mouth, and saw a strange little ape-like figure, its head held down in a peculiar manner, running across the sunlit space behind me. It blundered against a block of granite, staggered aside, and in a moment was hidden in a black shadow beneath another pile of ruined masonry.

"My impression of it is, of course, imperfect; but I know it was a dull white, and had strange large greyish-red eyes; also that there was flaxen hair on its head and down its back. But, as I say, it went too fast for me to see distinctly. I cannot even say whether it ran on all fours, or only with its forearms held very low.

"After an instant's pause I followed it into the second heap of ruins. I could not find it at first; but, after a time in the deep darkness,

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staggered: moved unsteadily from side to side
flaxen: pale yellow

I came upon one of those round well-like openings of which I have told you, half closed by a fallen pillar. A sudden thought came to me. Could this Thing have vanished down the shaft? I lit a match, and, looking down, I saw a small, white, moving creature, with large bright eyes which regarded me as it retreated. It made me shudder. It was so like a human spider! It was clambering down the wall, and now I saw for the first time a number of metal foot and hand rests forming a kind of ladder down the shaft. Then the light burned my fingers and fell out of my hand, going out as it dropped, and by the time I had lit another match the little monster had disappeared.

"I do not know how long I sat peering down that well. I could hardly persuade myself that the thing I had seen was human. But, gradually, the truth dawned on me: that Man had not remained one species, but had differentiated into two distinct animals: that my graceful children of the Upper World were not the only descendants of our generation, but that this bleached, obscene,

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descendants: offspring; people related to past groups of people
obscene: disgusting; repulsive; nasty

nocturnal Thing, which had flashed before me, was also heir to all the ages.

"I thought of the flickering pillars and of my theory of an underground ventilation. I began to suspect their true significance. And what, I wondered, was this lemur doing in my scheme of a perfectly balanced organization? How was it related to the indolent serenity of the beautiful Overworlders? And what was hidden down there, at the foot of that shaft? I sat upon the edge of the well telling myself that there was nothing to fear, and that there I must descend for the solution of my difficulties. And yet I was absolutely afraid to go!

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nocturnal: mainly active at night

heir to all the ages: An heir is a person who inherits property from someone who has died. In a famous poem by the Victorian poet Alfred Tennyson, the phrase "heir of all the ages" suggests a person who inherits the history and traditions of the people who came before him, and who represents a sense of possibility for the future. H. G. Wells's Time Traveler is shocked to think that these strange, pale creatures might be the heirs of humanity.

the flickering pillars: In the earlier chapter titled "Explanation" (see page 93), the Time Traveler sees "circular wells" dotting the landscape. Related to these, he thinks, as part of "an extensive system of subterranean ventilation," are "tall towers standing here and there upon the slopes; for above them there was often just such a flicker in the air as one sees on a hot day above a sun-scorched beach."

lemur: a small monkey-like mammal with large eyes

"As I hesitated, two of the beautiful upperworld people came running across the daylight in the shadow. They seemed distressed to find me, my arm against the overturned pillar, peering down the well. Apparently it was considered inappropriate to take note of these apertures; for when I pointed to this one, and tried to ask about it in their language, they were still more distressed and turned away. But they were interested by my matches, and I struck some to amuse them. I soon left them. My mind was turning. I had now a clue to the meaning of these wells, to the ventilating towers, to the mystery of the ghosts—as well as a hint at the meaning of the bronze gates and the fate of the Time Machine! And very vaguely there came a suggestion towards the solution of the economic problem that had puzzled me.

"Here was the new view. Plainly, this second species of Man was subterranean. There were three circumstances in particular which made me think that its rare emergence above ground was the outcome of a long-continued underground

apertures: openings; holes
economic problem: The Time Traveler refers to his puzzlement about how the little people meet their needs when they neither work nor have any system of manufacturing or trade.
emergence: the act of coming into view

habit. In the first place, there was the bleached look common in most animals that live largely in the dark—the white fish of the Kentucky caves, for instance. Then, those large eyes, with that ability to reflect light, are common features of nocturnal things, such as the owl and the cat. And last of all, that evident confusion in the sunshine, that hasty yet fumbling awkward flight towards dark shadow, and that peculiar carriage of the head while in the light—all reinforced the theory of an extreme sensitiveness of the retina.

"Beneath my feet, then, the earth must be tunneled enormously, and these tunnels were the habitat of the New Species. The presence of ventilating shafts and wells along the hill slopes—everywhere, in fact, except along the river valley, made it natural to assume that it was in this artificial Underworld that such work as was necessary to the comfort of the daylight people was done. The notion was so plausible that I at once accepted it, and went on to consider how the human species had been split.

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retina: the light-sensitive tissue at the back of the eyeball
notion: idea; opinion

"At first, proceeding from the problems of our own age, it seemed clear as daylight to me that the key lay in the gradual widening of the present social difference between the Capitalist and the Laborer. No doubt it will seem wildly incredible to you, and yet even now there are existing circumstances to point that way. There is a tendency to utilize underground space for the less ornamental purposes of civilization; for instance, there are new electric railways, there are subways, there are underground workrooms and restaurants, and they increase and multiply. Evidently, I thought, this tendency had increased till Industry had gradually gone deeper and deeper into larger and ever larger underground factories, till, in the end—! Even now, does not an East End worker live in such artificial conditions as practically to be cut off from the natural surface of the earth?

Capitalist and the Laborer: Here, the Time Traveler begins "to consider how the human species had been split" by examining the division of society into social classes. The "Capitalists" are the upper class, those who have money, who own businesses, and who employ the "Laborers," the working class. This analysis of society in terms of class divisions recalls the ideas of the German scholar Karl Marx. For more information on the influence of Marx, see the Introduction to this book, page 6.

ornamental: decorative; used to make more attractive

East End: the eastern part of the city of London, known in the Victorian era as an overcrowded area of great poverty

"The exclusive tendency of richer people is already leading to the closing, in their interest, of considerable portions of the surface of the land. About London, for instance, perhaps half the prettier country is shut in against intrusion. There is a widening gulf between the refinement of the rich and the rude violence of the poor. This gap is due to the length and expense of the higher educational process and the increasingly refined habits on the part of the rich. This same widening gulf will make social advancement by marriage between the classes less and less frequent, which at present delays the splitting of our species along lines of social stratification. So, in the end, above ground you must have the Haves, pursuing pleasure and comfort and beauty, and below ground the Have-nots, the Workers getting continually adapted to the conditions of their

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exclusive tendency of richer people: The Time Traveler uses this phrase to suggest that wealthy people tend to exclude and keep themselves apart from those who are not rich.
in their interest: for their benefit (that is, for the good of the richer people)
intrusion: unwanted or illegal entrance
gulf: a large difference or division between two people or groups
refinement: polite manners and sophisticated tastes
social stratification: the division of society into different classes

labor. Once they were there, they would no doubt have to pay rent, and not a little of it, for the ventilation of their caverns; and if they refused, they would starve or be suffocated. The miserable and rebellious would die; and, in the end, the survivors would become as well adapted to the conditions of underground life, and as happy in their way, as the Overworld people were to theirs.

"The great triumph of Humanity had been no triumph of moral education and general cooperation as I had imagined. Instead, I saw a real aristocracy with a perfected science taking the industrial system of today to a logical conclusion—not simply a triumph over Nature, but a triumph over Nature and the fellow-man. This, I must warn you, was my theory at the time. My explanation may be absolutely wrong. I still think it is the most plausible one. But this balanced civilization must have long since passed its zenith, and was now far fallen into decay. The too-perfect security of the Overworlders had led them to a slow movement of degeneration, to a general decrease in size, strength, and intelligence.

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aristocracy: the highest social class
zenith: highest point of success
degeneration: process of becoming worse, weaker, lower in quality

That I could see clearly enough already. What had happened to the Undergrounders I did not yet suspect; but, from what I had seen of the Morlocks—that was the name by which these creatures were called—I could imagine that the modification of the human type was even far more profound than among the 'Eloi,' the beautiful little people that I already knew.

"Then came troublesome doubts. Why had the Morlocks taken my Time Machine? For I felt sure it was they who had taken it. Why, too, if the Eloi were masters, could they not restore the machine to me? And why were they so terribly afraid of the dark?

"I questioned Weena about this Underworld, but she refused to answer. She shivered as though the topic was unbearable. And when I pressed her, perhaps a little harshly, she burst into tears. They were the only tears, except my own, I ever saw in that Golden Age. When I saw them I ceased abruptly to trouble Weena about the Morlocks. And very soon she was smiling and clapping her hands, while I solemnly burnt a match.

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solemnly: in a serious and unsmiling manner

The Time Traveler's "New View": The Theory of Two Species

In an earlier chapter (see pages 74-79), the Time Traveler offered his first theory about the world of the distant future. He theorized that the human race had achieved a "conquest of nature" resulting in "an automatic civilization" in which there was no hunger or disease, and all of humanity's basic needs were met without work or struggle. Even as he explained this first theory, he told us it would prove to be "wrong."

Now, faced by new facts—especially his encounter with the underground creatures—the Time Traveler offers his "new view." He no longer thinks that the small, childlike people live in a civilization in which their needs are somehow automatically met. Instead, he now thinks that there is an "Underworld" populated by creatures who do "such work as was necessary to the comfort of the daylight people." His revised theory, he says, grows out of his thinking about "the problems of our own age"—that is, the Time Traveler's present-day, the late Victorian era in England, around 1900.

"It seemed clear as daylight to me," he says, "that the key lay in the gradual widening of the present social difference" between the upper and lower classes. According to the Time Traveler's new theory, great social changes eventually led to great biological changes: "Man had not remained one species," he theorizes, "but had differentiated into two distinct animals." He thinks that in the far distant future, the upper and lower classes have grown so far apart that they have actually evolved into two different species: above ground, the childlike Eloi, and below, the "ape-like" Morlocks. According to the Time Traveler, what led to the gradual splitting of humanity into two different species?

When the Time Traveler talks of the upper classes of his own time, he does not criticize them—after all, the Time Traveler is himself wealthy enough to hold frequent dinner parties in a nice house staffed by a number of servants. The Time Traveler is mainly interested in scientific theory, not social criticism. But through the Time Traveler's theories about the future, the author, H. G. Wells, draws attention to what he sees as serious problems in his own time, including the growing gap between the rich and the poor.

THE MORLOCKS

"It may seem odd to you, but it was two days before I could follow up the newfound clue in the proper way. I felt a peculiar shrinking from those pallid bodies. They were just the half-bleached color of the worms and things one sees preserved in alcohol in a museum. And they were filthily cold to the touch. Probably my shrinking was largely due to the influence of the Eloi, whose disgust of the Morlocks I now began to appreciate.

"The next night I did not sleep well. I was oppressed with perplexity and doubt. Once or twice I had a feeling of intense fear for which I could perceive no definite reason. I remember creeping noiselessly into the great hall where the little people were sleeping in the moonlight. That night Weena was among them. I felt reassured by their presence. It occurred to me that in the course of a few days the moon must pass through its last quarter, and the nights would grow dark—

shrinking: moving away from, in fear or disgust
pallid: pale in a sickly way
oppressed: distressed; discouraged; emotionally weighed down

then these unpleasant creatures from below, these whitened lemurs, this new vermin that had replaced the old, might appear more often.

"On these days I had the restless feeling of one who shirks an inevitable duty. I felt sure that the Time Machine was only to be recovered by boldly penetrating these mysteries of underground. Yet I could not face the mystery. If only I had had a companion it would have been different. But I was so horribly alone, and even to clamber down into the darkness of the well appalled me. I don't know if you will understand my feeling, but I never felt quite safe at my back.

"It was this restlessness, this insecurity, perhaps, that drove me farther and farther away in my exploring expeditions. Going towards the rising country south-westward, I observed far off a vast green structure, different in character from any I had seen. It was larger than the largest of the palaces or ruins I knew, and the face of it had the bluish-green tint of a certain type of

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vermin: pests; harmful animals such as rats or cockroaches
shirks: avoids (a duty or responsibility)
appalled: horrified and discouraged
tint: shade or small amount of a color

Chinese porcelain. This difference in appearance suggested a difference in use, and I wanted to push on and explore. But the day was growing late, so I resolved to hold over the adventure for the following day, and I returned to the welcome of little Weena. But next morning I perceived that my curiosity regarding the Palace of Green Porcelain had enabled me to put off an experience I dreaded. I resolved I would make the descent without further waste of time, and started out in the early morning towards a well near the ruins of granite and aluminum.

"Little Weena ran with me. She danced beside me to the well, but when she saw me lean over the well-mouth and look downward, she seemed strangely upset. 'Good-bye, little Weena,' I said, and then I reached in and began to feel for the climbing hooks. Rather hastily, I may as well confess, for I feared my courage might leak away! At first she watched me in amazement. Then she gave a most piteous cry, and running to me, she

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porcelain: a hard material made from baking clay, sometimes used to make dishes, vases, figurines, etc.
well-mouth: the opening into the well
piteous: sad; pitiful; heartbreaking

began to pull at me with her little hands. I think her opposition encouraged me to proceed. I shook her off, perhaps a little roughly, and in another moment I was in the throat of the well. I saw her agonized face and smiled to reassure her. Then I had to look down at the unstable hooks to which I clung.

"I had to clamber down a shaft of perhaps two hundred yards, by means of metallic bars projecting from the sides of the well. These being adapted to the needs of a creature much smaller and lighter than myself, I was quickly cramped and fatigued by the descent. And not simply fatigued! One of the bars bent suddenly under my weight, and almost swung me off into the blackness beneath. For a moment I hung by one hand, and after that experience I did not dare to rest again. Though my arms and back were soon in great pain, I went on clambering down the sheer descent with as quick a motion as possible. Glancing upward, I saw the opening, a small blue disc in which a star was visible, while little

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agonized: showing great mental or physical pain
sheer: very steep

Weena's head showed as a round black projection. The thudding sound of a machine below grew louder and more oppressive. Everything except that little disc above was profoundly dark, and when I looked up again Weena had disappeared.

"I was in an agony of discomfort. I had some thought of trying to go up the shaft again, and leave the Underworld alone. But I continued to descend. At last, with intense relief, I saw dimly coming up, a foot to the right of me, a slender loophole in the wall. Swinging myself in, I found it was the opening to a narrow horizontal tunnel in which I could lie down and rest. It was not too soon. My arms ached, my back was cramped, and I was trembling with the prolonged terror of a fall. Besides this, the unbroken darkness had had a distressing effect upon my eyes. The air was full of the throb and hum of machinery pumping air down the shaft.

"I do not know how long I lay. I was roused by a soft hand touching my face. Starting up in the darkness I snatched at my matches and, hastily

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agony: extreme mental or physical pain
roused: brought out of a state of sleep or inactivity

striking one, I saw three stooping white creatures similar to the one I had seen above ground in the ruin, hastily retreating before the light. Living, as they did, in what appeared to me impenetrable darkness, their eyes were abnormally large and sensitive, just as are the pupils of the fishes of the deep, and they reflected the light in the same way. I have no doubt they could see me in that rayless obscurity, and they did not seem to have any fear of me apart from the light. But when I struck a match in order to see them, they fled, vanishing into dark gutters and tunnels, from which their eyes glared at me in the strangest fashion.

"I tried to call to them, but the language they had was apparently different from that of the Overworld people. The thought of fleeing rather than exploring crossed my mind. Feeling my way along the tunnel, I found the noise of machinery grow louder. Soon I came to a large open space. Striking another match, I saw that I had entered a vast arched cavern, which stretched into utter darkness beyond the range of my light. The view

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obscurity: dimness or darkness

I had of it was as much as one could see in the burning of a match.

"My memory is vague. Great shapes like big machines rose out of the dimness, and cast grotesque black shadows, in which dim spectral Morlocks sheltered from the glare. The place was very stuffy and oppressive, and the faint scent of freshly-shed blood was in the air. Some way down was a little table of white metal, laid with what seemed a meal. The Morlocks were carnivorous! Even at the time, I remember wondering what large animal could have survived to furnish the red joint I saw. It was all very indistinct: the heavy smell, the big shapes, the obscene figures lurking in the shadows, and only waiting for the darkness to come at me again! Then the match burnt down, and stung my fingers, and fell, a wriggling red spot in the blackness.

"I have thought since how ill-equipped I was for such an experience. When I had started with the Time Machine, I had started with the

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spectral: ghostlike
carnivorous: meat-eating
joint: large piece of meat
ill-equipped: badly prepared

absurd assumption that the men of the Future would certainly be infinitely ahead of ourselves in all ways. I had come without arms, without medicine, even without enough matches. If only I had thought of a camera! I could have flashed that glimpse of the Underworld in a second, and examined it at leisure. But, as it was, I stood there with only the weapons and the powers that Nature had given me—hands, feet, and teeth; these, and four matches that still remained.

"I was afraid to push my way in among all this machinery in the dark, and it was only with my last glimpse of light I discovered that my store of matches had run low. It had never occurred to me until that moment that there was any need to economize them, and I had wasted almost half the box in astonishing the Overworlders, to whom fire was a novelty. Now, as I said, I had four left, and while I stood in the dark, a hand touched mine, thin fingers came feeling over my face, and I was sensible of a peculiar unpleasant odor. I thought I heard the breathing of a crowd of those dreadful

arms: weapons
economize: use carefully so as to avoid waste
novelty: something new and unusual

little beings about me. I felt the box of matches in my hand being gently disengaged, and other hands behind me plucking at my clothing.

"The sense of these unseen creatures examining me was indescribably unpleasant. There in the darkness, I suddenly realized how little I knew about them. I shouted at them as loudly as I could. They started away, and then I could feel them approaching me again. They clutched at me more boldly, whispering odd sounds to each other. I shivered violently, and shouted again. This time they were not so seriously alarmed, and they made a strange laughing noise as they came back at me.

"I will confess I was horribly frightened. I determined to strike another match and escape under the protection of its glare. I did so, and eking out the flicker with a scrap of paper from my pocket, I made my retreat to the narrow tunnel. But I had barely entered this when my light was blown out and in the blackness I could hear the Morlocks rustling like wind among leaves, and pattering like the rain, as they hurried after me.

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disengaged: separated; removed
eking out: making something last longer

"In a moment I was clutched by several hands, and there was no mistaking that they were trying to haul me back. I struck another light, and waved it in their dazzled faces. You can hardly imagine how nauseatingly inhuman they looked—those pale, chinless faces and great, lidless, pinkish-grey eyes!—as they stared in their blindness and bewilderment.

"But I did not stay to look. I retreated again, and when my second match had ended, I struck my third. It had almost burnt through when I reached the opening into the shaft. I lay down on the edge, for the throb of the great pump below made me giddy. Then I felt sideways for the projecting hooks, and, as I did so, my feet were grasped from behind, and I was violently tugged backward. I lit my last match . . . and it went out. But I had my hand on the climbing bars now, and, kicking violently, I disengaged myself from the clutches of the Morlocks, and was speedily clambering up the shaft, while they stayed peering and blinking up at me, all except one who followed me for some way and almost took my boot as a trophy.

giddy: dizzy



I struck another light, and waved it in their dazzled faces.

"That climb seemed interminable to me. With the last twenty or thirty feet of it a deadly nausea came upon me. I had the greatest difficulty in keeping my hold. The last few yards was a frightful struggle against this faintness. Several times my head swam, and I felt all the sensations of falling. At last, however, I got over the well-mouth somehow, and staggered out of the ruin into the blinding sunlight. I fell upon my face. Even the soil smelled sweet and clean. Then I remember Weena kissing my hands and ears, and the voices of others among the Eloi. Then, for a time, I was insensible.



insensible: unconscious; passed out

WHEN NIGHT CAME

"Now, indeed, I seemed in a worse case than before. Until now I had hope of escape, but that hope was shaken by these new discoveries. Until now I had simply thought myself held back by the childish simplicity of the little people, and by some unknown forces which I had only to understand to overcome; but there was an altogether new element in the sickening quality of the Morlocks—a something inhuman and malign. Instinctively I loathed them. Before, I had felt as a man might feel who had fallen into a pit: my concern was with the pit and how to get out of it. Now I felt like a beast in a trap, whose enemy would come upon him soon.

"The enemy I dreaded may surprise you. It was the darkness of the coming new moon. Weena had put this into my head by some remarks about the Dark Nights, which at first I did not understand. The moon was waning: each

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malign: evil in nature
loathed: hated intensely
waning: appearing thinner and less full than the night before

night there was a longer interval of darkness. And I now understood to some slight degree the reason of the fear of the little Upperworld people for the dark. I wondered what foul villainy the Morlocks did under the new moon. I felt pretty sure now that my second hypothesis was all wrong. The Upperworld people might once have been the favored aristocracy, and the Morlocks their mechanical servants, but that had long since passed away.

"The two species that had resulted from the evolution of man were sliding down towards, or had already arrived at, an altogether new relationship. The Eloi had decayed to a mere beautiful futility. They still possessed the earth, since the Morlocks, subterranean for innumerable generations, had come at last to find the daylit surface intolerable. I inferred that the Morlocks made the garments of the Eloi, and maintained them in their habitual needs, perhaps through the

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interval: a period of time between events
my second hypothesis: See pages 110-114.
mechanical: acting in an unthinking, automatic, machine-like way
futility: uselessness; ineffectiveness
intolerable: unbearable

survival of an old habit of service. They did it as a standing horse paws with his foot, or as a man enjoys killing animals in sport, because of ancient and departed necessities. But, clearly, the old order was already in part reversed. The Nemesis of the delicate ones was creeping on apace. Ages ago, thousands of generations ago, man had thrust his brother man out of the ease and the sunshine. And now that brother was coming back—changed! Already the Eloi had begun to learn one old lesson anew. They were becoming reacquainted with Fear. And suddenly, almost like a question from outside, there came into my head the memory of the meat I had seen in the Underworld. I tried to recall the form of it. I had a vague sense of something familiar, but I could not tell what it was at the time.

"Still, however helpless the little people in the presence of their mysterious Fear, I was different. I came out of this age of ours, this prime of the

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Nemesis: In Greek mythology, the goddess Nemesis inflicted terrible punishments. Now, *nemesis* means an enemy you cannot avoid or overcome.

apace: quickly

prime: a time of greatest strength or success

human race, when Fear does not paralyze and mystery has lost its terrors. I at least would defend myself. Without further delay I determined to make myself arms and a safe place where I might sleep. Then I could face this strange world with some of that confidence I had lost in realizing how I lay unprotected from these creatures night by night. I felt I could never sleep again until my bed was secure from them. I shuddered with horror to think how they must already have examined me.

"I wandered during the afternoon along the valley of the Thames, but found no buildings or trees that seemed inaccessible to such dexterous climbers as the Morlocks. Then I remembered the tall pinnacles of the Palace of Green Porcelain and the polished gleam of its walls; and in the evening, taking Weena like a child upon my shoulder, I went up the hills towards the southwest. The distance, I thought, was seven or eight miles, but it must have been nearer eighteen. In addition, the heel of one of my shoes was loose, and a nail was working through the sole, so that I was lame. And

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dexterous: highly skillful
pinnacles: peaks; highest points

it was already long past sunset when I came in sight of the palace.

"Weena had been delighted when I began to carry her, but after a while she desired me to let her down, and ran along by the side of me, occasionally darting off on either hand to pick flowers to stick in my pockets. My pockets had always puzzled Weena, but she had concluded that they were an odd kind of vase for floral decoration. At least she used them for that purpose. And that reminds me! In changing my jacket I found. . ."

(The Time Traveler paused, put his hand into his pocket, and silently placed two withered, very large white flowers upon the little table. Then he resumed his narrative.)

"As the hush of evening crept over the world and we proceeded over the hill crest, Weena grew tired and wanted to return to the house of grey stone. But I pointed out the distant pinnacles of the Palace of Green Porcelain to her, and managed to make her understand that we were seeking a refuge there from her Fear.

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withered: dried out and wrinkled
refuge: a place that offers safety and shelter from danger



I pointed out the distant pinnacles of the Palace of Green Porcelain to her.

"You know that great pause that comes upon things before the dusk? Even the breeze stops in the trees. To me there is always an air of expectation about that evening stillness. The sky was clear, remote, and empty save for a few horizontal bars far down in the sunset. Well, that night the expectation took the color of my fears. In that darkling calm my senses seemed sharpened. I imagined I could even feel the hollowness of the ground beneath my feet, and see through it the Morlocks on their ant-hill waiting for the dark. In my excitement I imagined that they would receive my invasion of their burrows as a declaration of war. And why had they taken my Time Machine?

"So we went on in the quiet, and the twilight deepened into night. The clear blue of the distance faded, and one star after another came out. The ground grew dim and the trees black. Weena's fears and her fatigue grew upon her. I took her in my arms and talked to her and soothed her. Then, as the darkness grew deeper, she put her arms round my neck, and, closing her eyes, tightly

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darkling: growing dark

pressed her face against my shoulder. So we went down a long slope into a valley, and there in the dimness I almost walked into a little river. I waded across and went up the opposite side of the valley, past a number of sleeping houses, and by a statue—a Faun, or some such figure, without the head. So far I had seen nothing of the Morlocks, but it was yet early in the night, and the darker hours before the old moon rose were still to come.

"From the top of the next hill I saw a thick wood spreading wide and black before me. I hesitated at this. I could see no end to it, either to the right or the left. Feeling tired—my feet were especially sore—I carefully lowered Weena from my shoulder and sat down upon the turf. I could no longer see the Palace of Green Porcelain, and I was in doubt of my direction. I looked into the thickness of the wood and thought of what it might hide. Under that dense tangle of branches one would be out of sight of the stars. Even if there were no other lurking danger—a danger I did not care to imagine—there would still be all the

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Faun: in mythology, a creature that is part human and part goat

roots to stumble over and the tree trunks to strike against. I was very tired, too, after the excitements of the day; so I decided that I would not face it, but would pass the night upon the open hill.

"Weena, I was glad to find, was fast asleep. I carefully wrapped her in my jacket, and sat down beside her to wait for the moonrise. The hillside was quiet and deserted, but from the black of the wood there came now and then a stir of living things. Above me shone the stars, for the night was very clear. I felt a certain sense of friendly comfort in their twinkling. All the old constellations had gone from the sky, however: that slow movement which is imperceptible in a hundred human lifetimes, had long since rearranged them in unfamiliar groupings. But the Milky Way, it seemed to me, was still the same tattered streamer of star-dust as of yore.

"Looking at these stars suddenly dwarfed my own troubles. I thought of their unfathomable distance, and the slow inevitable drift of their movements out of the unknown past into the

imperceptible: impossible to see or observe
of yore: in the long-ago past
unfathomable: beyond understanding

unknown future. I thought of all the years that I had traversed, during which all the activity, all the traditions, the complex organizations, the nations, languages, literatures, aspirations, even the mere memory of Man as I knew him, had been swept out of existence. Instead were these frail creatures who had forgotten their high ancestry, and the white Things of which I went in terror. Then I thought of the Great Fear that was between the two species, and for the first time, with a sudden shiver, came the clear knowledge of what the meat I had seen might be. Yet it was too horrible! I looked at little Weena sleeping beside me, her face starlike under the stars, and immediately dismissed the thought.

"Through that long night I held my mind off the Morlocks as well as I could. The sky kept very clear, except for a hazy cloud or so. No doubt I dozed at times. Then, as my vigil wore on, came a faintness in the eastward sky, like the reflection of some colorless fire, and the old moon rose, thin and peaked and white. And close behind, and

traversed: moved across
aspirations: hopes and wishes to achieve something
vigil: a time of staying awake to keep watch

overtaking it, and overflowing it, the dawn came, pale at first, and then growing pink and warm. No Morlocks had approached us. Indeed, I had seen none upon the hill that night. And in the confidence of renewed day it almost seemed to me that my fear had been unreasonable. I stood up and found my foot with the loose heel swollen at the ankle and painful under the heel; so I sat down again, took off my shoes, and flung them away.

"I awakened Weena, and we went down into the wood, now green and pleasant instead of black and forbidding. We found some fruit for breakfast. We soon met others of the dainty ones, laughing and dancing in the sunlight as though there was no such thing in nature as the night. And then I thought once more of the meat that I had seen. I felt assured now of what it was, and from the bottom of my heart I pitied this last feeble rill from the great flood of humanity. Clearly, at some time in the Long-Ago the Morlocks' food had run short. And so these inhuman sons of men — —!

"I tried to look at the thing in a scientific

dainty: small and pretty
rill: a small stream

spirit. After all, they were less human and more remote than our cannibal ancestors of three or four thousand years ago. And the intelligence that would have made this state of things a torment had gone. Why should I trouble myself? These Eloi were mere fatted cattle, which the ant-like Morlocks preserved and preyed upon. And there was Weena dancing at my side!

"I tried to protect myself from the horror by regarding it as a punishment of human selfishness. Man had been content to live in ease and delight upon the labors of his fellow-man, had taken Necessity as his excuse, and in the fullness of time Necessity had come home to him. But however great their intellectual degradation, the Eloi had kept too much of the human form not to claim my sympathy, and to make me a sharer in their degradation and their Fear.

"I had at that time very vague ideas as to the course I should pursue. My first was to secure some safe place of refuge, and to make myself such arms of metal or stone as I could. That necessity

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preyed upon: hunted and killed for food
degradation: decline and decay

was immediate. In the next place, I hoped to obtain some means of fire, to have the weapon of a torch at hand, for nothing, I knew, would be more efficient against these Morlocks. Then I wanted to arrange some device to break open the doors of bronze under the White Sphinx. I had in mind a battering ram. I was convinced that if I could enter those doors and carry a blaze of light before me I would discover the Time Machine and escape. I could not imagine the Morlocks were strong enough to move it far away. I had resolved to bring Weena with me to our own time. And turning such schemes over in my mind I pursued our way towards the building I had chosen as our dwelling.



"Mere Fatted Cattle"

As you have seen, the Time Traveler offers his theories to explain the life he observes in the distant future, and then offers new theories when he encounters new facts that contradict the old theory. At first he imagined that the Eloi lived peaceful and carefree lives in an "automatic civilization," in which unseen technologies fulfilled the basic needs of the little people. After the Time Traveler sees the machinery in the underground world of the Morlocks, he theorizes that the Morlocks were once the servants of the Eloi, but that this relationship changed as the Eloi, once a "favored aristocracy," grew smaller, weaker, and less intelligent.

Now the Time Traveler reluctantly reaches a new and awful understanding of the relationship between the Morlocks and the Eloi. The Morlocks are not the servants of the Eloi—far from it. Instead, says the Time Traveler, "These Eloi were mere fatted cattle, which the ant-like Morlocks preserved and preyed upon."

The Time Traveler suggests that the Eloi might have brought on their own horrible fate: "I tried to protect myself from the horror," he says, "by regarding it as a punishment of human selfishness. Man had been content to live in ease and delight upon the labors of his fellow-man, had taken Necessity as his excuse, and in the fullness of time Necessity had come home to him."

What does the Time Traveler mean when he says that humans had "taken Necessity as [their] excuse"? Excuse for what? Do you agree that the Eloi might be partly responsible for the situation they are in?

In imagining a distant future in which the descendants of humanity have split into one species that eats the other, what warning do you think H. G. Wells was trying to deliver to the people of his own time?

THE PALACE OF GREEN PORCELAIN

"I found the Palace of Green Porcelain, when we approached it about noon, deserted and falling into ruin. Only fragments of glass remained in its windows, and great sheets of the green covering had fallen away from the corroded metallic framework. On the Palace I saw an inscription in some unknown writing. I thought, rather foolishly, that Weena might help me to interpret this, but the bare idea of writing had never entered her head. She always seemed to me, I think, more human than she was, perhaps because her affection was so human.

"Within the big door—which was open and broken—we found a long gallery lit by many side windows. At the first glance I was reminded of a museum. The tiled floor was thick with dust, and a remarkable array of miscellaneous objects

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corroded: worn down and damaged over time (such as by rust)
inscription: words written on a surface (such as the page of a book) or carved on a monument or building
array: a large group of things
miscellaneous: including things of many different kinds

was shrouded in the same grey covering. Then I perceived, standing in the center of the hall, what was clearly the lower part of the huge skeleton of some extinct creature. The skull and the upper bones lay beside it in the thick dust, and in one place, where rainwater had dropped through a leak in the roof, the thing itself had been worn away. Further in the gallery was the huge skeleton of a Brontosaurus. My museum hypothesis was confirmed. Clearing away the thick dust, I found the old familiar glass cases of our own time. They must have been air-tight to judge from the fair preservation of some of their contents. A very splendid array of fossils it must have been.

"The place was very silent. The thick dust deadened our footsteps. Weena very quietly took my hand and stood beside me.

"To judge from the size of the place, this Palace of Green Porcelain had a great deal more in it than a Gallery of Paleontology; possibly historical galleries; perhaps even a library! To me, at least in my present circumstances, these would be vastly

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shrouded: covered

Paleontology: the scientific study of the fossil remains of plants and animals from long ago

more interesting than this spectacle of old-time geology in decay. Exploring, I found another short gallery, which appeared to be devoted to minerals, and the sight of a block of sulfur set my mind running on gunpowder. But I could find no saltpeter. Yet the sulfur set up a train of thinking. As for the rest of the contents of that gallery, I had little interest.

"We came to a gallery of colossal proportions, but ill-lit, the floor of it running downward at a slight angle from the end at which I entered. White globes hung from the ceiling—many of them cracked and smashed—which suggested that originally the place had been artificially lit. Here, rising on either side of me were the huge bulks of big machines, all greatly corroded and many broken down, but some still fairly complete. I was inclined to linger among these, as they had the interest of puzzles, and I could only guess at what they were for. I imagined that if I could solve their puzzles I would find myself in possession of powers that might be of use against the Morlocks.

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spectacle: a large and impressive show or display

saltpeter: potassium nitrate, which when mixed with sulfur and charcoal make up gunpowder

"Suddenly Weena came very close to my side—so suddenly that she startled me. Had it not been for her I do not think I would have noticed that the floor of the gallery sloped at all. The end I had come in at was quite above ground, and was lit by slit-like windows. The ground came up against these windows, until at last there was a pit before each, and only a narrow line of daylight at the top. I went slowly along, puzzling about the machines, and had been too focused upon them to notice the gradual dimming of the light, until Weena's increasing fright drew my attention. Then I saw that the gallery ran down at last into a thick darkness. I hesitated and looked round me.

"Further away towards the dimness, the dust appeared to be broken by a number of small narrow footprints. My sense of the immediate presence of the Morlocks revived at that. I felt that I was wasting my time in the academic examination of machinery. It was already far advanced in the afternoon, and I had still no weapon, no refuge, and no means of making a fire. And then down in the remote blackness of the gallery I heard a

peculiar pattering, and the same odd noises I had heard down the well.

"I took Weena's hand. Then, struck with a sudden idea, I left her and turned to a machine from which projected a lever. Clambering upon the stand, and grasping this iron handle, I put all my weight upon it sideways. Suddenly Weena, deserted in the central aisle, began to whimper. The lever snapped after a minute's strain, and I rejoined her with a mace in my hand more than sufficient for any Morlock skull I might encounter. And I longed very much to kill a Morlock or so. Very inhuman, you may think, to want to go killing one's own descendants! But it was impossible, somehow, to feel any humanity in the things. Only my reluctance to leave Weena, and the thought that if I began to slake my thirst for murder my Time Machine might suffer, kept me from going straight down the gallery and killing the brutes I heard.

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mace: a heavy club used as a weapon
sufficient: enough; satisfactory for the purpose
slake my thirst: literally, to satisfy your thirst; figuratively, to satisfy your desire

"Killing the Brutes"

The more he feels threatened by the Morlocks, the more the Time Traveler shows a side of his character that we haven't seen before. When he says, "I longed very much to kill a Morlock or so," how do you respond? Do you sympathize with him? After all, he fears for his own survival (and that of Weena as well). But his words become even more extreme—he goes beyond self-defense and speaks of actively hunting and killing Morlocks. He speaks of his "thirst for murder" and says he can barely hold himself back from "killing the brutes."

The Time Traveler realizes that we might consider his feelings to be "very inhuman." He excuses himself, however, by explaining that "it was impossible, somehow, to feel any humanity in the things."

Notice that he calls the Morlocks "things." Earlier, he has compared them to apes, spiders, lemurs, worms, and ants, and labeled them "vermin." He repeatedly sees the Morlocks as less than, or other than, human. Still, while the Time Traveler does not "feel any humanity" in the Morlocks, he acknowledges they are "one's own descendants"—in short, they are humans of some kind.

What are we to think of these violent and bloodthirsty feelings on the part of a man who is, after all, a highly civilized British gentleman? H. G. Wells was well aware of the murderous violence that civilized people are capable of when they refuse to see other people as fully human. He had witnessed the expansion of the British empire across the globe during the Victorian era. As one scholar has noted, "To the empire builders, killing Africans or Indians was not 'really' murder; they were Other and hence less than truly human."

A few years after writing *The Time Machine*, Wells wrote *The War of the Worlds*, in which he described a Martian invasion of earth. With their advanced technology, the Martians use heat rays and poison gas to kill many people. To the Martians, says the novel's narrator, "the creatures who inhabit this earth must be . . . at least as alien and lowly as are the monkeys and lemurs to us." Furthermore, says the book's narrator, before we condemn the Martians, "we must remember what ruthless and utter destruction our own species has wrought." He then recalls the actions of Europeans in Tasmania (an island south of Australia) during the early 1800s: "The Tasmanians, in spite of their human likeness, were entirely swept out of existence in a war of extermination waged by European immigrants, in the space of fifty years."

The Time Traveler is far from engaging in "a war of extermination" such as the Europeans waged against the Tasmanians. But H. G. Wells understood that such horrible actions may have their beginnings in murderous impulses toward those who are seen as less than human.

"Well, mace in one hand and Weena in the other, I went out of that gallery and into another and still larger one, which at the first glance seemed to be hung with tattered flags. I soon recognized the brown and charred rags that hung from the sides as the decaying remnants of books. They had long since dropped to pieces, and every

tattered: ragged; old and torn

trace of print had left them. Seeing this wilderness of rotting paper, the thing that struck me was the enormous waste of labor. At the time I will confess that I thought chiefly of my own philosophical writings and seventeen papers upon physical optics.

"Then, going up a broad staircase, we came to what may once have been a gallery of technical chemistry. Except at one end where the roof had collapsed, this gallery was well preserved. I went eagerly to every unbroken case. And at last, in one of the really air-tight cases, I found a box of matches. Very eagerly I tried them. They were perfectly good. They were not even damp. I turned to Weena. 'Dance,' I cried to her. For now I had a weapon indeed against the horrible creatures we feared. And in that derelict museum, upon the thick soft carpeting of dust, to Weena's huge delight, I performed a kind of dance, whistling as cheerfully as I could.

"For this box of matches to have escaped the wear of time for so many years was most fortunate

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derelict: run-down due to neglect

for me. Yet, oddly enough, I found a far unlikelier substance, and that was camphor. I found it in a sealed jar so air-tight that this volatile substance had chanced to survive, perhaps through many thousands of centuries. I was about to throw it away, but I remembered that it was flammable and burnt with a good bright flame. It was, in fact, an excellent candle, so I put it in my pocket. I found no explosives, however, nor any means of breaking down the bronze doors. As yet my iron bar was the most helpful thing I had chanced upon. Nevertheless I left that gallery greatly elated.

"I cannot tell you all the story of that long afternoon. It would require a great effort of memory to recall my explorations in the proper order. As the evening drew on, I went through gallery after gallery, dusty, silent, often ruinous, the exhibits sometimes mere heaps of rust.

"We came to a little open court within the

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camphor: a white, strong-smelling substance used in some medicines
volatile: (in chemistry) tending to evaporate quickly at normal temperatures
flammable: able to be easily ignited and burned
elated: extremely happy

palace. It had three fruit-trees, so we rested and refreshed ourselves. Towards sunset I began to consider our position. Night was creeping upon us, and I still had to find a safe hiding-place. But that troubled me very little now. I had in my possession a thing that was, perhaps, the best of all defenses against the Morlocks—I had matches! I had the camphor, too, if a blaze were needed. It seemed to me that the best thing we could do would be to pass the night in the open, protected by a fire. In the morning I would go about getting the Time Machine. Towards that, as yet, I had only my iron mace. But now, with my growing knowledge, I felt very differently towards those bronze doors. Up to this, I had held back from forcing them, largely because of the mystery on the other side. They had never impressed me as being very strong, and I hoped to find my bar of iron adequate for the work.

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adequate: enough to meet the need or purpose

IN THE DARKNESS

"We emerged from the Palace while the sun was still in part above the horizon. I was determined to reach the White Sphinx early the next morning. My plan was to go as far as possible that night, and then, building a fire, to sleep in the protection of its glare. As we went along I gathered any sticks or dried grass I saw, and soon had my arms full. Thus loaded, our progress was slower than I had anticipated, and besides Weena was tired. And I, also, began to suffer from sleepiness, so that it was full night before we reached the wood. Upon the shrubby hill of its edge Weena would have stopped, fearing the darkness before us; but a strong sense of impending calamity drove me onward. I had been without sleep for a night and two days, and I was feverish and irritable. I felt sleep coming upon me, and the Morlocks with it.

"While we hesitated, I saw three crouching

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impending: about to happen
calamity: disaster; terrible misfortune

figures among the black bushes behind us. There was long grass all about us, and I did not feel safe. The forest, I calculated, was a little less than a mile across. If we could get through it to the bare hillside, there, it seemed to me, was an altogether safer resting-place. I thought that with my matches and my camphor I could keep my path illuminated through the woods. Yet it was evident that if I was to light matches with my hands I would have to abandon my firewood; so, rather reluctantly, I put it down. And then it came into my head that I would amaze our friends behind by lighting it. I was to discover the atrocious folly of this plan, but it came to my mind as an ingenious move for covering our retreat.

"I don't know if you have ever thought what a rare thing flame must be in the absence of man and in a temperate climate. The art of fire-making had been forgotten on the earth. The red tongues that went licking up my heap of wood were an altogether new and strange thing to Weena. She wanted to run to it and play with it. I believe she

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atrocious: awful; terrible

temperate: having mild temperatures, without extremes of hot or cold

would have cast herself into it had I not restrained her. But I caught her up, and in spite of her struggles, plunged boldly before me into the wood.

"For a little way the glare of my fire lit the path. Looking back, I could see, through the crowded stems, that from my heap of sticks the blaze had spread to some bushes, and a curved line of fire was creeping up the grass of the hill. I laughed at that, and turned again to the dark trees before me. It was very black, and Weena clung to me tightly, but as my eyes grew accustomed to the darkness, there was still enough light for me to avoid the branches. Overhead it was simply black, except where a gap of remote blue sky shone down upon us here and there. I lit none of my matches because I had no free hand. Upon my left arm I carried my little one, in my right hand I had my iron bar.

"For some way I heard nothing but the crackling twigs under my feet, the faint rustle of the breeze above, and my own breathing and the throb of the blood-vessels in my ears. Then I seemed to hear a pattering behind me. I pushed on. The pattering grew clearer, and then I caught

the same odd sound and voices I had heard in the Underworld. There were evidently several of the Morlocks, and they were closing in upon me. Indeed, in another minute I felt a tug at my coat, then something at my arm. And Weena shivered violently, and became quite still.

"It was time for a match. But to get one I must put her down. I did so, and, as I fumbled with my pocket, a struggle began in the darkness about my knees, perfectly silent on her part and with the same peculiar cooing sounds from the Morlocks. Soft little hands, too, were creeping over my coat and back, touching even my neck. Then the match scratched and fizzed. I held it flaring, and saw the white backs of the Morlocks in flight among the trees. I hastily took a lump of camphor from my pocket, and prepared to light it as soon as the match should start to die out. Then I looked at Weena. She was lying clutching my feet and quite motionless, with her face to the ground. With a sudden fright I stooped to her. She seemed scarcely to breathe. I lit the block of camphor and flung it to the ground. As it split and flared and drove back the Morlocks and the shadows, I knelt

down and lifted her. The wood behind seemed full of the stir and murmur of a great company!

"She seemed to have fainted. I put her carefully upon my shoulder and rose to push on, and then there came a horrible realization. In moving with my matches and Weena, I had turned myself about several times, and now I had not the faintest idea in what direction lay my path. For all I knew, I might be facing back towards the Palace of Green Porcelain. I found myself in a cold sweat. I had to think rapidly what to do. I determined to build a fire and camp where we were. I put Weena down, still motionless, and very hastily I began collecting sticks and leaves. Here and there out of the darkness round me the Morlocks' eyes shone like bright red jewels.

"My first lump of camphor flickered and went out. I lit a match, and as I did so, two white forms that had been approaching Weena dashed hastily away. One was so blinded by the light that he came straight for me, and I felt his bones grind under the blow of my fist. He gave a whoop of dismay, staggered a little way, and fell down. I lit

another piece of camphor, and went on gathering my bonfire. Soon I noticed how dry the foliage was above me, for since my arrival on the Time Machine, a matter of a week, no rain had fallen. So, instead of looking among the trees for fallen twigs, I began leaping up and dragging down branches. Very soon I had a choking smoky fire of green wood and dry sticks, and could save my camphor. Then I turned to where Weena lay beside my iron mace. I tried what I could to revive her, but she lay like one dead. I could not even tell whether or not she breathed.

"Now, the smoke of the fire beat over towards me, and the vapor of camphor was in the air. I felt very weary and sat down. I seemed just to nod and open my eyes. But all was dark, and the Morlocks had their hands upon me. Flinging off their clinging fingers I hastily felt in my pocket for the match-box, and—it had gone! Then they gripped and closed with me again. In a moment I knew what had happened. I had slept, and my fire had gone out, and the bitterness of death came over my soul. The forest seemed full of the smell of burning

foliage: the leaves of plants

wood. I was caught by the neck, by the hair, by the arms, and pulled down. It was indescribably horrible in the darkness to feel all these soft creatures heaped upon me. I felt as if I was in a monstrous spider's web. I was overpowered, and went down. I felt little teeth nipping at my neck. I rolled over, and as I did so my hand came against my iron lever. It gave me strength. I struggled up, shaking the human rats from me, and, holding the bar short, I thrust where I judged their faces might be. I could feel the succulent giving of flesh and bone under my blows, and for a moment I was free.

"The strange exultation that so often seems to accompany hard fighting came upon me. I knew that both I and Weena were lost, but I determined to make the Morlocks pay for their meat. I stood with my back to a tree, swinging the iron bar before me. The whole wood was full of the stir and cries of them. A minute passed. Their voices seemed to rise to a higher pitch of excitement, and their movements grew faster. Yet none came within reach. I stood glaring at the blackness.

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succulent: juicy
giving: bending and stretching
exultation: feeling of great excitement, joy, and triumph

Then suddenly came hope. What if the Morlocks were afraid? And close on the heels of that came a strange thing. The darkness seemed to grow luminous. Very dimly I began to see the Morlocks about me—three battered at my feet—and then, with surprise and disbelief, I saw that the others were running, in an unbroken stream, as it seemed, from behind me, and away through the wood in front. And their backs seemed no longer white, but reddish. As I stood staring, I saw a little red spark go drifting across a gap of starlight between the branches, and vanish. And at that I understood the smell of burning wood, the gusty roar, the red glow, and the Morlocks' flight.

"Stepping out from behind my tree and looking back, I saw, through the black pillars of the nearer trees, the flames of the burning forest. It was the first fire I had made, coming after me. With that I looked for Weena, but she was gone. The hissing and crackling behind me, the explosive thud as each fresh tree burst into flame, left little time for careful thought. Still gripping my iron bar, I followed in the Morlocks' path. It was a close race.

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gusty: characterized by strong, sudden blasts of wind

As I ran, once the flames crept forward so swiftly on my right that I had to strike off to the left. But at last I emerged upon a small open space, and as I did so, a Morlock came blundering towards me, and past me, and went on straight into the fire!

"And now I was to see the most weird and horrible thing, I think, of all that I beheld in that future age. This whole space was as bright as day with the reflection of the fire. In the center was a small hill, on top of which stood a scorched hawthorn. Beyond this was another arm of the burning forest, with yellow tongues of flame already writhing from it, completely encircling the space with a fence of fire. Upon the hillside were some thirty or forty Morlocks, dazzled by the light and heat, and blundering against each other in their bewilderment. At first I did not realize their blindness, and struck furiously at them with my bar, in a frenzy of fear, as they approached me, killing one and crippling several more. But when I saw the gestures of one of them groping under the hawthorn against the red sky, and heard their

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hawthorn: a type of small tree
writhing: twisting from side to side

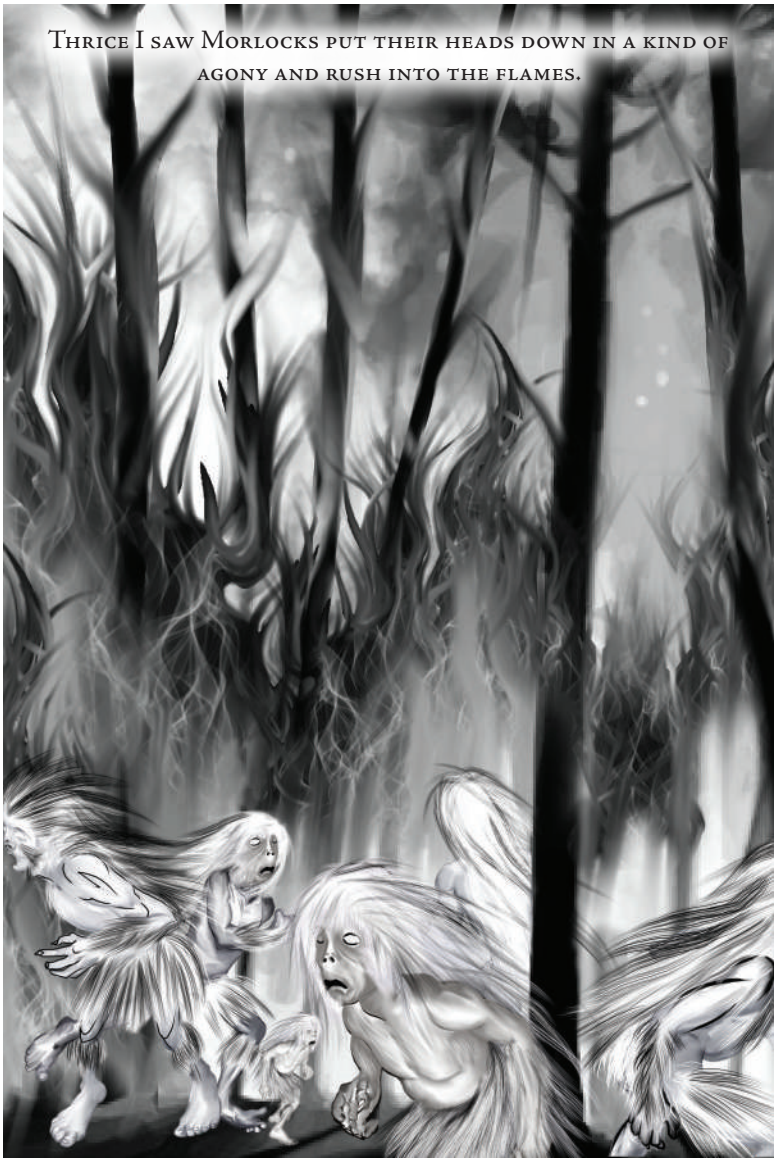
moans, I was assured of their absolute helplessness and misery in the glare, and I struck no more of them.

"Yet every now and then one would come straight towards me, setting loose a quivering horror that made me quick to elude him. At one time the flames died down somewhat, and I feared the foul creatures would soon be able to see me. I was thinking of beginning the fight by killing some of them before this should happen; but the fire burst out again brightly, and I held back. I walked about the hill among them and avoided them, looking for some trace of Weena. But Weena was gone.

"At last I sat down on the summit of the hill, and watched this strange incredible company of blind things groping to and fro, and making uncanny noises to each other, as the glare of the fire beat on them. The coiling uprush of smoke streamed across the sky. Two or three Morlocks came blundering into me, and I drove them off with blows of my fists, trembling as I did so.

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elude: to avoid or escape
uncanny: strange or mysterious in a way that causes feelings of fear and anxiety


Thrice I saw Morlocks put their heads down in a kind of agony and rush into the flames.

"Most of that night was a nightmare. I beat the ground with my hands, and got up and sat down again, and wandered here and there, and again sat down. Then I would fall to rubbing my eyes and calling upon God to let me awake. Thrice I saw Morlocks put their heads down in a kind of agony and rush into the flames. But, at last, above the red of the fire, above the streaming masses of black smoke and the whitening and blackening tree stumps, and the diminishing numbers of these dim creatures, came the white light of the day.

"I searched again for traces of Weena, but there were none. It was plain that they had left her poor little body in the forest. I cannot describe how it relieved me to think that it had escaped the awful fate to which it seemed destined. As I thought of that, I was almost moved to begin a massacre of the helpless abominations about me, but I held myself back.

"From the top of the small hill I could now make out through a haze of smoke the Palace of

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diminishing: becoming less
abominations: things that cause disgust or hatred

Green Porcelain, and from that I could get my bearings for the White Sphinx. And so, leaving the remaining creatures still moaning as the day grew clearer, I tied some grass about my feet and limped on across smoking ashes towards the hiding-place of the Time Machine. I walked slowly, for I was almost exhausted, as well as lame, and I felt the greatest misery for the horrible death of little Weena. It seemed an overwhelming calamity. Now, in this old familiar room, it is more like the sorrow of a dream than an actual loss. But that morning it left me absolutely lonely again—terribly alone. I began to think of this house of mine, of this fireside, of some of you, and with such thoughts came a longing that was pain.

"But, as I walked over the smoking ashes under the bright morning sky, I made a discovery. In my trouser pocket were still some loose matches. The box must have leaked before it was lost.

THE TRAP OF THE WHITE SPHINX

"About eight or nine in the morning I came to the same seat of yellow metal from which I had viewed the world upon the evening of my arrival. I thought of my hasty conclusions upon that evening and could not help laughing bitterly at my confidence. Here was the same beautiful scene, the same abundant foliage, the same splendid palaces and magnificent ruins, the same silver river running between its fertile banks. The lively robes of the beautiful people moved among the trees. Some were bathing in exactly the place where I had saved Weena, and that suddenly gave me a keen stab of pain. And like blots upon the landscape rose the cupolas above the ways to the Underworld. I understood now what all the beauty of the Overworld people covered. Very pleasant was their day, as pleasant as the day of the cattle in the field. Like the cattle, they knew of no enemies and provided against no needs. And their end was the same.

seat of yellow metal: See page 71.

"I grieved to think how brief the dream of the human intellect had been. It had committed suicide. It had set itself steadfastly towards comfort and ease, a balanced society with security and permanency as its watchword, it had attained its hopes—to come to this at last. Once, life and property must have reached almost absolute safety. The rich had been assured of their wealth and comfort, the toilers assured of their life and work. No doubt in that perfect world there had been no unemployment problem, no social question left unsolved. And a great quiet had followed.

"It is a law of nature we overlook, that there is no intelligence where there is no change and no need of change. Only those animals develop intelligence that have to meet a huge variety of needs and dangers. Intellectual versatility is what we get in return for change, danger, and trouble.

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steadfastly: with firm, unchanging focus and dedication
watchword: a word or phrase that expresses a principle or rule to be followed
toilers: those who do the long, hard work
versatility: ability to do may different things and quickly adapt to different needs

"So, as I see it, the Upperworld man had drifted towards his feeble prettiness, and the Underworld to mere machine-like labor. But that perfect state had lacked one thing even for mechanical perfection—absolute permanency. Apparently as time went on, the feeding of an Underworld, however it was done, had become disordered. Mother Necessity, who had been held off for a few thousand years, came back again, and she began below. The Underworld being in contact with machinery—which, however perfect, still needs some little thought—had probably retained more initiative, if less of every other human characteristic, than the Upper. And when other meat failed them, they turned to what old habit had previously forbidden. So I saw it in my last view of the world of Eight Hundred and Two Thousand Seven Hundred and One. It may be as wrong an explanation as a human mind could invent. It is how it all seemed to me, and as such I give it to you.

"After the fatigues, excitements, and terrors of the past days, and in spite of my grief, this seat

initiative: readiness and willingness to take action

The Time Traveler's Final Theory

Returning to the place where he first crash-landed in the Time Machine, the Time Traveler sums up his final theory. He thinks that at some point humanity, in its pursuit of "comfort and ease," had achieved a "balanced society," a "perfect world" in which "there had been no unemployment problem, no social question left unsolved." But this so-called "perfect world" was built on a shaky foundation of social inequality, with the "wealth and comfort" of the rich relying on the steady labor of "the toilers."

This state of affairs did not last—as the Time Traveler says, it lacked "absolute permanency." As time went on, what changed? Eventually, says the Time Traveler, "Mother Necessity, who had been held off for a few thousand years, came back again, and she began below." What do you think he means by that?

Even as he sums up his final theory, the Time Traveler admits (as he has before), "It may be as wrong an explanation as a human mind could invent. It is how it all seemed to me, and as such I give it to you." Why do you think he says this?

Do you think any parts of the Time Traveler's theory apply to our world today? For example, do you think most people still put a high priority on increasing their "comfort and ease"? Does social inequality remain a great problem?

and the tranquil view and the warm sunlight were very pleasant. I was very tired and sleepy, and soon spread myself out upon the turf and had a long and refreshing sleep.

"I awoke a little before sunset. I now felt safe against being caught napping by the Morlocks, and, stretching myself, I came on down the hill towards

tranquil: calm and peaceful

the White Sphinx. I had my iron bar in one hand, and the other hand played with the matches in my pocket.

"And now came a most unexpected thing. As I approached the pedestal of the sphinx I found the bronze panels were open. I stopped before them, hesitating to enter.

"Within was a small apartment, and on a raised place in the corner of this was the Time Machine. I had the small levers in my pocket. So here, after all my preparations for the siege of the White Sphinx, was a meek surrender. I threw my iron bar away, almost sorry not to use it.

"A sudden thought came into my head as I stooped towards the doorway. For once, at least, I understood the mental operations of the Morlocks. Holding back a strong desire to laugh, I stepped through the bronze frame and up to the Time Machine. I was surprised to find it had been carefully oiled and cleaned. I have suspected since that the Morlocks had even partially taken it to pieces while trying in their dim way to grasp its purpose.

"Now as I stood and examined it, the thing I had expected happened. The bronze panels suddenly slid up and struck the frame with a clang.

I was in the dark—trapped. So the Morlocks thought. At that I chuckled gleefully.

"I could already hear their murmuring laughter as they came towards me. Very calmly I tried to strike the match. I had only to fix on the levers and depart then like a ghost. But I had overlooked one little thing. The matches were of that kind that light only on the box.

"You may imagine how all my calm vanished. The little brutes were close upon me. One touched me. I made a sweeping blow in the dark at them with the levers, and began to scramble into the saddle of the machine. Then came one hand upon me and then another. Then I had to fight against their persistent fingers as I tried to put the levers in place. Indeed, they almost got one away from me. As it slipped from my hand, I had to butt in the dark with my head—I could hear the Morlock's skull ring—to recover it.

"But at last the lever was attached and I pulled it over. The clinging hands slipped from me. The darkness presently fell from my eyes. I found myself in the same grey light and confusion I have already described.

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grey light: See page 48: "As I went on, still gaining velocity, night and day merged into one continuous greyness."

THE FURTHER VISION

"I have already told you of the sickness and confusion that comes with time traveling. And this time I was not seated properly in the saddle, but sideways and in an unstable fashion. For an indefinite time I clung to the machine as it swayed and vibrated, paying no attention to how I went, and when I brought myself to look at the dials again I was amazed to find where I had arrived. One dial shows days, and another thousands of days, another millions of days, and another thousands of millions. Now, instead of reversing the levers, I had pulled them over so as to go forward with them, and when I came to look at these indicators I found that the thousands hand was sweeping round as fast as the seconds hand of a watch—into the future.

"As I drove on, a peculiar change crept over the appearance of things. The greyness grew darker; then—though I was still traveling with prodigious velocity—the blinking succession of

prodigious: tremendous; extraordinary in size or amount

day and night, which indicated a slower pace, returned, and grew more and more noticeable. This puzzled me very much at first. The alternations of night and day grew slower and slower, and so did the passage of the sun across the sky, until they seemed to stretch through centuries. At last there came a steady twilight over the earth, a twilight only broken now and then when a comet glared across the darkling sky. The band of light that had indicated the sun had long since disappeared; for the sun had ceased to set—it simply rose and fell in the west, and grew ever broader and more red. All trace of the moon had vanished. The circling of the stars, growing slower and slower, had given place to creeping points of light.

"At last, some time before I stopped, the sun, red and very large, halted motionless upon the horizon, a vast dome glowing with a dull red heat. I perceived by this slowing down of its rising and setting that the earth had come to rest with one face to the sun, even as in our own time the moon faces the earth. Very cautiously, I began to reverse my motion. Slower and slower went the circling

hands until the thousands one seemed motionless and the daily one was no longer a mere mist upon its scale. Still slower, until the dim outlines of a desolate beach grew visible.

"I stopped very gently and sat upon the Time Machine, looking round. The sky was no longer blue. Northeastward it was inky black, and out of the blackness shone brightly and steadily the pale white stars. Overhead it was a deep red and starless, and southeastward it grew brighter to a glowing scarlet where, cut by the horizon, lay the huge hull of the sun, red and motionless. The rocks about me were of a harsh reddish color, and the only trace of life that I could see at first was the intensely green vegetation that covered every point on their southeastern face. It was the same rich green that one sees on forest moss or on the lichen in caves—plants which, like these, grow in a perpetual twilight.

"The machine was standing on a sloping beach. The sea stretched away to the southwest, to rise

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lichen: slow-growing plant that grows in a crust-like way on rocks and walls

perpetual: going on forever without stopping

into a sharp bright horizon against the pale sky. There were no waves, for not a breath of wind was stirring. Only a slight oily swell rose and fell like a gentle breathing, and showed that the eternal sea was still moving and living. And along the margin where the water sometimes broke was a thick crust of salt—pink under the lurid sky. My head felt weighted down, and I noticed that I was breathing very fast. The sensation reminded me of my only experience of mountaineering, and from that I judged the air to be more rarefied than it is now.

"Far away up the desolate slope I heard a harsh scream, and saw a thing like a huge white butterfly go slanting and fluttering up into the sky and, circling, disappear over some low hills beyond. The sound of its voice was so dismal that I shivered and seated myself more firmly upon the machine. Looking round me again, I saw that, quite near, what I had taken to be a reddish mass of rock was moving slowly towards me. Then I saw the thing was really a monstrous crab-like creature.

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lurid: shining with a harsh, unpleasant light
rarefied: (when used to describe air) thin and having little oxygen
dismal: extremely sad and gloomy, or causing such emotions



Then I saw the thing was really a monstrous crab-like creature.

Can you imagine a crab as large as yonder table, with its many legs moving slowly and uncertainly, its big claws swaying, its long antennae waving and feeling, and its stalked eyes gleaming at you on either side of its metallic front? Its back was ridged and covered with bulky lumps, and greenish scabs blotched it here and there. I could see the many feelers of its complicated mouth flickering as it moved.

"As I stared at this sinister creature crawling towards me, I felt a tickling on my cheek as though a fly had lighted there. I tried to brush it away with my hand, but in a moment it returned, and almost immediately came another by my ear. I struck at this, and caught something threadlike. It was drawn swiftly out of my hand. I turned and saw that I had grasped the antenna of another monster crab that stood just behind me. Its evil eyes were wriggling on their stalks, its mouth was all alive with appetite, and its huge ungainly claws, smeared with slime, were descending upon me.

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yonder: over there; at that place
sinister: threatening; menacing
ungainly: clumsy; awkward

In a moment my hand was on the lever, and I had placed a month between myself and these monsters. But I was still on the same beach, and I saw them as soon as I stopped. Dozens of them seemed to be crawling here and there in the somber light.

"I cannot convey the sense of abominable desolation that hung over the world. The red eastern sky, the northward blackness, the salt Dead Sea, the stony beach crawling with these foul, slow-stirring monsters, the uniform poisonous-looking green of the lichenous plants, the thin air that hurts one's lungs: all contributed to an appalling effect. I moved on a hundred years, and there was the same red sun—a little larger, a little duller—the same dying sea, the same chill air, and the same crowd of earthy crustacea creeping in and out among the green weed and the red rocks. And in the westward sky, I saw a curved pale line like a vast new moon.

"So I traveled in great strides of a thousand

abominable: awful; terrible
desolation: a state of complete emptiness or destruction; a feeling of completely miserable aloneness
crustacea (plural of *crustacean*): creatures like crabs and lobsters

years or more, drawn on by the mystery of the earth's fate, watching with a strange fascination the sun grow larger and duller in the westward sky, and the life of the old earth ebb away. At last, more than thirty million years hence, the huge red-hot dome of the sun had come to obscure nearly a tenth part of the darkling heavens. Then I stopped once more, for the crawling multitude of crabs had disappeared, and the red beach, except for its livid green mosses and lichens, seemed lifeless. And now it was flecked with white. A bitter cold assailed me. Rare white flakes came swirling down. To the northeastward, the glare of snow lay under the starlight of the sable sky, and I could see the rise and fall of pinkish white hills. There were fringes of ice along the sea margin, with drifting masses farther out; but the main expanse of that salt ocean, all bloody under the eternal sunset, was still unfrozen.

"I looked about me to see if any traces of animal life remained. A vague apprehension still kept me in the saddle of the machine. But I saw

assailed: attacked
sable: black
apprehension: a worried fear that something bad will happen

nothing moving, in earth or sky or sea. The green slime on the rocks alone testified that life was not extinct. A shallow sandbank had appeared in the sea and the water had receded from the beach. I thought I saw some black object flopping about, but it became motionless as I looked at it, and I judged that my eye had been deceived, and that the black object was merely a rock. The stars in the sky were intensely bright and seemed to me to twinkle very little.

"Suddenly I noticed that the circular westward outline of the sun had changed—a gap had appeared in the curve. I saw this grow larger. For a minute perhaps I stared aghast at this blackness creeping over the day, and then I realized that an eclipse was beginning. Either the moon or the planet Mercury was passing across the sun's disk.

"The darkness grew quickly; a cold wind began to blow in gusts from the east, and the showering white flakes in the air increased in number. From the edge of the sea came a ripple and whisper. Beyond these lifeless sounds the world was silent. Silent? It would be hard to convey the stillness of it.

aghast: shocked and horrified

All the sounds of man, the bleating of sheep, the cries of birds, the hum of insects, the stir that makes the background of our lives—all that was over. As the darkness thickened, the swirling flakes grew more abundant, dancing before my eyes, and the cold of the air more intense. At last, swiftly, one after the other, the white peaks of the distant hills vanished into blackness. The breeze rose to a moaning wind. I saw the black central shadow of the eclipse sweeping towards me. In another moment the pale stars alone were visible. All else was rayless obscurity. The sky was absolutely black.

"A horror of this great darkness came on me. The cold, that struck to my marrow, and the pain I felt in breathing, overcame me. I shivered, and a deadly nausea seized me. Then like a red-hot bow in the sky appeared the edge of the sun. I got off the machine to recover myself. I felt giddy and incapable of facing the return journey. As I stood sick and confused I saw again the moving thing upon the beach—there was no mistake now that it was a moving thing—against the red water of the sea. It was a round thing, the size of a football

perhaps, or, it may be, bigger, and tentacles trailed down from it; it seemed black against the blood-red water, and it was hopping fitfully about. Then I felt I was fainting. But a terrible dread of lying helpless in that remote and awful twilight sustained me while I clambered upon the saddle.



A Vision of the End

The chapter titled "A Further Vision" might just as well be called "A Final Vision," because it describes the imagined end of the world, some thirty million years in the future. The dying sun, the blood-red ocean, the crusty green vegetation, the primitive life forms—H. G. Wells describes the scene with the visual power and detail of a horror movie (well before the time of movies, of course!). How do you respond to the strange and bleak vision presented in this chapter?

Why would Wells choose to take the Time Traveler to the world's end? In part, Wells was thinking of scientific ideas that had found their way into the general culture—in particular, ideas about the age of the sun. Scientific discussions of "the age of the sun's heat" led people to worry about when that heat would run out. The brilliant scientist Sir William Thomson (also known as Lord Kelvin), stated that "inhabitants of the earth cannot continue to enjoy the light and heat essential to their life for many million years longer." While he did not say the world would end anytime soon, the topic itself raised fears and anxieties about the eventual transformation of the earth into a cold, dark, dead planet.

Lord Kelvin's estimates were corrected by later scientists, who gained new knowledge of the sources of the sun's energy. Decades after writing *The Time Machine*, Wells looked back and had this to say about the "Further Vision" chapter: "The geologists and astronomers of that time told us dreadful lies about the 'inevitable' freezing up of the world—and of life and mankind with it. There was no escape it seemed."

THE TIME TRAVELER'S RETURN

"So I came back. For a long time I must have been insensible upon the machine. The blinking succession of the days and nights was resumed, the sun got golden again, the sky blue. I breathed with greater freedom. The hands spun backward upon the dials. At last I saw again the dim shadows of houses. These, too, changed and passed, and others came. When the million dial was at zero, I reduced speed. I began to recognize our own familiar architecture, the thousands hand ran back to the starting-point, the night and day flapped slower and slower. Then the old walls of the laboratory came round me. Very gently, I slowed the mechanism down.

"I saw one little thing that seemed odd to me. I think I have told you that when I set out, before my velocity became very high, Mrs. Watchett had walked across the room, traveling, as it seemed to me, like a rocket. As I returned, I passed again across that minute when she crossed the

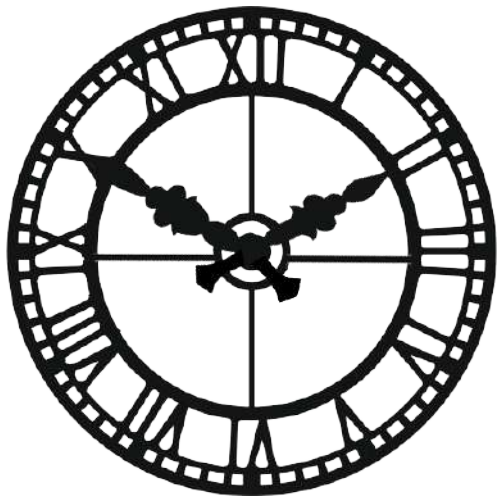
laboratory. But now her every motion appeared to be the exact opposite of her previous ones. The door at the lower end opened, and she glided quietly up the laboratory, back foremost, and disappeared behind the door by which she had previously entered.

"Then I stopped the machine, and saw about me again the old familiar laboratory, my tools just as I had left them. I got off the thing very shakily, and sat down upon my bench. For several minutes I trembled violently. Then I became calmer. Around me was my old workshop again, exactly as it had been. I might have slept there, and the whole thing have been a dream.

"And yet, not exactly! The thing had started from the southeast corner of the laboratory. It had come to rest again in the northwest, against the wall where you saw it. That gives you the exact distance from my little lawn to the pedestal of the White Sphinx, into which the Morlocks had carried my machine.

"I got up and came through the passage here, limping, because my heel was still painful. I saw the newspaper on the table by the door. I found

the date was indeed today, and looking at the timepiece, saw the hour was almost eight o'clock. I heard your voices and the clatter of plates. I hesitated—I felt so sick and weak. Then I sniffed good wholesome meat, and opened the door on you. You know the rest. I washed, and dined, and now I am telling you the story."



AFTER THE STORY

"I know," he said, after a pause, "that all this will be absolutely incredible to you, but to me the one incredible thing is that I am here tonight in this old familiar room looking into your friendly faces and telling you these strange adventures." He looked at the Medical Man. "No. I cannot expect you to believe it. Take it as a lie—or a prophecy. Say I dreamed it in the workshop. Think that I have been speculating upon the destinies of humanity, until I have hatched this fiction. Treat my assertion of its truth as a mere stroke of art to increase its interest. And taking it as a story, what do you think of it?"

He took up his pipe. There was a momentary stillness. Then chairs began to creak and shoes to scrape upon the carpet. I took my eyes off the Time Traveler's face, and looked round at his audience. The Medical Man seemed absorbed

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prophecy: prediction; statement of what will happen in the future

assertion: forceful statement of belief or fact

in the contemplation of our host. The Editor was looking hard at the end of his cigar. The Journalist fumbled for his watch. The others, as far as I remember, were motionless.

The Editor stood up with a sigh. "What a pity it is you're not a writer of stories!" he said, putting his hand on the Time Traveler's shoulder.

"You don't believe it?"

"Well — —"

"I thought not."

The Time Traveler turned to us. "Where are the matches?" he said. He lit one and spoke over his pipe, puffing. "To tell you the truth . . . I hardly believe it myself. . . . And yet . . ."

His eye fell upon the withered white flowers upon the little table. Then he turned over the hand holding his pipe, and I saw he was looking at some half-healed scars on his knuckles.

The Medical Man rose, came to the lamp, and examined the flowers. "The structure's odd," he said. The Psychologist leaned forward to see.

"It's a quarter to one," said the Journalist.

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contemplation: the act of thinking deeply about something; also, the act of looking carefully

"How shall we get home?"

"Plenty of cabs at the station," said the Psychologist.

"It's a curious thing," said the Medical Man, "but I certainly don't know the natural order of these flowers. May I have them?"

The Time Traveler hesitated. Then suddenly: "Certainly not."

"Where did you really get them?" said the Medical Man.

The Time Traveler put his hand to his head. He spoke like one who was trying to keep hold of an idea that eluded him. "They were put into my pocket by Weena, when I traveled into Time." He stared round the room. "This room and you and the atmosphere of every day is too much for my memory. Did I ever make a Time Machine, or a model of a Time Machine? Or is it all only a dream? They say life is a dream, a precious poor dream at times—but I can't stand another that won't fit. It's madness. And where did the dream come from? . . . I must look at that machine. If there is one!"

He grabbed the lamp swiftly, and carried it, flaring red, through the door into the corridor. We followed him. There in the flickering light of the lamp was the machine sure enough, squat, ugly, and tilted, a thing of brass, ebony, ivory, and translucent glimmering quartz. Solid to the touch—for I put out my hand and felt the rail of it—and with brown spots and smears upon the ivory, and bits of grass and moss upon the lower parts, and one rail bent.

The Time Traveler put the lamp down on the bench, and ran his hand along the damaged rail. "It's all right now," he said. "The story I told you was true. I'm sorry to have brought you out here in the cold." He took up the lamp, and, in an absolute silence, we returned to the drawing-room.

He came into the hall with us and helped the Editor on with his coat. The Medical Man looked into his face and, with a certain hesitation, told him he was suffering from overwork, at which he laughed hugely. I remember him standing in the open doorway, calling out good-night.

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squat: low and broad

translucent: not see-through like glass but clear enough to allow light to pass through

I shared a cab with the Editor. He thought the tale a "gaudy lie." For my own part I was unable to come to a conclusion. The story was so fantastic and incredible, the telling so credible and serious. I lay awake most of the night thinking about it. I determined to go next day and see the Time Traveler again. I was told he was in the laboratory, and I went up to him. The laboratory, however, was empty. I stared for a minute at the Time Machine and put out my hand and touched the lever. At that the squat solid-looking mass swayed like a bough shaken by the wind. Its instability startled me extremely, and I had a strange memory of the childish days when I used to be forbidden to meddle. I came back through the corridor. The Time Traveler met me. He was coming from the house. He had a small camera under one arm and a knapsack under the other. He laughed when he saw me, and gave me an elbow to shake. "I'm frightfully busy," said he, "with that thing in there."

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gaudy: showy; flashy
meddle: to touch or handle without permission; to get involved in matters that aren't your business
frightfully: (slang) very; extremely

"But is it not some hoax?" I said. "Do you really travel through time?"

"Really and truly I do." And he looked frankly into my eyes. He hesitated. His eye wandered about the room. "I only want half an hour," he said. "I know why you came, and it's awfully good of you. There's some magazines here. If you'll stay for lunch I'll offer complete proof of this time traveling, specimens and all. If you'll forgive my leaving you now?"

I consented, hardly understanding then the full meaning of his words, and he nodded and went on down the corridor. I heard the door of the laboratory slam, seated myself in a chair, and took up a daily paper. What was he going to do before lunchtime? Then suddenly I was reminded by an advertisement that I had promised to meet Richardson, the publisher, at two. I looked at my watch, and saw that I could barely keep that appointment. I got up and went down the passage to tell the Time Traveler.

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hoax: something meant to trick or deceive people
specimens: plants, animals, or objects collected for scientific study

As I took hold of the handle of the door I heard an exclamation, oddly cut off at the end, and a click and a thud. A gust of air whirled round me as I opened the door, and from within came the sound of broken glass falling on the floor. The Time Traveler was not there. I seemed to see a ghostly, indistinct figure sitting in a whirling mass of black and brass for a moment—a figure so transparent that the bench behind with its sheets of drawings was absolutely distinct; but this phantasm vanished as I rubbed my eyes. The Time Machine had gone. Save for a stir of dust, the further end of the laboratory was empty.

I felt an unreasonable amazement. I knew that something strange had happened, and for the moment could not tell what the strange thing might be. As I stood staring, the door into the garden opened, and a servant appeared.

We looked at each other. Then ideas began to come. "Has Mr. —— gone out that way?" said I.

"No, sir. No one has come out this way. I was expecting to find him here."

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phantasm: illusion; ghostly appearance

At that I understood. At the risk of disappointing Richardson I stayed on, waiting for the Time Traveler; waiting for the second, perhaps still stranger story, and the specimens and photographs he would bring with him. But I am beginning now to fear that I must wait a lifetime. The Time Traveler vanished three years ago. And, as everybody knows now, he has never returned.



EPILOGUE

One cannot choose but wonder. Will he ever return? It may be that he swept back into the past, and fell among blood-drinking savages, or into the abysses of the sea, or among the huge reptilian brutes of the Jurassic times. He may even now—if I may use the phrase—be wandering on some prehistoric coral reef beside lonely salt seas.

Or did he go forward, into one of the nearer ages, in which men are still men, but with the riddles of our own time answered and its wearisome problems solved? Into the maturity of humanity: for I, for my own part, cannot think that these days of weak experiment, fragmentary theory, and mutual discord are indeed man's culminating time!

But I know that he—for the question had been discussed among us long before the Time

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Epilogue: a final section after the main part of a book
wearisome: causing tiredness and irritation
mutual: experienced by two or more people or groups
discord: disagreement; conflict
culminating: reaching a high point of development

Machine was made—thought cheerlessly of the Advancement of Mankind, and saw in the growing pile of civilization only a foolish heaping that must inevitably fall back upon and destroy its makers in the end. If that is so, it remains for us to live as though it were not so. But to me the future is still black and blank—is a vast ignorance, lit at a few casual places by the memory of his story. And I have by me, for my comfort, two strange white flowers—shriveled now, and brown and flat and brittle—to confirm that even when mind and strength had gone, gratitude and a mutual tenderness still lived on in the human heart.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Herbert George Wells



Herbert George Wells was born on September 21, 1866, in Bromley, England, which at the time was a growing suburb southeast of the busy heart of London. He was the fourth of four children, including a sister who died young and two older brothers. The family lived in what Wells later remembered as a "needy, shabby home" at the back of a run-down shop where his father and mother tried to sell china and glassware, with little success.

When Bertie (as he was called) was seven, he badly broke his leg. During the weeks he spent in bed while recovering, his father brought him books from the local library—adventure stories, history and science books, and much more. Looking back, Wells later wrote, "I cannot recall now many of the titles of the books I read, I devoured them so fast."

When the family business failed, Wells's mother left Bromley to work as a housekeeper at a country estate called Uppark, where she had been previously employed. Like his older brothers before him, Wells, now 14 years old, was apprenticed to a draper's, a shop that sold cloth and other goods. He put his memories of this work into an early novel, in which the main character, a draper's assistant, says:

> *It's not a particularly honest nor a particularly useful trade; it's not very high up; there's no freedom and no leisure—seven to eight-thirty every day in the week; don't leave much edge to live on, does it? . . . You look respectable outside, and inside you are packed in dormitories like convicts, fed on bread and butter and bullied like slaves.*

Wells left this job and for a time went to live with his mother at Uppark. There, he was struck by the contrast between the comfortable lives of the wealthy family and the hard lives of the many servants who waited on them. At Uppark and elsewhere, he continued to read many books, including philosophical works by Plato, *Gulliver's Travels* by Jonathan Swift, and the novels of Charles Dickens.

Lacking money, Wells had to find work, and he soon he ended up as a draper's assistant yet again. After two miserable years in this job, one day Wells walked out of the shop. In a heated argument with his mother, he insisted he would never do such work again. He later looked back at this experience and reflected, "If life is not good enough for you, change it; never endure a way of life that is dull and dreary."

Wells found work as an assistant teacher at a local school. He did such excellent work that at the age of eighteen he was offered a scholarship to attend the Normal School of South Kensington, in London. (A "normal school" prepares its students to become teachers.) In his first year, Wells

took two science courses taught by Thomas H. Huxley, a well-known biologist and supporter of the theories of Charles Darwin. Wells was inspired by Huxley's teaching. Looking back, Wells later recalled, "That year I spent in Huxley's class, was beyond all question, the most educational year of my life."

While at the Normal School, Wells and some friends started a magazine they called the *Science Schools Journal*. Wells wrote some stories for the magazine, including, in 1888, "The Chronic Argonauts," in which one of the main characters is the inventor of a time machine. The story provided the seed that, over the next seven years, would grow into *The Time Machine*, although the early story is very different from the later novel.

As Wells moved on to different teaching jobs, he also continued writing stories and articles that he sold to various magazines. Some of the articles explored scientific topics in imaginative ways, while some of the stories were "scientific romances," or what we now call science fiction.

Darwin: See the Introduction to this book (pages 8-11) for a brief discussion of Darwin and Huxley, and how their ideas influenced H. G. Wells.

In one, called "The Star," Wells imagined an approaching asteroid that threatened to destroy the earth. Later, looking back on how his active imagination shaped these early stories, Wells recalled, "I found that, taking almost anything as a starting-point and letting my thoughts play about it, . . . I would discover I was peering into remote and mysterious worlds."

In trying to both teach and write, Wells was overworked and often ill. He was also unhappy in his marriage to his cousin, Isabel Mary Wells, whom he had wed in 1891. That marriage lasted only a few years. In 1895, Wells married a former student, Amy Catherine Robbins.

From 1894 to 1895, Wells continued to expand and rework the idea he had first explored in his story of "The Chronic Argonauts." He published "The Time Traveler's Story" in episodes that came out in a monthly magazine, then published an updated version of the story in a different magazine. He reworked the story yet again for publication in book form as his first novel, *The Time Machine*. When it was published in 1895, the novel sold well and received high praise.

The success of *The Time Machine* suddenly turned Wells into a well-known and successful author. He quickly set to work to write more "scientific romances," all of which are now recognized as pioneering works of science fiction. *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) tells of a mad scientist who creates hybrid creatures, part animal and part human. The central character of *The Invisible Man* (1897) is a scientist who discovers a way to make himself invisible, and of the violent and tragic consequences that follow. In *The War of the Worlds* (1898), the unnamed narrator describes an invasion by Martians, who have left their dying planet to find a new home on earth. With their superior technology and weapons—including a heat ray and poison gas—they threaten to wipe out humanity in short order, until their advance is unexpectedly halted by a surprising (and scientifically plausible) means. In *The First Men in the Moon* (1901), when an eccentric scientist develops a gravity-defying material, he and a British businessman travel to the moon and there discover an underground civilization.

H. G. Wells's science fiction works have remained popular to this day, and have been adapted for radio, theater, television, and movies. Wells is sometimes called "the father of science fiction." He went on to write many books of many different kinds, not only science fiction but also philosophical works, lighthearted novels, and a three-volume history of the world. In his writings, he foresaw the development of armored tanks, airplanes, space travel, and atomic weapons.

As Wells's career went on, social and political concerns began to dominate his writings—he was a socialist, deeply concerned about social equality, human rights, and world peace. As an internationally famous writer, he met with various world leaders, including U.S. President Franklin D. Roosevelt. He became a friend of the young Winston Churchill, who would lead Britain as Prime Minister in World War II. That war left the aging Wells deeply skeptical about the fate of mankind. He died in London on August 13, 1946.

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In this first novel from "the father of science fiction," H. G. Wells takes us hundreds of thousands of years into the future. The main character, the Time Traveler, encounters a green and peaceful world where all the needs of the people seem to be mysteriously taken care of—but the mystery reveals a dark vision of the possible destiny of humankind.

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PART FOUR

Voices of the Harlem Renaissance

An anthology, with background by VenvLearning

Read in Units 7 and 9: history, background, and the poems and essays of the movement.

SECTION 1

Introduction and a Note on Historical Language

WORDS TO KNOW

renaissance	a rebirth; a time of new energy in art and learning
movement	a group of people working toward shared goals over time
context	the time, place, and situation in which something was written
slur	an insulting word used to hurt a group of people

In the 1920s, a neighborhood in the northern part of New York City called Harlem became the center of an explosion of art, music, writing, and ideas. Poets, novelists, painters, musicians, scholars, and journalists poured into Harlem from the American South, from the Caribbean, and from cities across the country. Together they created a movement that people at the time called the "New Negro" movement. Today we call it the Harlem Renaissance.

The word renaissance means "rebirth." It was first used for the great flowering of art and learning in Europe in the 1400s and 1500s. The writers and artists of Harlem were not reborn, of course. But many of them felt that something new was being born: a new confidence, a new pride, and a new determination to tell the story of Black life in America in their own words.

The Harlem Renaissance did not happen all at once, and it did not happen only in Harlem. It grew out of decades of struggle and achievement. It was shaped by the Great Migration, by newspapers and magazines, by the music of jazz and the blues, and by writers who came before. It also reached far beyond New York, to cities such as Washington, D.C., and Chicago, and to readers around the world.

In this Reader you will meet some of the people who made the movement and read some of their own words: poems, essays, and speeches written between 1895 and 1930.

A note on historical language. The writers in this book lived about one hundred years ago, and they used the words for race that were common in their time. In the 1920s, the word Negro was the respectful, standard term, and many writers capitalized it proudly; the "New Negro" was a phrase of pride. Today we use the terms Black and African American, and

Negro is considered out of date. You will also see at least one word, in Countee Cullen's poem “Incident,” that was meant as a cruel insult. Cullen used it on purpose, to show the hurt that a single hateful word can cause a child.

When you read historical texts, read the words in their context: ask who is speaking, when, to whom, and why. Quote the texts accurately when you write about them, but use today's respectful terms in your own sentences and discussions. A slur is never acceptable to use in conversation, even when you are discussing a poem that contains one.

SECTION 2

Literary Tradition and Paul Laurence Dunbar

WORDS TO KNOW

dialect	a way of speaking that belongs to a particular region or group
forerunner	someone who comes before and prepares the way
guile	clever trickery
myriad	countless; a great many

The writers of the Harlem Renaissance did not appear out of nowhere. They built on a long literary tradition. In the 1700s, Phillis Wheatley, who had been brought to Boston as an enslaved child, became the first African American to publish a book of poetry. In the 1800s, Frederick Douglass wrote powerful accounts of his life in slavery and his escape to freedom. These writers showed that Black Americans could use the written word to tell the truth about their lives.

One writer from the generation before the Harlem Renaissance was especially important to the poets who came later: Paul Laurence Dunbar. Dunbar was born in Dayton, Ohio, in 1872. His parents had been enslaved in Kentucky. In high school, he was the only Black student in his class, and he edited the school newspaper and wrote poems. After graduating, he could not find work as a writer because of racial prejudice, so he took a job running an elevator. Between rides, he wrote poetry.

Dunbar published his first books himself and sold copies to his elevator passengers. In 1896, his collection Lyrics of Lowly Life, with an introduction by the famous critic William Dean Howells, made him one of the best-known poets in America. He was one of the first African American writers to earn national fame and to support himself by writing.

Dunbar wrote in two different styles. Some of his poems were written in dialect, imitating the speech of Black Southerners. White audiences loved these poems, and they made him famous. But many of his most powerful poems were written in standard English. In these poems he wrote about pain, pride, and the hidden feelings of people forced to smile in the face of injustice. Dunbar was sometimes frustrated that critics praised his dialect poems and paid less attention to his other work.

Dunbar died of tuberculosis in 1906, when he was only thirty-three. But the poets of the Harlem Renaissance read his work and saw him as a forerunner, a writer who had opened the door for them. His poem “Sympathy,” about a caged bird, later gave the writer Maya Angelou the title for her famous memoir, I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings.

POEM

We Wear the Mask

Paul Laurence Dunbar · Lyrics of Lowly Life (1896)

We wear the mask that grins and lies,
It hides our cheeks and shades our eyes,—
This debt we pay to human guile;
With torn and bleeding hearts we smile,
And mouth with myriad subtleties.

Why should the world be over-wise,
In counting all our tears and sighs?
Nay, let them only see us, while
    We wear the mask.

We smile, but, O great Christ, our cries
To thee from tortured souls arise.
We sing, but oh the clay is vile
Beneath our feet, and long the mile;
But let the world dream otherwise,
    We wear the mask!

POEM

Sympathy

Paul Laurence Dunbar · Lyrics of the Hearthside (1899)

I know what the caged bird feels, alas!
    When the sun is bright on the upland slopes;
When the wind stirs soft through the springing grass,
And the river flows like a stream of glass;
    When the first bird sings and the first bud opes,
And the faint perfume from its chalice steals--
I know what the caged bird feels!

I know why the caged bird beats his wing

Till its blood is red on the cruel bars;
For he must fly back to his perch and cling
When he fain would be on the bough a-swing;
And a pain still throbs in the old, old scars
And they pulse again with a keener sting--
I know why he beats his wing!

I know why the caged bird sings, ah me,
When his wing is bruised and his bosom sore,--
When he beats his bars and he would be free;
It is not a carol of joy or glee,
But a prayer that he sends from his heart's deep core,
But a plea, that upward to Heaven he flings--
I know why the caged bird sings!

SECTION 3

The Great Migration and Charles S. Johnson

WORDS TO KNOW

migration	the movement of people from one place to another
segregation	the separation of people by race
sociologist	a scientist who studies how people live in groups
benediction	a blessing

Around 1915, one of the largest movements of people in American history began. Over the next several decades, about six million Black Americans left the rural South and moved to cities in the North, the Midwest, and the West. Historians call this the Great Migration.

People left the South for many reasons. Historians sometimes divide these reasons into push factors, which pushed people out, and pull factors, which pulled them toward a new place. Push factors included the unfair Jim Crow laws that enforced segregation and kept Black Southerners from voting, the constant threat of violence, and hard times on Southern farms, where a tiny insect called the boll weevil destroyed cotton crops. Pull factors included jobs in Northern factories, which needed workers when World War I cut off immigration from Europe, better schools, and the hope of greater freedom.

Many migrants learned about life in the North from Black newspapers, which printed job advertisements and letters from people who had already moved. Families often traveled north by train, carrying everything they owned. They settled in cities such as Chicago, Detroit, Philadelphia, Pittsburgh, and New York.

In New York, many settled in Harlem. By the 1920s, Harlem had become the largest Black community in the United States. Newcomers from the South lived alongside immigrants from Jamaica, Barbados, Haiti, and other Caribbean islands. The mix of people, experiences, and ideas helped make Harlem a place of tremendous creative energy. The Jamaican-born poet Claude McKay, who came to the United States in 1912, captured the homesickness that many newcomers felt in his poem “The Tropics in New York.”

One person who understood the importance of the Great Migration was Charles S. Johnson. Johnson, born in Virginia in 1893, was a sociologist, a scientist who studies how people live in groups. After serving in World War I, he studied the Black migrants who had moved to Chicago and helped write a major report on race relations there after a deadly riot in 1919.

In 1923, Johnson became the first editor of Opportunity: A Journal of Negro Life, the magazine of the National Urban League. Johnson believed that art and literature could change the way Americans saw one another. He used Opportunity to publish young writers, and in 1924 he began holding literary contests with cash prizes. Langston Hughes, Countee Cullen, and Zora Neale Hurston were among the early prizewinners. In March 1924, Johnson organized a dinner at the Civic Club in New York where young Black writers were introduced to publishers and editors. Many historians see that evening as one of the starting points of the Harlem Renaissance.

Johnson later became a leading scholar of race in America, and in 1946 he became the first Black president of Fisk University in Nashville, Tennessee.

POEM

The Tropics in New York

Claude McKay · Harlem Shadows (1922)

Bananas ripe and green, and ginger-root,
Cocoa in pods and alligator pears,
And tangerines and mangoes and grape fruit,
Fit for the highest prize at parish fairs,

Set in the window, bringing memories
Of fruit-trees laden by low-singing rills,
And dewy dawns, and mystical blue skies
In benediction over nun-like hills.

My eyes grew dim, and I could no more gaze;
A wave of longing through my body swept,
And, hungry for the old, familiar ways,
I turned aside and bowed my head and wept.

SECTION 4

Harlem, the Black Press, and J. A. Rogers

WORDS TO KNOW

press	newspapers and magazines, and the people who write them
columnist	a writer who regularly writes articles for a newspaper
descent	family origin; ancestry
antidote	a remedy; something that cures a poison

Newspapers and magazines were the internet of the 1920s. They carried news, opinions, poems, stories, and advertisements to readers across the country. For Black Americans, the Black press was especially important. Mainstream white newspapers often ignored Black communities or wrote about them unfairly. Black newspapers and magazines told the stories that others left out.

In 1905, Robert S. Abbott founded the Chicago Defender. Abbott's newspaper reported on injustice in the South and described the opportunities waiting in the North. Railroad porters carried copies of the Defender south on the trains, and it was passed from hand to hand and read aloud in churches and barbershops. The Defender helped encourage the Great Migration.

In 1910, the scholar W. E. B. Du Bois became the editor of The Crisis, the magazine of the NAACP, the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People. Du Bois used The Crisis to fight for civil rights, and he also used it to publish poetry and fiction. The Crisis published Langston Hughes's first famous poem, “The Negro Speaks of Rivers,” in 1921. Its literary editor, Jessie Redmon Fauset, discovered and encouraged many young writers. Along with Charles S. Johnson's Opportunity, The Crisis gave the writers of the Harlem Renaissance a place to be read.

Journalists also worked to recover a history that had been ignored. J. A. Rogers, born in Jamaica around 1880, came to the United States as a young man. He worked as a railroad porter and spent his free time in libraries, researching the achievements of people of African descent throughout history. He became a columnist for the Pittsburgh Courier, one of the most widely read Black newspapers, and wrote books challenging the claim that Black people

had no history worth studying. In 1925 he contributed an essay about jazz to The New Negro.

Rogers was part of a larger effort to “dig up” the past. The book collector Arthur A. Schomburg, born in Puerto Rico, gathered thousands of books, pamphlets, and documents about Black history from around the world. His collection became the foundation of what is now the Schomburg Center for Research in Black Culture, part of the New York Public Library, which still stands in Harlem today. In an essay published in 1925, Schomburg explained why this work mattered.

EXCERPT

The Negro Digs Up His Past

Arthur A. Schomburg · The New Negro (1925)

The American Negro must remake his past in order to make his future. Though it is orthodox to think of America as the one country where it is unnecessary to have a past, what is a luxury for the nation as a whole becomes a prime social necessity for the Negro. For him, a group tradition must supply compensation for persecution, and pride of race the antidote for prejudice. History must restore what slavery took away, for it is the social damage of slavery that the present generations must repair and offset.

Gradually as the study of the Negro’s past has come out of the vagaries of rhetoric and propaganda and become systematic and scientific, three outstanding conclusions have been established:

First, that the Negro has been throughout the centuries of controversy an active collaborator, and often a pioneer, in the struggle for his own freedom and advancement. This is true to a degree which makes it the more surprising that it has not been recognized earlier.

Second, that by virtue of their being regarded as something "exceptional,” even by friends and well-wishers, Negroes of attainment and genius have been unfairly disassociated from the group, and group credit lost accordingly.

Third, that the remote racial origins of the Negro, far from being what the race and the world have been given to understand, offer a record of credible group achievement when scientifically viewed, and more important still, that they are of vital general interest because of their bearing upon the beginnings and early development of human culture.

With such crucial truths to document and establish, an ounce of fact is worth a pound of controversy.

SECTION 5

The New Negro: Locke and Kellogg

WORDS TO KNOW

stereotype	an oversimplified, often unfair idea about a group of people
norns	in Norse myth, three women who control fate
changeling	in folk tales, a child secretly swapped for another
chrysalis	the case a caterpillar forms before becoming a butterfly

In March 1925, a magazine called Survey Graphic published a special issue with the title Harlem: Mecca of the New Negro. Survey Graphic was a magazine about social issues, and its editor, Paul Kellogg, was a white reformer who wanted Americans to understand the changes happening in their country. Kellogg invited a Black scholar to serve as guest editor of the issue: Alain Locke.

Locke, born in Philadelphia in 1885, was a philosopher who taught at Howard University in Washington, D.C. In 1907 he had become the first African American Rhodes Scholar, earning the chance to study at Oxford University in England. Locke believed that the young Black writers and artists of the 1920s were creating something new and important, and he wanted the rest of the country to see it.

The Harlem issue of Survey Graphic included essays, poems, stories, and portraits by Black writers and artists. It was so popular that the magazine had to print extra copies. Later in 1925, Locke expanded it into a book called The New Negro: An Interpretation. The New Negro collected poetry by Langston Hughes, Countee Cullen, Claude McKay, and Georgia Douglas Johnson; stories by Zora Neale Hurston and Jean Toomer; essays on history, music, art, and education; and illustrations by the artist Aaron Douglas. It became the defining book of the Harlem Renaissance.

In his title essay, Locke argued that a “New Negro” had arrived: Black Americans who refused to accept old stereotypes, who were proud of their heritage, and who spoke for themselves. For generations, he wrote, Black Americans had been treated as “a problem” to be argued about rather than as people. Now, through art and self-expression, they were defining themselves.

Not everyone agreed with every part of Locke's vision. Some critics, including W. E. B. Du Bois, believed that art should be used more directly as a tool in the fight for civil rights. Others worried that white publishers and audiences were more interested in entertainment than in the truth about Black life. These debates were part of what made the Harlem Renaissance so lively.

EXCERPT

The New Negro

Alain Locke · The New Negro (1925)

In the last decade something beyond the watch and guard of statistics has happened in the life of the American Negro and the three norns who have traditionally presided over the Negro problem have a changeling in their laps. The Sociologist, the Philanthropist, the Race-leader are not unaware of the New Negro, but they are at a loss to account for him. He simply cannot be swathed in their formulæ. For the younger generation is vibrant with a new psychology; the new spirit is awake in the masses, and under the very eyes of the professional observers is transforming what has been a perennial problem into the progressive phases of contemporary Negro life.

Recall how suddenly the Negro spirituals revealed themselves; suppressed for generations under the stereotypes of Wesleyan hymn harmony, secretive, half-ashamed, until the courage of being natural brought them out—and behold, there was folk-music. Similarly the mind of the Negro seems suddenly to have slipped from under the tyranny of social intimidation and to be shaking off the psychology of imitation and implied inferiority. By shedding the old chrysalis of the Negro problem we are achieving something like a spiritual emancipation. Until recently, lacking self-understanding, we have been almost as much of a problem to ourselves as we still are to others. But the decade that found us with a problem has left us with only a task. The multitude perhaps feels as yet only a strange relief and a new vague urge, but the thinking few know that in the reaction the vital inner grip of prejudice has been broken.

EXCERPT

Negro Youth Speaks

Alain Locke · The New Negro (1925)

The Younger Generation comes, bringing its gifts. They are the first fruits of the Negro Renaissance. Youth speaks, and the voice of the New Negro is heard. What stirs inarticulately in the masses is already vocal upon the lips of the talented few, and the future listens, however the present may shut its ears.

Our poets have now stopped speaking for the Negro—they speak as Negroes. Where formerly they spoke to others and tried to interpret, they now speak to their own and try to express. They have stopped posing, being nearer the attainment of poise.

SECTION 6

Langston Hughes

WORDS TO KNOW

syncopated	with the beat shifted to unexpected places, as in jazz
croon	to sing softly
melancholy	sad and thoughtful
variation	a different version of something

Of all the writers of the Harlem Renaissance, the one most often read today is Langston Hughes. Hughes was born in Joplin, Missouri, in 1901, and grew up mostly in Lawrence, Kansas, with his grandmother, and later in Cleveland, Ohio. His grandmother told him stories of heroes who had fought against slavery, and he read every book he could find.

When Hughes was about eighteen, he took a train across the Mississippi River on his way to visit his father in Mexico. Looking out at the great muddy river at sunset, he thought about the rivers that had been part of Black history: the Euphrates, the Congo, the Nile, and the Mississippi. On the back of an envelope, he wrote “The Negro Speaks of Rivers.” The Crisis published it in 1921, and it made him known.

Hughes moved to Harlem, worked at many jobs, and traveled the world as a sailor. In 1925, his poem “The Weary Blues” won first prize in Opportunity's poetry contest, and in 1926 his first book of poems, also called The Weary Blues, was published. Hughes was one of the first poets to use the rhythms of jazz and the blues in poetry. He wanted his poems to sound like the music and speech of ordinary Black people, not just educated readers.

In a 1926 essay, Hughes declared that young Black artists should express themselves “without fear or shame.” He wrote poems, novels, short stories, plays, newspaper columns, and books for children for more than forty years. He died in 1967. His home in Harlem still stands, and his poems are read in classrooms around the world.

POEM

The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Langston Hughes · The Weary Blues (1926); first published in The Crisis (1921)

(To W. E. B. DuBois)

I've known rivers:
I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.
I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.
I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.
I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

I've known rivers:
Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

POEM

Mother to Son

Langston Hughes · The Weary Blues (1926)

Well, son, I'll tell you:
Life for me ain't been no crystal stair.
It's had tacks in it,
And splinters,
And boards torn up,
And places with no carpet on the floor—
Bare.
But all the time
I'se been a-climbin' on,
And reachin' landin's,
And turnin' corners,
And sometimes goin' in the dark
Where there ain't been no light.
So boy, don't you turn back.

Don't you set down on the steps
'Cause you finds it's kinder hard.
Don't you fall now—
For I'se still goin', honey,
I'se still climbin',
And life for me ain't been no crystal stair.

POEM

Dream Variation

Langston Hughes · The Weary Blues (1926)

To fling my arms wide
In some place of the sun,
To whirl and to dance
Till the white day is done.
Then rest at cool evening
Beneath a tall tree
While night comes on gently,
Dark like me,—
That is my dream!

To fling my arms wide
In the face of the sun,
Dance! whirl! whirl!
Till the quick day is done.
Rest at pale evening. . . .
A tall, slim tree. . . .
Night coming tenderly
Black like me.

POEM

The Dream Keeper

Langston Hughes · The Weary Blues (1926)

Bring me all of your dreams,
You dreamers.
Bring me all of your
Heart melodies
That I may wrap them
In a blue cloud-cloth

Away from the too rough fingers
Of the world.

POEM

Epilogue (“I, Too”)

Langston Hughes · The Weary Blues (1926)

I, too, sing America.

I am the darker brother.
They send me to eat in the kitchen
When company comes,
But I laugh,
And eat well,
And grow strong.

Tomorrow,
I'll sit at the table
When company comes.
Nobody'll dare
Say to me,
"Eat in the kitchen,"
Then.

Besides,
They'll see how beautiful I am
And be ashamed,—

I, too, am America.

POEM

The Weary Blues

Langston Hughes · The Weary Blues (1926)

Droning a drowsy syncopated tune,
Rocking back and forth to a mellow croon,
I heard a Negro play.
Down on Lenox Avenue the other night
By the pale dull pallor of an old gas light
He did a lazy sway. . . .
He did a lazy sway. . . .

To the tune o' those Weary Blues.
With his ebony hands on each ivory key
He made that poor piano moan with melody.
O Blues!
Swaying to and fro on his rickety stool
He played that sad raggy tune like a musical fool.
Sweet Blues!
Coming from a black man's soul.
O Blues!
In a deep song voice with a melancholy tone
I heard that Negro sing, that old piano moan—
"Ain't got nobody in all this world,
Ain't got nobody but ma self.
I's gwine to quit ma frownin'
And put ma troubles on the shelf."
Thump, thump, thump, went his foot on the floor.
He played a few chords then he sang some more—
"I got the Weary Blues
And I can't be satisfied.
Got the Weary Blues
And can't be satisfied—
I ain't happy no mo'
And I wish that I had died."

And far into the night he crooned that tune.
The stars went out and so did the moon.
The singer stopped playing and went to bed
While the Weary Blues echoed through his head.
He slept like a rock or a man that's dead.

SECTION 7

Georgia Douglas Johnson

WORDS TO KNOW

salon	a regular gathering of writers and thinkers in someone's home
turrets	small towers
contraband	goods forbidden by law; here, things that block the way
countermand	to cancel an order

Georgia Douglas Johnson was one of the first Black women poets to win national attention in the twentieth century. She was born in Atlanta, Georgia, around 1877, studied at Atlanta University, and also studied music at Oberlin Conservatory in Ohio. In 1910 she moved with her husband to Washington, D.C., where she lived for the rest of her life.

Johnson published her first book of poems, The Heart of a Woman, in 1918. Its poems explored the feelings and hopes of women, and especially the dreams that women were often not free to follow. Her second book, Bronze (1922), focused on race and on the experiences of Black mothers. A third book, An Autumn Love Cycle, followed in 1928. She also wrote many plays. Her play Plumes won first prize in Opportunity's contest in 1927.

Johnson is also remembered for what happened in her home. Her house at 1461 S Street NW in Washington, which she called the Half-Way House, became a gathering place for writers and artists. On Saturday nights, poets and thinkers such as Langston Hughes, Jean Toomer, Countee Cullen, Alain Locke, Jessie Redmon Fauset, Angelina Weld Grimké, and Zora Neale Hurston came to read their work, share ideas, and encourage one another. This gathering became known as the S Street Salon.

Johnson worked at government jobs to support her two sons after her husband died in 1925, and she wrote late at night. She continued writing for the rest of her long life. She died in 1966. Her life shows that the Harlem Renaissance was not only a New York story, and that its writers depended on friendship, community, and generous hosts.

POEM

The Heart of a Woman

Georgia Douglas Johnson · The Heart of a Woman and Other Poems (1918)

The heart of a woman goes forth with the dawn,
As a lone bird, soft winging, so restlessly on,
Afar o'er life's turrets and vales does it roam
In the wake of those echoes the heart calls home.

The heart of a woman falls back with the night,
And enters some alien cage in its plight,
And tries to forget it has dreamed of the stars
While it breaks, breaks, breaks on the sheltering bars.

POEM

Calling Dreams

Georgia Douglas Johnson · Bronze (1922)

The right to make my dreams come true
I ask, nay, I demand of life,
Nor shall fate's deadly contraband
Impede my steps, nor countermand.

Too long my heart against the ground
Has beat the dusty years around,
And now, at length, I rise, I wake!
And stride into the morning-break!

SECTION 8

Elise Johnson McDougald

WORDS TO KNOW

emancipation	freedom from control or unfair limits
vocational	relating to jobs and careers
domestic worker	a person paid to clean, cook, or care for children in someone's home
principal	the leader of a school

Not every voice of the Harlem Renaissance belonged to a poet or a novelist. Elise Johnson McDougald was an educator, a social researcher, and a writer who spent her life working for children, workers, and women in Harlem.

McDougald was born in Manhattan in 1885. She became a teacher in New York City's public schools in 1905. She also worked to improve the lives of working people. She studied the working conditions of Black women in New York, helped organize laundry workers, and served as a vocational counselor, helping young people find jobs that matched their skills.

In March 1925, McDougald wrote an essay for the Harlem issue of Survey Graphic called “The Double Task: The Struggle of Negro Women for Sex and Race Emancipation.” Alain Locke included a version of it, titled “The Task of Negro Womanhood,” in The New Negro later that year. In her essay, McDougald described the “double task” facing Black women: they had to struggle against unfair treatment both because they were women and because they were Black. She described Black women in many kinds of work, from domestic workers and factory workers to teachers, nurses, business owners, and writers, and she argued that their contributions deserved respect.

McDougald's own career showed what she meant. In the 1930s she became the principal of P.S. 24 in Harlem and is often described as the first Black woman to serve as a principal in a New York City public school. One of her students there was the future writer James Baldwin. She later led P.S. 119 until she retired in 1954. After retiring, she wrote a newspaper column about Harlem's schools.

When you read about the Harlem Renaissance, remember McDougald's point: a movement is made not only by famous artists but also by the many people who teach, organize, and build the community that artists depend on.

SECTION 9

More Voices of the Harlem Renaissance

WORDS TO KNOW

sonnet	a fourteen-line poem with a set rhyme pattern
anthropology	the study of human cultures
Tantalus, Sisyphus	figures in Greek myth punished forever: one never reaching food, one forever pushing a rock uphill
inscrutable	impossible to understand

The Harlem Renaissance included many more writers than one Reader can hold. Here are a few more voices.

Claude McKay (about 1889–1948) was born in Jamaica and came to the United States in 1912. In 1919, a summer of violent attacks on Black communities across the United States, he wrote “If We Must Die,” a sonnet calling for courage and dignity in the face of attack. His collection Harlem Shadows (1922) is often seen as one of the first books of the Harlem Renaissance.

Countee Cullen (1903–1946) grew up in New York City and was a star student at New York University and Harvard. He loved traditional poetic forms such as the sonnet. His first book, Color, was published in 1925, when he was only twenty-two. “Incident” describes a moment from his childhood in just twelve lines; “Yet Do I Marvel” is a sonnet about faith, suffering, and the gift of poetry. Cullen later taught English and French at a junior high school in New York City.

Zora Neale Hurston (1891–1960) grew up in Eatonville, Florida, one of the first all-Black towns in the United States to be incorporated. She studied anthropology and collected the folktales and songs of Black communities in the South. Her stories, essays, and later her novel Their Eyes Were Watching God (1937) captured the voices of the people she grew up with.

POEM

If We Must Die

Claude McKay · Harlem Shadows (1922); first published 1919

If we must die, let it not be like hogs
Hunted and penned in an inglorious spot,
While round us bark the mad and hungry dogs,
Making their mock at our accursèd lot.
If we must die, O let us nobly die,
So that our precious blood may not be shed
In vain; then even the monsters we defy
Shall be constrained to honor us though dead!
O kinsmen! we must meet the common foe!
Though far outnumbered let us show us brave,
And for their thousand blows deal one death-blow!
What though before us lies the open grave?
Like men we'll face the murderous, cowardly pack,
Pressed to the wall, dying, but fighting back!

POEM

Incident

Countee Cullen · Color (1925)

(for Eric Walrond)

Once riding in old Baltimore,
Heart-filled, head-filled with glee,
I saw a Baltimorean
  Keep looking straight at me.

Now I was eight and very small,
  And he was no whit bigger,
And so I smiled, but he poked out
  His tongue, and called me, “Nigger.”

I saw the whole of Baltimore
  From May until December;
Of all the things that happened there
  That’s all that I remember.

POEM

Yet Do I Marvel

Countee Cullen · Color (1925)

I doubt not God is good, well-meaning, kind,
And did He stoop to quibble could tell why
The little buried mole continues blind,
Why flesh that mirrors Him must some day die,
Make plain the reason tortured Tantalus
Is baited by the fickle fruit, declare
If merely brute caprice dooms Sisyphus
To struggle up a never-ending stair.
Inscrutable His ways are, and immune
To catechism by a mind too strewn
With petty cares to slightly understand
What awful brain compels His awful hand.
Yet do I marvel at this curious thing:
To make a poet black, and bid him sing!

SOURCES

The background sections in this anthology were written for VenvLearning. Every poem and essay excerpt was first published in 1930 or earlier and is in the public domain in the United States. The texts follow the first book editions as transcribed on Wikisource (en.wikisource.org): Paul Laurence Dunbar, Lyrics of Lowly Life (1896) and Lyrics of the Hearthside (1899); Claude McKay, Harlem Shadows (1922); Georgia Douglas Johnson, The Heart of a Woman (1918) and Bronze (1922); Langston Hughes, The Weary Blues (1926); Countee Cullen, Color (1925); Alain Locke, ed., The New Negro (1925), for the essays by Alain Locke and Arthur A. Schomburg.

Excerpts are marked. Spelling and punctuation follow the original editions, including period spellings and dialect.

To read more, The Genius of the Harlem Renaissance Reader from the Core Knowledge Foundation is free at coreknowledge.org, and the Schomburg Center for Research in Black Culture (New York Public Library) has extensive free online exhibits.

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